

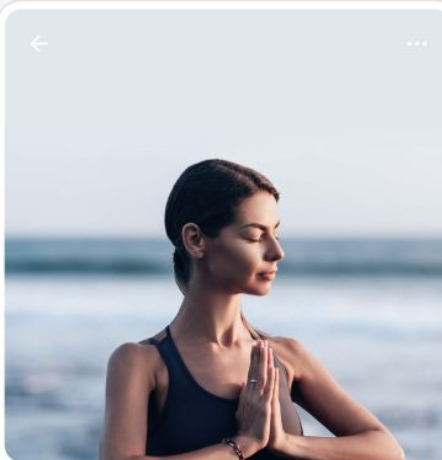


Design Guidelines



Learning Objectives

Explore design guidelines



Morning Yoga Workout

WITH BROOKLYN SIMS

★★★★★ 5.0 (23 reviews)

Inhale Good Vibes

20 mins

Beginner

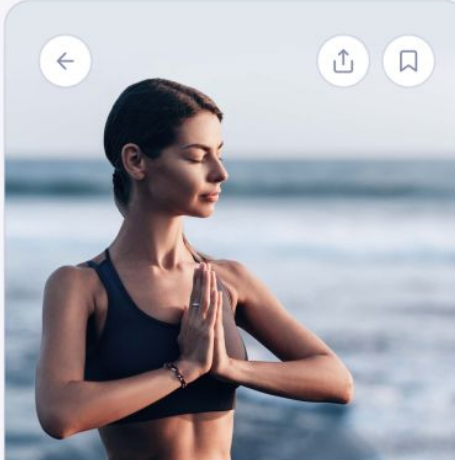
Ambient

None

Escape the stresses of quotidian existence with this harmonious fusion of contemplative pranayama techniques and corporeal postures. You will feel rejuvenated and ready to take on the day.

The session commences with a succinct centering exercise, fostering a seamless detachment from external distractions and inviting full immersion into the present moment.

You shall cultivate an unwavering focus on your breath, laying the foundation for the ensuing practice.



Morning yoga workout

With Brooklyn Sims

★★★★★ 5.0 (23 reviews)

20 mins

Beginner

Ambient

None

Escape the stresses of everyday life with this balanced blend of mindful breathing techniques and physical postures. You'll feel refreshed and ready to take on the day.

Start workout

Which design is better (the one on the right or the one on the left)? why?

Design Guidelines

Ensure an interface is accessible

Make sure that your designs meet Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG)

Aim to at least meet WCAG 2.1 level AA requirements

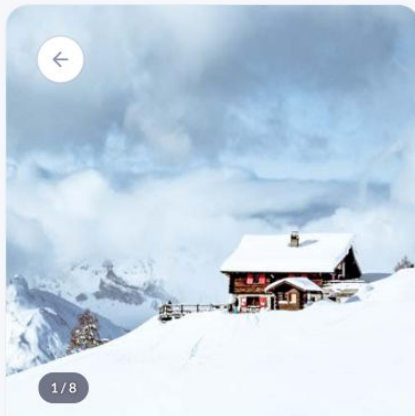
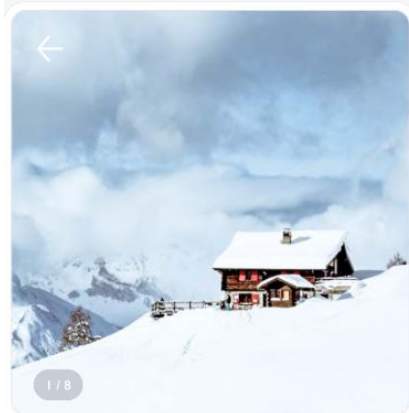
Design Guidelines

Ensure an interface is accessible

Many of the guidelines for creating an accessible interface for people with disabilities also helps create a more user-friendly interface for everyone else

Things like ensuring sufficient contrast, minimising interaction cost, and minimising cognitive load, are all essential for good usability

good accessibility = great usability



Identify the usability issues in the UI on the left that are resolved in the UI on the right

Low contrast form field versus high contrast form field



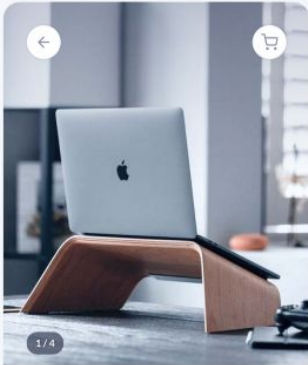
First name



First name

Why the UI marked ✓ on the right side is better with respect to accessibility?

✗



1/4

Wood laptop stand

★★★★★ 5.0 (23 reviews)

Free shipping Australia-wide

This handmade curved laptop stand is skillfully crafted from natural Walnut timber veneer pressed on Premium Birch Plywood.

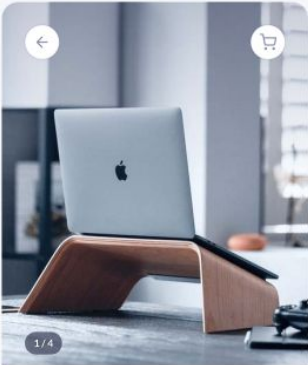
Ideal for home or office workspaces, the stand is designed at an angle for improved ergonomics.

[Add to cart](#) \$129.00

Colour blind people can't distinguish between link text and plain text

Colour contrast ratio is less than 4.5:1 making it difficult to read for some

✓



1/4

Wood laptop stand

★★★★★ 5.0 [\[23 reviews\]](#)

Free shipping Australia-wide

This handmade curved laptop stand is skillfully crafted from natural Walnut timber veneer pressed on Premium Birch Plywood.

Ideal for home or office workspaces, the stand is designed at an angle for improved ergonomics.

[Add to cart](#) \$129.00

Link is underlined to help colour blind people distinguish it from other text

Colour contrast ratio was increased to more than 4.5:1 to make it accessible

Design Guidelines

Have a logical reason for every design detail

It's important to have a rationale (logical reason) behind each design decision you make and to be able to clearly articulate it to support your designs

Example Logical Design Reasons



Website builder

With access to over 100 beautifully designed website templates, your site will be up and running in no time.

[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

Launch professionally branded email campaigns in minutes and monitor engagement with powerful analytics.

[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

Empower your business by creating your own affiliate program and turning your customers into a sales team.

[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Icons and text are left aligned to improve readability and aesthetics while decreasing cognitive load



Website builder

With access to over 100 beautifully designed website templates, your site will be up and running in no time.

[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

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[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

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[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Headings and text links are descriptive, making them scannable and understandable out of context for screen readers



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[Explore templates](#)



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[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

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[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Secondary text is less important than headings, so it's made less prominent (using size and contrast) to create a clear visual hierarchy



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[Explore templates](#)



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[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

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[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Secondary text line height is at least 1.5 to improve readability



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[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

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[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

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[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Text links are coloured blue to indicate they're interactive and underlined so the color blind can distinguish them from other text



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[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

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[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

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[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Spacing inside each block is less than the spacing between each block to create groups of related information



Website builder

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[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

Launch professionally branded email campaigns in minutes and monitor engagement with powerful analytics.

[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

Empower your business by creating your own affiliate program and turning your customers into a sales team.

[How affiliates work](#)

Example Logical Design Reasons

Information is broken up into smaller groups to make it easier to understand and to help speed up decision making



Website builder

With access to over 100 beautifully designed website templates, your site will be up and running in no time.

[Explore templates](#)



Email marketing

Launch professionally branded email campaigns in minutes and monitor engagement with powerful analytics.

[Email marketing features](#)



Affiliate program

Empower your business by creating your own affiliate program and turning your customers into a sales team.

[How affiliates work](#)

Design Guidelines

Minimise interaction cost

Interaction cost is the sum of physical and mental effort required to achieve a task

Looking, scrolling, searching, reading, clicking, waiting, typing, thinking, and remembering all add to interaction cost

The higher the interaction cost, the harder it is for someone to achieve their task

How to minimise interaction cost

Keep related actions close

According to Fitts's Law, the closer and larger a target, the faster it is to click on that target

Keep actions close to the element they relate to and try to ensure they have a sufficient target area (at least 48pt by 48pt is a safe size)

How to minimise interaction cost

Reduce distractions

Attention grabbing distractions like animated banners, pop-ups, and unnecessary visuals, can pull people's attention away from the task they're trying to complete

How to minimise interaction cost

Minimise choice

According to Hick's Law, the time it takes to make a decision increases with the number and complexity of choices

Reduce choices to speed up decisions

Highlight a smaller set of recommended or popular items to help people make decisions faster

Example

Removing unnecessary form fields can make forms faster and easier to complete



Design tips emailed to you weekly

Subscribe to join 6,899 designers getting practical design tips each week.

Required fields are marked with an asterisk *

First name *

Company name *

Email *

Subscribe



Design tips emailed to you weekly

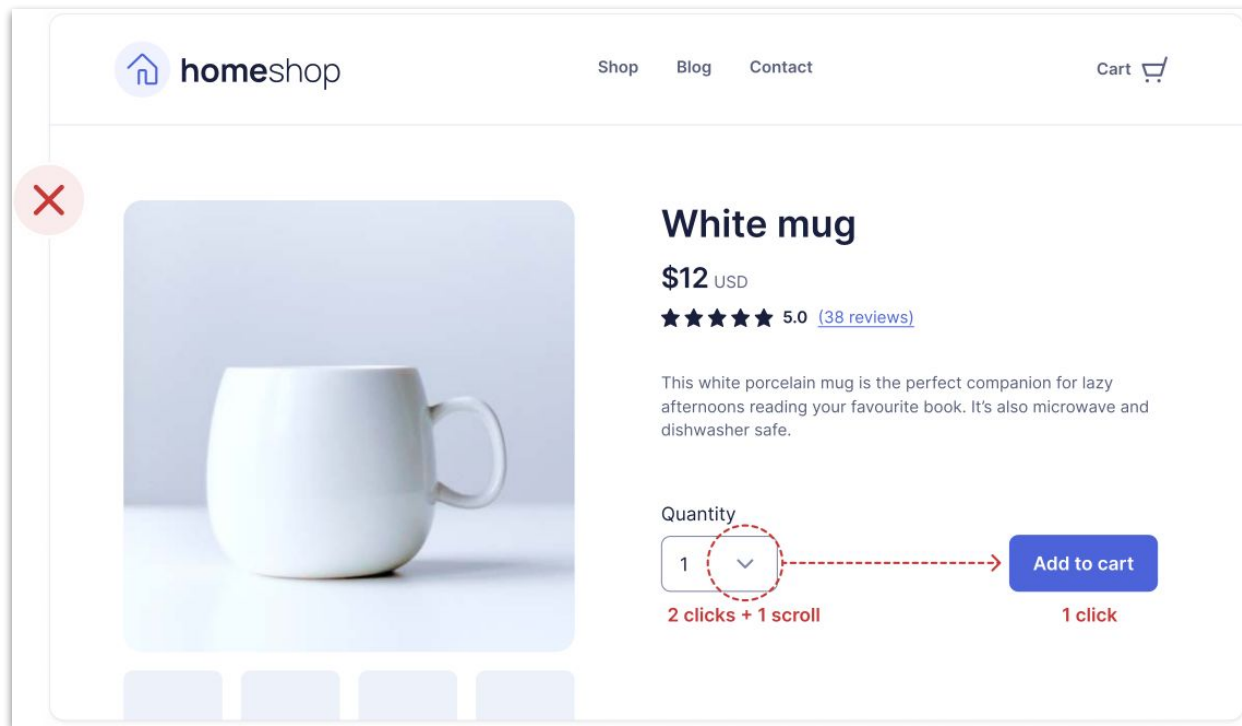
Subscribe to join 6,899 designers getting practical design tips each week.

Email

Subscribe

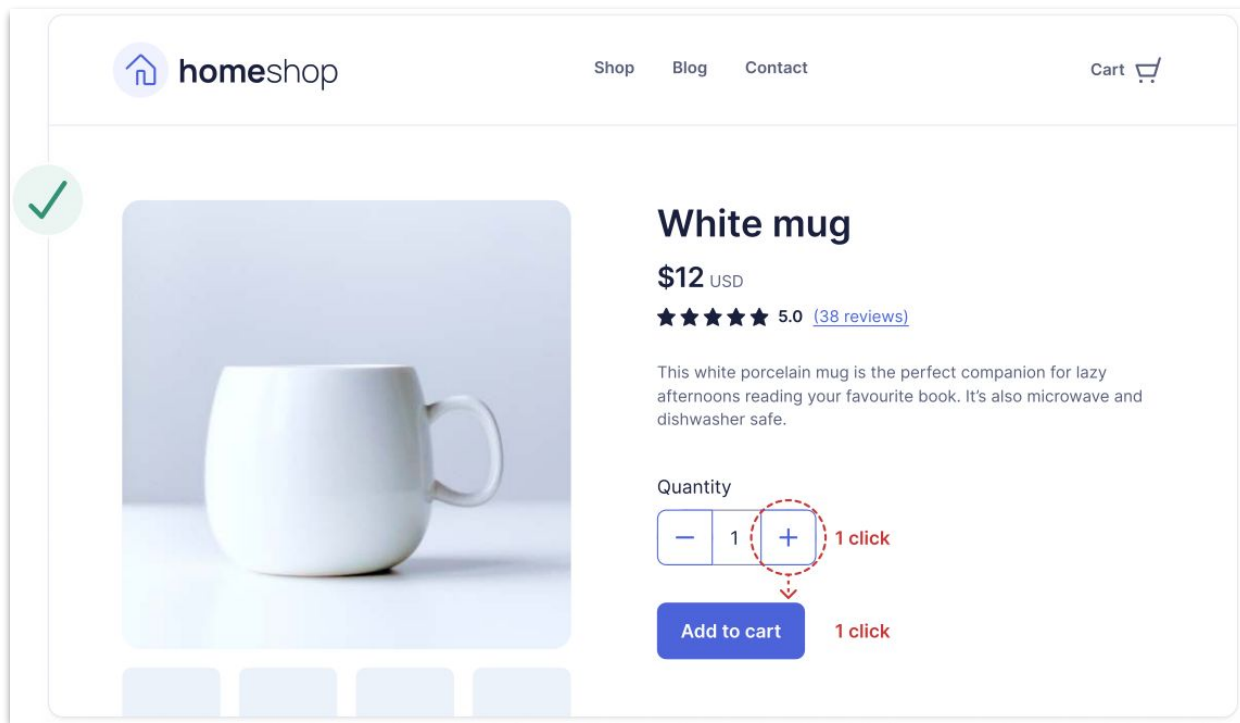
Example

High interaction cost



Example

Reduced interaction cost



Design Guidelines

Minimise cognitive load

Cognitive load is the amount of brain power required to use an interface

Minimise cognitive load to make your interface as easy to use as possible

How to reduce unnecessary cognitive load

Remove unnecessary styles, information, and decisions to reduce distractions

Break up information into smaller groups to clearly show relationships and speed up decision making

Use conventional design patterns that people are familiar with

Maintain consistency by ensuring that similar elements look and work in a similar way

Create a clear visual hierarchy to show the level of importance of information

Example

Why the UI marked  on the right side is better with respect to cognitive load?



Survey

Required fields are marked with an asterisk *

How often do you use our app? *

☐ Daily

☐ Weekly

☐ Monthly

Which of our product features did you find most useful? *

☐ Trend monitoring

☐ Custom reports

☐ User segmentation

☐ Live dashboard

☐ Website builder

☐ Email marketing

Would you recommend our app? *

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Maybe

What would you like to see improved? *

Submit survey



Step 2 of 4

[< Back](#)

SURVEY

Which of our product features did you find most useful?

☐ Trend monitoring

☐ Custom reports

☐ User segmentation

☐ Live dashboard

☐ Website builder

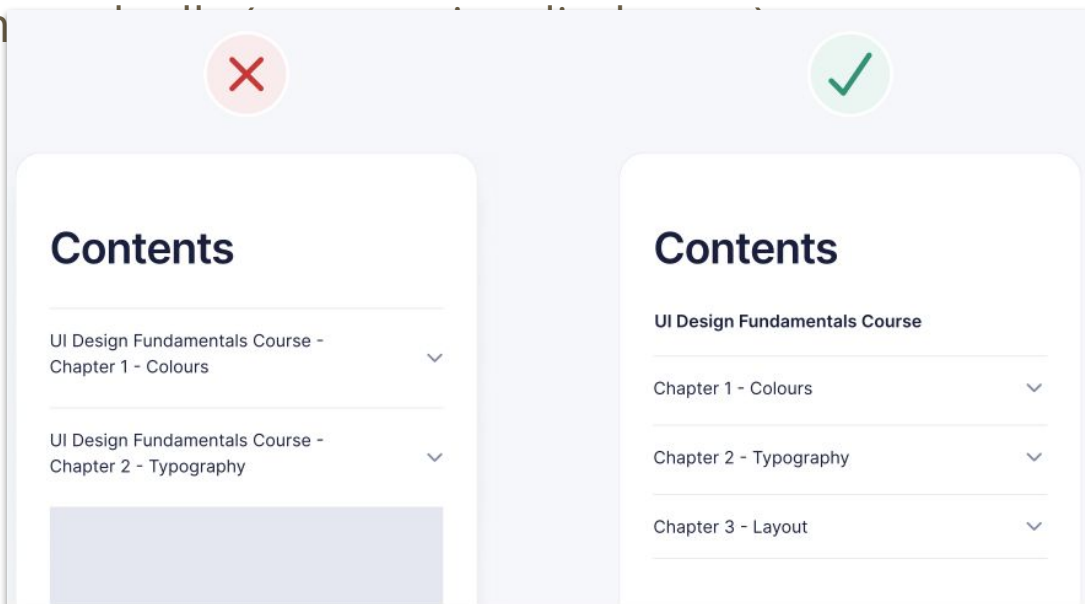
☐ Email marketing

Continue

Example

Why the UI marked ✓ on the right side is better with respect to cognitive load?

Reveal less important information



Example

Why the UI marked ✓ on the right side is better with respect to cognitive load?

Using progressive disclosure

The mobile number field is displayed on click of the checkbox

The diagram illustrates the concept of progressive disclosure in a user interface. It shows two states of a checkbox labeled "Receive updates via text message". In the first state, the checkbox is unchecked. A red arrow points down to the second state, where the checkbox is checked. A blue line connects the checked checkbox to a text input field labeled "Mobile number *", demonstrating how the input field is only revealed when the user selects the option.

☐ Receive updates via text message

↓

☒ Receive updates via text message

Mobile number *

Example

Why the UI marked ✓ on the right side is better with respect to cognitive load?

Using progressive disclosure

✗



×

Strengthen your brand with a custom domain

Look professional and help your customers find you online by adding a custom domain.

Benefits of a custom domain

Unlock the full potential of your online presence with the numerous benefits a custom domain brings to your digital identity. A custom domain not only enhances your brand's professionalism but also fosters trust among your audience.

- ✓ Boost search engine visibility
- ✓ Improve credibility and build trust
- ✓ Strengthen your brand

Secure your custom domain today and take the first step towards a stronger online presence.

Add domain

×

✓



×

Strengthen your brand with a custom domain

Look professional and help your customers find you online by adding a custom domain.

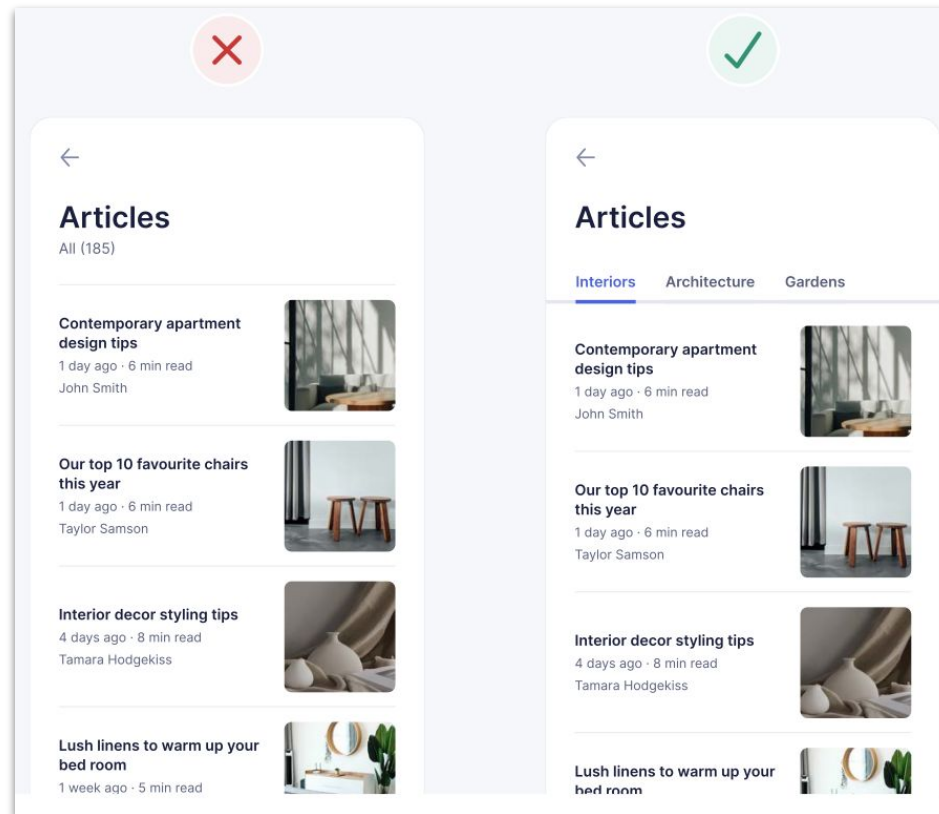
[Benefits of a custom domain](#) ▾

Add domain

×

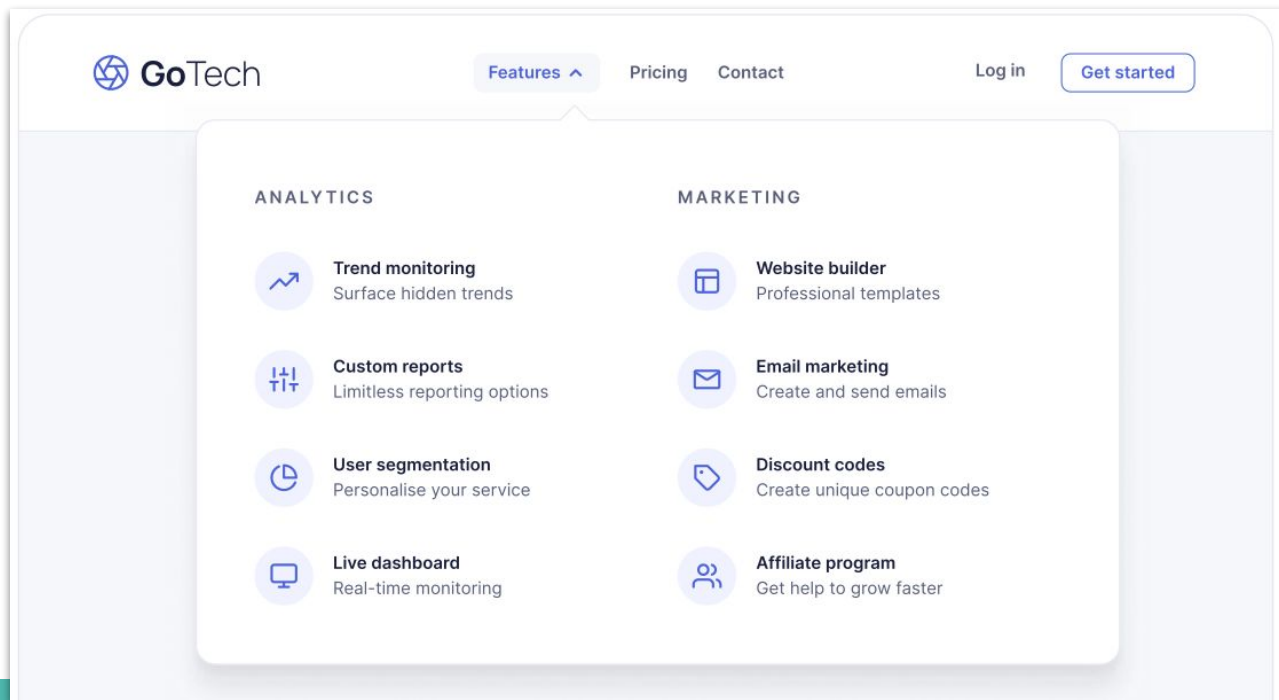
Example

Reduce the number and complexity of choices people need to make by grouping or categorising the options



Example

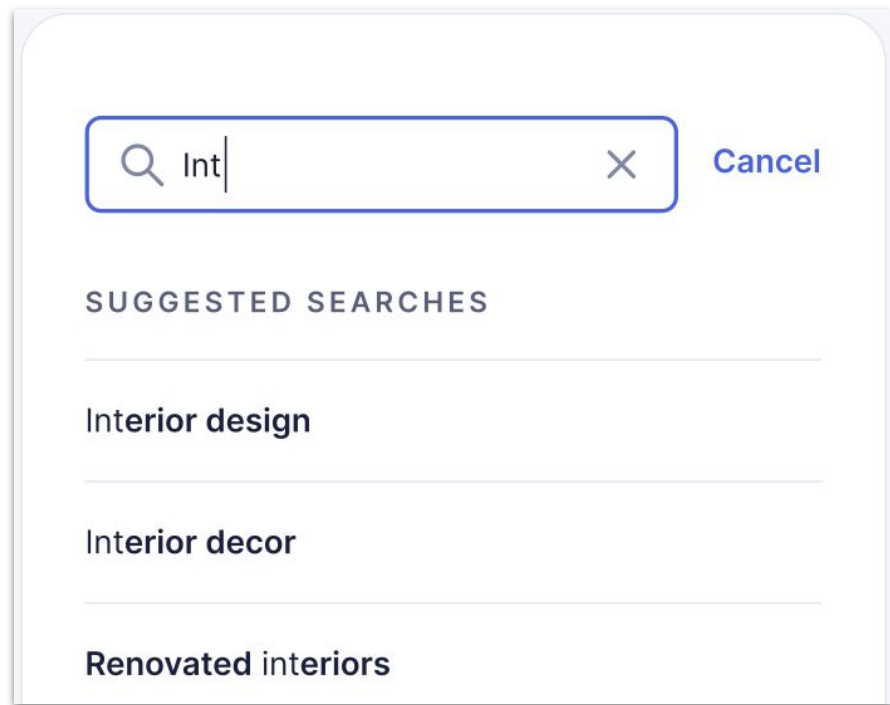
To make large, complex tasks seem less overwhelming, break them up into multiple smaller steps



Example

Video streaming websites often recommend popular videos

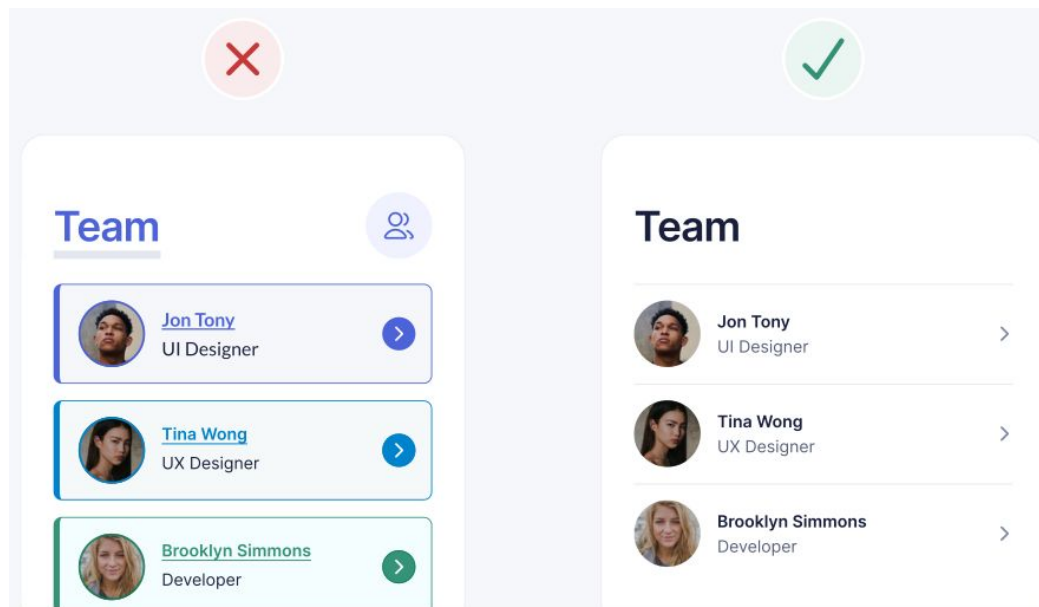
Search boxes often suggest common search terms to help people narrow down their search faster



A search interface example. At the top is a search bar with a magnifying glass icon on the left, the text 'Int' in the center, and a close 'X' icon on the right. To the right of the search bar is a blue 'Cancel' button. Below the search bar is the heading 'SUGGESTED SEARCHES' in a bold, dark blue font. Underneath this heading are three horizontal lines, each followed by a suggested search term: 'Interior design', 'Interior decor', and 'Renovated interiors'.

Example

Remove unnecessary styles



Design Guidelines

Use common design patterns

According to Jakob's Law, it's safest to stick with common or conventional design patterns that people are already familiar with

Design patterns are established solutions to recurring problems

Using common design patterns is a quick and easy way to reduce usability issues, cognitive load, and interaction cost

Example

The following accordion component is a common design pattern used to save space when displaying information

Frequently asked questions

If you have any other questions or feedback, please [contact me](#) and I'll get back to you shortly.

Is UX design covered too?



Does this book cover UI design for apps or websites?



Who is this book for?



Example

Unconventional form field styles
versus conventional form field
styles

✗

←

Payment details

Credit card

Paypal

Required fields are marked with an asterisk *

Name on card *

Card number *

Expiry date *

CVC *

Pay \$99.00

✓

←

Payment details

Credit card

Paypal

Required fields are marked with an asterisk *

Name on card *

Card number *

Expiry date *

CVC *

MM / YY

Pay \$99.00

Design Guidelines

Be consistent

Make similar elements look and work in a similar way

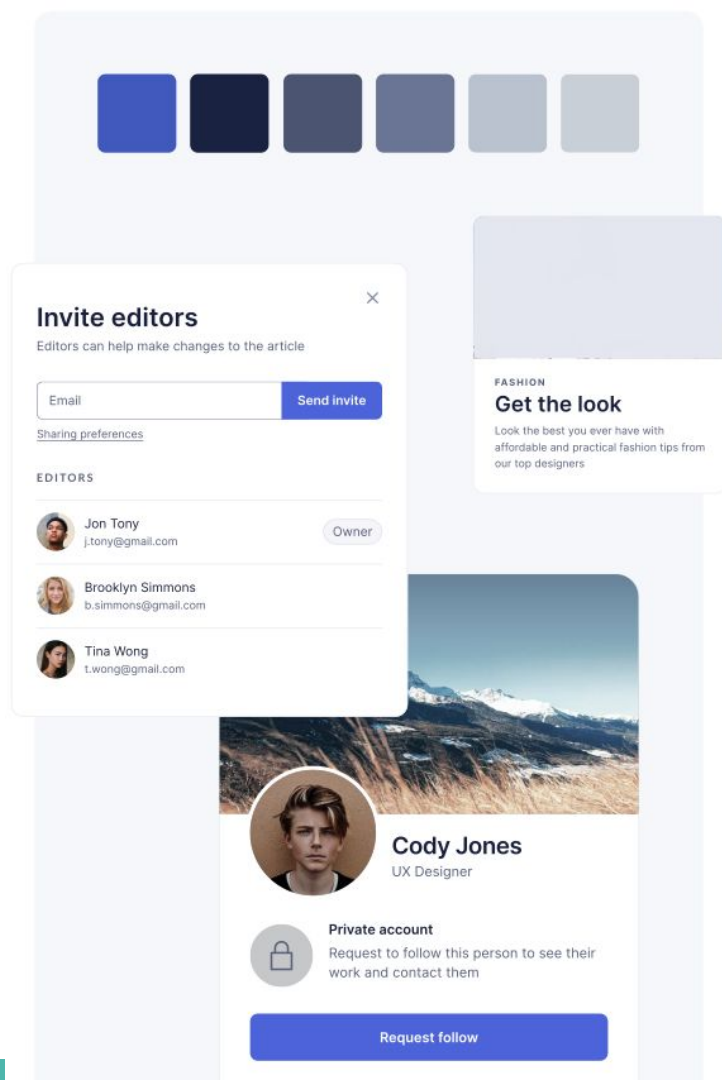
Consistency should be applied both within your product and when compared with other well-established products

Consistency improves usability and reduces errors, as people don't need to keep learning how things work

Design system and design system guideline helps ensure consistency with in your product

Example

Consistency within a product



Example

Consistency with other product

If your product sits on a certain platform, like an app on iOS or Android, it's generally safest to follow the platform guidelines

The image displays a set of UI components arranged in a grid-like fashion, illustrating consistency with platform guidelines. The components are as follows:

- Text Inputs:** Two rectangular input fields. The left one is a standard text box. The right one is a dropdown menu, indicated by a small downward arrow on its right side. Both are preceded by the label "Label *".
- Radio buttons:** A section titled "Radio buttons" containing two options. The first is an unselected radio button followed by the text "Label". The second is a selected radio button (filled with blue) followed by the text "Label".
- Checkboxes:** A section titled "Checkboxes" containing two options. The first is an unselected checkbox followed by the text "Label". The second is a selected checkbox (filled with blue and containing a white checkmark) followed by the text "Label".
- Buttons:** A horizontal row of three buttons at the bottom. The first is a solid blue button with the text "Primary". The second is a white button with a blue border and the text "Secondary". The third is a blue text link with the text "Tertiary".

Design Guidelines

Clearly indicate interaction states

Interactive elements, like buttons and text links should change their appearance when they're interacted with



Default



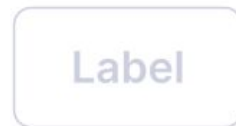
Hover



Press



Focus



Disabled

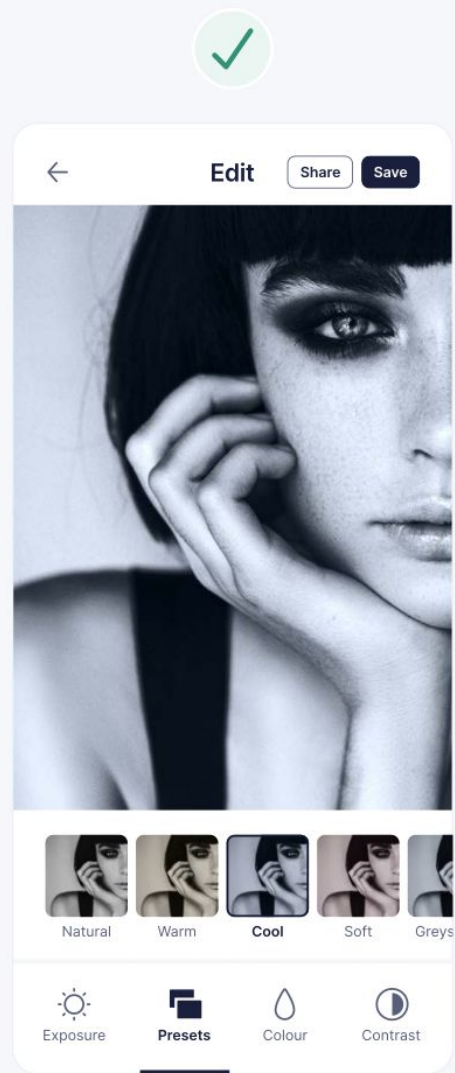
Design Guidelines

Don't confuse minimalism with simplicity

Simplification isn't just about reduction

Removing or hiding too much can harm usability

You need to make sure that you're not removing critical information or details

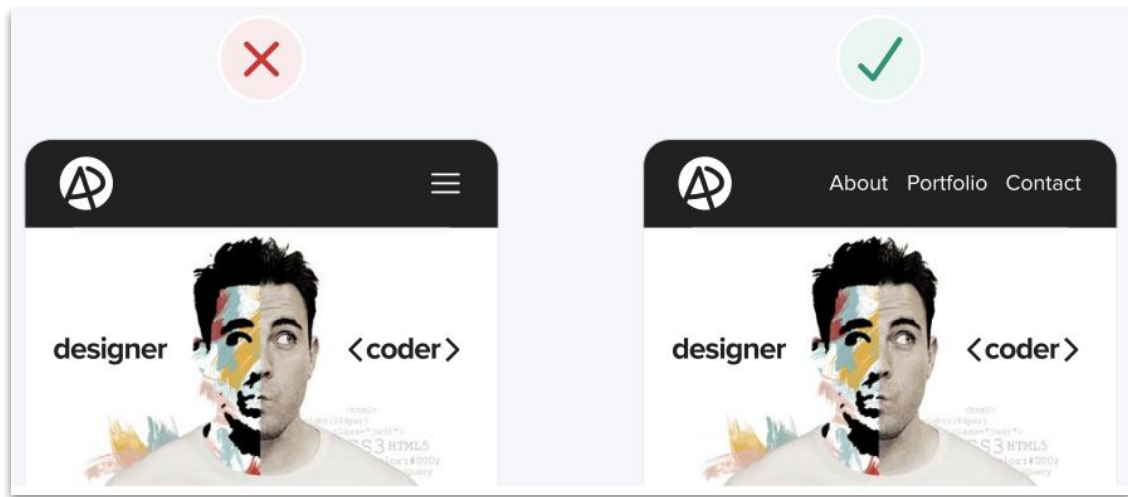


Design Guidelines

Make sure important content is visible

People don't use what they can't see

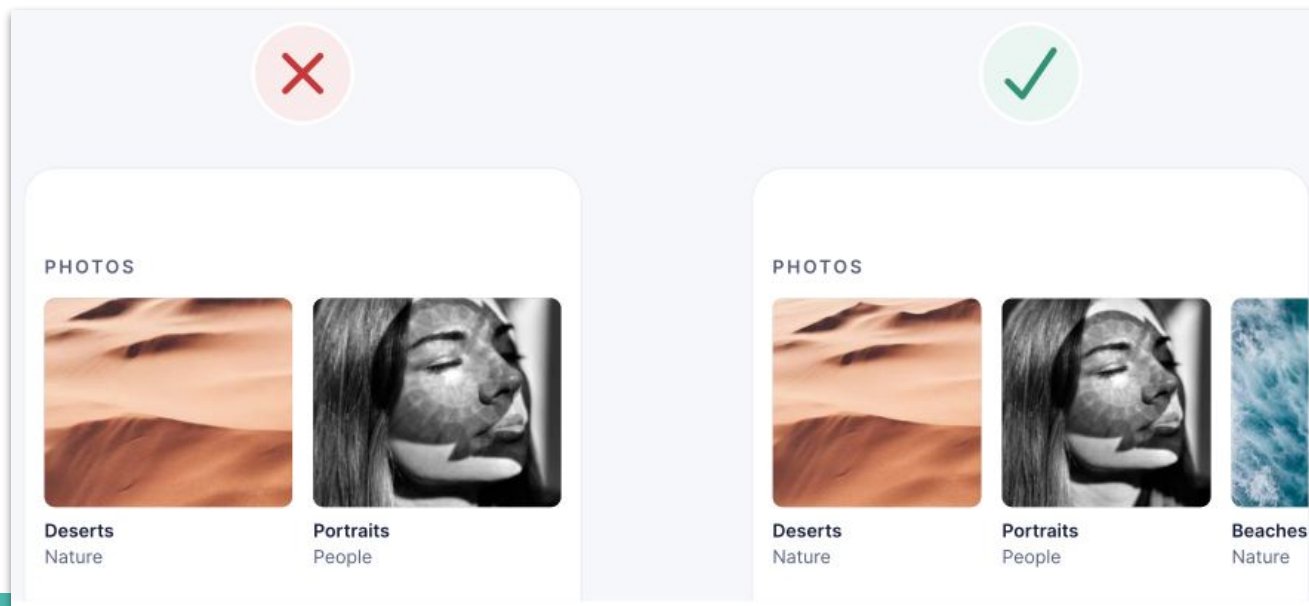
Hiding things behind interactive menus is risky, as some people might miss those things



Design Guidelines

Make sure important content is visible

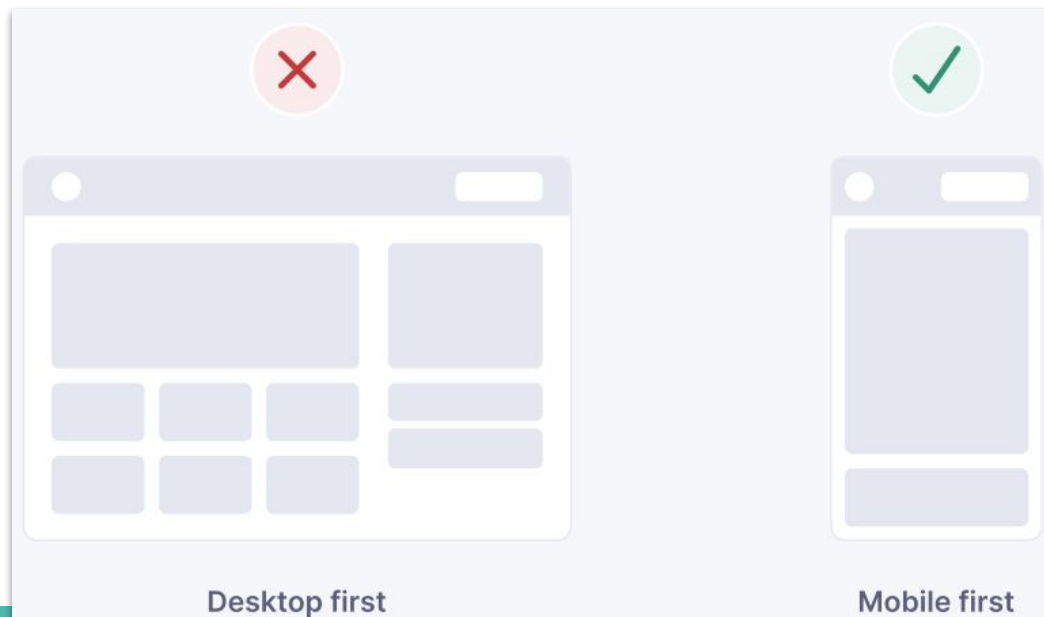
If you need to hide content due to space constraints, make sure it's discoverable



Design Guidelines

Design for the smallest screen first

The restricted space forces you to prioritise important elements and remove unnecessary ones



Design Guidelines

Create a design system

When designing an interface, there are so many options to choose from regarding layout, spacing, typography, and color

Having a system of predefined options and guidelines helps to make efficient design decisions

How to create a Design System

Use the following steps to create a Design System

- Set predefined style options

- Create reusable modules

- Define usage guidelines

Set predefined style options

Rather than choosing from unlimited options for things like color, typography, and spacing, create a small set of predefined options to choose from

Limiting your options helps improve consistency and speeds up decision making

These predefined reusable options are often referred to as “**tokens**”

Example: Set predefined style options

Color Options

Brand				
Text strong	Text weak	Stroke strong	Stroke weak	Fill

Example: Set predefined style options

Typography options

TYPE SCALE (1.200)	SIZE	LINE HEIGHT
Heading 1	40px	48px
Heading 2	32px	40px
Heading 3	24px	32px
Heading 4	20px	28px
Small	16px	24px
Tiny	14px	20px

Example: Set predefined style options

Spacing options

XS

8pt



S

16pt



M

24pt



L

32pt



XL

48pt



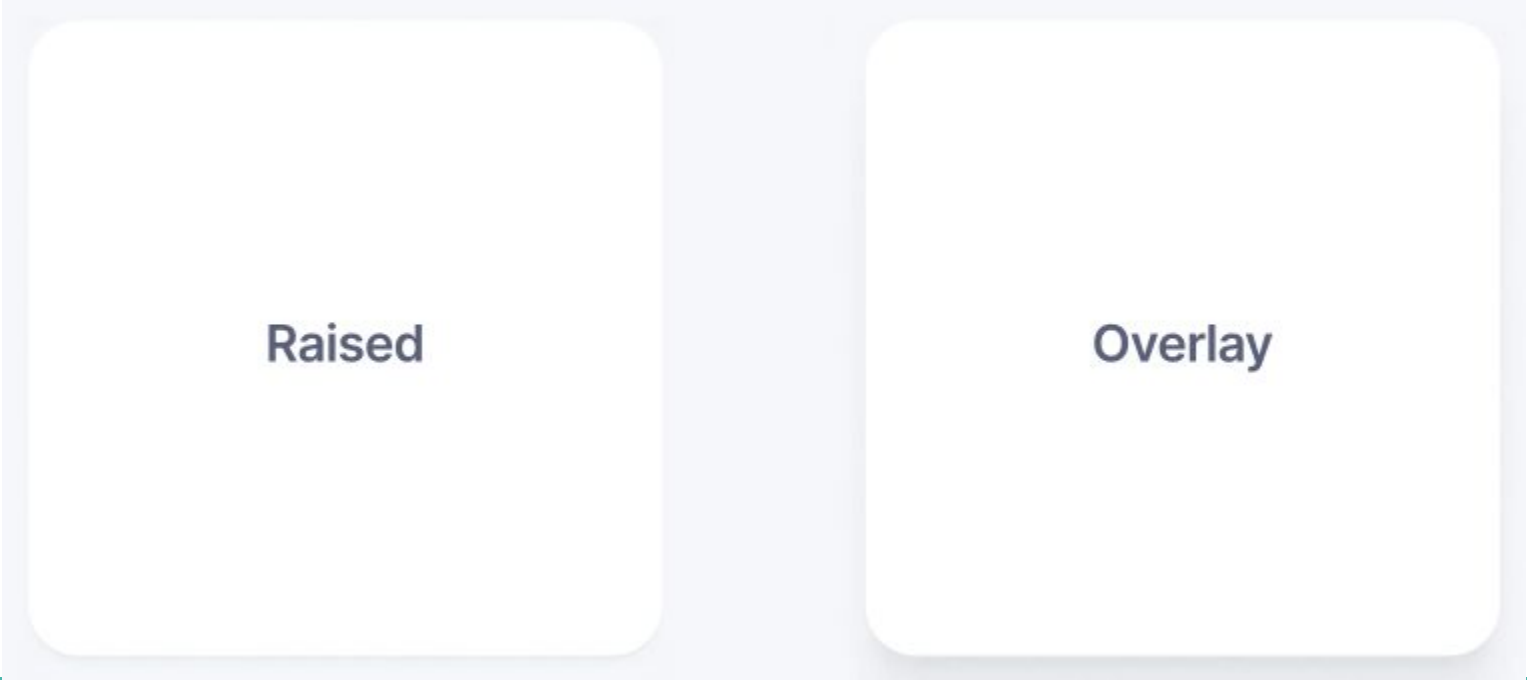
XXL

80pt



Example: Set predefined style options

Shadow options



The diagram consists of a light gray rectangular container. Inside this container are two white rounded squares. The left square is labeled 'Raised' and has a subtle gray drop shadow beneath it. The right square is labeled 'Overlay' and has a more pronounced gray drop shadow beneath it, making it appear to float above the background.

Raised

Overlay

Example: Set predefined style options

Border radius options

Small
8pt

Medium
16pt

Large
32pt

Create reusable modules

Modular design involves breaking things down into smaller, reusable, and replaceable parts called modules or components

Aim to design interfaces in a modular way

Modularity helps to improve productivity, efficiency and consistency

The goal is to create a collection of all components, known as a component library or UI kit

How to design interfaces in a modular way

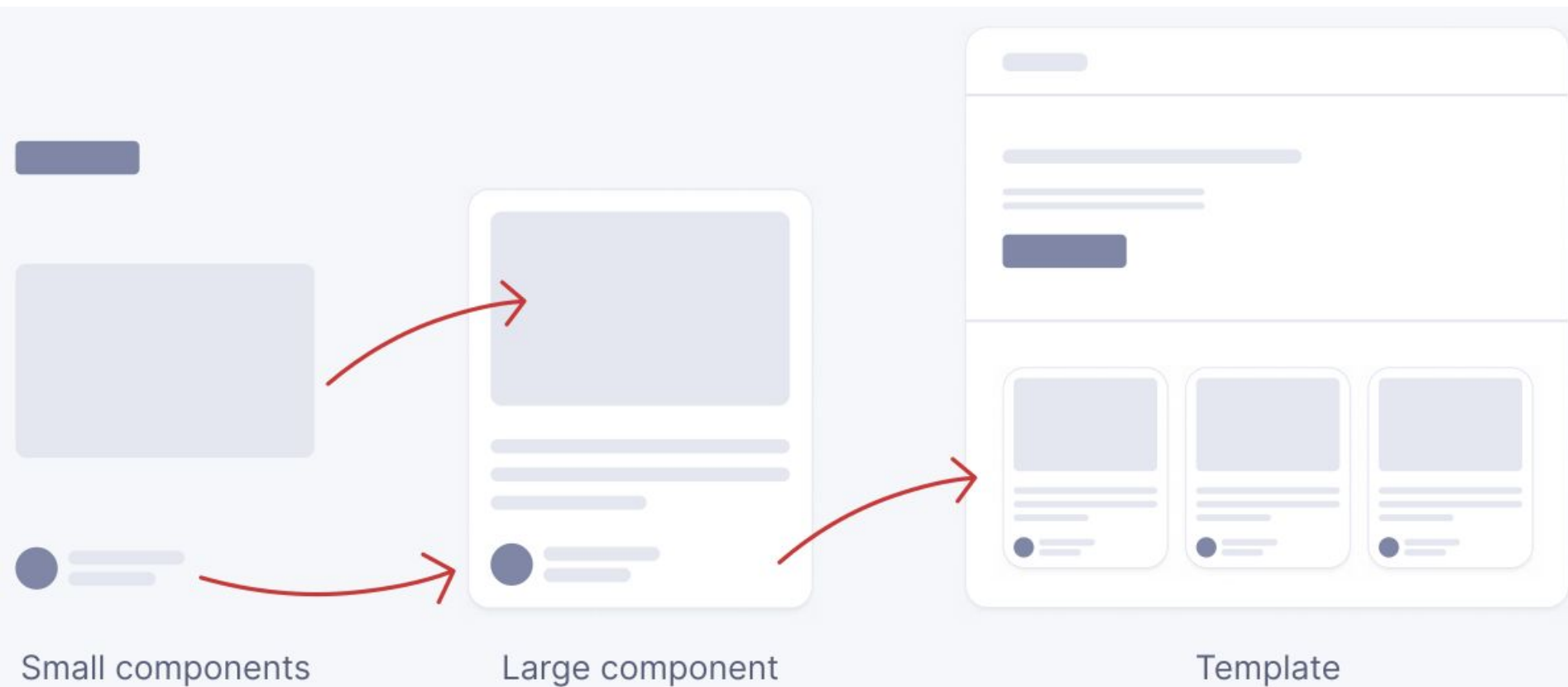
Start by creating the smallest components such as buttons, avatars, and form input fields

These will be your building blocks

Combine small components to create larger, more complex ones

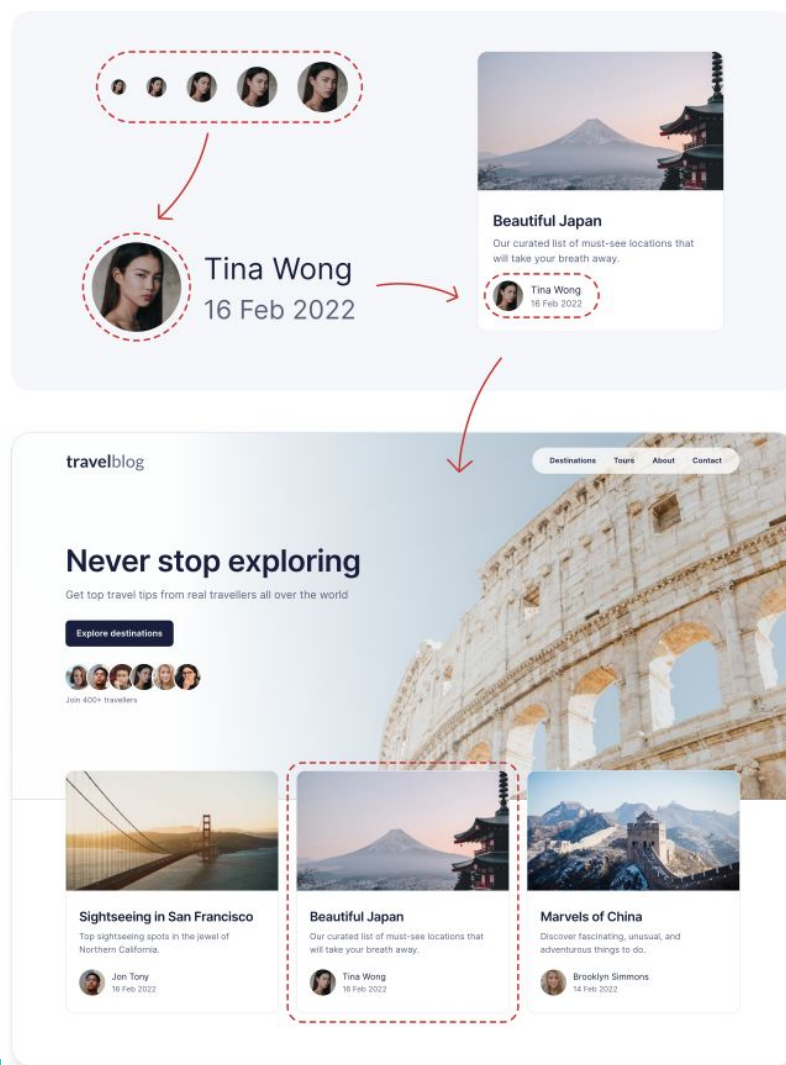
Arrange components in specific layouts to create reusable page templates

Example: Designing interfaces in a modular way



Example

Designing interfaces in a modular way



Define usage guidelines

After/while creating the design systems include guidance on how to use the components and visual styles in the system

Example usage guidelines

Indicate interactive elements using the brand color

Use sentence case

Left align button

Left align text

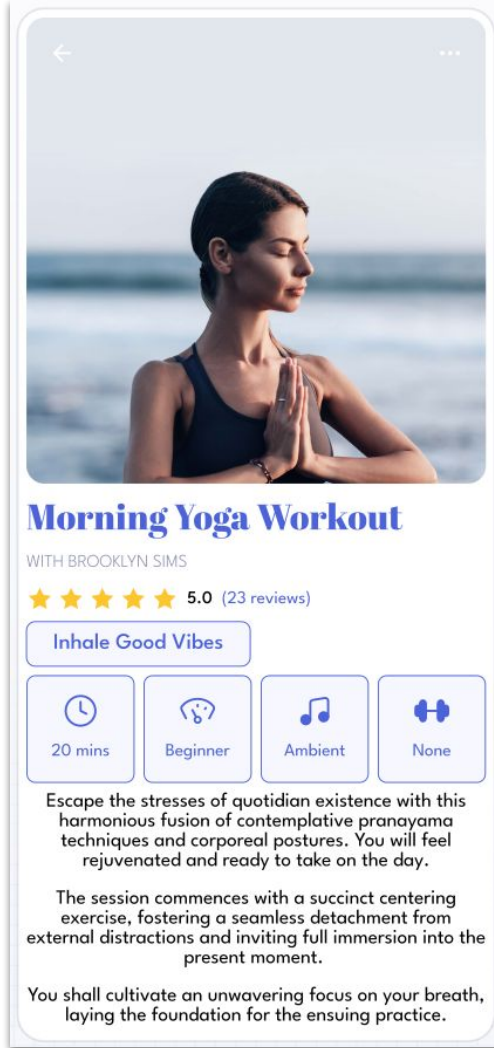
Try to avoid disabled button

Front-load text

Be concise and use plain and simple language

Applying Design Guidelines

Identify design issues on the UI shown on the right

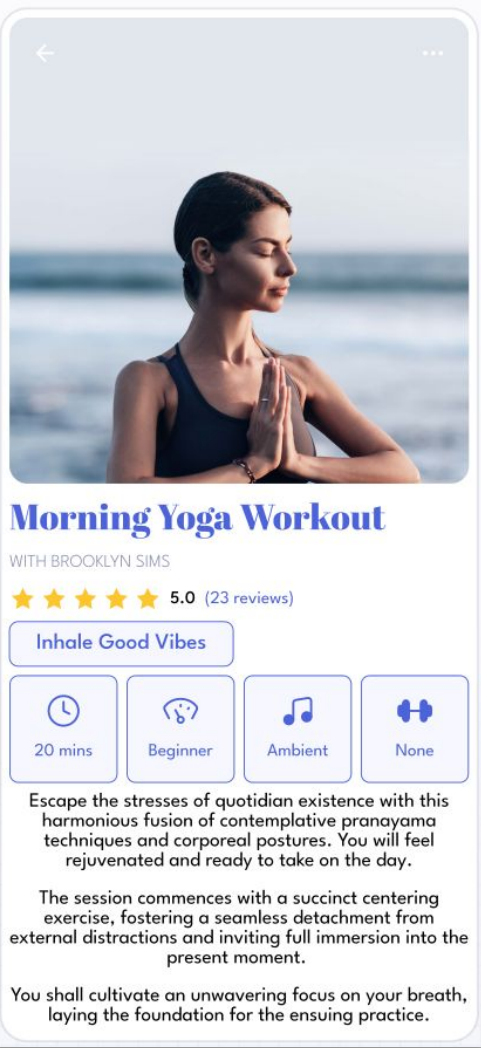


Minimise interaction cost

The main call to action button is relatively small

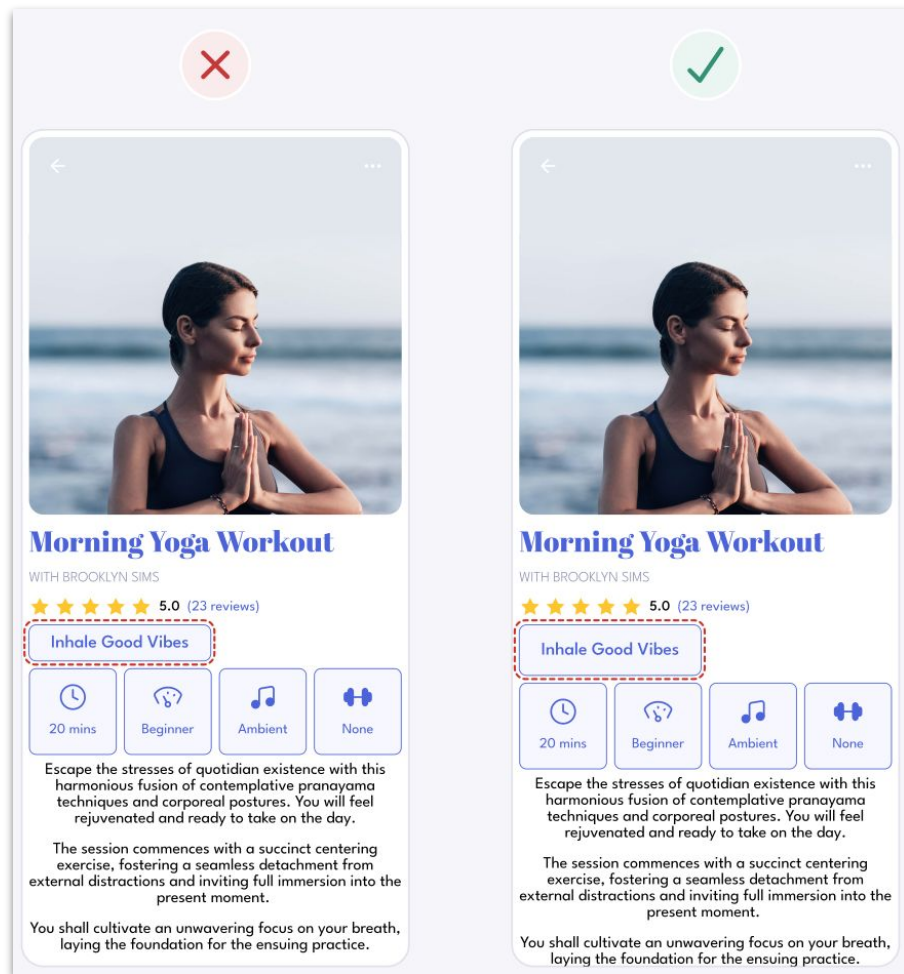
Small targets are more difficult to touch than large ones

This is especially true for those with impaired motor control, or even someone holding their phone with one hand and using their thumb



Minimise interaction cost

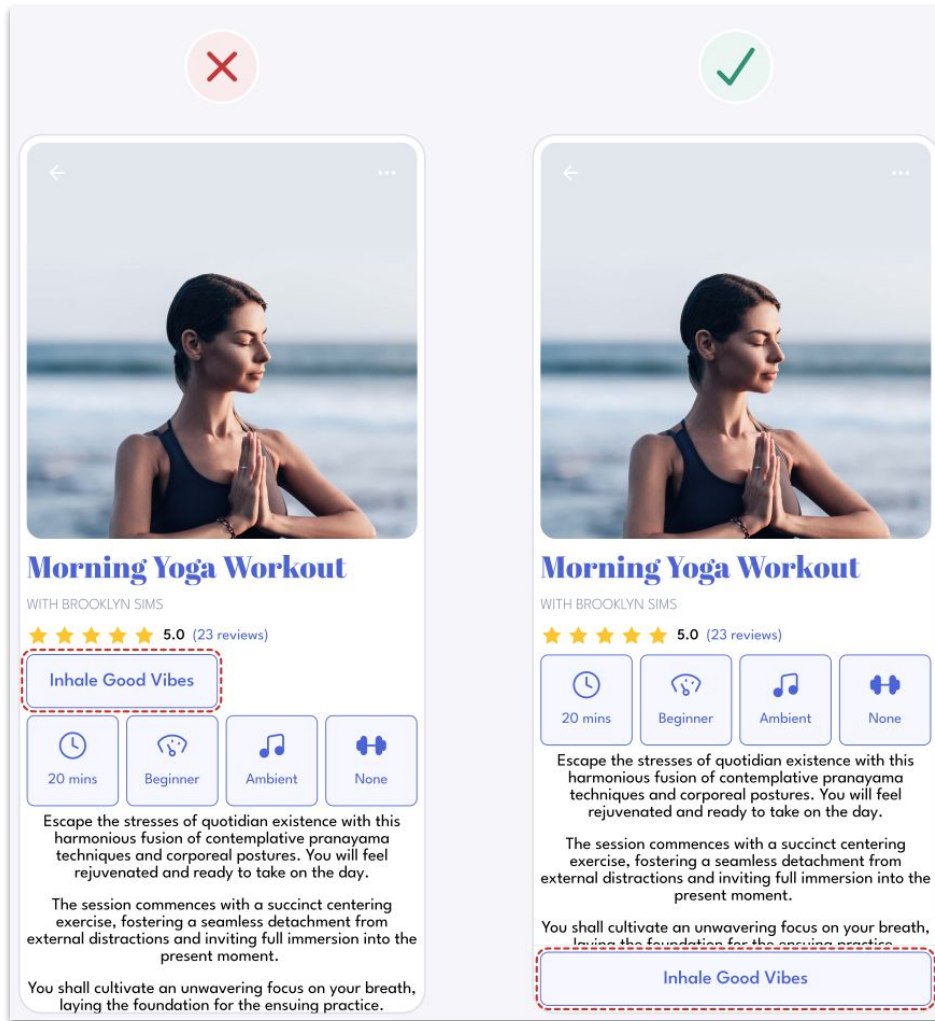
Increasing the button size to at least 48pt tall makes it faster and easier for people to press it



Minimise interaction cost

Moving the button to the bottom of the screen makes it easier to reach for those using one hand

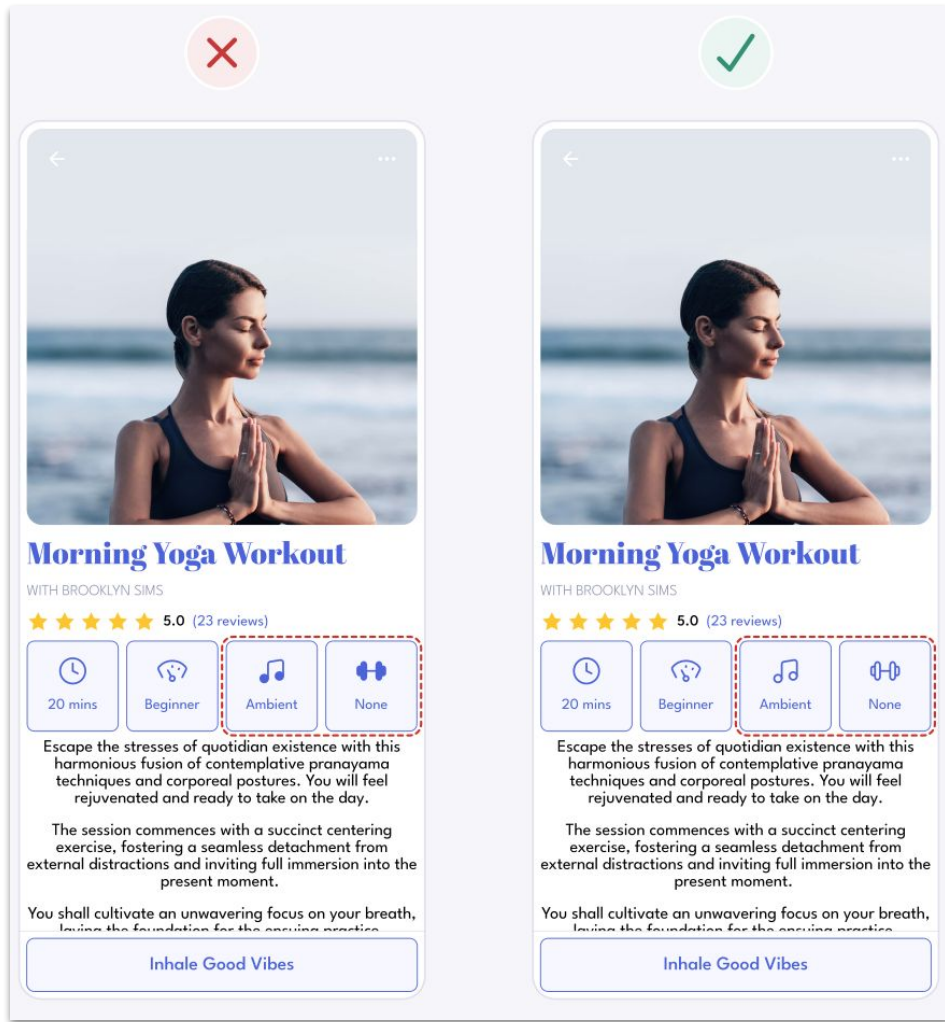
Stretching the button the full-width of the screen helps both left and right handed people to reach it



Minimise interaction cost

The icon styles are inconsistent, as some are filled and others aren't

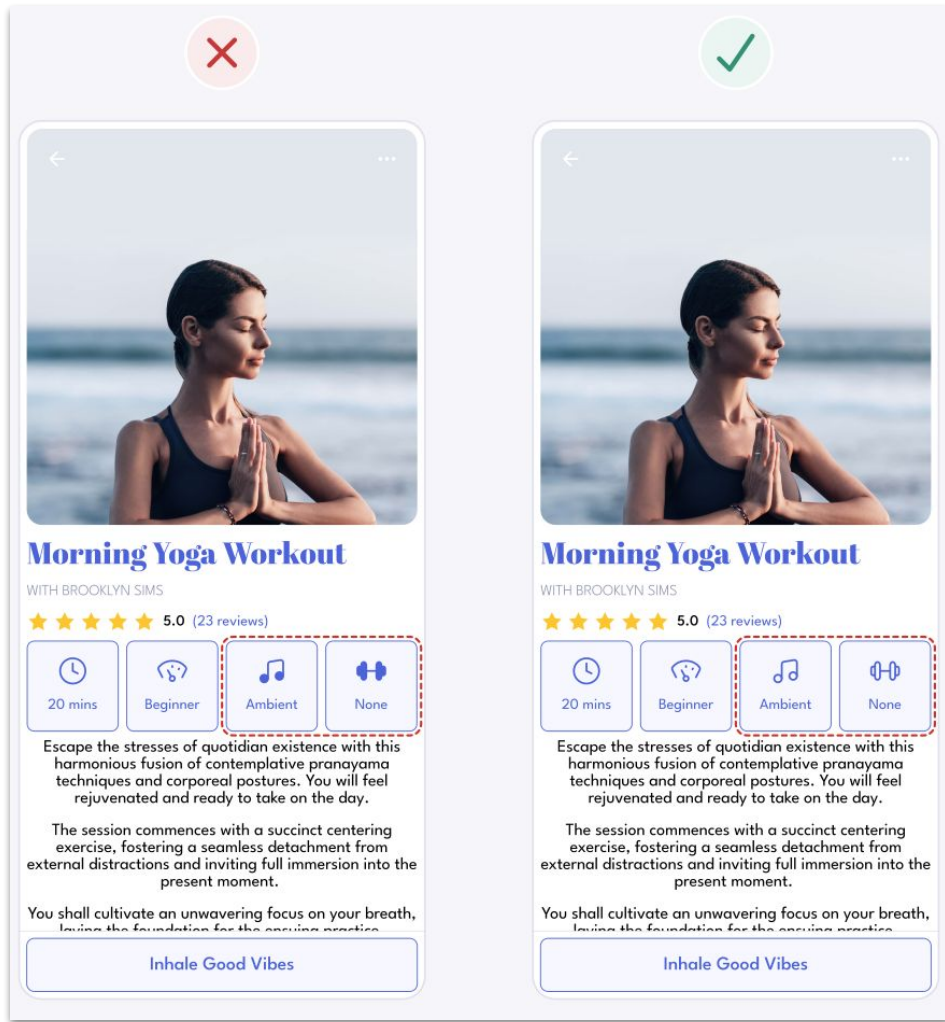
This could confuse some people, as filled icons often indicate that an element is selected



Minimise interaction cost

Sticking with an outlined style for all icons helps improve consistency and gives each icon a similar level of prominence

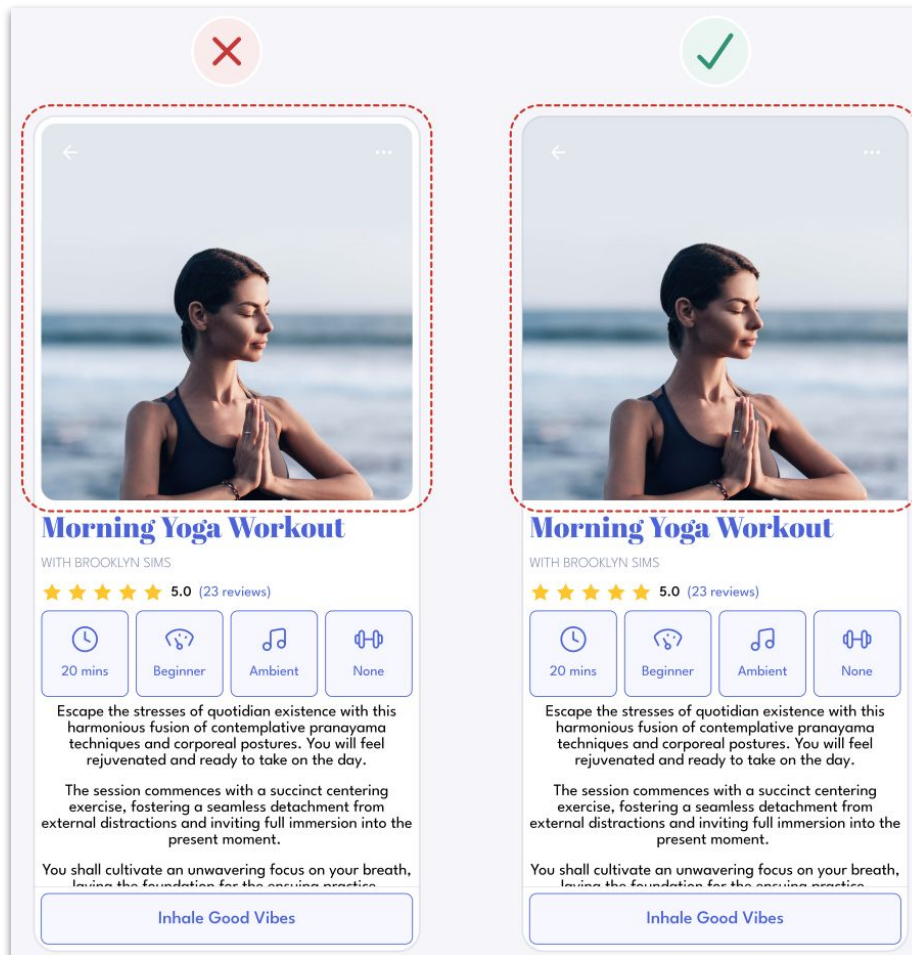
Make the thickness of outlines consistent



Remove unnecessary styles

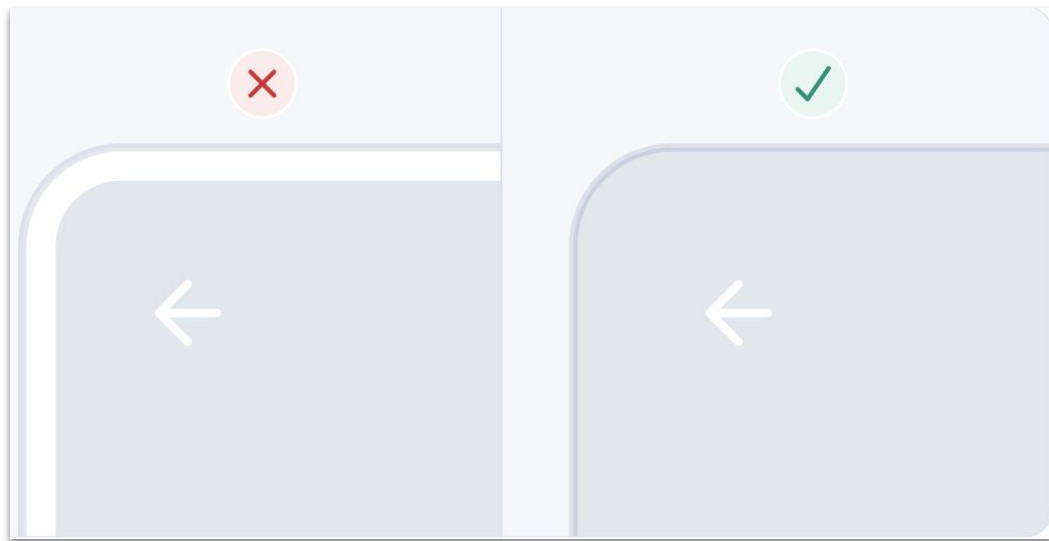
Avoid unnecessary lines, colours, backgrounds, and animations to create a simpler, more focused interface

The white space around the photo adds unnecessary visual complexity. It's not needed to convey information or group elements, so you can safely remove it to simplify the design



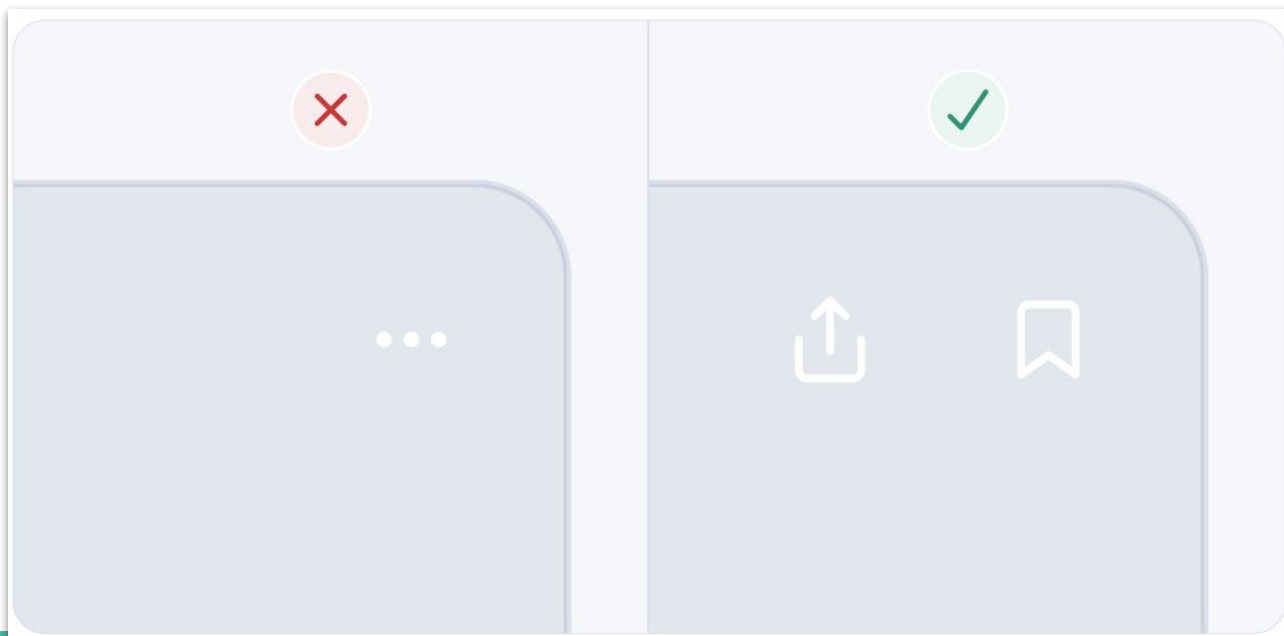
Remove unnecessary styles

White space around the photo is removed to reduce complexity



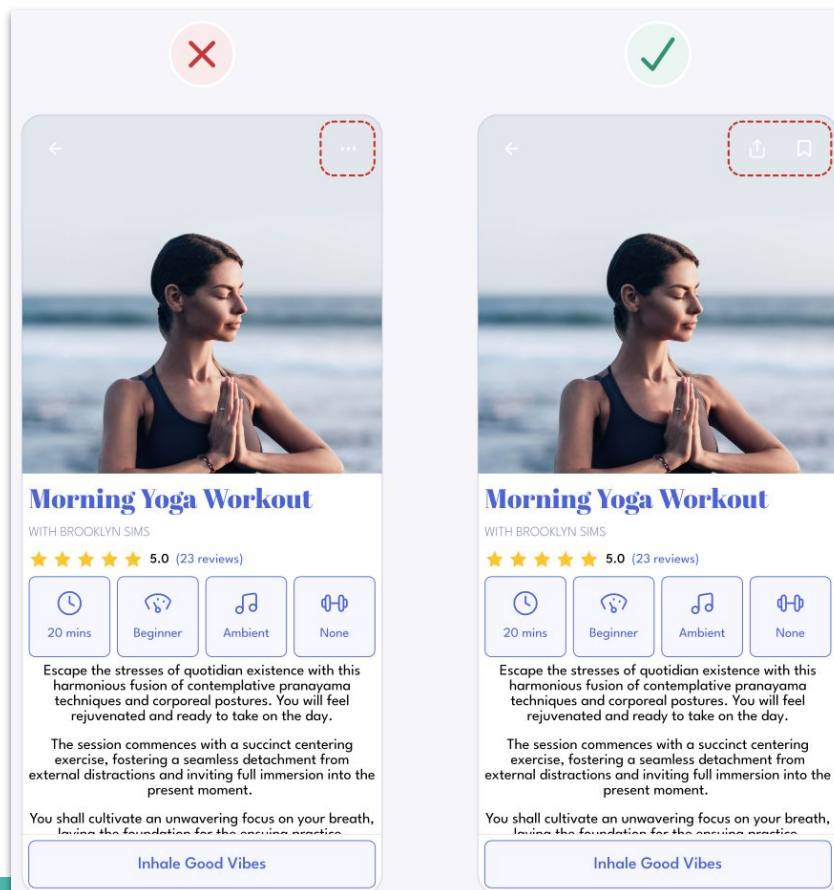
Make important content visible

Since there's space to display the 2 actions, "share" and "bookmark", keep them visible to help ensure they're not missed



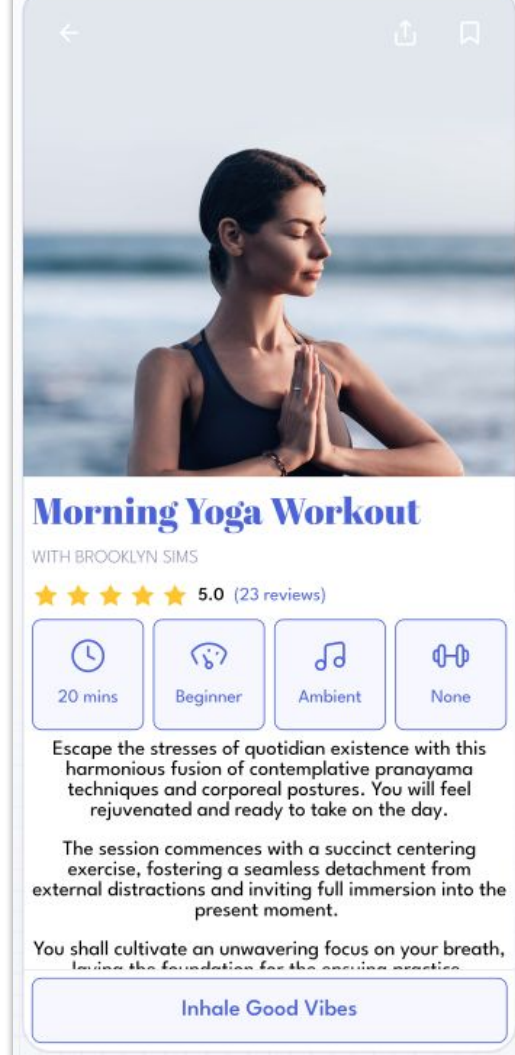
Make important content visible

Actions are made visible, rather than being hidden inside an interactive menu



Color Usage Guidelines

Are there any color related issues on the UI displayed?



Ensure sufficient contrast

Contrast is a measure of the difference in perceived brightness between two colors

It's expressed as a ratio ranging from 1 : 1 to 21 : 1

For example, black text on a black background has the lowest 1 : 1 contrast ratio, whereas black text on a white background has the highest 21 : 1 ratio

Ensure sufficient contrast

In order to help ensure that people with low vision can clearly see interface details, aim to at least meet Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1 level AA colour contrast requirements

Ensure sufficient contrast

Below are the two WCAG 2.1 level AA color contrast requirements

3:1 - Minimum for large text (above 18px with bold weight or above 24px with regular weight) and user interface elements (like form fields)

4.5:1 - Minimum for small text (18px or less)

Ensure sufficient contrast

WCAG 2.1 level AA color contrast requirements

3 : 1

Large text

24px regular & above
18px bold & above

UI elements

Like form inputs, radio
buttons, & checkboxes.

4.5 : 1

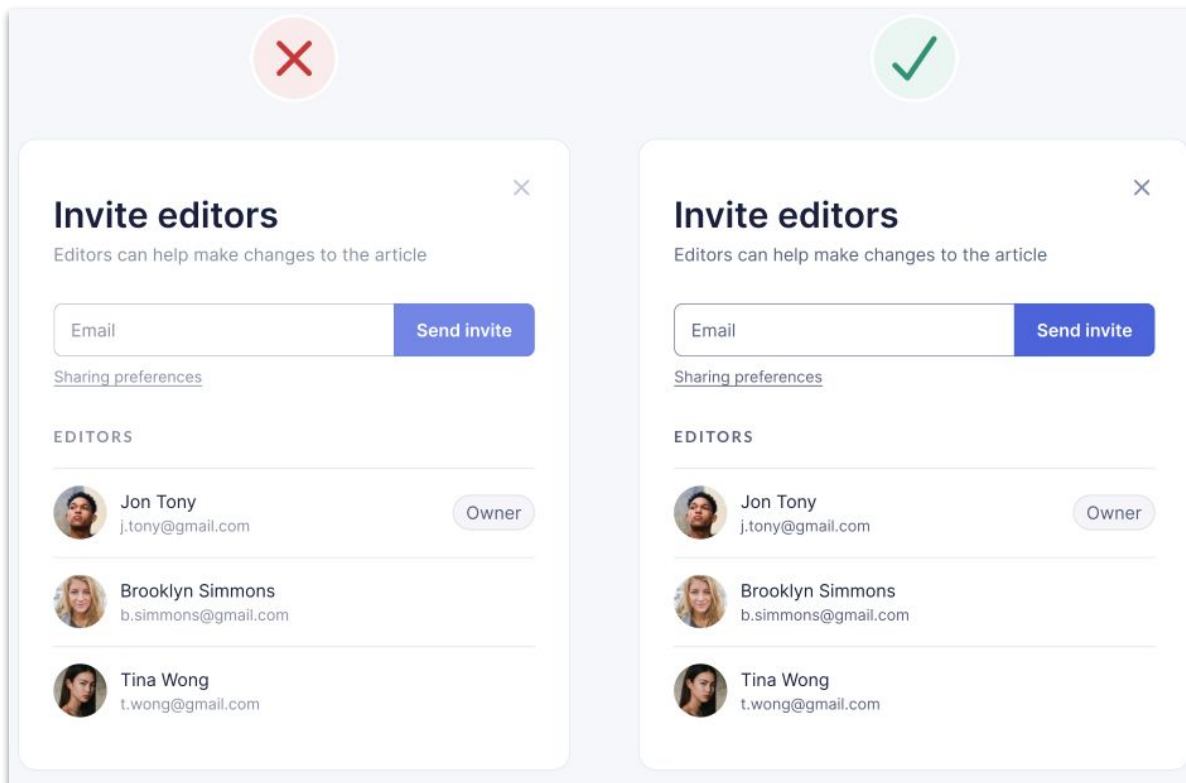
Small text

18px or less

Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

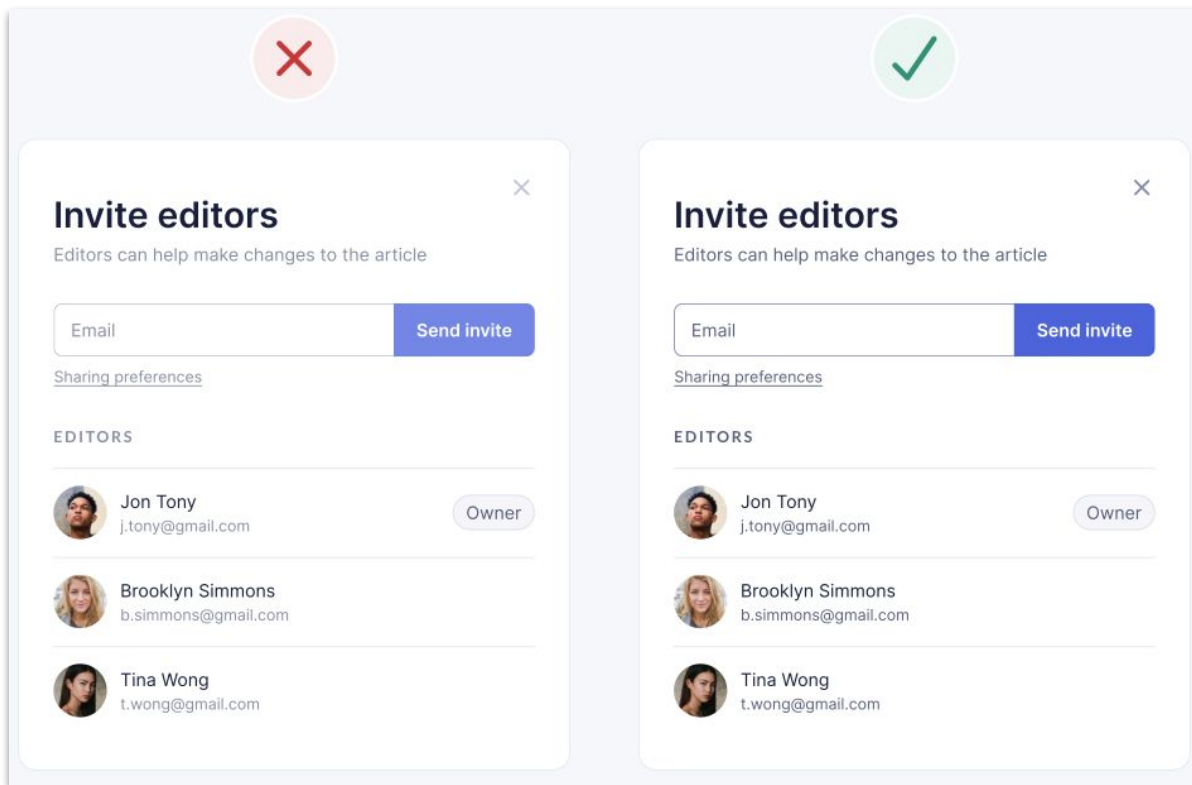
Identify the contrast issues



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

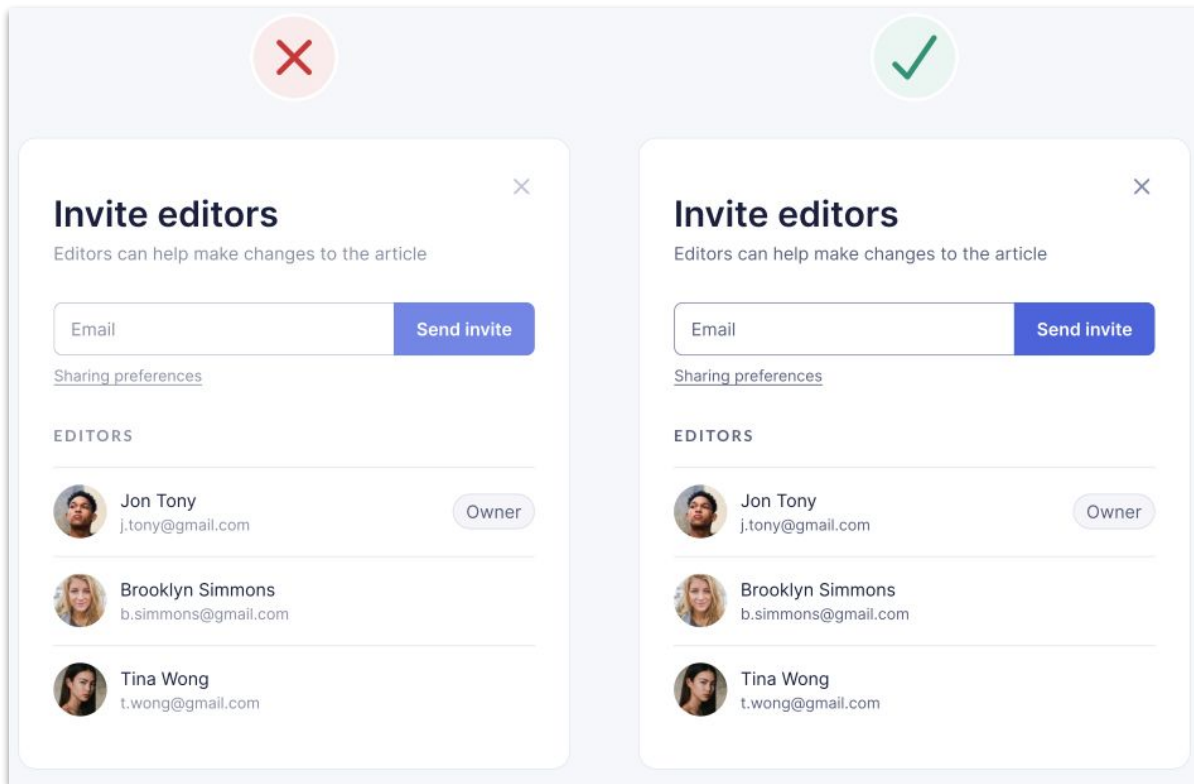
**Close icon contrast is less
than 3:1**



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

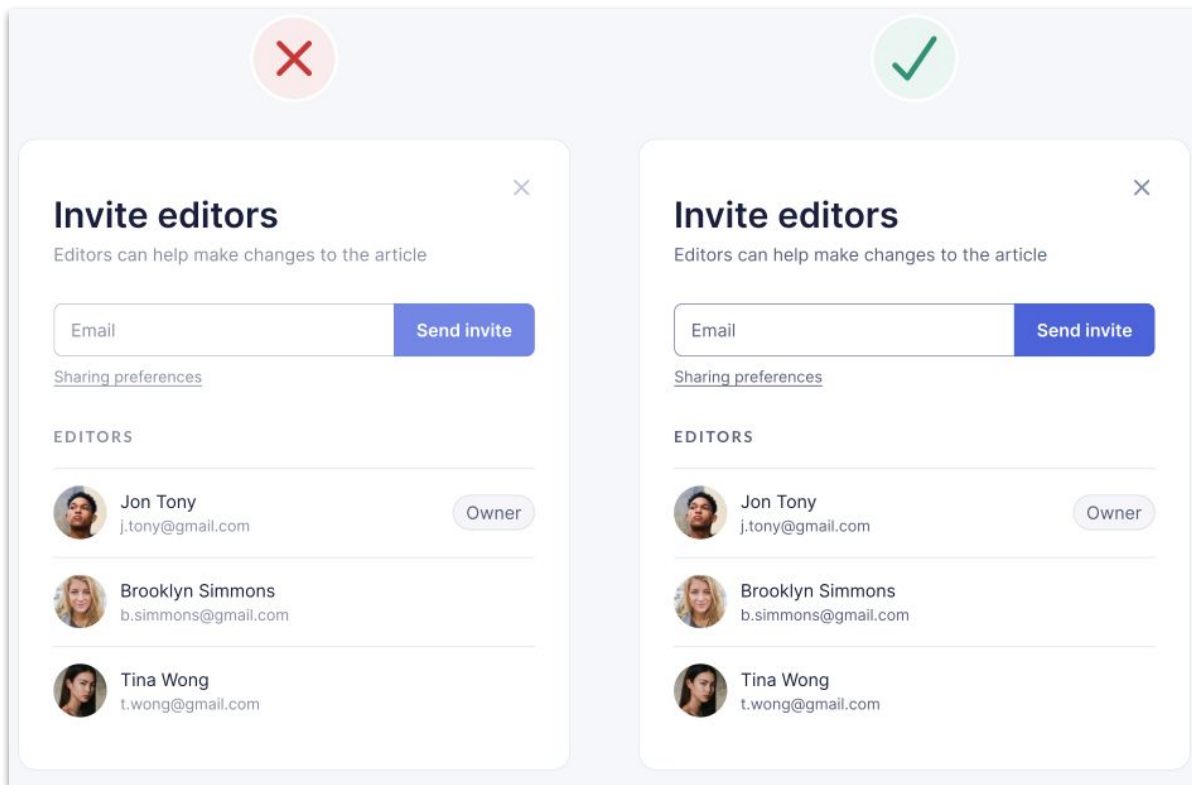
**Secondary text contrast is
less than 4.5:1**



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

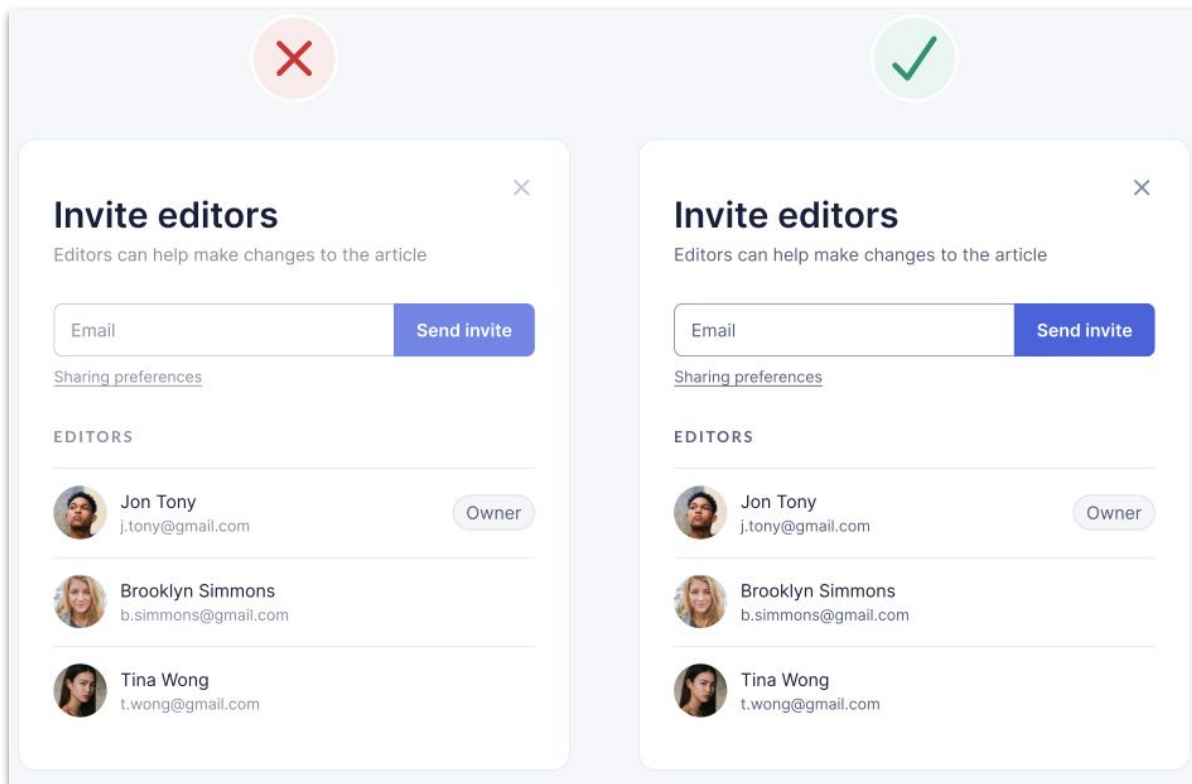
**Email field border
contrast ratio is less than
3:1**



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

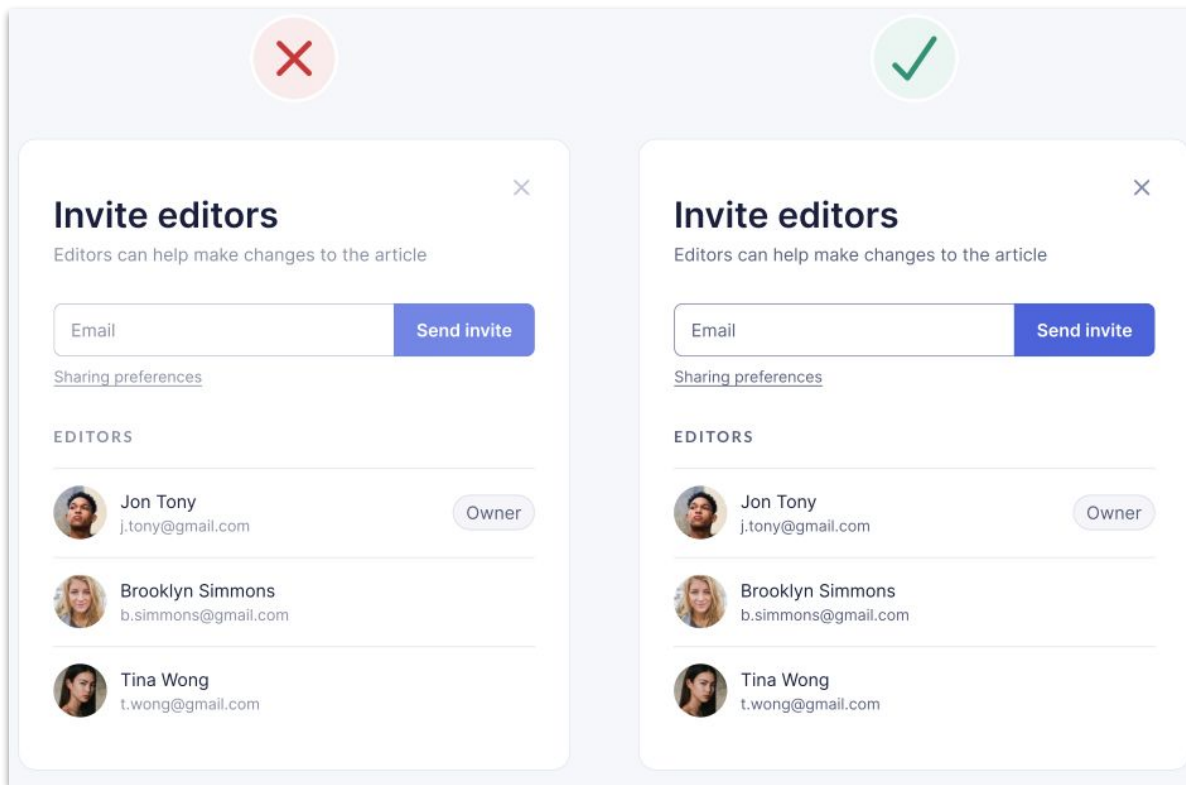
**Placeholder text in the
email field is less than
4.5:1**



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

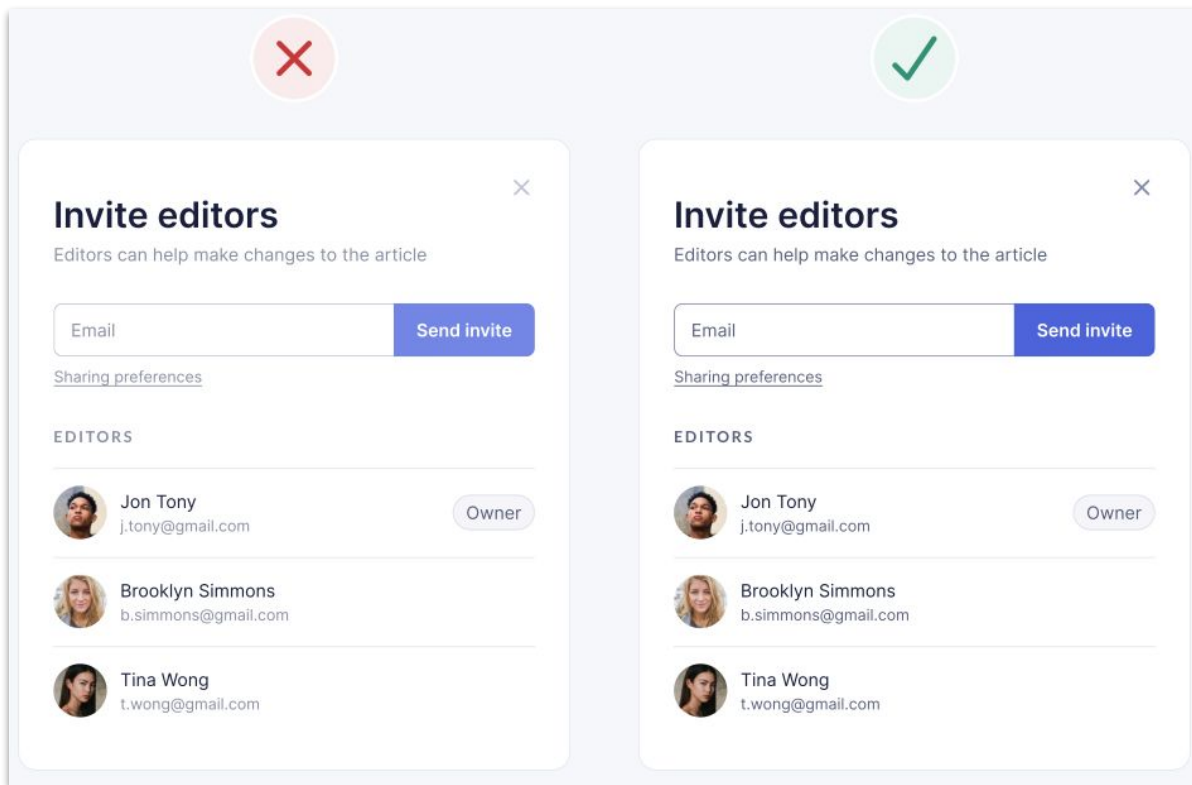
**Button background
contrast against white
text is less than 4.5:1**



Example

Low contrast interface
versus a high contrast
interface

**Link text contrast is less
than 4.5:1**



Accessible Perceptual Contrast Algorithm (APCA)

It is a new and improved way to measure contrast

It's part of the WCAG 3 draft and it helps solve some of the limitations of the WCAG 2 method

APCA vs WCAG 2

In the example shown, white text on an orange background fails WCAG 2, while black text passes

Using APCA, the white text passes and the black text fails. This matches our actual perception of the text

	Easier to read	Harder to read
		
WCAG 2	3.04 : 1 Fail	4.5 : 1 Pass
APCA	62 Pass	43 Fail

Accessible Perceptual Contrast Algorithm (APCA)

APCA contrast is measured in numbers

The higher the number, the higher the contrast

The APCA contrast value also depends on the size and weight of text

Smaller and thinner text gets a lower score

APCA key contrast values for neutral grey

90 - Preferred for body text (14px regular and above)

75 - Minimum for body text (18px regular and above)

60 - Minimum for other text (24px regular or 16px bold and above)



15



30



45



60



75



90

APCA key contrast values for neutral grey

45 - Minimum for large text (36px regular or 24px bold and above) and interface elements

30 - Absolute minimum for text like form field placeholder text and disabled button text

15 - Minimum for non-text elements



15



30



45



60



75



90

Accessible Perceptual Contrast Algorithm (APCA)

The APCA contrast measurement differs depending on whether the color is being used on text or a background

For example, white text on a blue background passes, while blue text on a white background doesn't

	Button	Button
WCAG 2	2.98 : 1 Fail	2.98 : 1 Fail
APCA	61 Pass	56 Fail

Accessible Perceptual Contrast Algorithm (APCA)

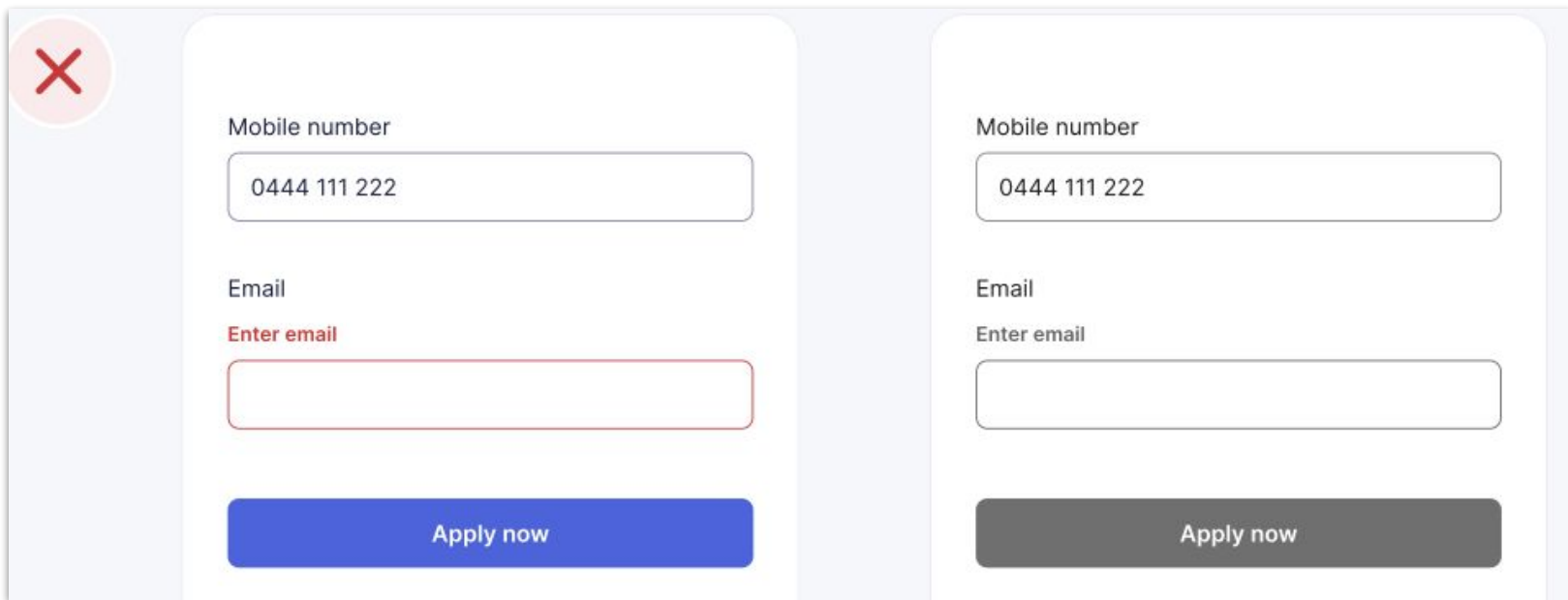
Unlike APCA, WCAG 2 contrast requirements don't work well for interfaces with dark backgrounds

It results in text that's hard to read

	Button	Button
WCAG 2	4.5 : 1 Pass	7.67 : 1 Pass
APCA	38 Fail	62 Pass

Don't rely on color alone to convey meaning

To ensure an interface is accessible to those who are colour blind, you need to use additional visual cues to differentiate interface elements



The image displays two side-by-side versions of a web form to illustrate accessibility differences for color blindness. Both forms have a 'Mobile number' field containing '0444 111 222' and an 'Email' field with the placeholder text 'Enter email'. The left form features a red 'X' icon in a circle at the top left, indicating an error. Below the email field is a blue 'Apply now' button. The right form lacks the error icon and has a dark grey 'Apply now' button. This comparison shows that relying solely on color (like a red border or button) to convey information is not accessible to all users.



Mobile number

Email

Enter email

Apply now

Mobile number

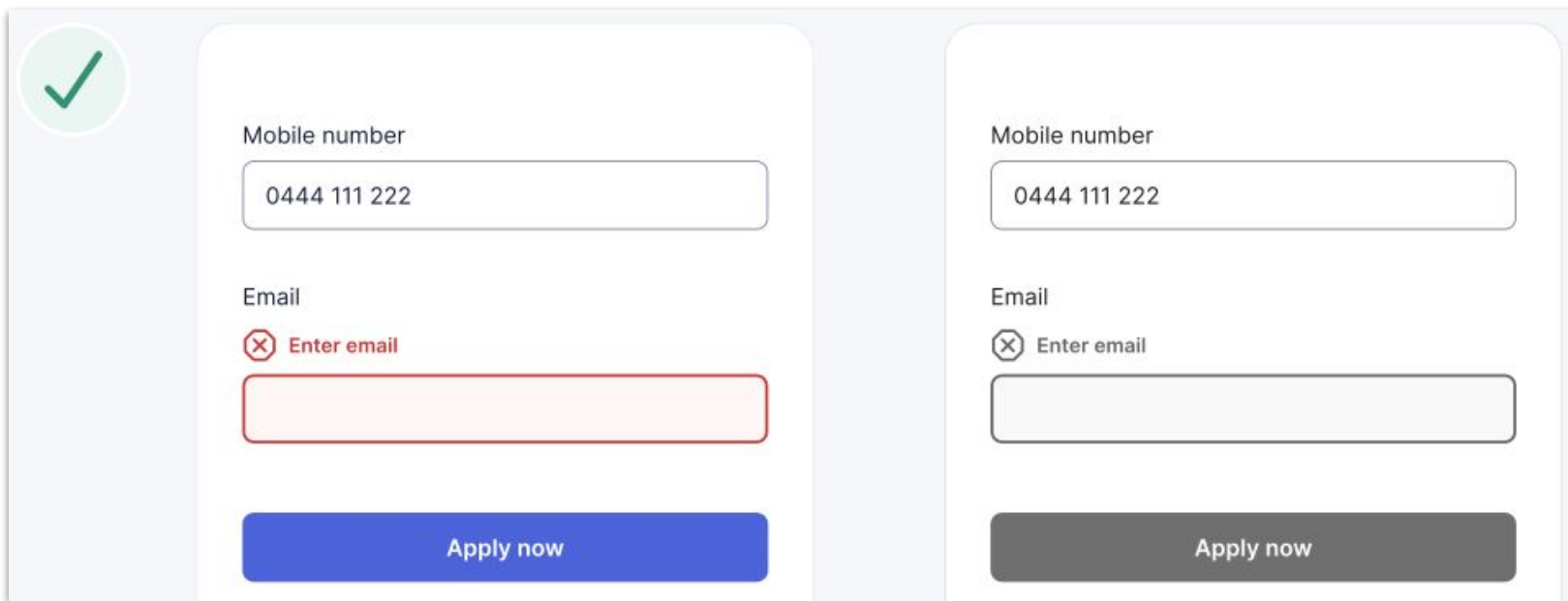
Email

Enter email

Apply now

Don't rely on color alone to convey meaning

To ensure an interface is accessible to those who are colour blind, you need to use additional visual cues to differentiate interface elements



The image shows two side-by-side form designs. The left design is marked with a green checkmark in a circle, indicating it is the preferred, accessible version. It features a 'Mobile number' field with the value '0444 111 222' and an 'Email' field with a red border and a red 'X' icon and text 'Enter email'. Below the email field is a blue 'Apply now' button. The right design is not marked, indicating it is less accessible. It features the same 'Mobile number' field, but the 'Email' field has a grey border and a grey 'X' icon and text 'Enter email'. Below the email field is a grey 'Apply now' button.

Element	Left Design (Accessible)	Right Design (Less Accessible)
Mobile number	0444 111 222	0444 111 222
Email	Red border, red 'X' icon, red text 'Enter email'	Grey border, grey 'X' icon, grey text 'Enter email'
Apply now	Blue button	Grey button

Don't rely on color alone to convey meaning

To ensure an interface is accessible to those who are colour blind, you need to use additional visual cues to differentiate interface elements



Wood laptop stand

★★★★★ 5.0 (38 reviews)

Free shipping Australia-wide

A handmade curved laptop stand skilfully crafted from natural Walnut timber veneer pressed on Premium Birch Plywood.



Wood laptop stand

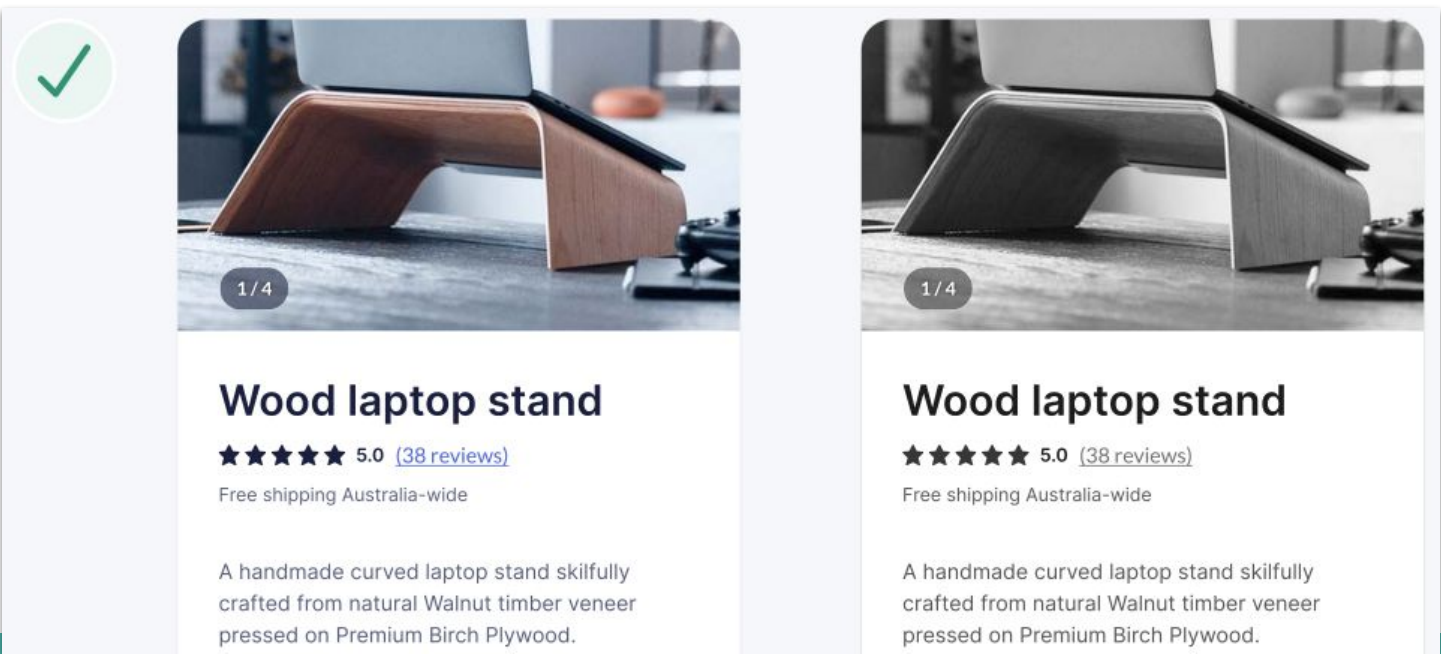
★★★★★ 5.0 (38 reviews)

Free shipping Australia-wide

A handmade curved laptop stand skilfully crafted from natural Walnut timber veneer pressed on Premium Birch Plywood.

Don't rely on color alone to convey meaning

To ensure an interface is accessible to those who are colour blind, you need to use additional visual cues to differentiate interface elements



Use system colors to indicate status

You'll generally need 3 system colors to indicate errors, warnings, and success states

Traffic light colors (red, amber, and green) are commonly used for system colors, as they already have familiar meanings associated with them

Use system colors to indicate status

Red (error) - used to indicate a negative message such as an error or system failure that needs urgent attention

Amber (warning) - used to warn people to be cautious and that taking an action could be risky

Green (success) - used to indicate a positive message or that an action was completed as expected

Use system colors to indicate status


Error


Warning

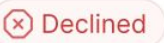

Success

Dream team

Members



Aisha Abboud
UX designer





Jon Tony
Developer





Darlene Robs
UI designer



Invite person

Cancel

Ensure system colors are accessible

Use additional visual cues such as icons to ensure people who are colour blind can also understand what the system messages mean

The image compares two user interface designs for a form, illustrating how to ensure accessibility for people who are color blind.

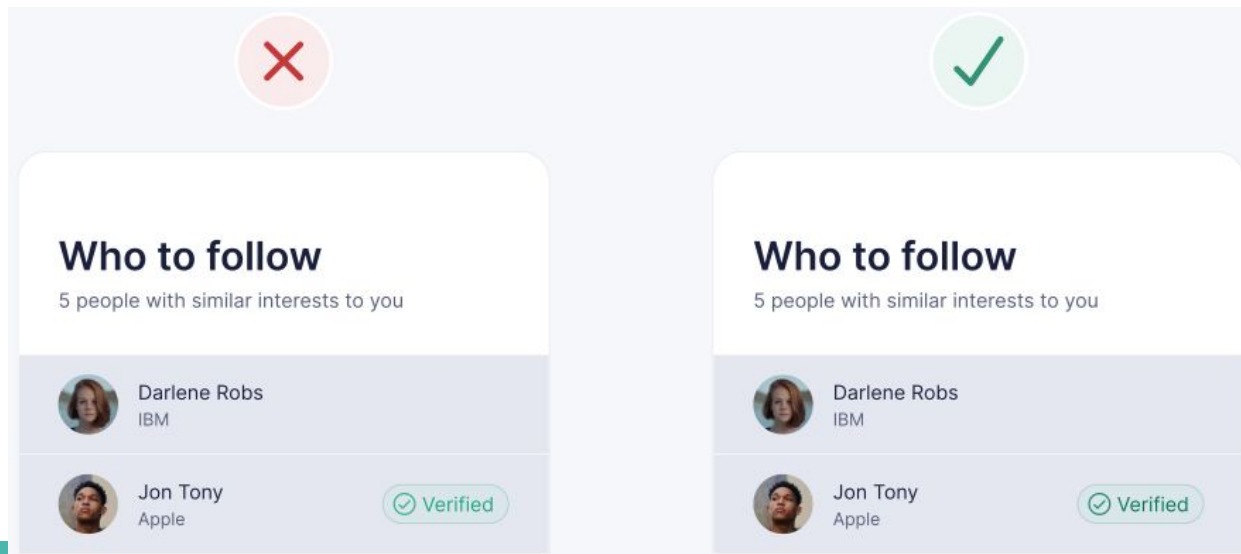
Left Design (Incorrect): This design uses only color to indicate an error. It features a red 'X' icon at the top. The 'Email' input field has a red border and the text 'Enter email' in red. The 'Apply now' button is blue.

Right Design (Correct): This design uses additional visual cues. It features a green checkmark icon at the top. The 'Email' input field has a red border and the text 'Enter email' in red, with a red 'X' icon to the left of the text. The 'Apply now' button is blue.

Ensure system colors are accessible

If you're using system colors for text, make sure they at least have a 4.5:1 contrast ratio

If you're only using system colors for interface elements and icons, they need a 3:1 contrast ratio



Use color to define a clear visual hierarchy

Aim to present information in order of importance by making more important elements look more prominent

A clear order of importance, or visual hierarchy, helps people scan information quickly and focus on areas of interest

Use color to define a clear visual hierarchy

Use variations in color **saturation**, **hue**, and **contrast** to help define a clear visual hierarchy

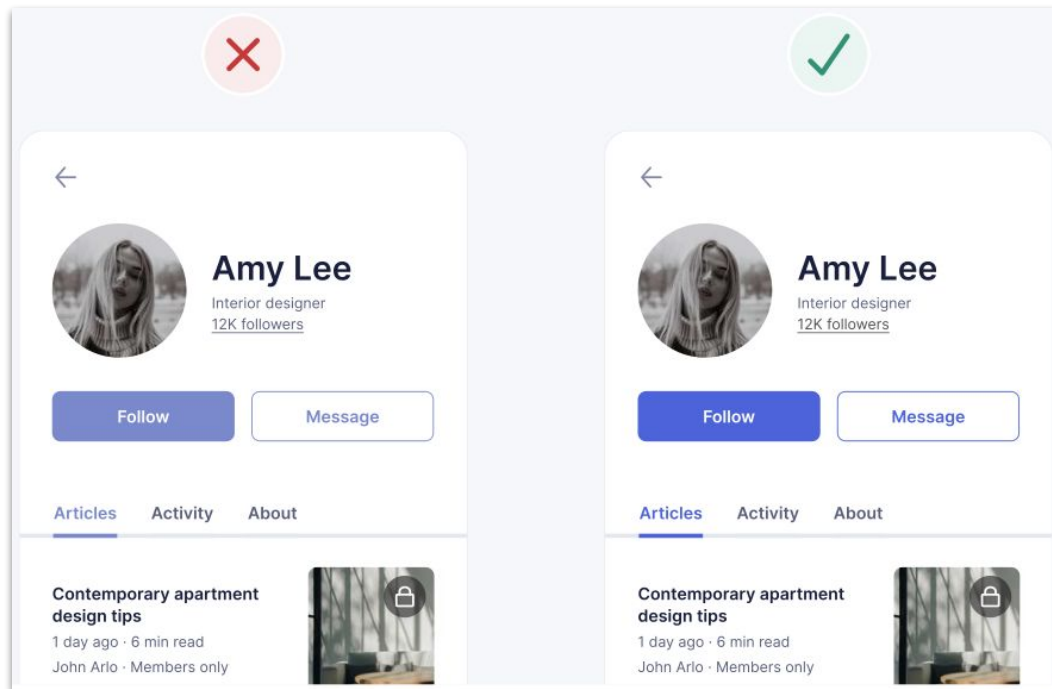
Use color to define a clear visual hierarchy

Saturation

Saturation is the degree of richness or intensity of a color

Use saturated colors for more important elements

For example, use a saturated color for text links and buttons to help them stand out



Use color to define a clear visual hierarchy

Hue

A hue is a number between 0 and 360 degrees that represents the colors of the rainbow

Certain color hues are more prominent than others. For example, red stands out a lot, which is one of the reasons it's used to indicate urgent errors

Email



Enter email

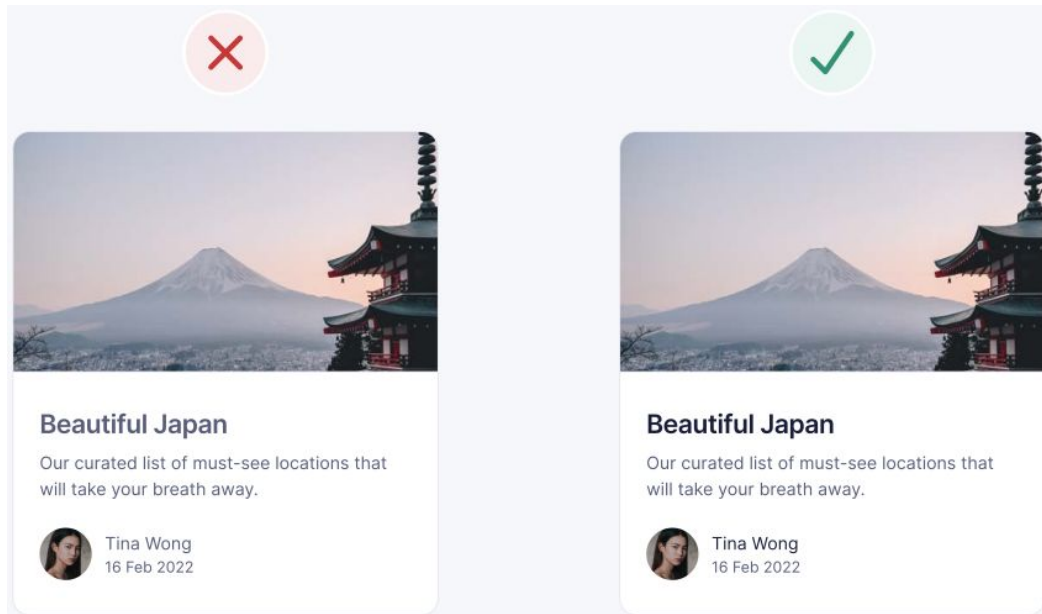
Use color to define a clear visual hierarchy

Contrast

Color contrast is the difference in brightness between 2 colors

Give more important elements higher contrast to make them more prominent

For example, make headings darker than body text to help them stand out



Use black and white for a timeless aesthetic

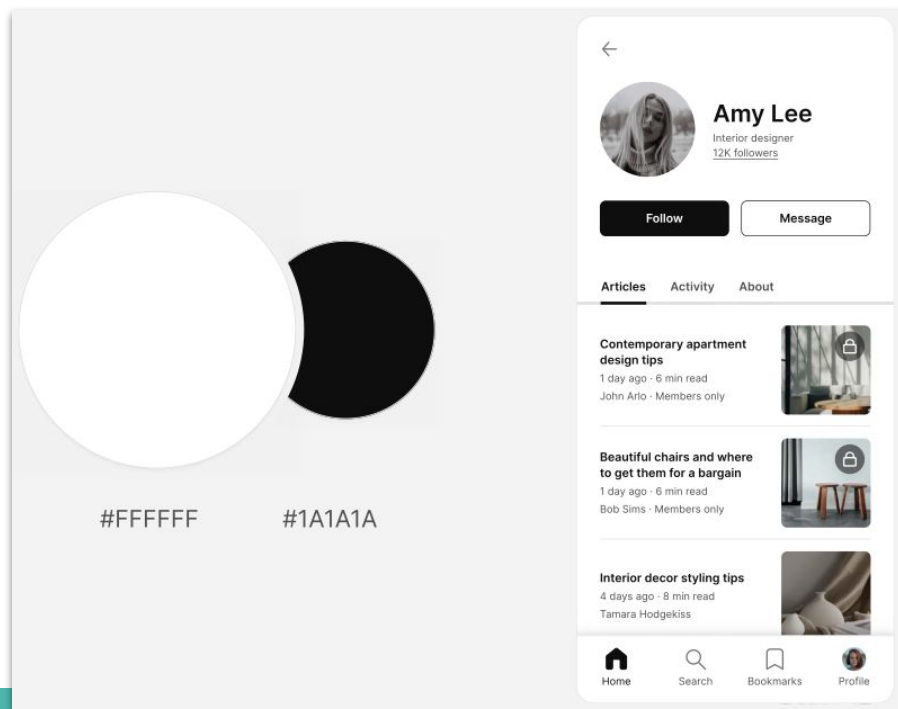
Black and white including shades of gray interfaces are especially good at highlighting content, as there are fewer distractions

It's a good idea to design interfaces without color first, regardless of the brand colors

Designing in black and white first helps you focus on spacing, size, layout, and contrast, without the extra challenge of color

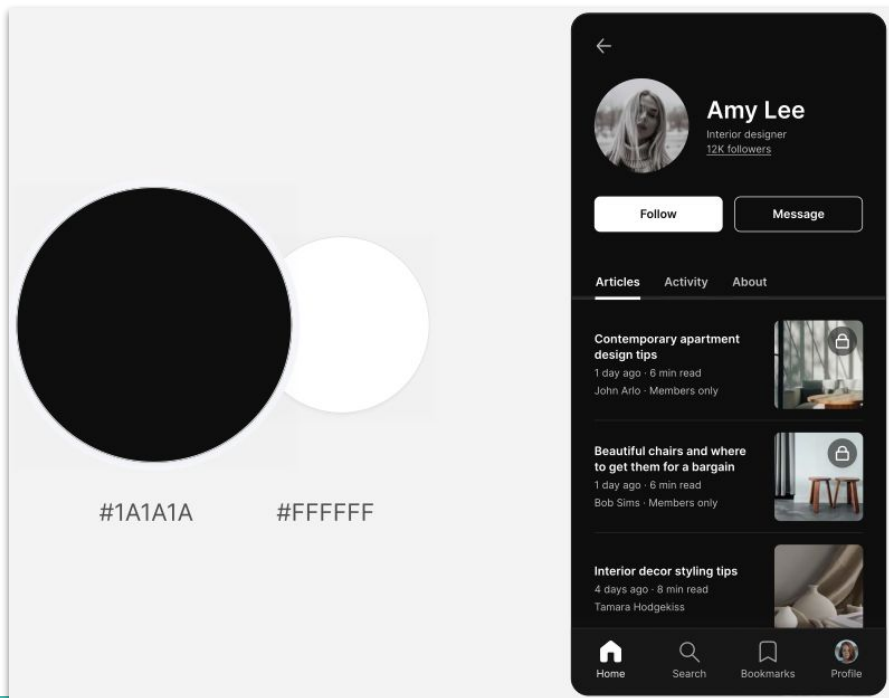
Use black and white for a timeless aesthetic

Use mostly white backgrounds to create a light interface that conveys a simple, classic, or minimal feel



Use black and white for a timeless aesthetic

Use mostly black backgrounds to create a dark interface that conveys a dramatic, powerful, or luxurious feel



Avoid pure black

It's generally safest to avoid pure black as it has a high contrast against white

This high contrast can cause eye strain and fatigue, especially when reading long text

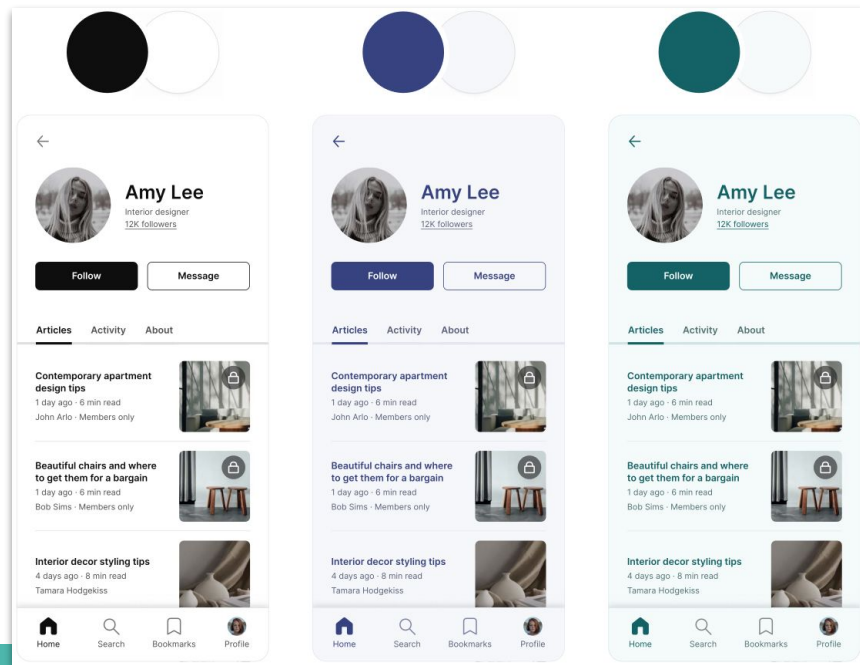
Black has 0% color brightness and white has 100% colour brightness

The large difference in color brightness causes our eyes to work harder

It's safest to avoid pure black against white and opt for a dark grey instead

Add a tinge of color to black and white

With this approach, you get most of the benefits of a simple black and white interface design, but you're able to adjust the mood with a pinch of color



Use 1 brand color

Many of the top brands use a single unique color, alongside black and white, to help convey the brand mood or personality

This works well for interface design, as you can use the brand colour purposefully to indicate interactive elements

Use 1 brand color



Apply the brand color to interactive elements

Use color sparingly and with purpose

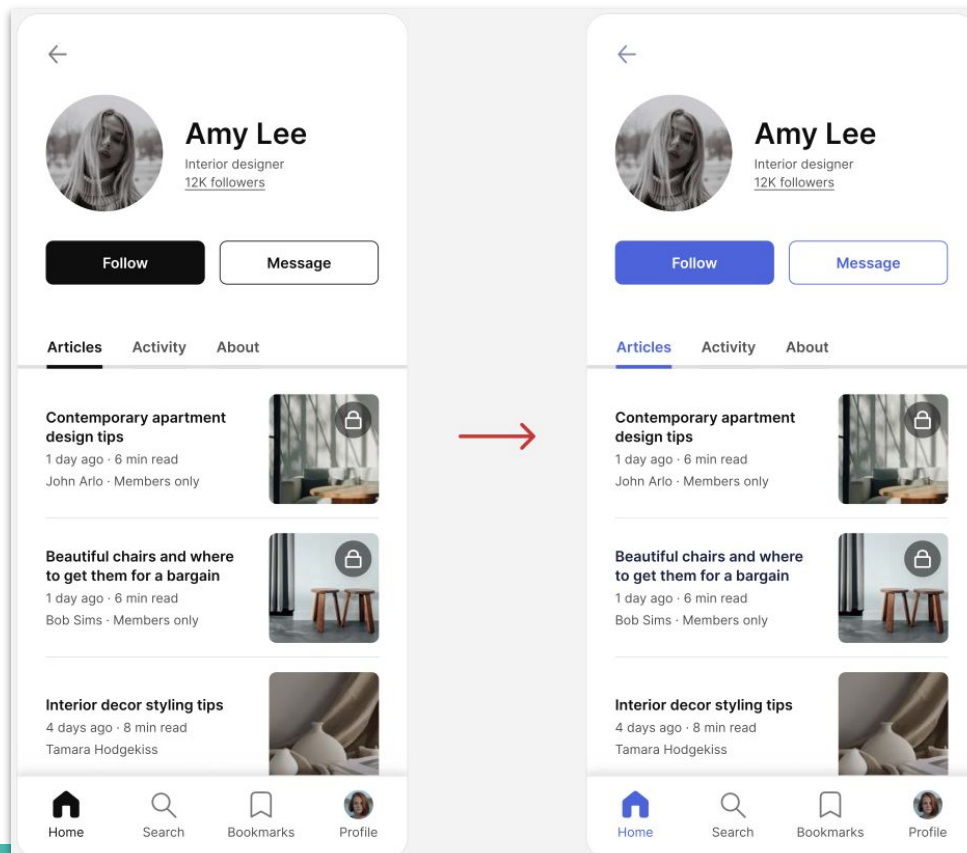
Try to avoid using color purely for decoration, as it can be confusing and distracting

Start with black and white and introduce color where it conveys meaning

You don't need to add color to all interactive elements, as some already have visual cues that indicate they're interactive

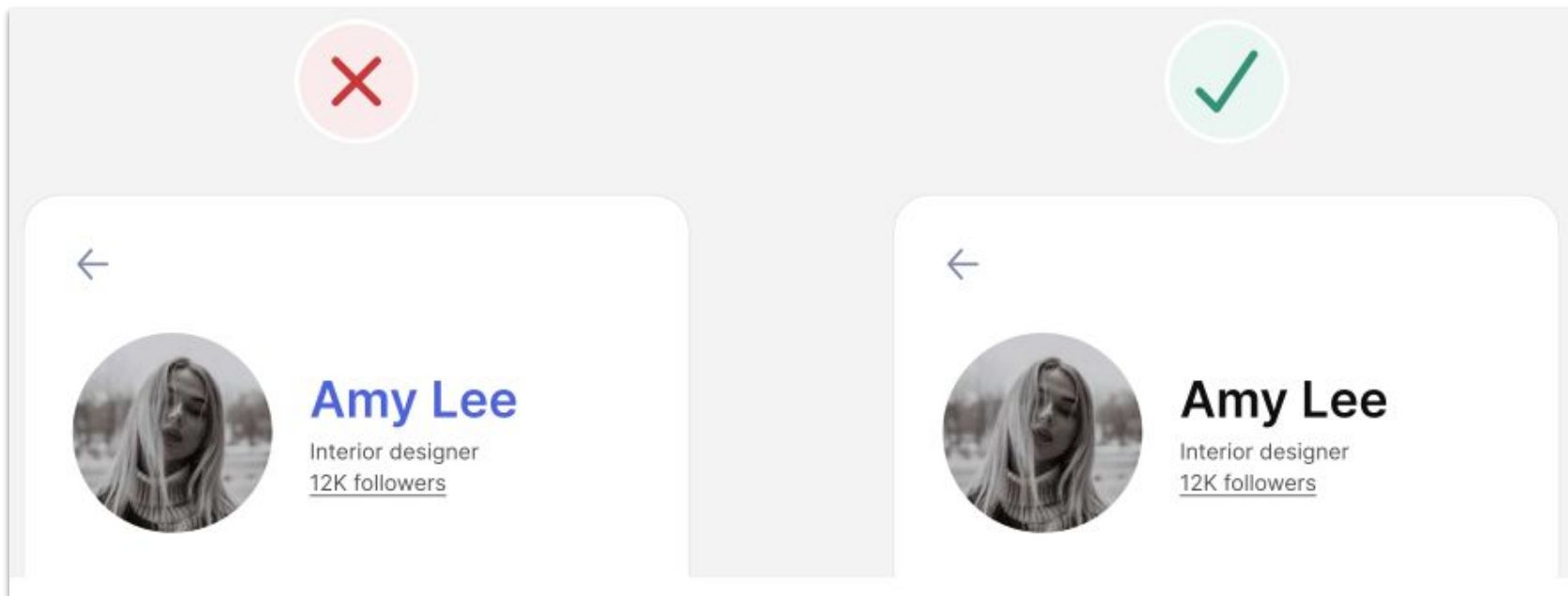
Apply the brand color to interactive elements

The brand color is applied to interactive elements to indicate they're interactive



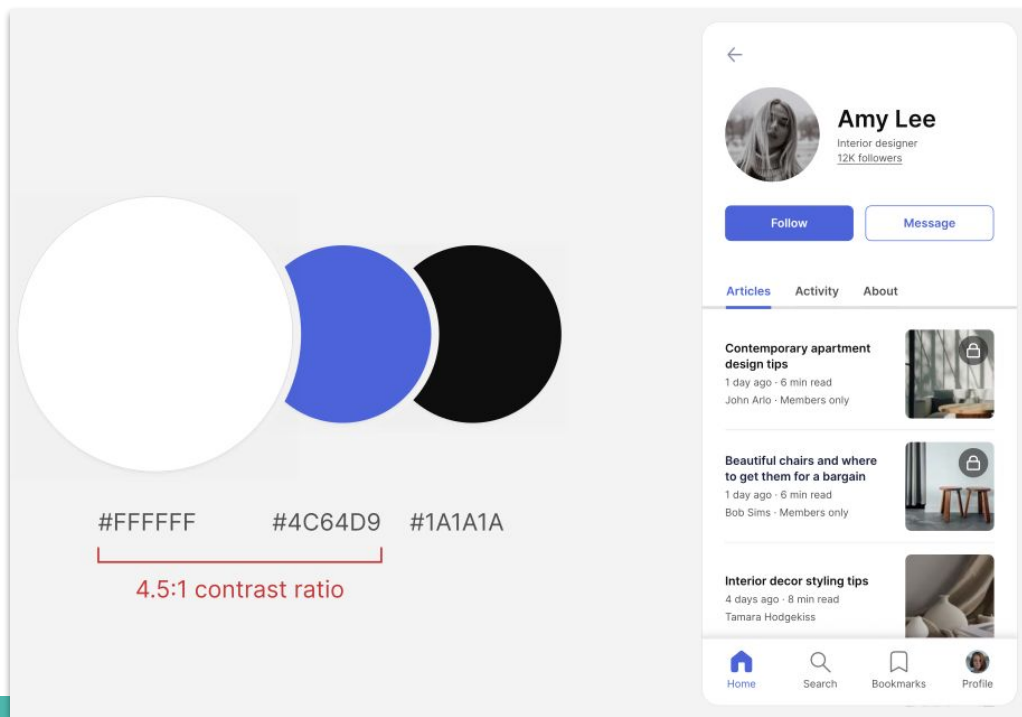
Apply the brand color to interactive elements

Avoid using color on non-interactive headings, as they could be mistaken for links



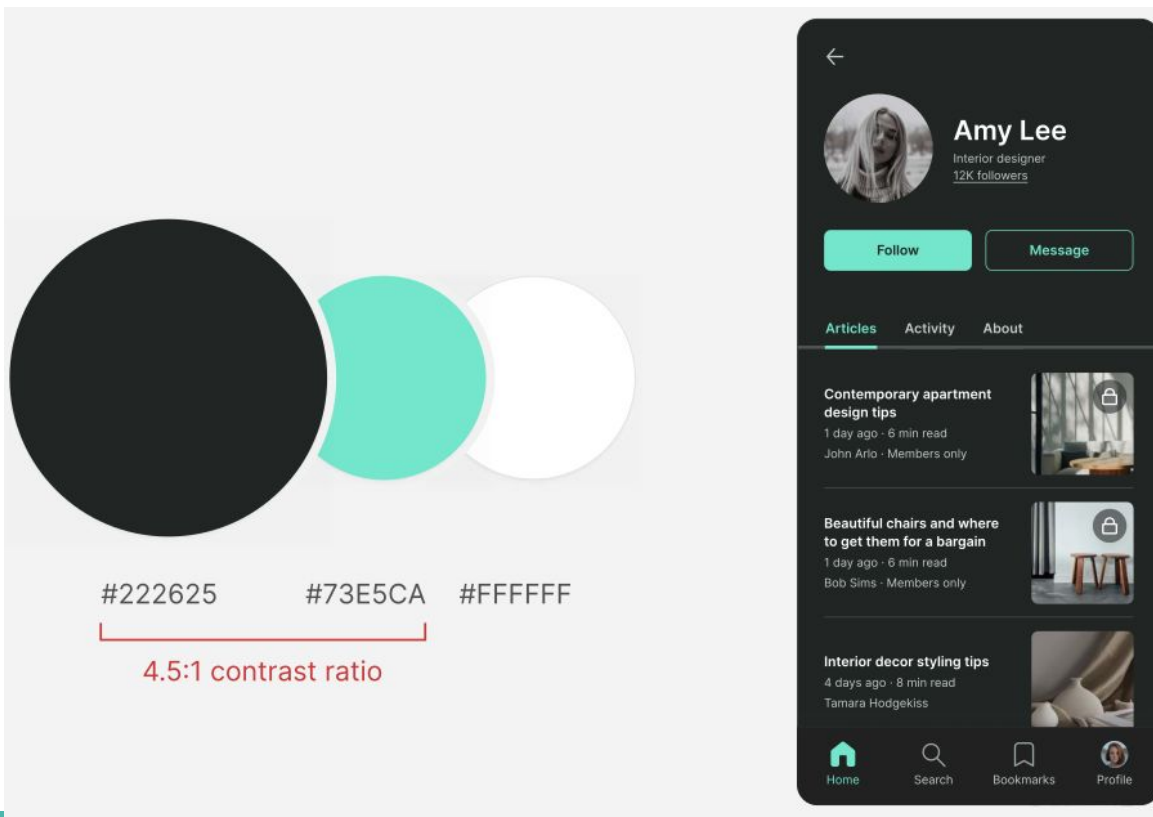
Ensure a contrast ratio of 4.5:1

The brand color needs to have a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 against the background



Ensure a contrast ratio of 4.5:1

You should also check the contrast using the APCA method, as the standard method doesn't work well with certain colors



What about low contrast colors?

If the brand color is a light colour like yellow, it won't have enough contrast to be accessible against light background colors like white

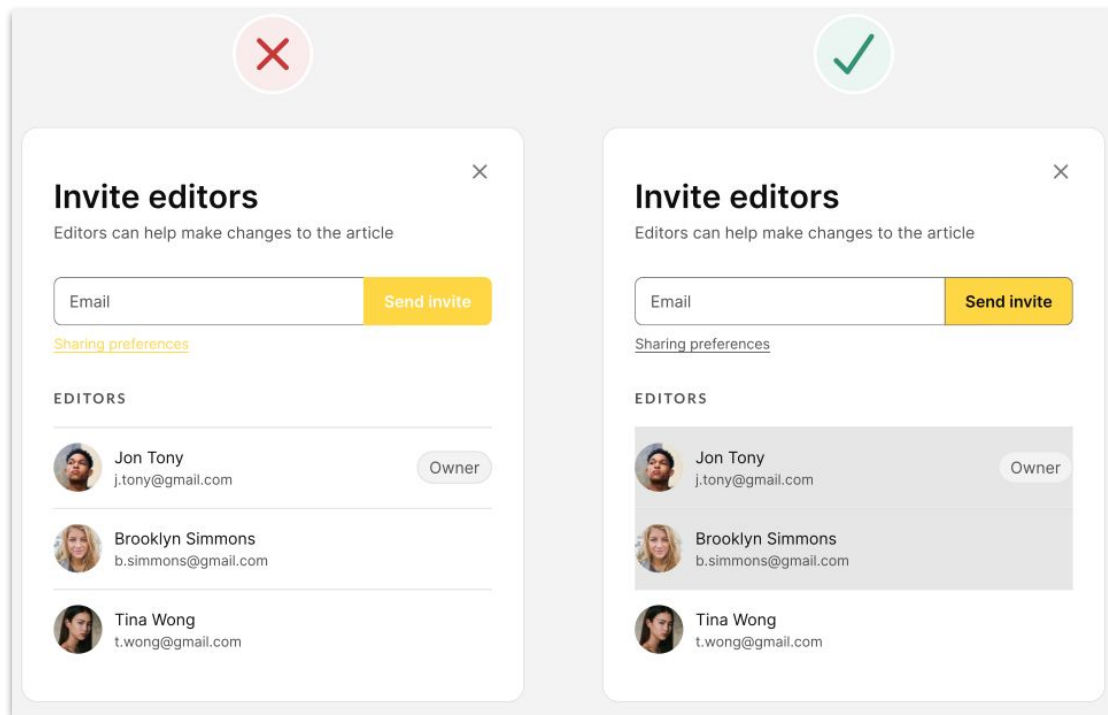
Depending on the brand color, you might be able to darken it slightly to get it to an accessible contrast ratio (without losing brand recognition)

Another trick is to add a text shadow to the white button text

What about low contrast colors?

Use the text color for button text, text links, and other interactive elements to ensure they're accessible and prominent

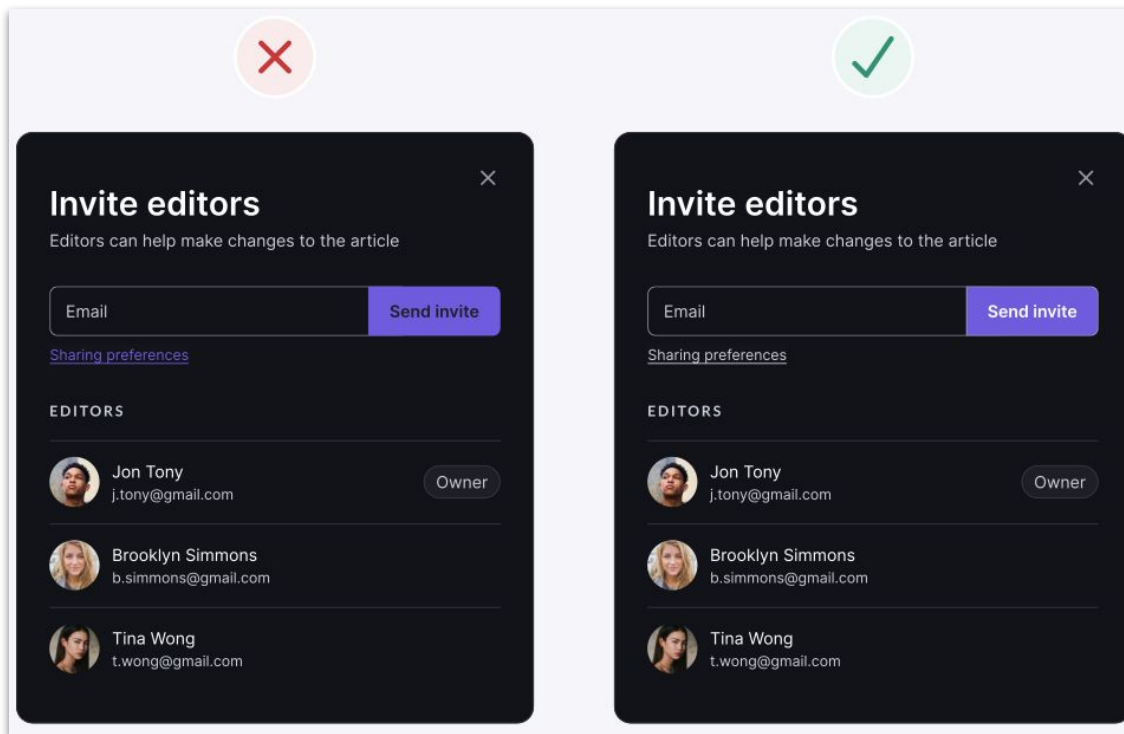
Add a border to buttons to ensure they have at least a 3:1 contrast ratio



What about low contrast colors?

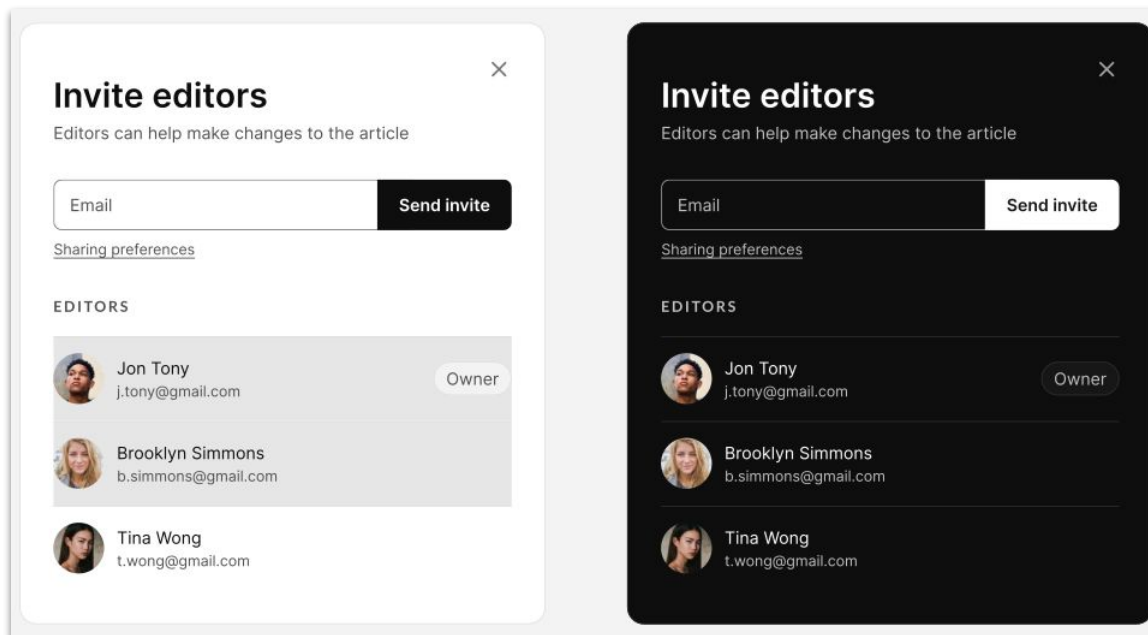
Use the text color for button text, text links, and other interactive elements to ensure they're accessible and prominent

Add a border to buttons to ensure they have at least a 3:1 contrast ratio



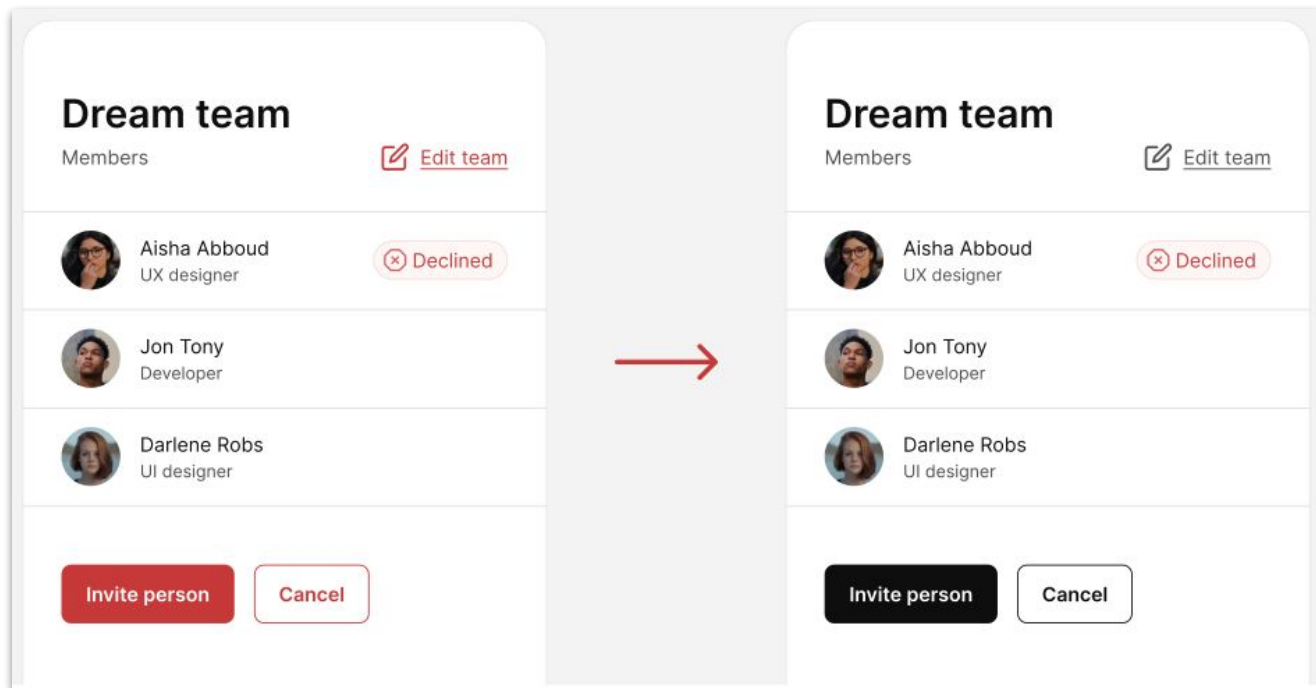
What about low contrast colors?

You could also consider not using your brand color for interactive elements and opt for a simple black and white aesthetic instead



If the brand color has meaning, avoid using it for interactive elements

Using red for interactive elements can cause confusion

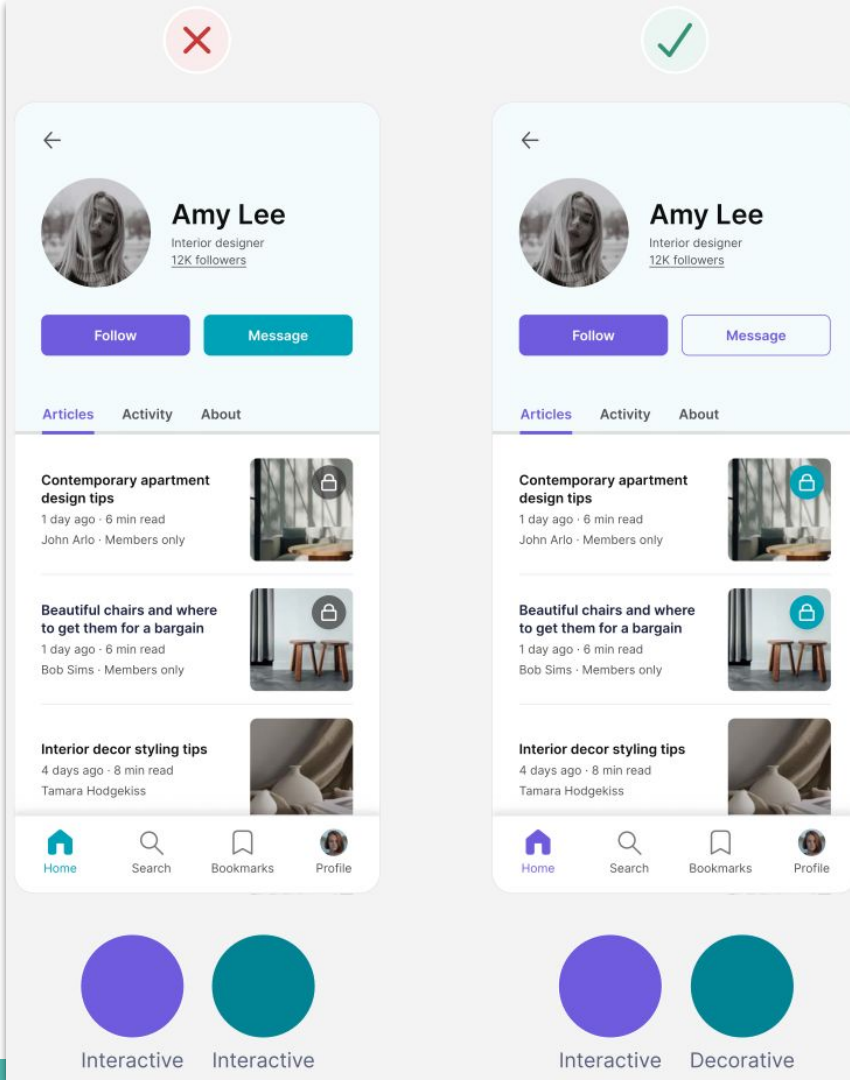


What if there are multiple brand colors?

If there are multiple brand colors, use the highest contrast color for interactive elements and use the others sparingly for decorative elements

Decorative elements might include backgrounds, borders, icons, and illustrations

Don't use more than one color for interactive elements, as it could cause confusion around what colors mean



Use the HSB color system

Using the **HSB** (**Hue, Saturation, Brightness**) color system makes it much easier to define your color variations

Use the HSB color system

Hue - a number between 0 and 360 degrees that represents the colors of the rainbow

Saturation - a number between 0 and 100 that represents the intensity or richness of a hue

A saturation of 100 is the richest version of the hue and 0 is a grey version of the hue



Use the HSB color system

Brightness- a number between 0 and 100 that represents the lightness/darkness of a hue

A brightness of 100 is the lightest version of the hue and 0 is always black



5 color variations is often all you need

Color palettes can be unnecessarily large and complex, making them difficult to understand and follow

In many cases, all you need is 1 brand color and 5 variations of that color

You can add more variations if needed

	Brand HSB: 230, 65, 85	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text strong HSB: 230, 57, 24	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text weak HSB: 230, 27, 48	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Stroke strong HSB: 230, 23, 65	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	3 : 1
	Stroke weak HSB: 230, 5, 94	This is a decorative colour, so it doesn't need to be high contrast.	
	Fill HSB: 230, 2, 98	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	
	Background HSB: 0, 0, 100	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	

Create a color palette with rules that govern its usage

Brand - used to indicate interactive elements like text links and buttons

Text strong - used for primary text, like headings, body content, and form labels to ensure they're prominent and legible



Create a color palette with rules that govern its usage

Text weak - used for supporting text to make it less prominent

Stroke strong - used for non-decorative borders on interface elements like form input fields and icons

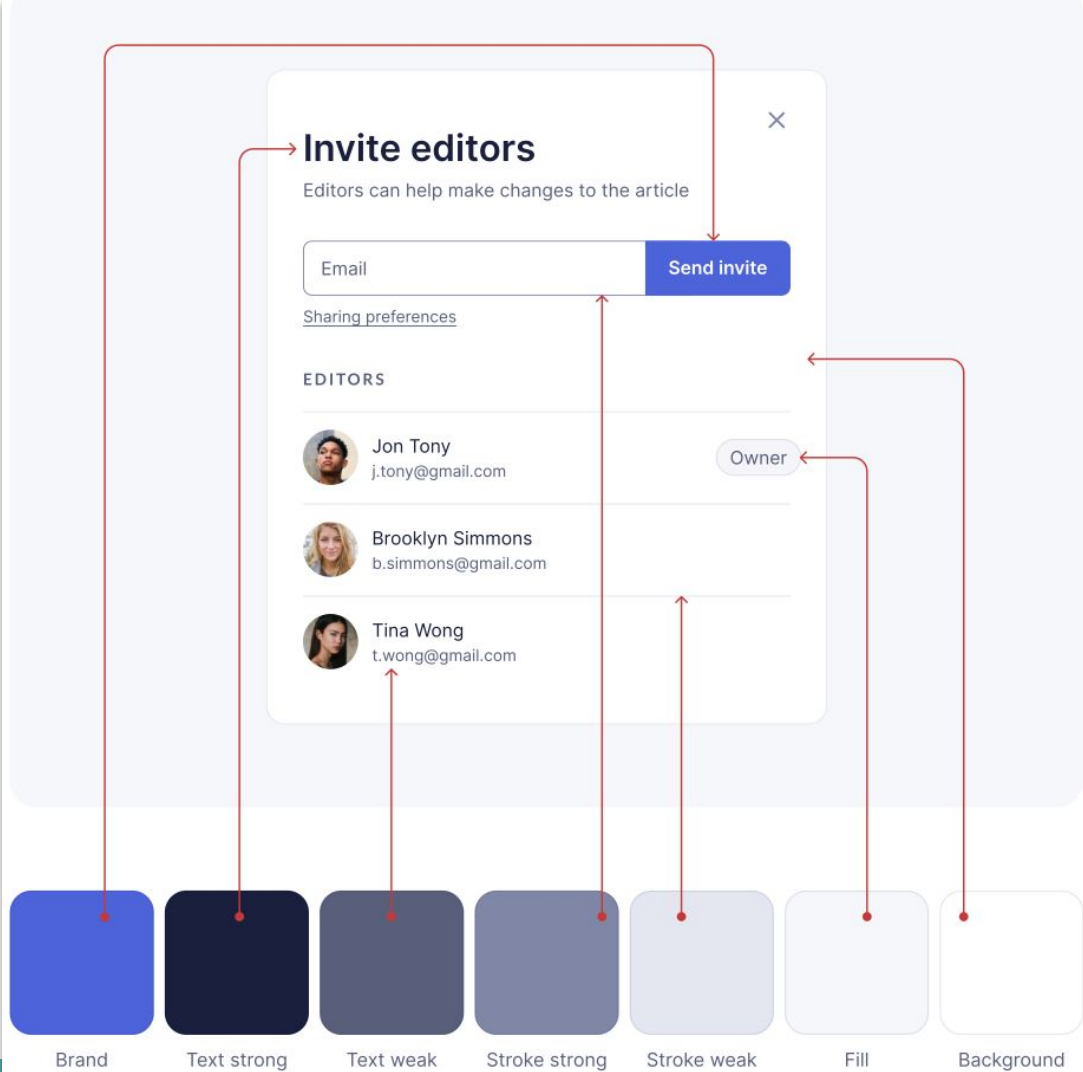


Create a color palette with rules that govern its usage

Stroke weak - used for decorative borders, like dividing lines

Fill - used as a secondary background to help differentiate elements, like tags or badges, that sit on the main white background





Using Colors for interaction states

To indicate interactive states such as hover, press, focus, and disabled consider the following options

- Change the opacity

- Change the fill color

- Change the elevation

- Toggle a text underline

- Use animation

Change the opacity

Solid colors have an opacity of 100%, which means that you can't see through them

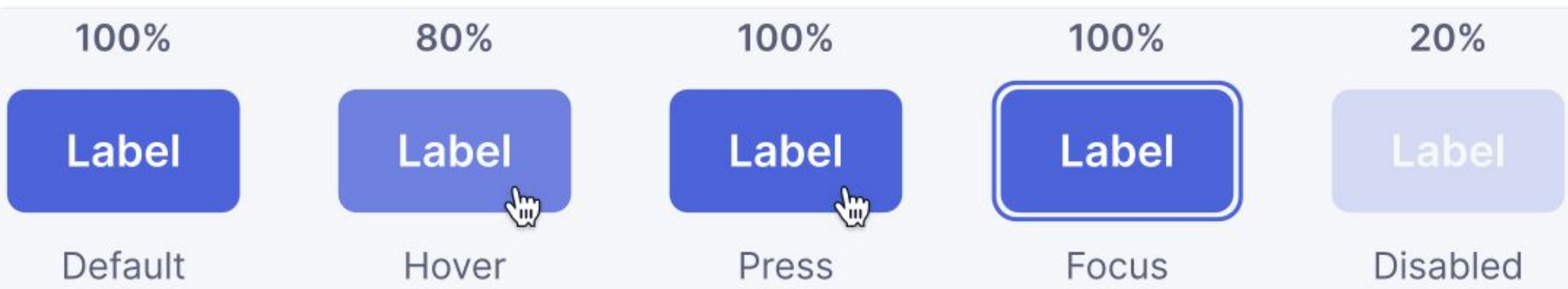
Lowering the opacity of a color makes it more transparent or see-through

Change the opacity

Use changes in opacity to indicate interaction states

The hover state could have an opacity of 80%, while the disabled state could have an opacity of 20% to help indicate that it's not interactive

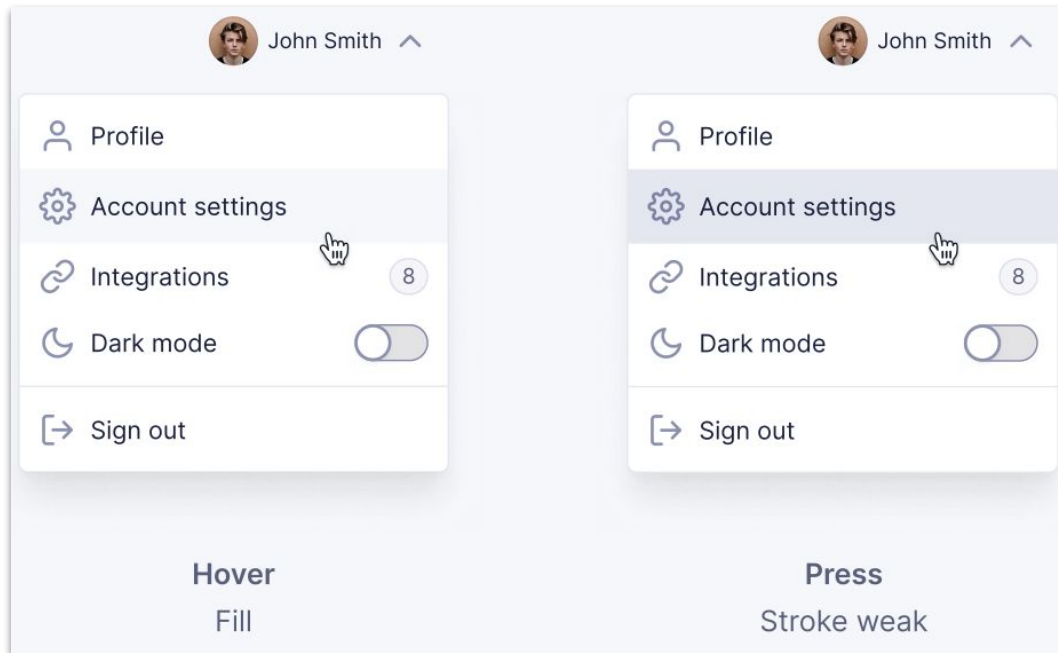
An outline is generally used to indicate the focus state



Change the fill color

For interactive elements with the “Background” color, you can use the “Fill” color variation from the palette for the hover state

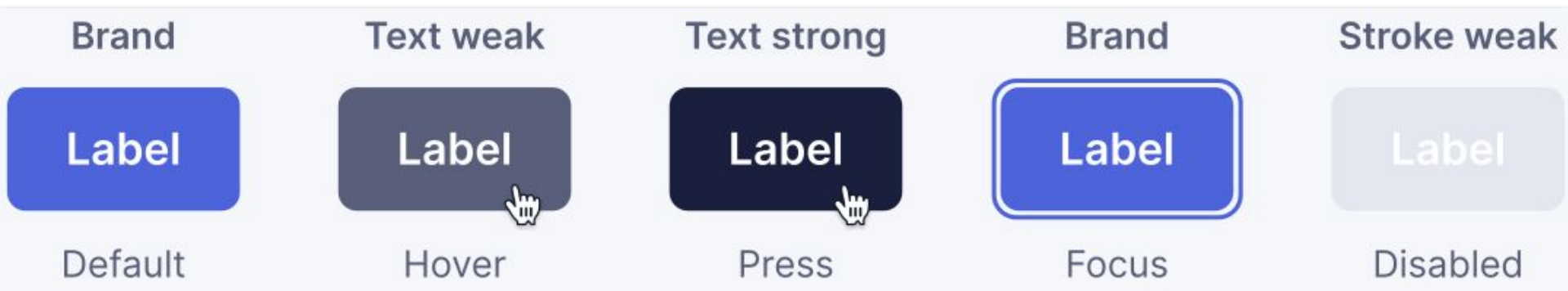
For the press state, use the “Stroke weak” color variation



Change the fill color

For interactive elements that use the brand color, like buttons, you could change the fill color to others from the palette

“Text weak” could be used for the hover state, “Text strong” for the press state, and “Stroke weak” for the disabled state

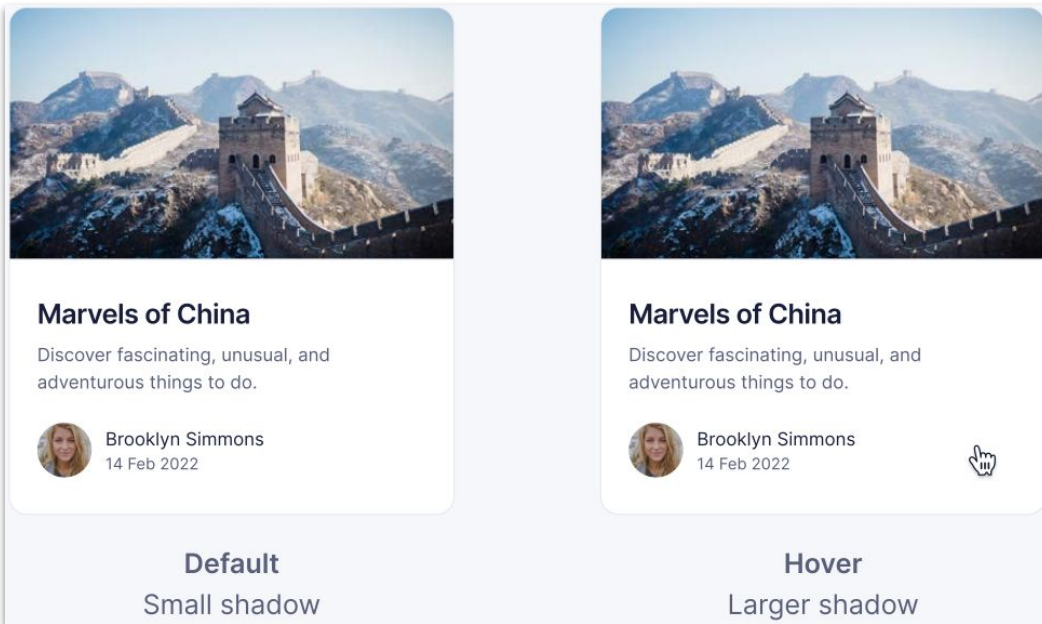


Change the elevation

Another quick and simple way of indicating state is to change the elevation of interactive elements

Elements can be elevated using shadows

In the following example, the card component is elevated higher on hover



Change the elevation

A shadow is used to elevate a button on hover

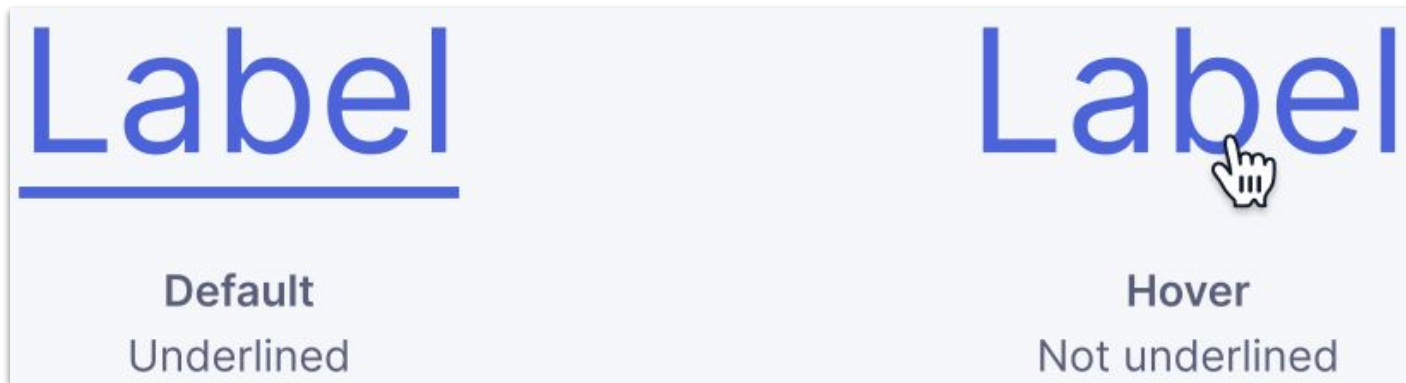
The press state is often the same as the default state, as it only needs to differ from the hover state



Toggle a text underline

For interactive text that's underlined, like text links, you could simply remove the underline on hover

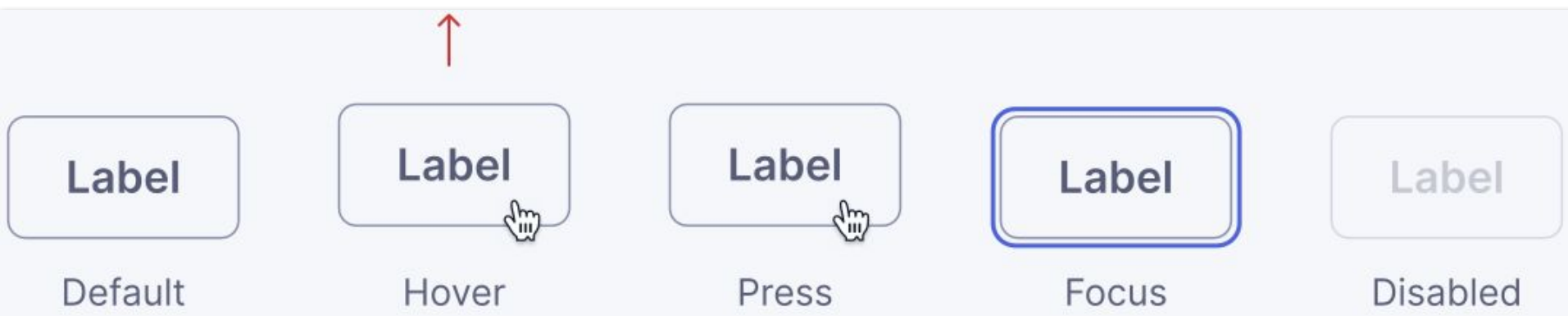
For interactive text that isn't underlined, like text in a navigation menu, consider underlining it on hover



Use animation

You can also use subtle animations to differentiate states

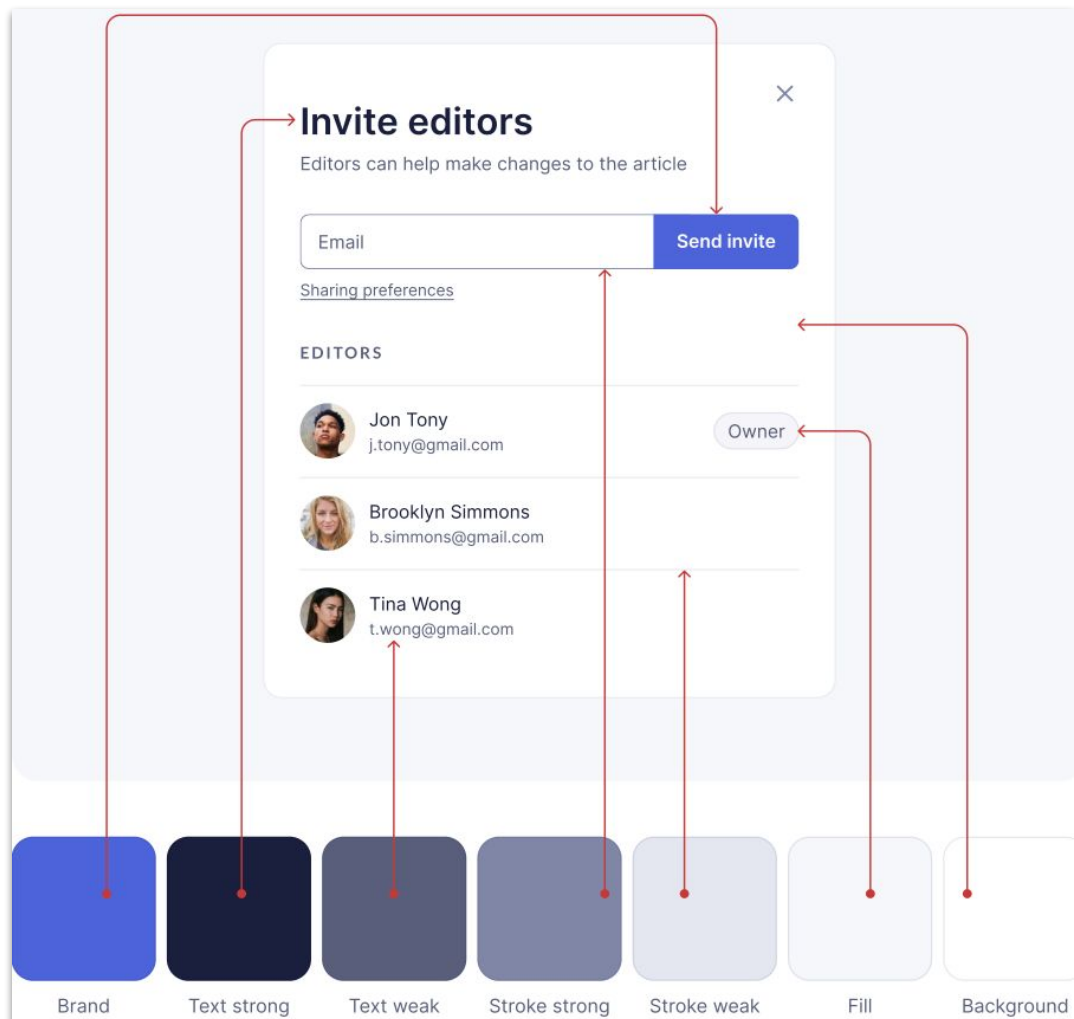
For example, you could move a button slightly upwards on hover, or animate the border, or the background



Test your color palette

Test your color palette using an interface example that contains all color variations

Seeing all of the colors in context is the only way to be sure they'll work well together



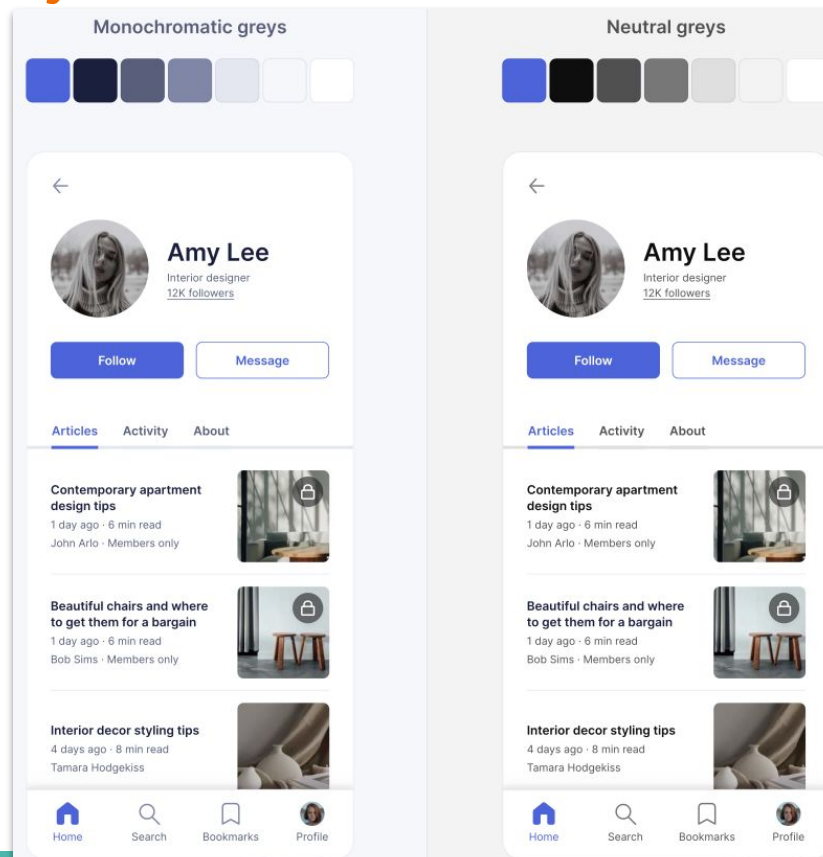
Monochromatic versus neutral greys

Monochromatic grey consists of variations of a single colour hue

Neutral greys don't contain any color hue

They have a saturation of zero

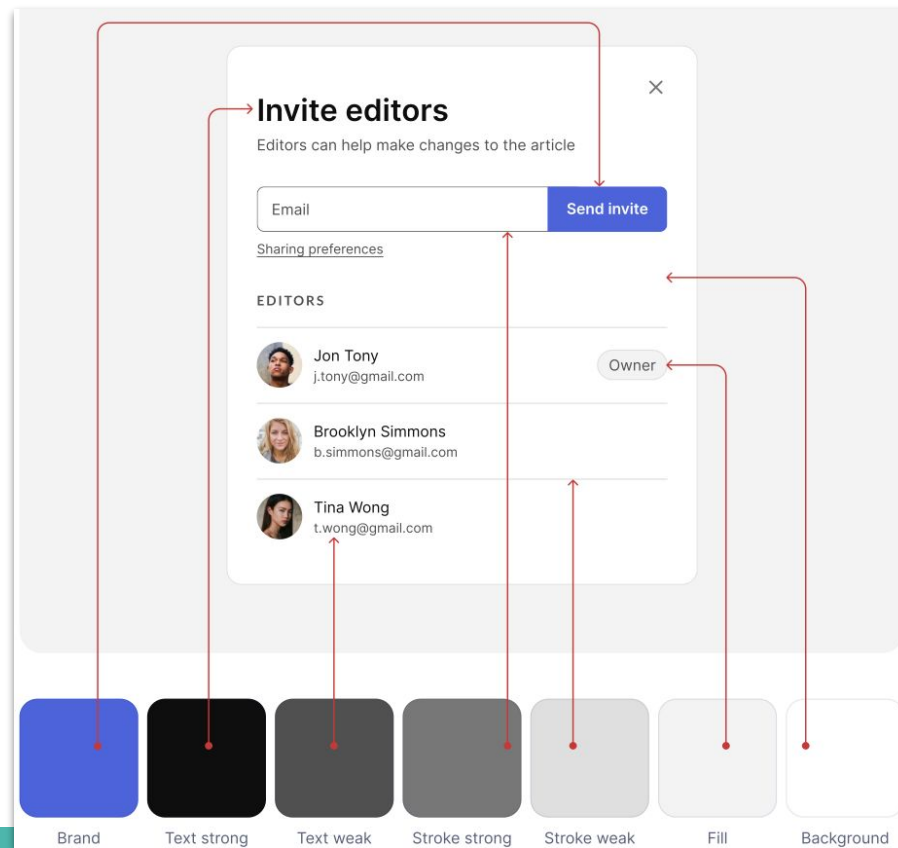
Variations of a single color create a simple and cohesive look



Monochromatic versus neutral greys

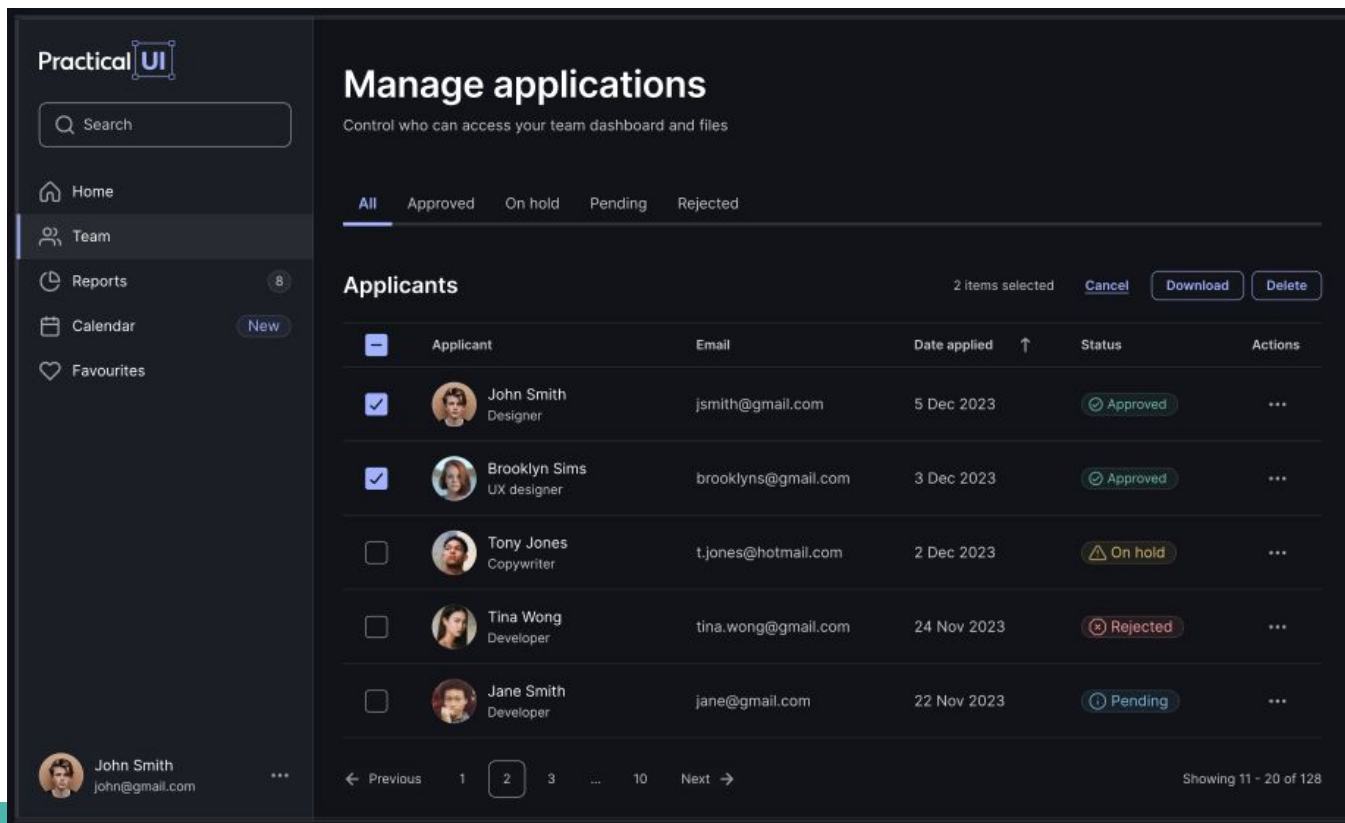
If you prefer a neutral color palette like the following example, simply use variations of neutral grey along with your brand color

Set the saturation to zero to create neutral variations of grey



Create a dark color palette

An example of a dark interface



Create a dark color palette

Use the main brand color hue as a base and change the saturation and brightness to create the other variations

Increase the contrast well above the minimum WCAG requirements for dark interfaces, as they can be more difficult to see

Check contrast using the APCA method for more accurate contrast measurements

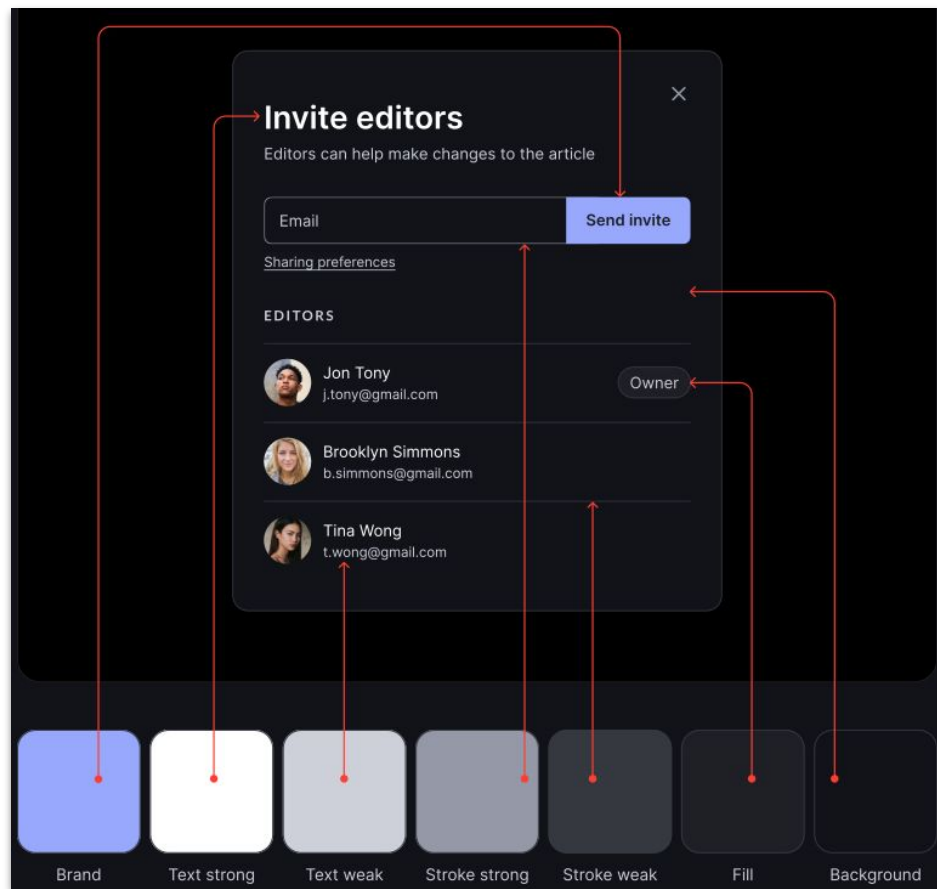
	Brand HSB: 230, 40, 99	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text strong HSB: 230, 0, 100	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text weak HSB: 230, 5, 85	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Stroke strong HSB: 230, 10, 65	Contrast with fill variation must be at least:	3 : 1
	Stroke weak HSB: 230, 15, 25	This is a decorative colour, so it doesn't need to be high contrast.	
	Fill HSB: 230, 20, 15	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	
	Background HSB: 230, 30, 10	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	

Create a dark color palette

Start with white for the “Text strong” variation, it has a saturation of 0 and a brightness of 100

Gradually increase saturation and decrease brightness to create the other colour variations

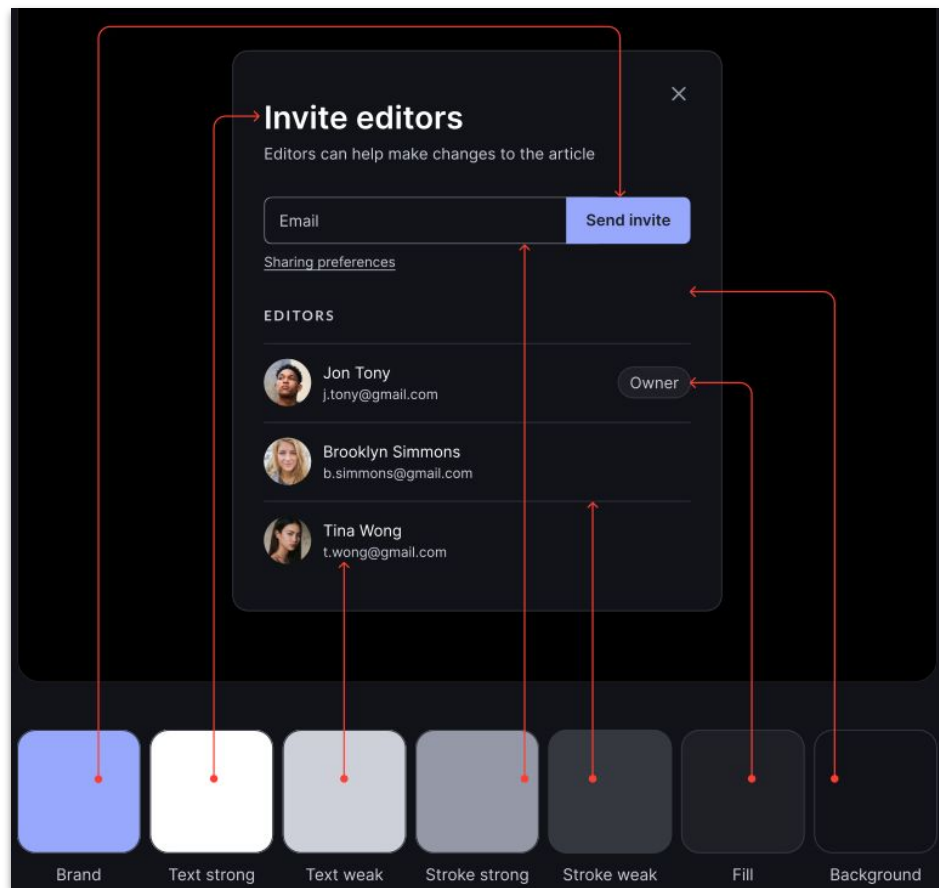
Avoid pure black for the background colour and opt for a dark grey instead



Create a dark color palette

In order to use the brand color on interactive elements like text links and buttons, it needs sufficient contrast

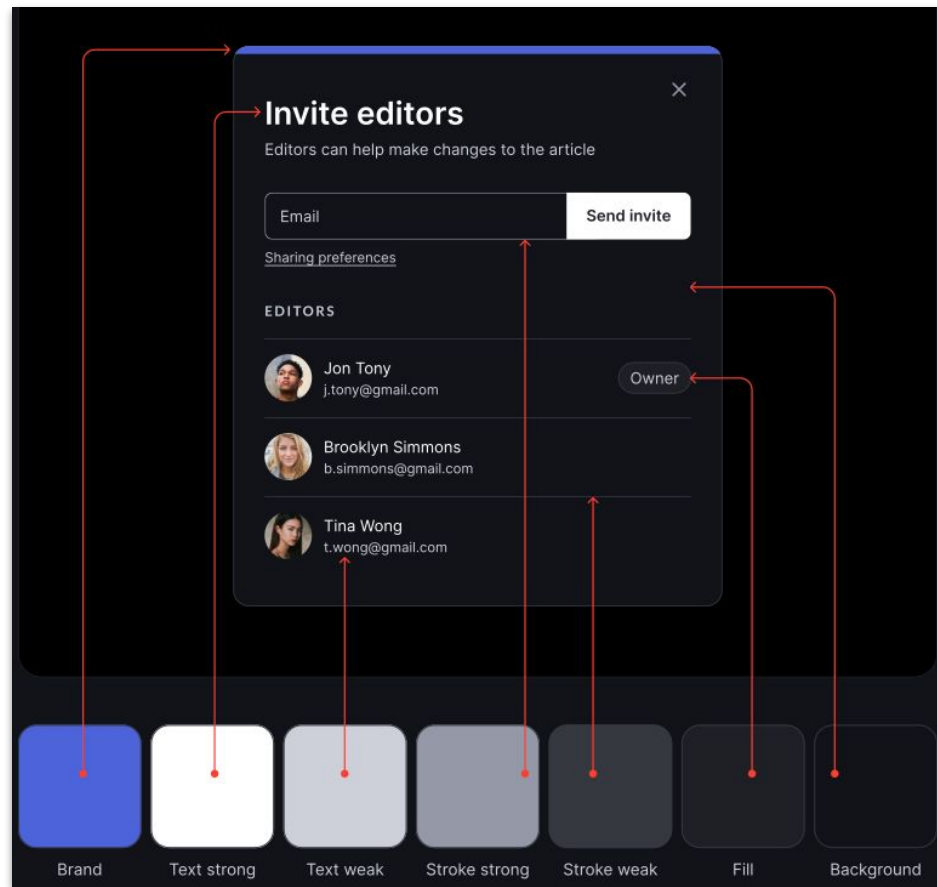
Dark brand colors will generally need to be lightened and desaturated to achieve the required contrast



Create a dark color palette

If the adjusted color no longer reflects the brand closely enough, consider using white for interactive elements instead

You can use the brand color decoratively in other areas to maintain a subtle brand presence



Add depth using color and shadows

To add depth to an interface, use color and shadows to raise or lower interface elements to different levels of elevation

Elements with a higher elevation appear closer to you and are more prominent

Add depth using color and shadows

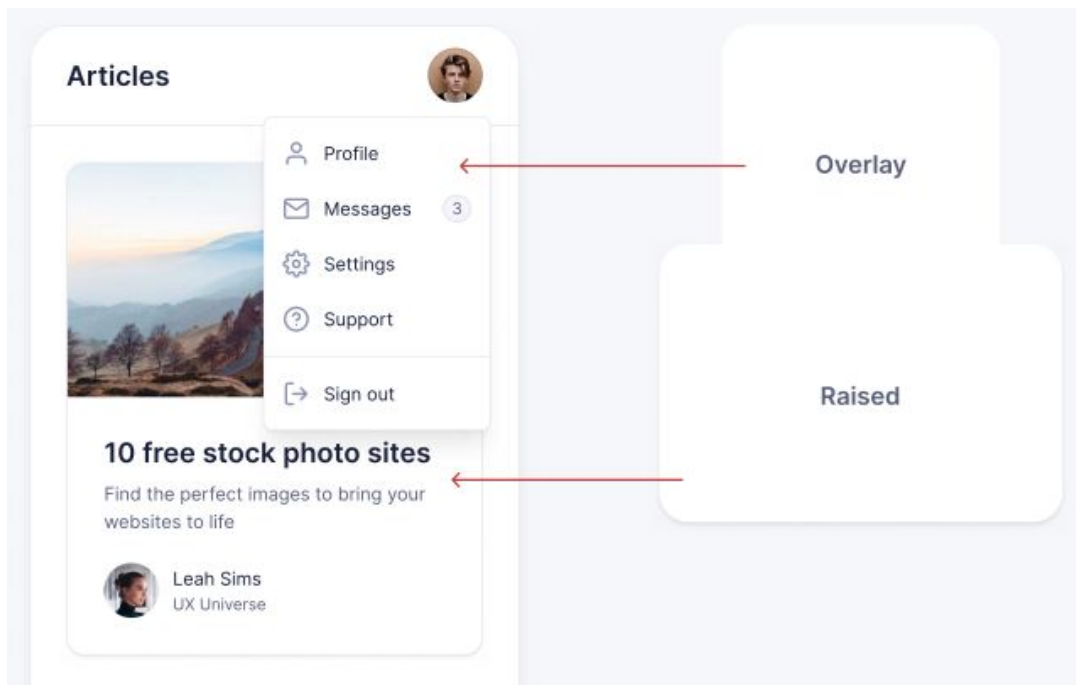
Define 2 shadow options

Raised - a small and sharp shadow used to slightly elevate interactive elements like cards

Overlay - a larger and softer shadow used for elements that float high above the page like dropdown menus and floating dialog boxes

Add depth using color and shadows

Define 2 shadow options



Add depth using color and shadows

Use a small and sharp shadow to slightly raise an interface element off the page

Use a larger and softer shadow to elevate an interface element higher

Make sure the light comes from the top to mimic real world objects

Rather than using black for the shadow color, try using the “Text strong” variation from your predefined color palette

This will help ensure the shadow fits in with the rest of the interface

Adding depth in dark interfaces

Shadows can be difficult to see in dark interfaces, so you mostly need to rely on colour to indicate depth

Adding depth in dark interfaces

Take your background color as your base and define 2 progressively brighter background colors to help indicate elevation above the page

This gives you 3 background colors to use when designing dark interfaces:

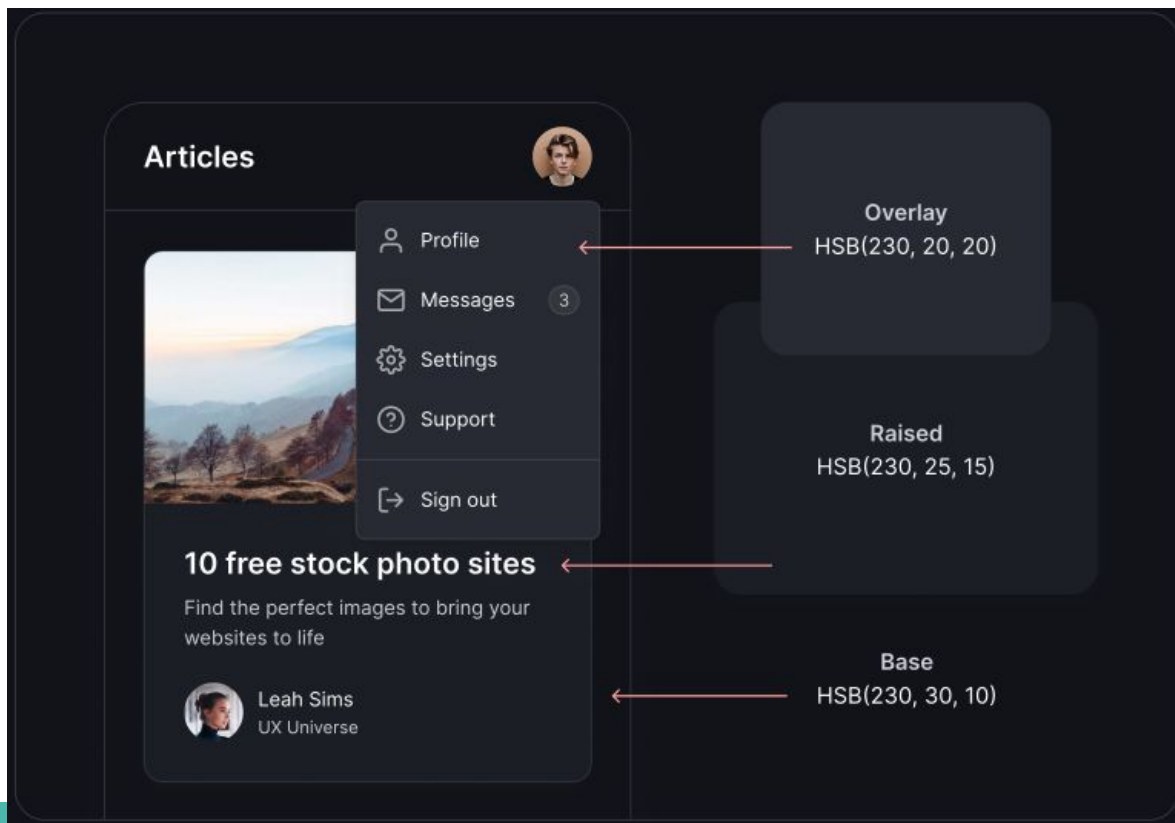
Base - darkest colour for the main background

Raised - slightly brighter than the base color

Overlay - slightly brighter than the raised color

Adding depth in dark interfaces

3 levels of elevation in dark interfaces



Adding Depth

If you're designing an interface that supports switching between light and dark mode, make sure each level of elevation looks consistent across modes

Transparent colors

Solid colours have an opacity of 100%, which means that you can't see through them

Lowering the opacity of a colour makes it more transparent or see-through

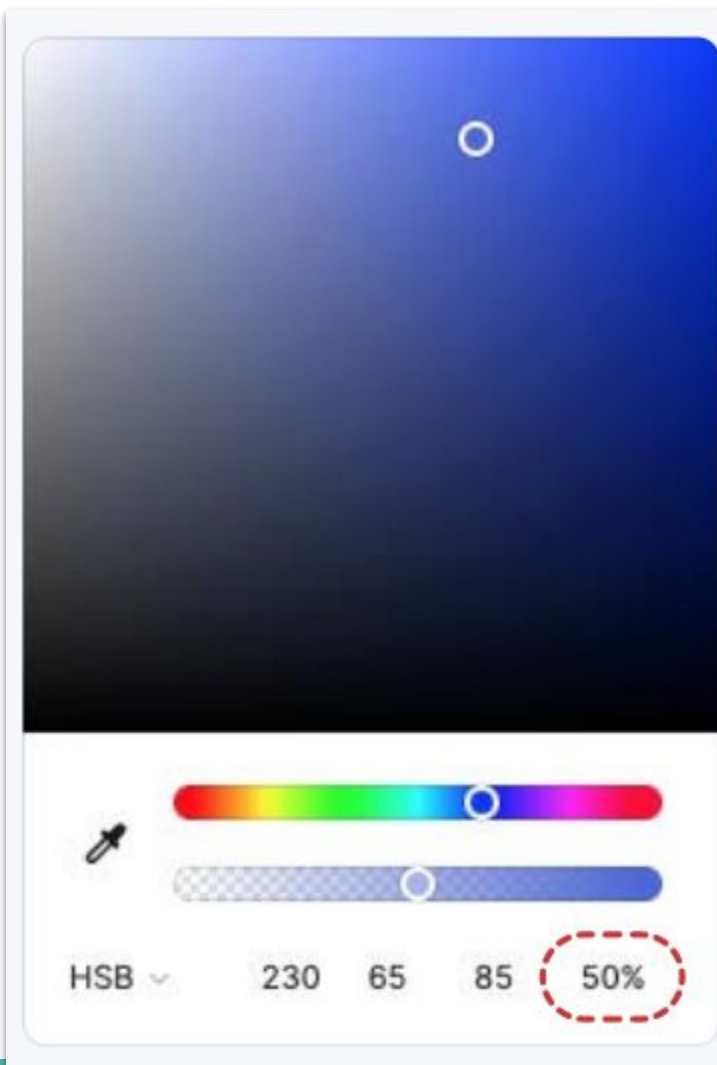
Transparent colors

There's a 4th value in the HSB colour system that controls the opacity of a colour

It's known as the "alpha" value and it's represented by the letter "A"

It can have a value from 0 to 1, with 1 being 100% opacity

```
HSBA(230, 70, 80, 0.5)
```



Problem with solid colors

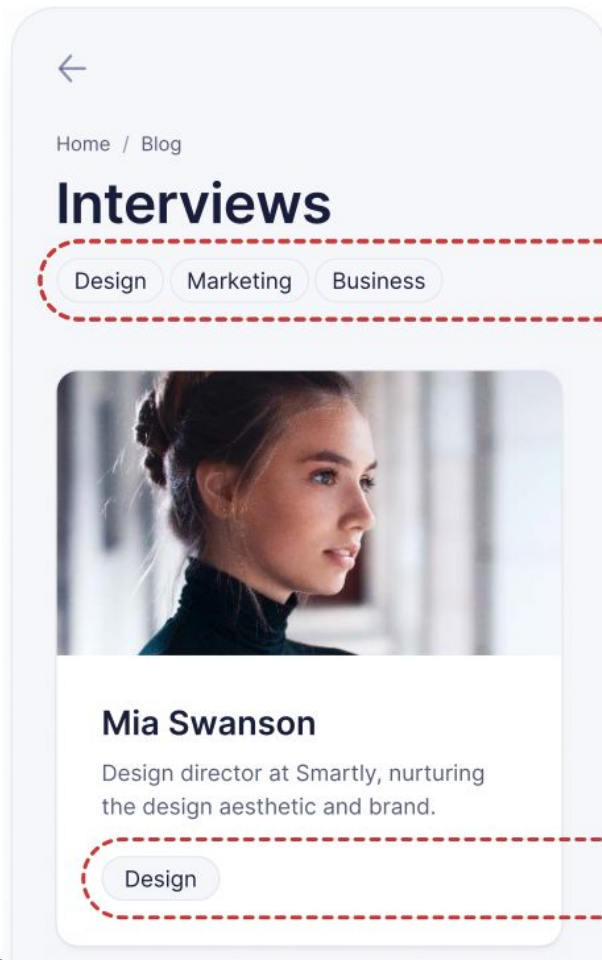
Solid colors remain the same regardless of the background they sit on

In the example shown in the next slide, some tags sit on a white background, while others sit on a grey background

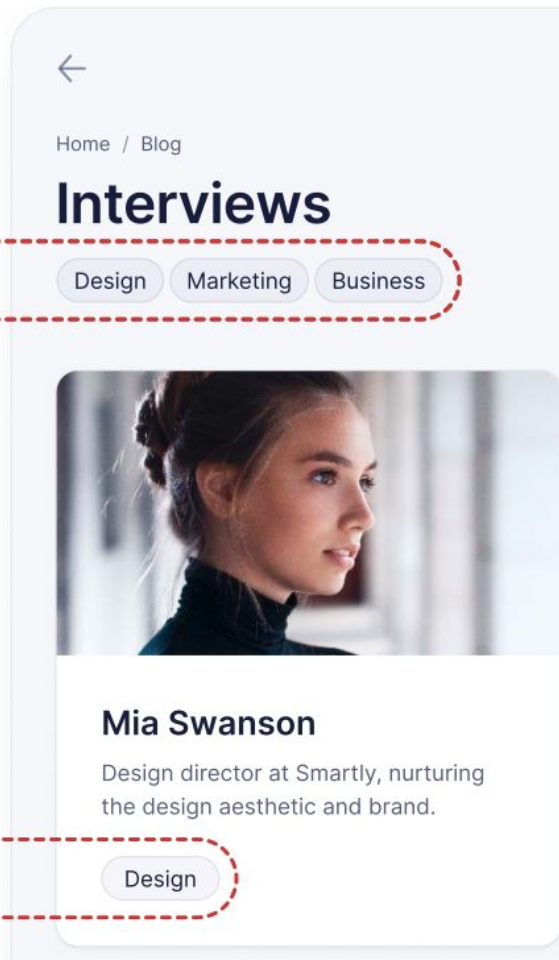
Tags with a solid grey fill look less prominent on the grey background, which affects their visual hierarchy

Ideally, these tags should always look slightly more prominent than the background they sit on to help them stand out

Solid Color



Ideal Design



Problem with solid colors

Solid tags have varied prominence on different backgrounds in dark mode as shown in the next slide

Light mode

Overlay

Raised

Base

Dark mode

Overlay

Raised

Base



Using Transparent Color

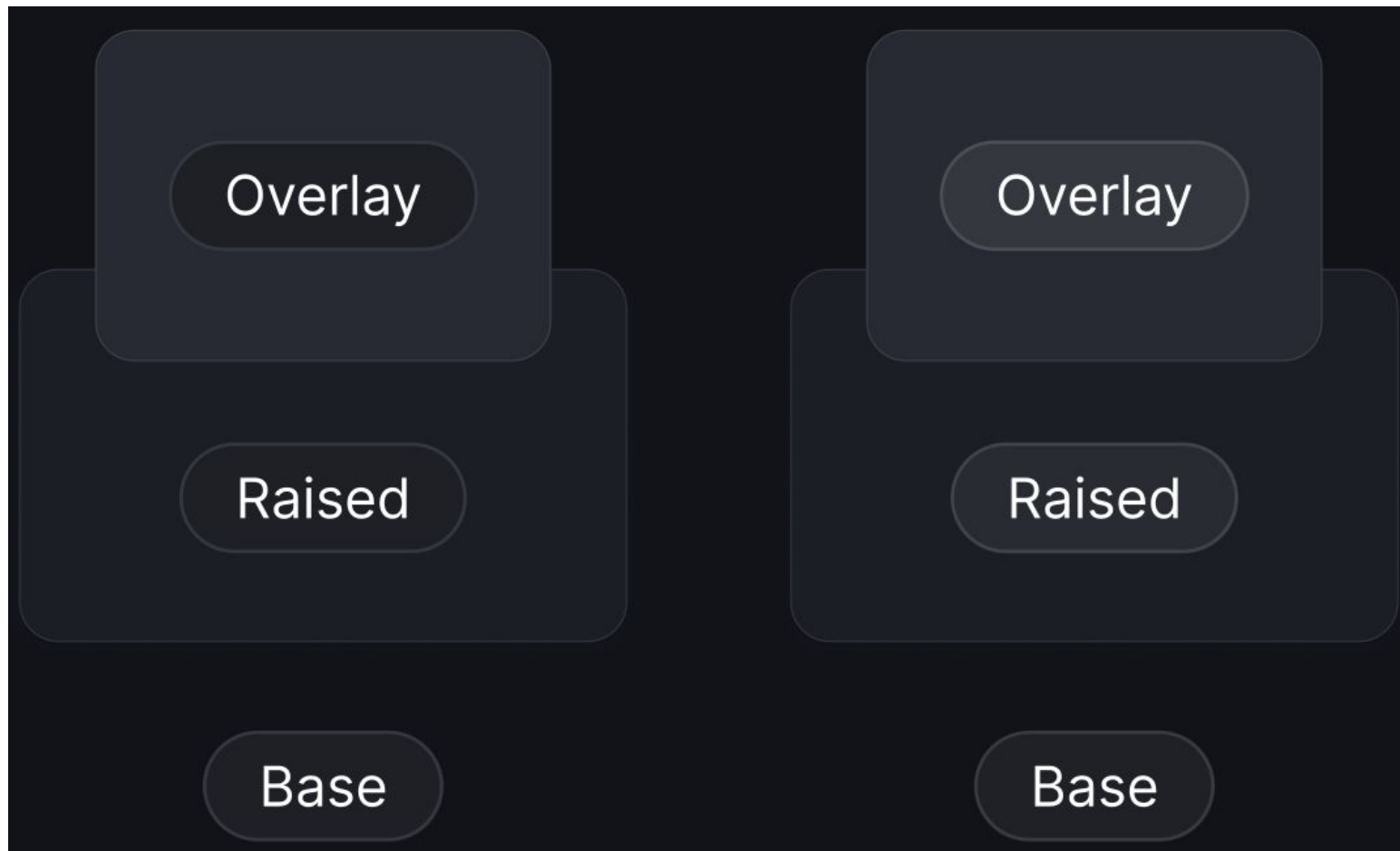
Using varying levels of transparency on foreground elements, allows some of the background color to mix with the foreground color

This layering of color helps us resolve the solid color issue

Example design using transparent color is shown in the next slide

Solid Color

Transparent Color

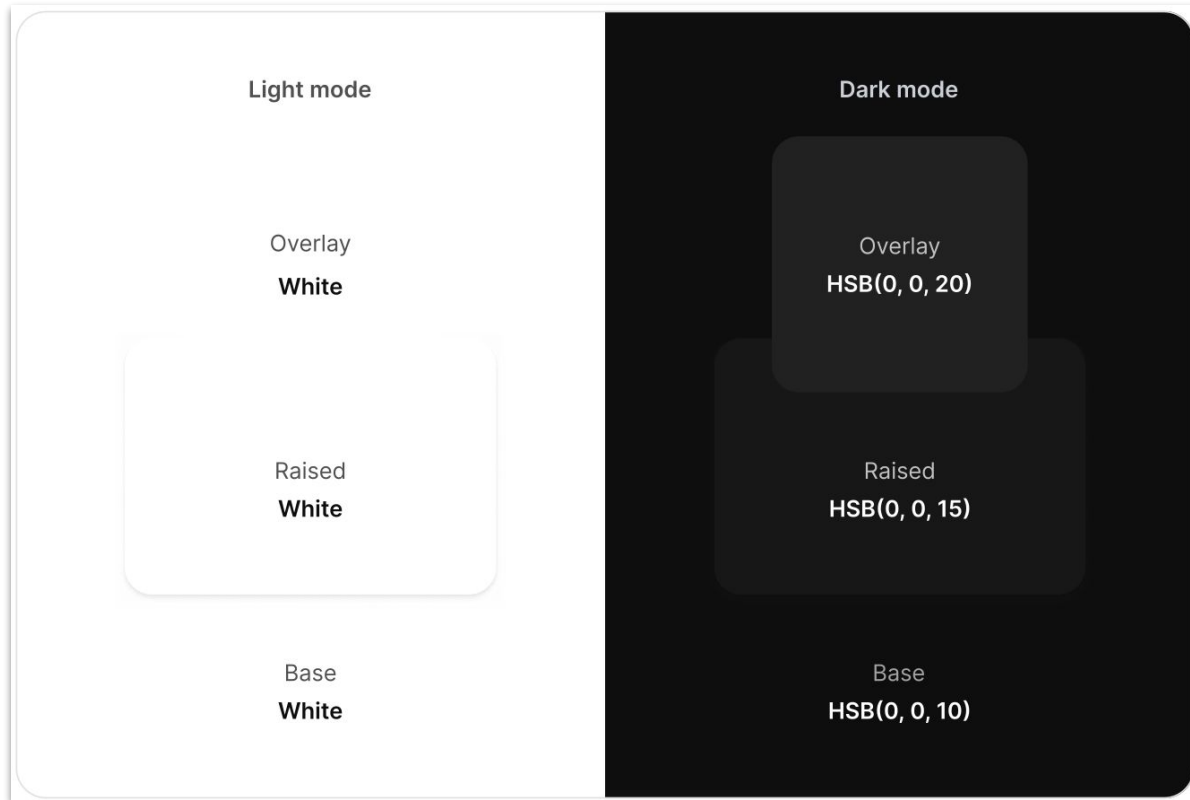


Transparent color palette

Steps to create transparent color palette

1. Define 3 solid background colors
2. Define transparent foreground colors
 - a. Define 5 variations of white for dark mode
 - b. Define 5 variations of black for light mode
3. Define 4 variations of the brand color
4. Define 4 variations of system colors

Define 3 solid background colors

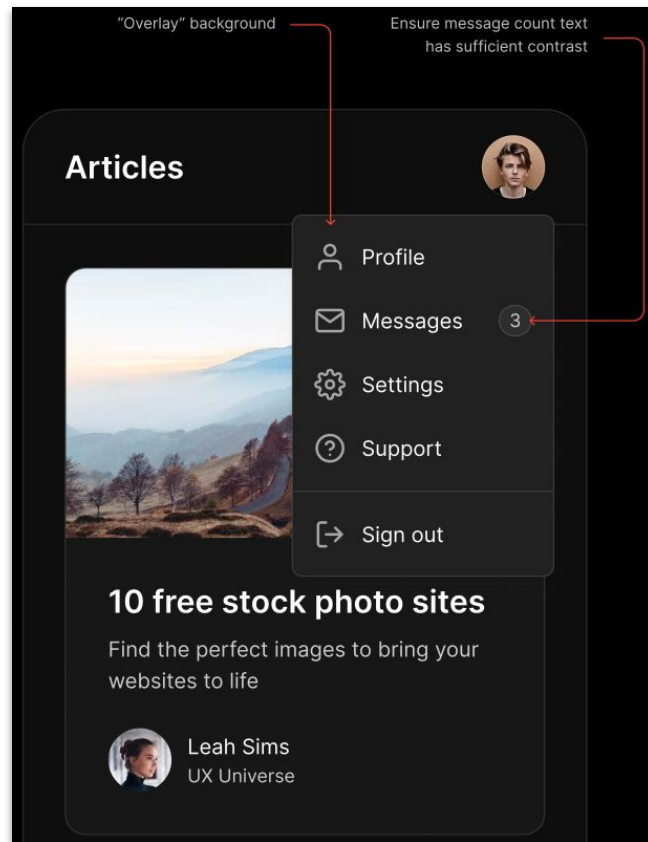


Define 5 variations of white for dark mode

	Text strong 100% opacity	Contrast with fill on overlay background must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text weak 78% opacity	Contrast with fill on overlay background must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Stroke strong 60% opacity	Contrast with fill on overlay background must be at least:	3 : 1
	Stroke weak 12% opacity	This is a decorative colour, so it doesn't need to be high contrast.	
	Fill 6% opacity	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	

Define 5 variations of white for dark mode

Ensure foreground colours used for text and interface elements have sufficient contrast

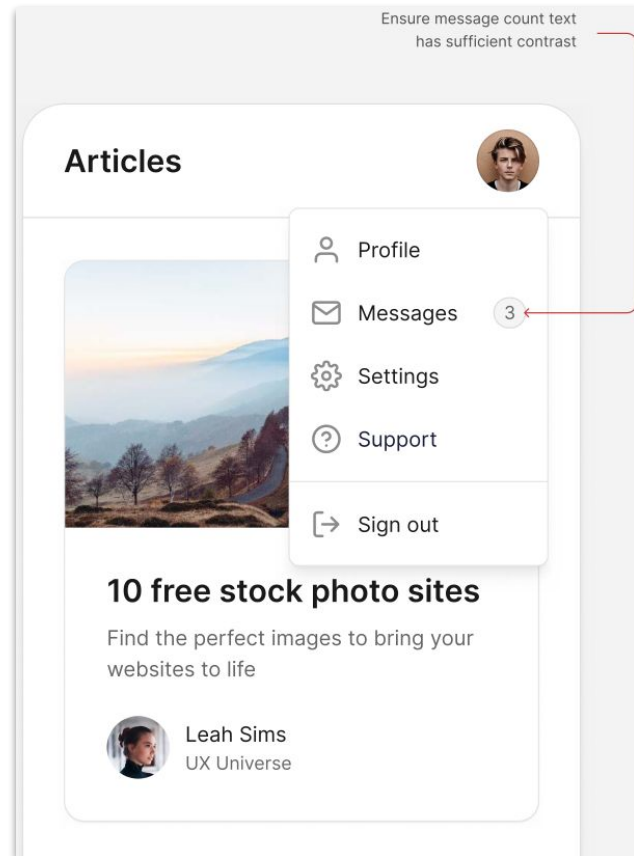


Define 5 variations of black for light mode

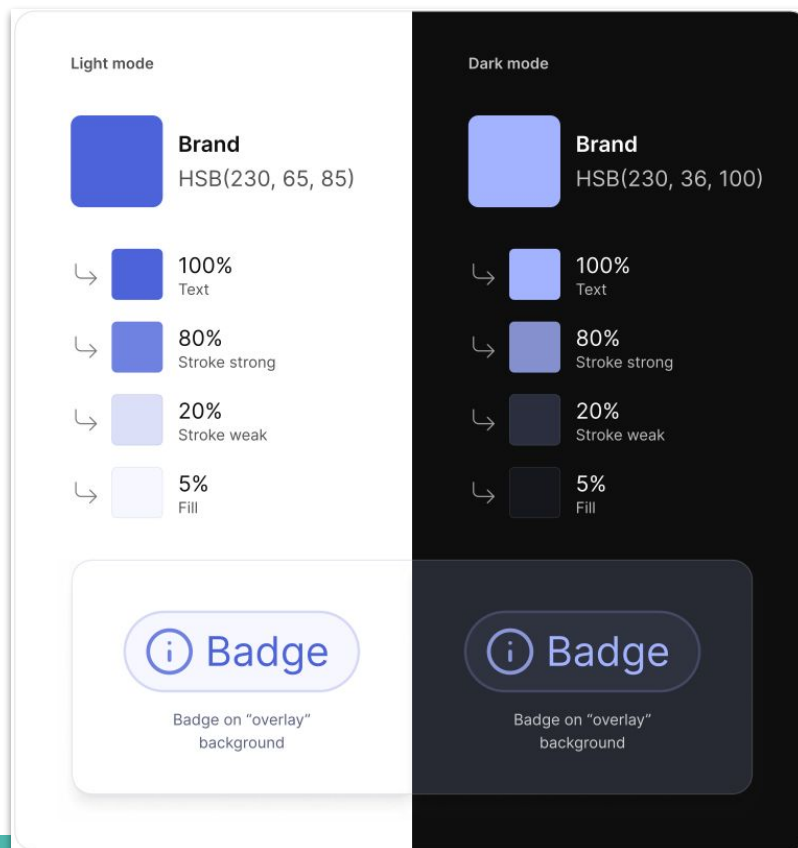
	Text strong 90% opacity	Contrast with fill on background must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Text weak 60% opacity	Contrast with fill on background must be at least:	4.5 : 1
	Stroke strong 45% opacity	Contrast with fill on background must be at least:	3 : 1
	Stroke weak 10% opacity	This is a decorative colour, so it doesn't need to be high contrast.	
	Fill 4% opacity	Text and interface elements sitting on this colour must have sufficient contrast	

Define 5 variations of black for light mode

Ensure foreground colours used for text and interface elements have sufficient contrast



Define 4 variations of the brand colour



Define 4 variations of system colours

Each system colour needs 4 variations in both light and dark mode

Light mode



Red

HSB(0, 71, 78)



Amber

HSB(42, 82, 56)



Green

HSB(162, 95, 48)

Dark mode



Red

HSB(0, 39, 100)



Amber

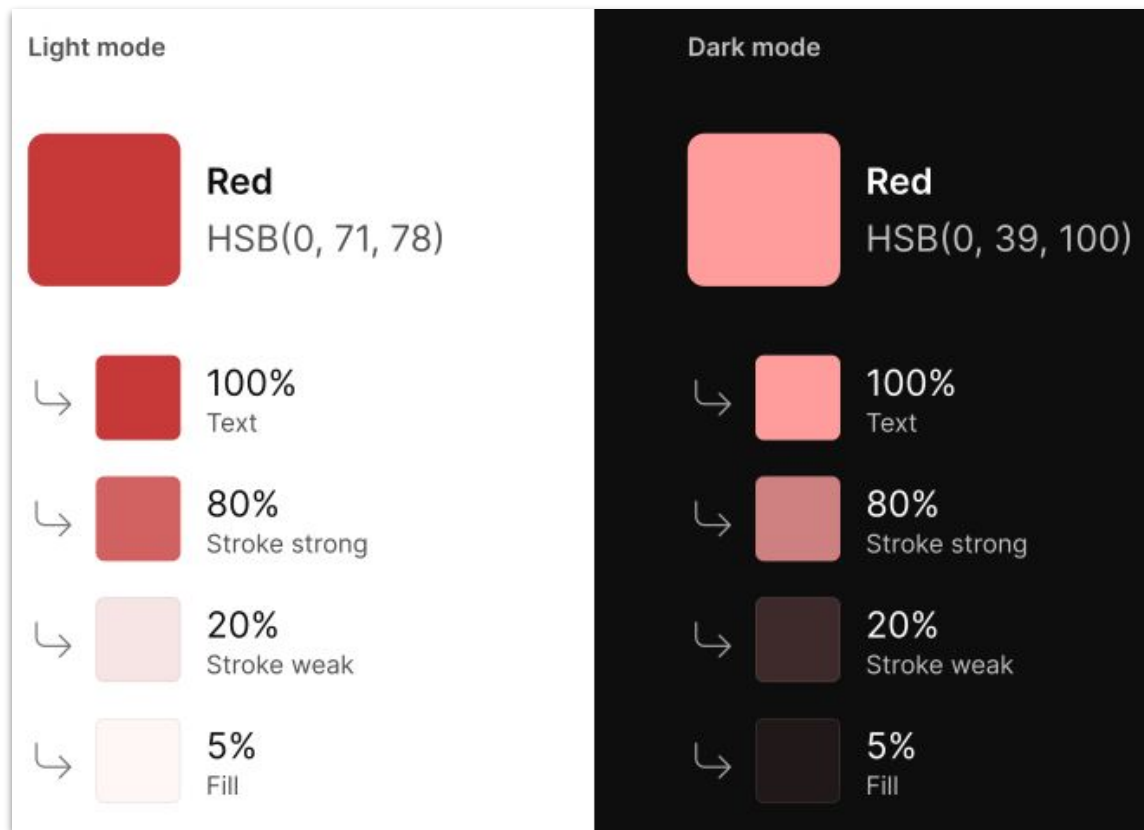
HSB(42, 50, 88)



Green

HSB(162, 40, 78)

Define 4 variations of system colours



Define 4 variations of system colours

Light mode



Amber

HSB(42, 82, 56)



100%

Text



80%

Stroke strong



20%

Stroke weak



5%

Fill

Dark mode



Amber

HSB(42, 50, 88)



100%

Text



80%

Stroke strong



20%

Stroke weak



5%

Fill

Define 4 variations of system colours

Light mode



Green

HSB(162, 95, 48)



100%
Text



80%
Stroke strong



20%
Stroke weak



5%
Fill

Dark mode



Green

HSB(162, 40, 78)



100%
Text



80%
Stroke strong

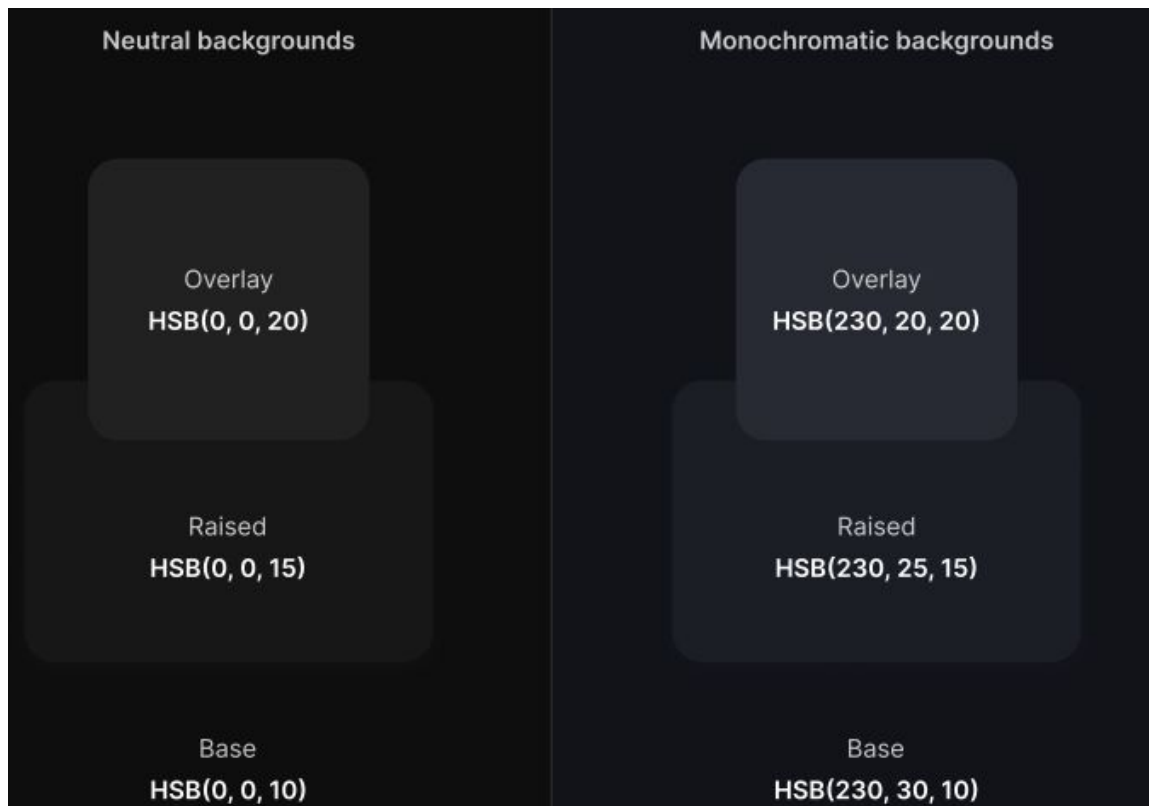


20%
Stroke weak



5%
Fill

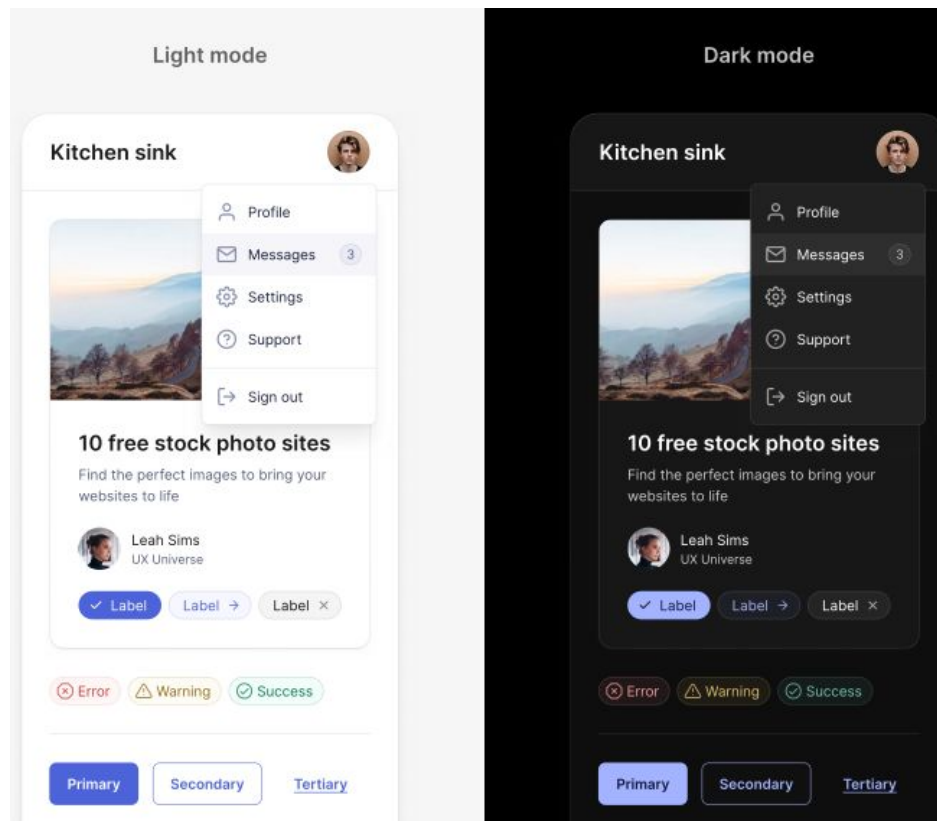
Monochromatic transparent color palette



Monochromatic transparent color palette

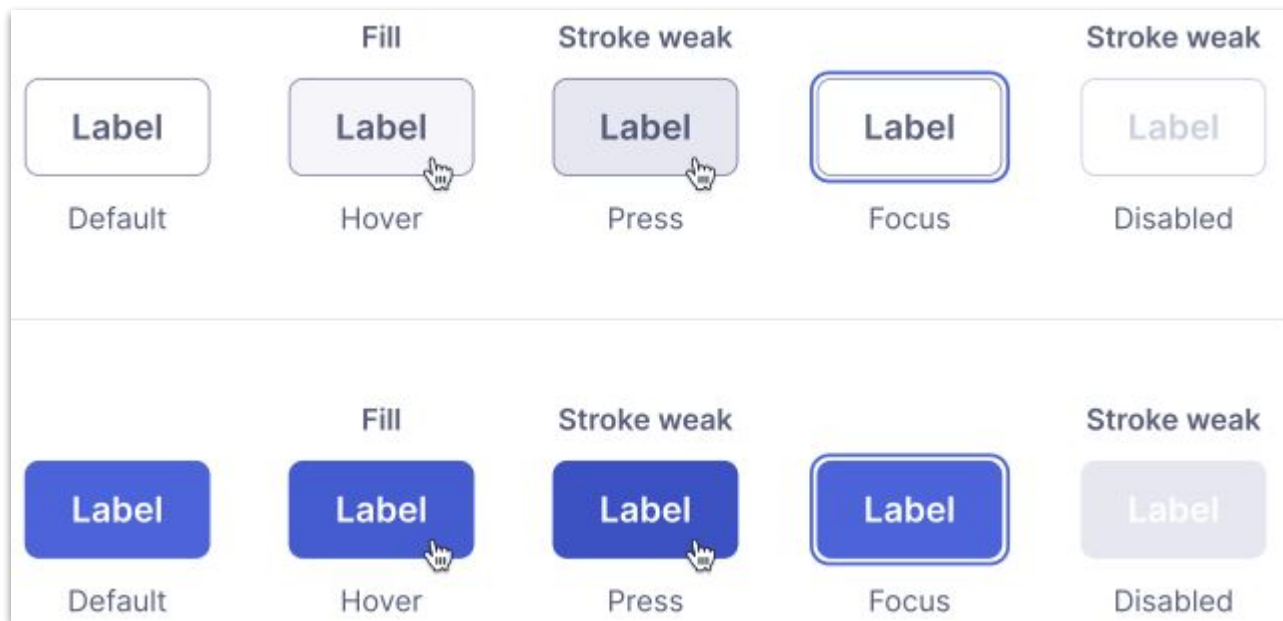
Neutral greys	Monochromatic greys
 Text strong HSB(0, 0, 0) 90%	 Text strong HSB(230, 100, 15) 90%
 Text weak HSB(0, 0, 0) 60%	 Text weak HSB(230, 100, 20) 65%
 Stroke strong HSB(0, 0, 0) 45%	 Stroke strong HSB(230, 100, 30) 45%
 Stroke weak HSB(0, 0, 0) 10%	 Stroke weak HSB(230, 100, 40) 10%
 Fill HSB(0, 0, 0) 4%	 Fill HSB(230, 100, 50) 4%

Using the transparent color palette



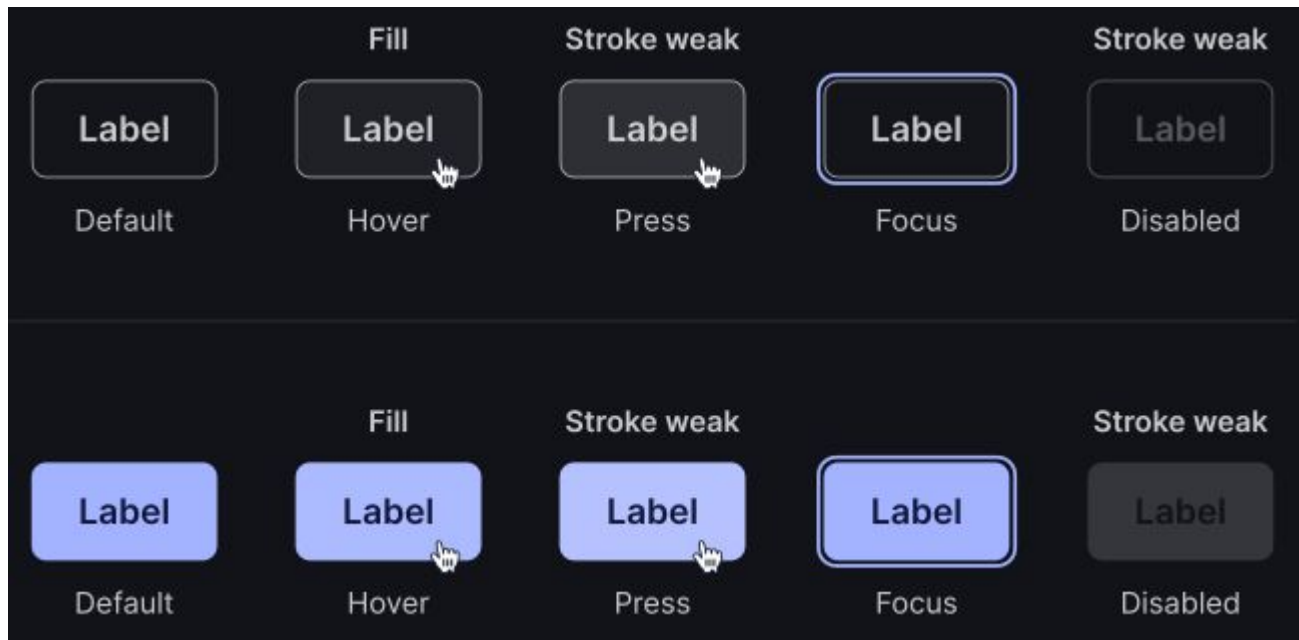
Using the transparent color palette

A transparent overlay is layered on top of interactive elements on hover and press



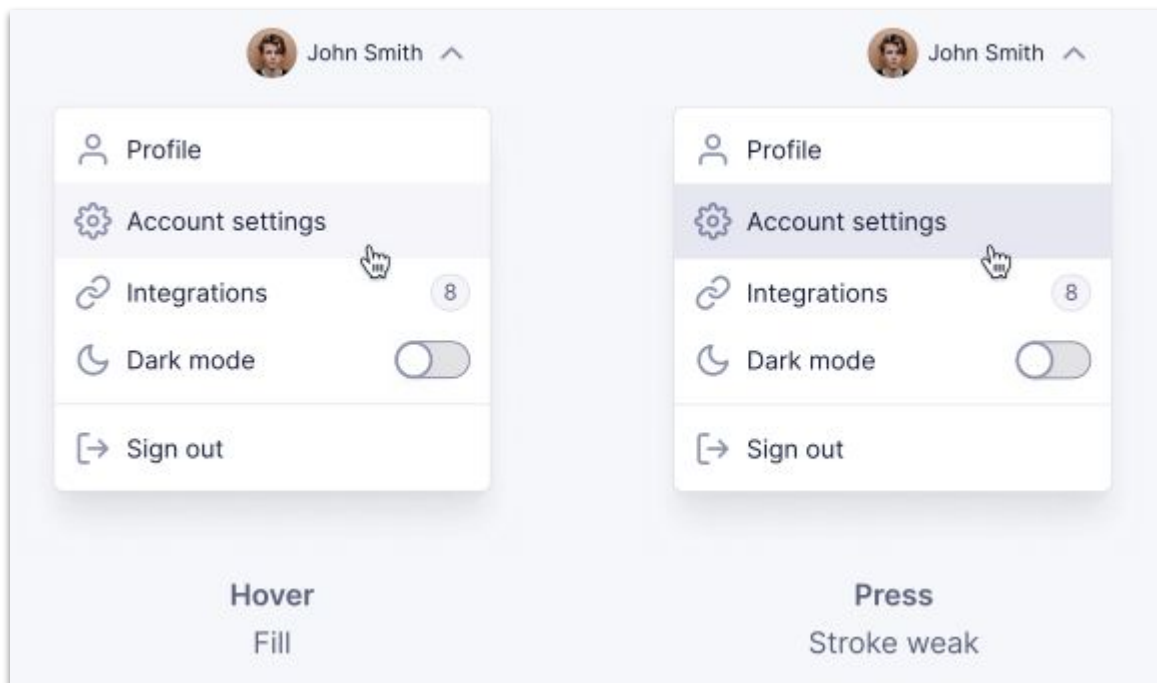
Using the transparent color palette

A transparent overlay is layered on top of interactive elements on hover and press



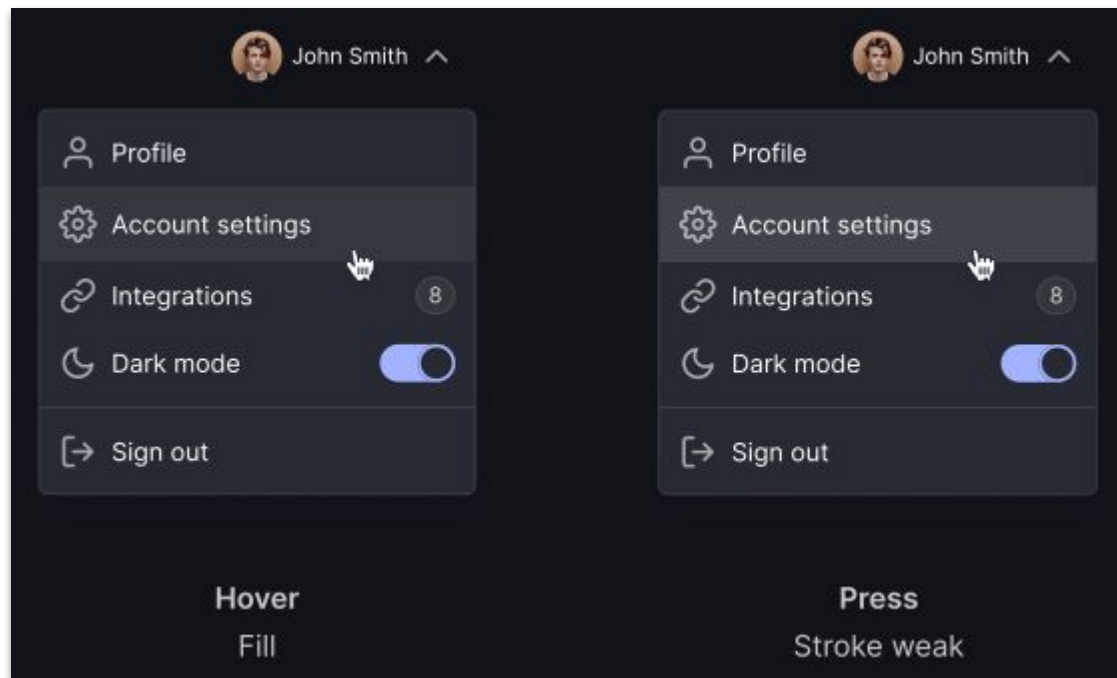
Using the transparent color palette

Transparent overlays applied to a drop down menu



Using the transparent color palette

Transparent overlays applied to a drop down menu



Name colors to keep them organised

Colors are commonly named in 2 ways

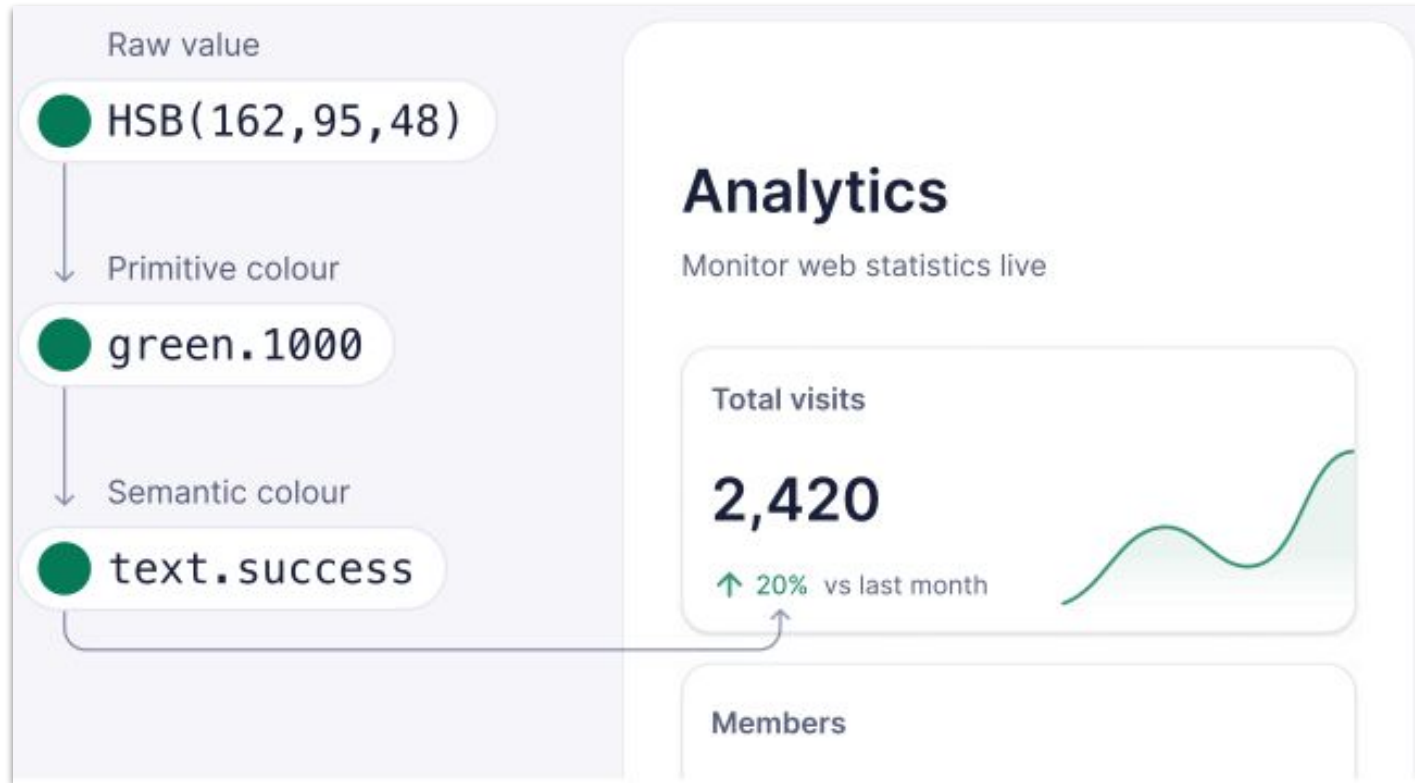
Primitive colors - includes all available colors in the design system

Colors are named based on their appearance and shouldn't be used directly in your designs

Semantic colors - also known as “**color tokens**”, refers to a way of naming primitive colours based on how they should be used

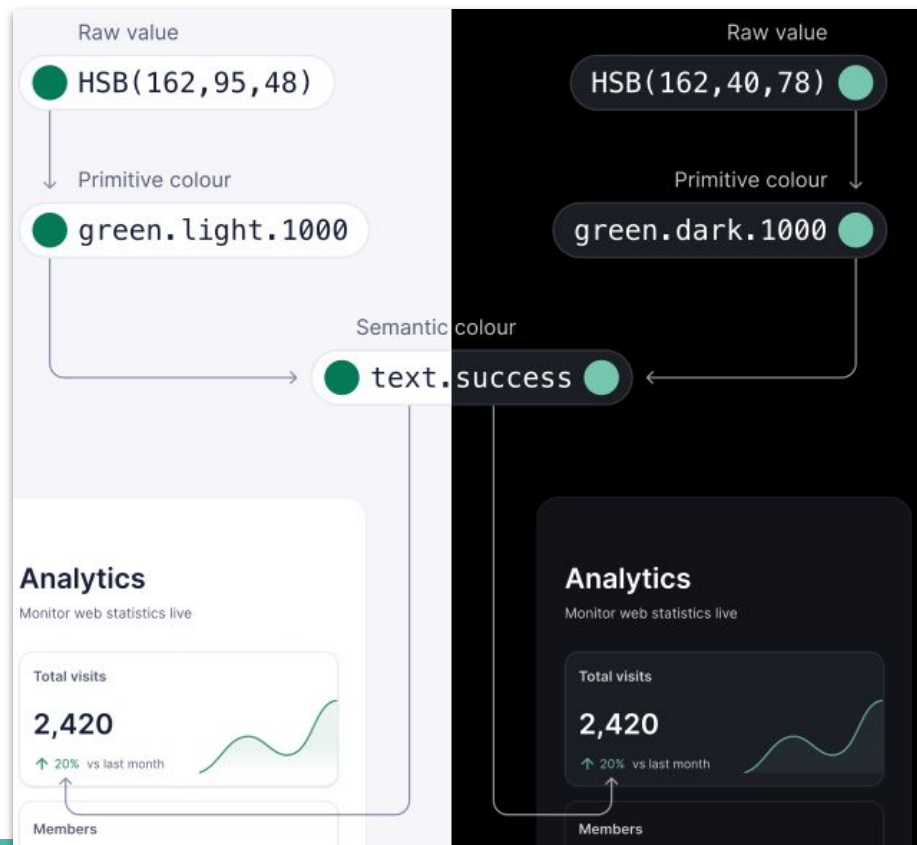
A single primitive color can be used for multiple semantic colors. Use semantic colors directly in your designs

The relationship between primitive and semantic colors



The relationship between primitive and semantic colors

A single semantic color maps to different primitives in light and dark mode



Naming primitive colors

Name primitive colors based on their appearance

Assign each variation of a color hue a number from 0 to 1000

This indicates its level of contrast relative to the other variations

1000 has the highest level of contrast

Primitive color names should have the following format:

[color.number]

Naming primitive colors

Primitive grey colors in light and dark mode

Light mode



grey.light.1000

HSBA(230, 100, 15)

90%



grey.light.700

HSB(230, 100, 20)

65%



grey.light.500

HSB(230, 100, 30)

45%



grey.light.100

HSB(230, 100, 40)

10%



grey.light.50

HSB(230, 100, 50)

5%

Dark mode



grey.dark.1000

White

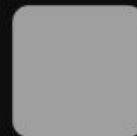
100%



grey.dark.700

White

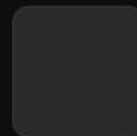
78%



grey.dark.500

White

60%



grey.dark.100

White

12%



grey.dark.50

White

6%

Naming primitive colors

Primitive green colors in light and dark mode

Light mode



green.light.1000
HSB(162, 95, 48)
100%



green.light.800
HSB(162, 95, 48)
80%



green.light.200
HSB(162, 95, 48)
20%



green.light.50
HSB(162, 95, 48)
5%

Dark mode



green.dark.1000
HSB(162, 40, 78)
100%



green.dark.800
HSB(162, 40, 78)
80%



green.dark.200
HSB(162, 40, 78)
20%



green.dark.50
HSB(162, 40, 78)
5%

Naming primitive colors

You can add more color variations as you need them



grey.light.25
HSB(230, 100, 50)
2.5%



grey.dark.25
White
3%

Naming semantic colors

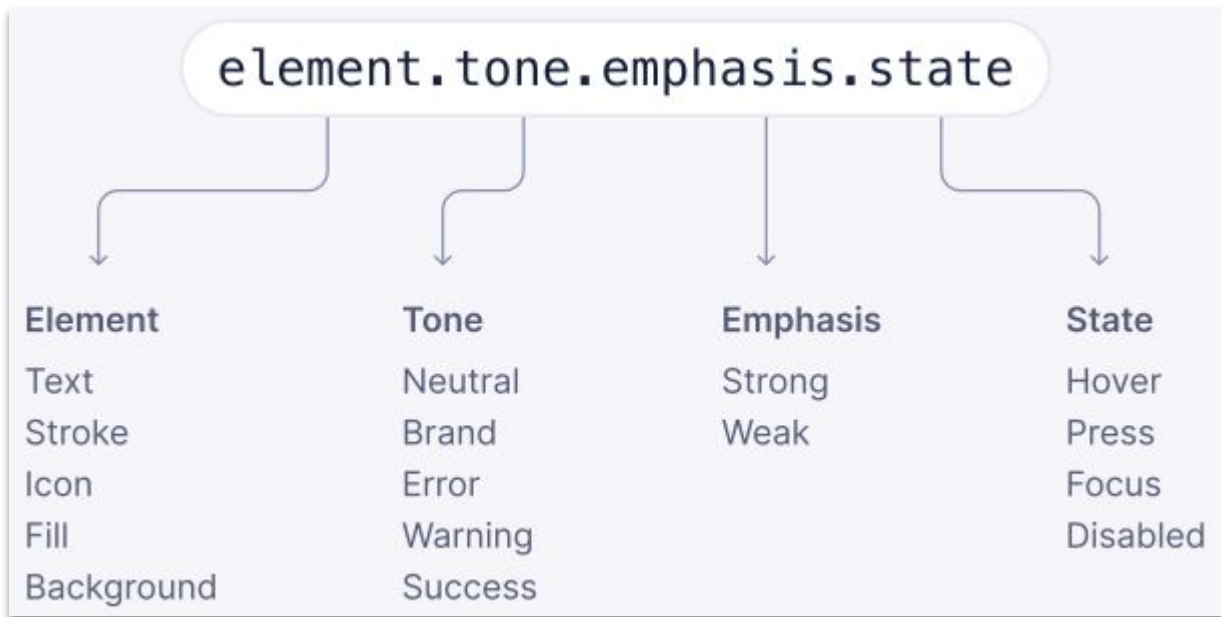
You can use the following naming approach

The name of each color consists of up to 4 words that describe how and where to use the color on an interface

`[element.tone.emphasis.state]`

Naming semantic colors

`[element.tone.emphasis.state]`



Naming semantic colors

Examples

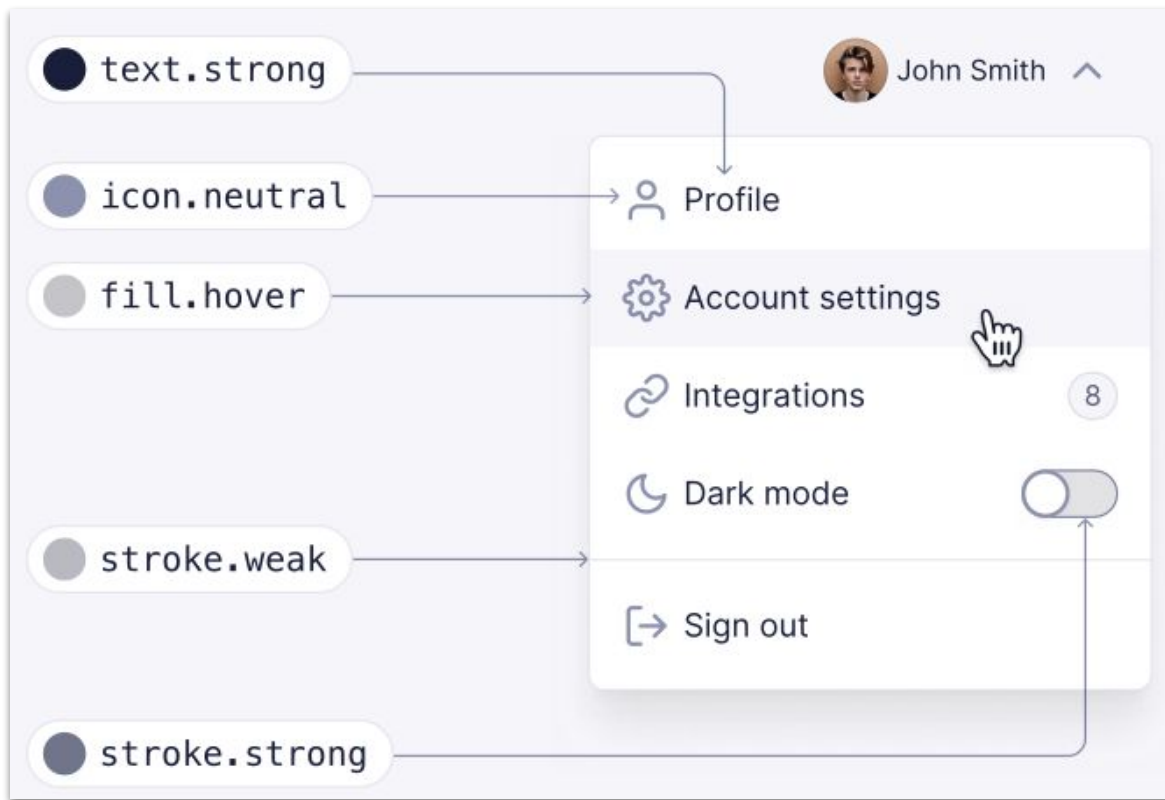
text.error - used for error messages on forms

stroke.strong - used for form input field borders

fill.success.weak - used for the background of success alert messages

Naming semantic colors

Semantic color naming
usage



Match photo color temperature to the color palette

Some photos look warmer or more orange and others look cooler or more blue

If your color palette is based on a cool color like blue, using photos with a cooler color temperature can help create a more cohesive look and feel

The opposite applies to warm colour palette

You can use a photo editing tool to adjust the color temperature of photos

Match photo color temperature to the color palette

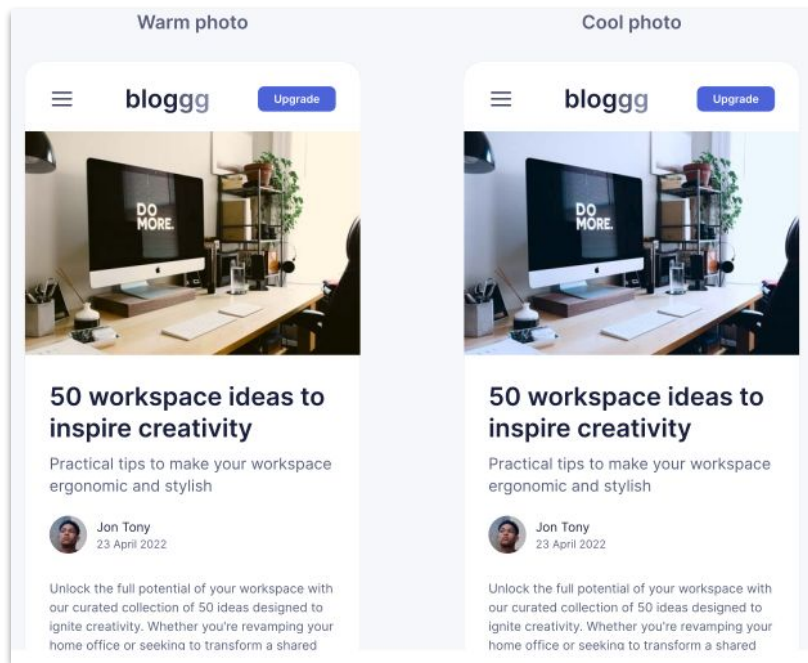
In the following diagram the middle photo is the original

The color temperature of the left photo was decreased, while the one on the right was increased



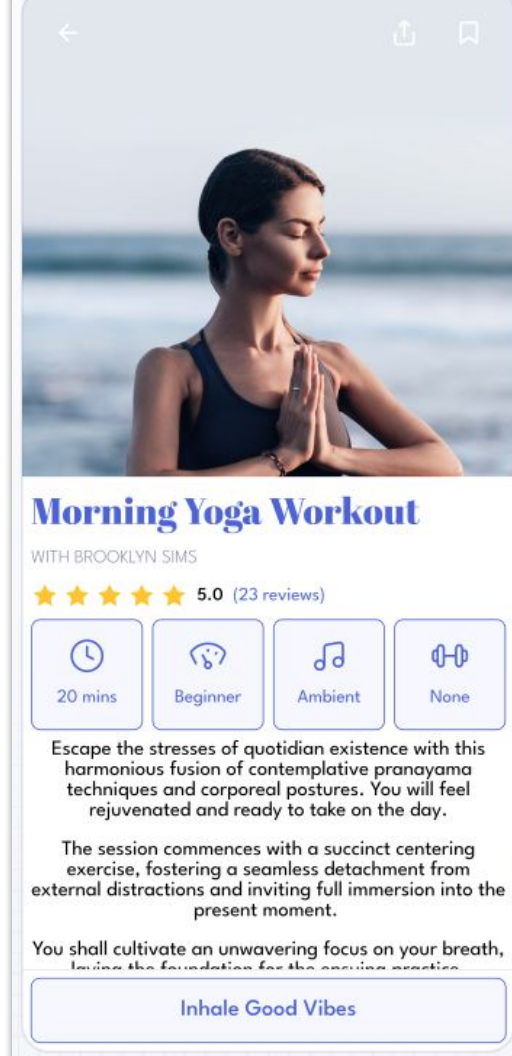
Match photo color temperature to the color palette

The below example demonstrates how a warm photo can conflict with a cool color palette



Applying the Color Guideline

Identify any color-related issues in the displayed UI design



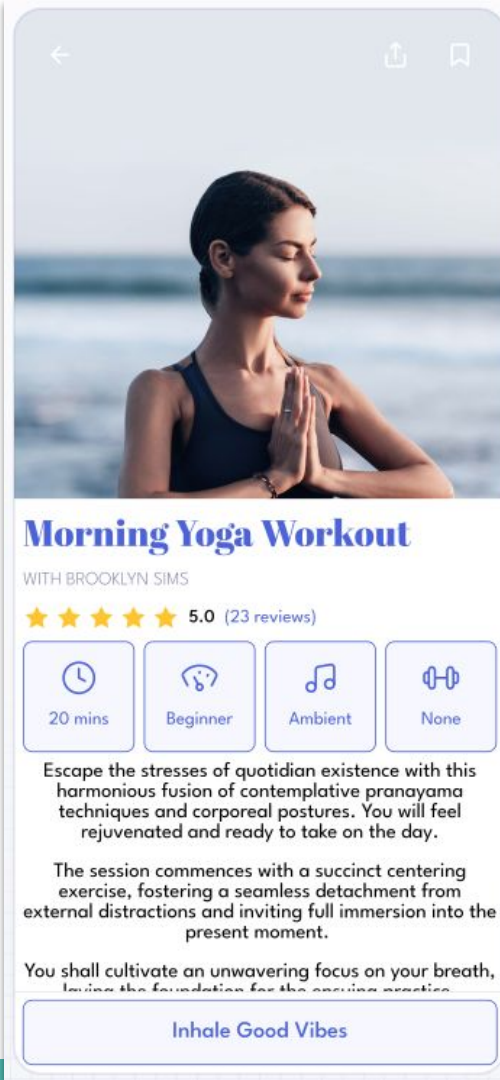
Color palette



Apply brand color to interactive elements

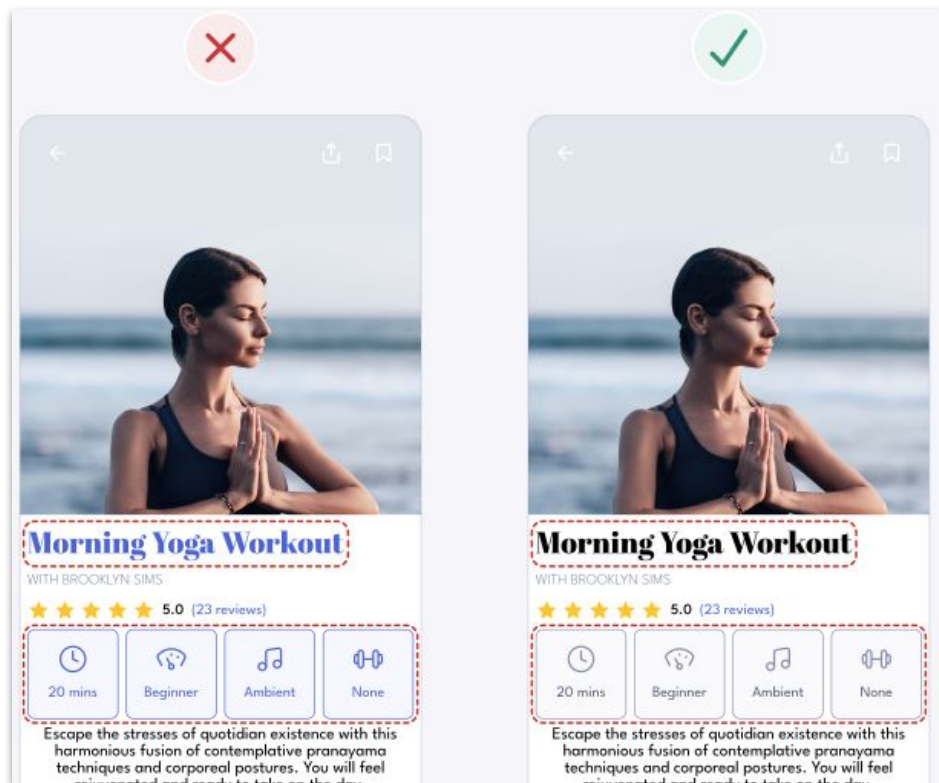
Issues in brand color usage

non-interactive elements like the heading and icons are using the brand color



Apply brand color to interactive elements

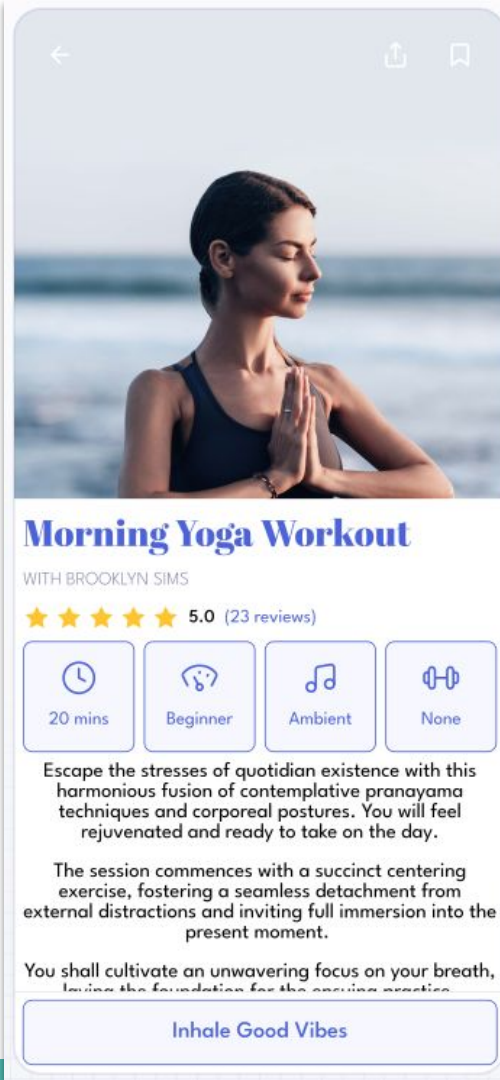
Remove the brand color from the heading and icons, as they're not interactive



Ensure a 3:1 contrast ratio

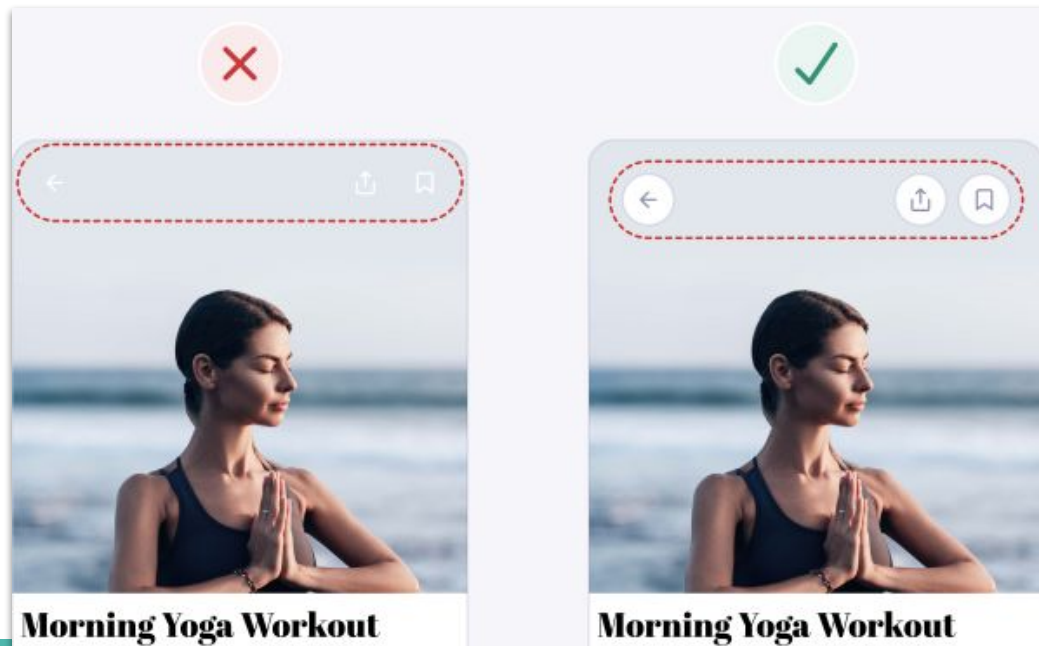
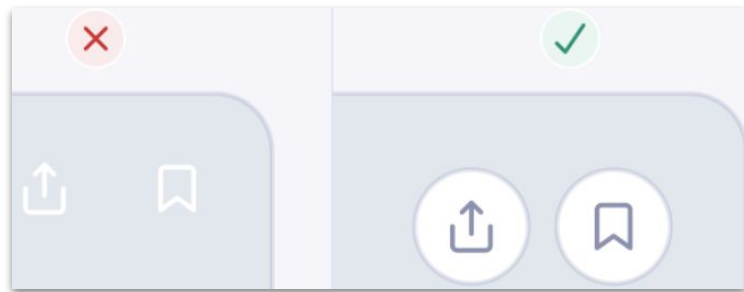
Issue related to interface element color contrast

the contrast of the icons sitting on the photo is too low



Ensure a 3:1 contrast ratio

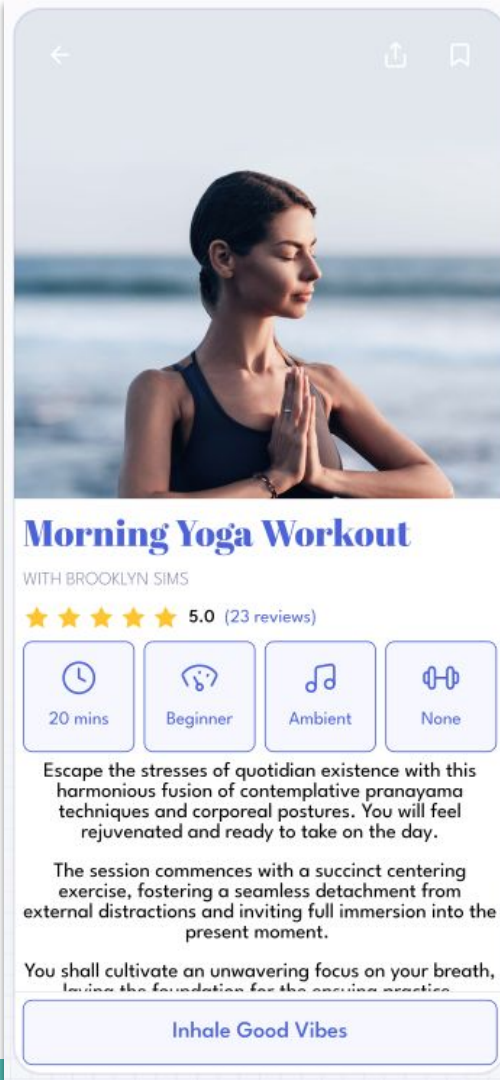
Use the “Stroke strong” color from the palette and add a solid white background to the icons to give them sufficient 3:1 contrast



Ensure a 3:1 contrast ratio

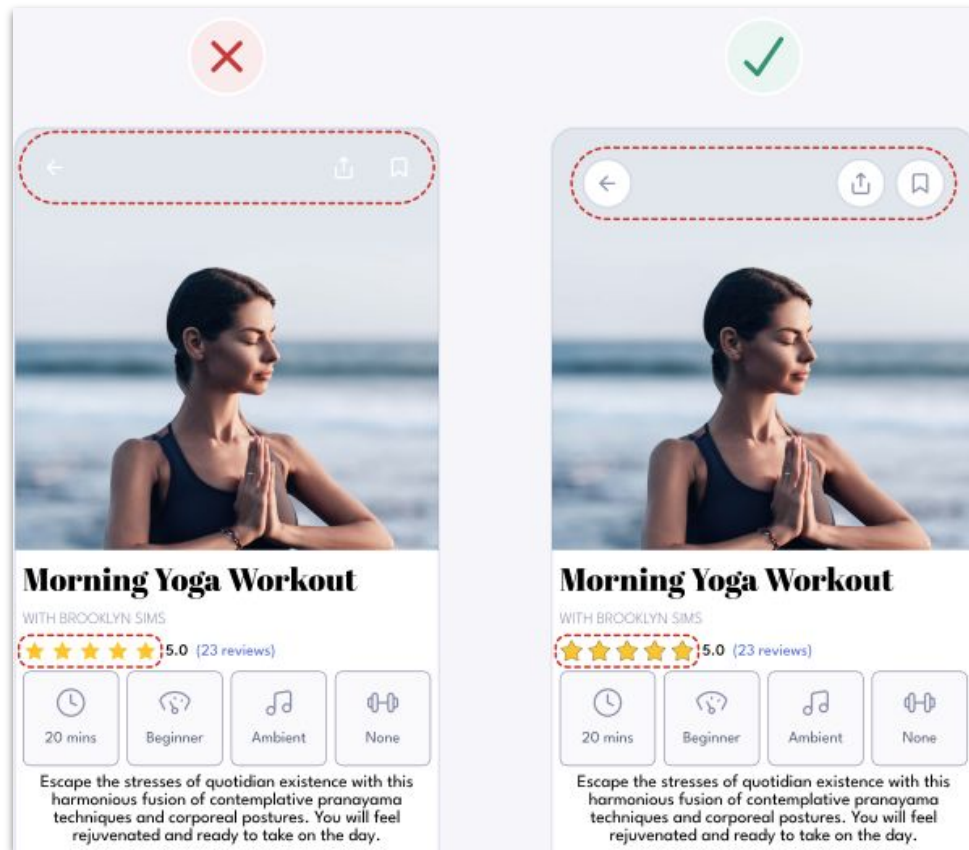
Issue related to interface element color contrast

the contrast of the star ratings are also less than 3:1



Ensure a 3:1 contrast ratio

Add a darker border to give them sufficient contrast



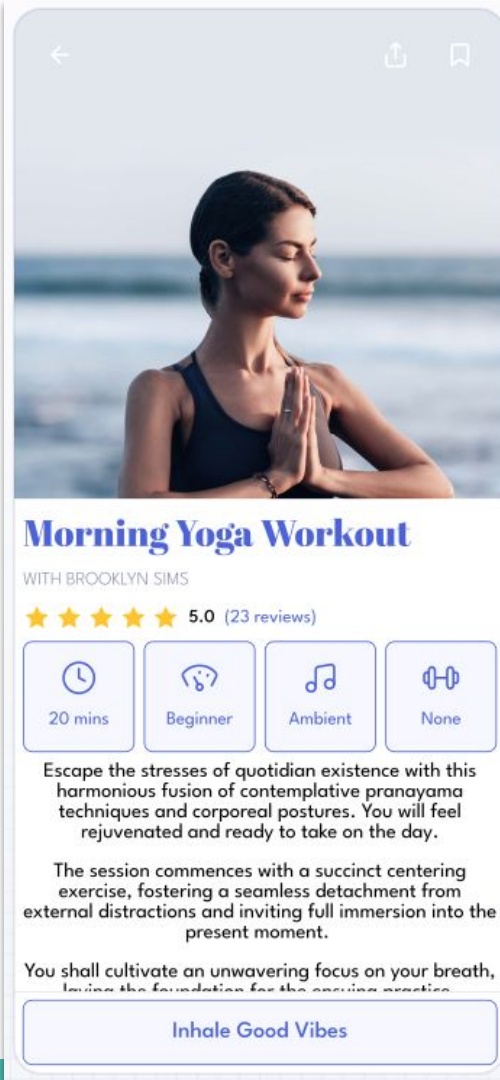
Ensure a 4.5:1 contrast ratio

Issue related to text color contrast

The contrast of the trainer's name is too low

The thin font weight makes it even harder to read

Using the "Text weak" color from the palette helps make the text more legible



Ensure a 4.5:1 contrast ratio

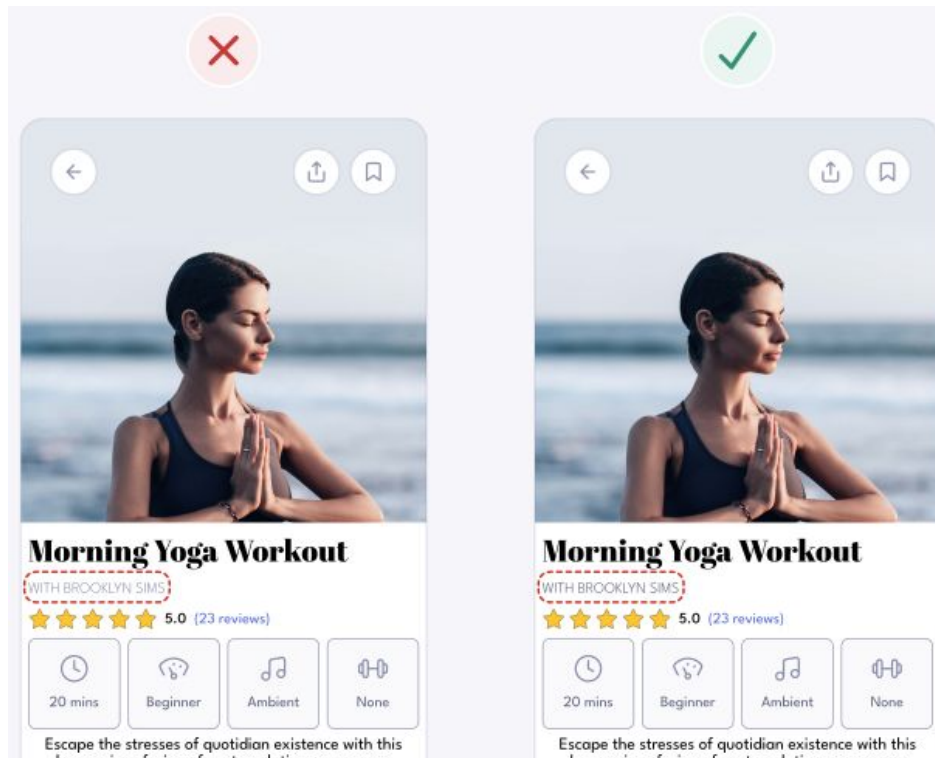
Issue related to text color contrast



WITH BROOKLYN SIMS



WITH BROOKLYN SIMS

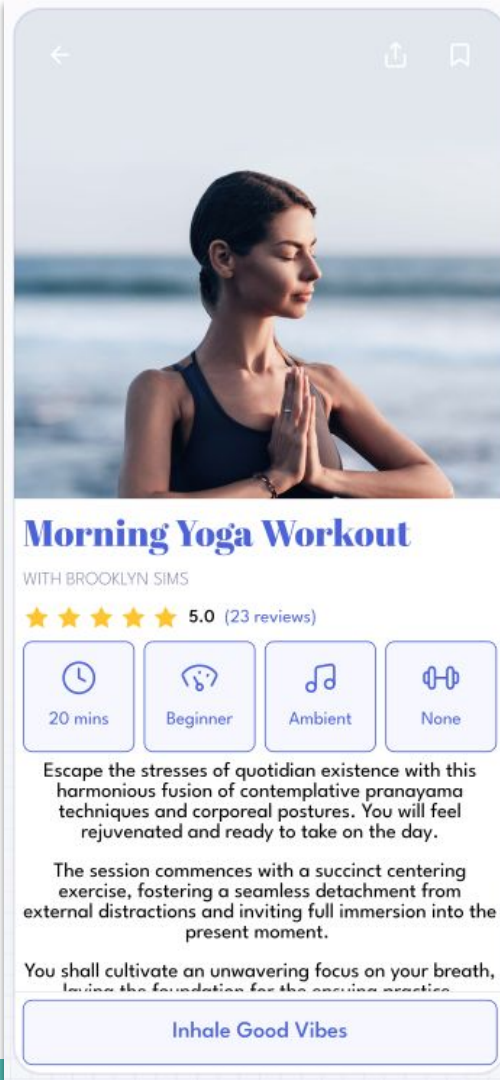


Don't rely on color alone as an indicator

Issue

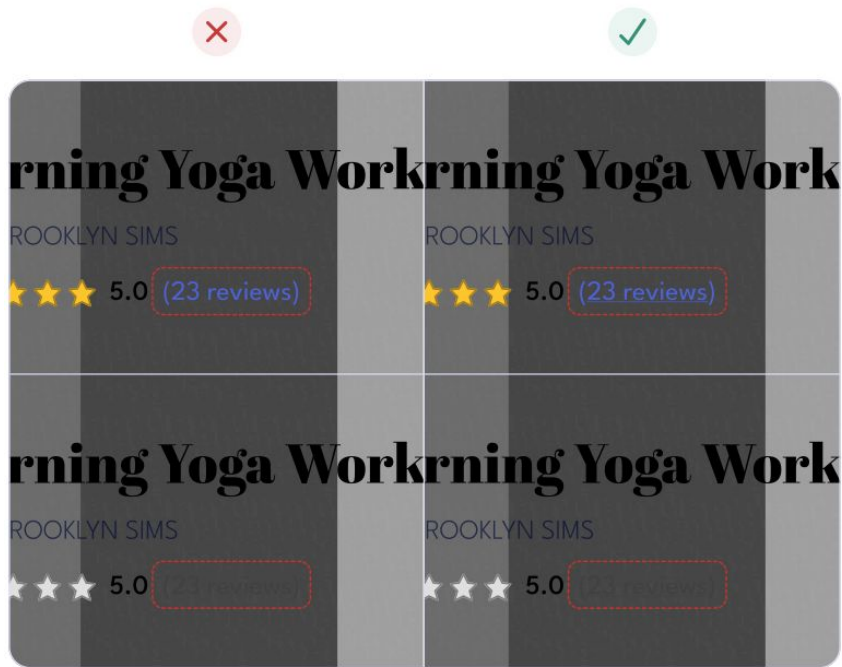
The brand colour is used on the “reviews” text to indicate that it’s a link

If color is removed, the link text looks the same as other text, so people who are color blind won't be able to tell it's a link



Don't rely on color alone as an indicator

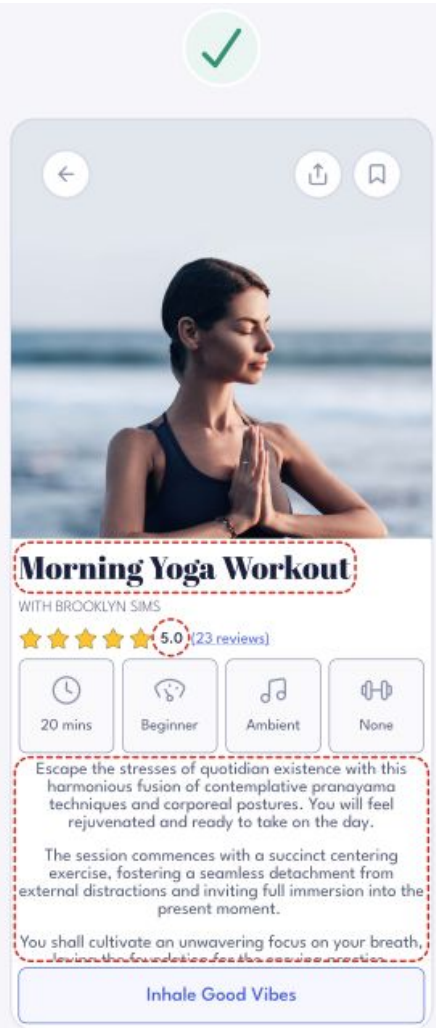
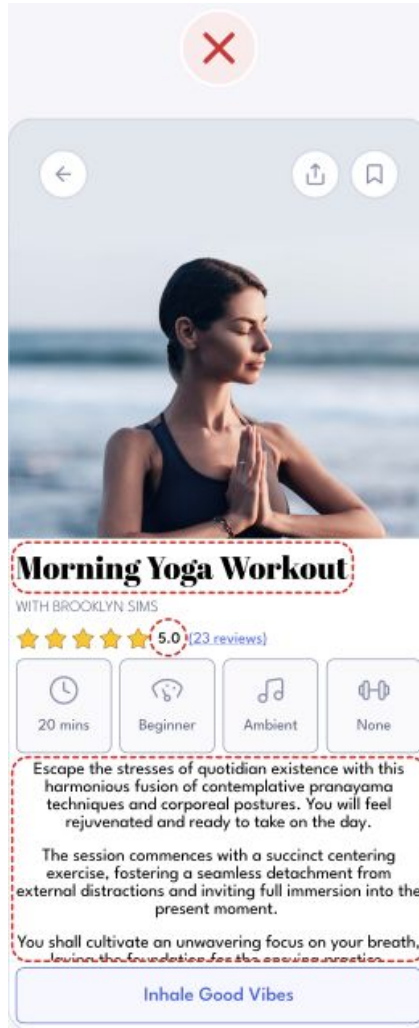
Underline the link text to clearly differentiate it from other text in the absence of color



Avoid pure black

Pure black is used for multiple text elements

Using dark grey instead helps to improve readability



Layout and Spacing Usage Guidelines

The slide features a light blue background with a central title in orange. The title is framed by two horizontal teal bars at the top and bottom. Below the top teal bar is a thin light blue line. Below the bottom teal bar is a thin light blue line. Two short, thick olive green bars are positioned horizontally on either side of the title, centered vertically relative to the text.

Group related elements

Breaking up information into smaller groups of related elements makes it faster and easier for people to understand and remember

Group related elements

Group related elements using the following methods

1. Place related elements in the same container
2. Space related elements close together
3. Make related elements look similar
4. Align related elements in a continuous line

Place related elements in the same container

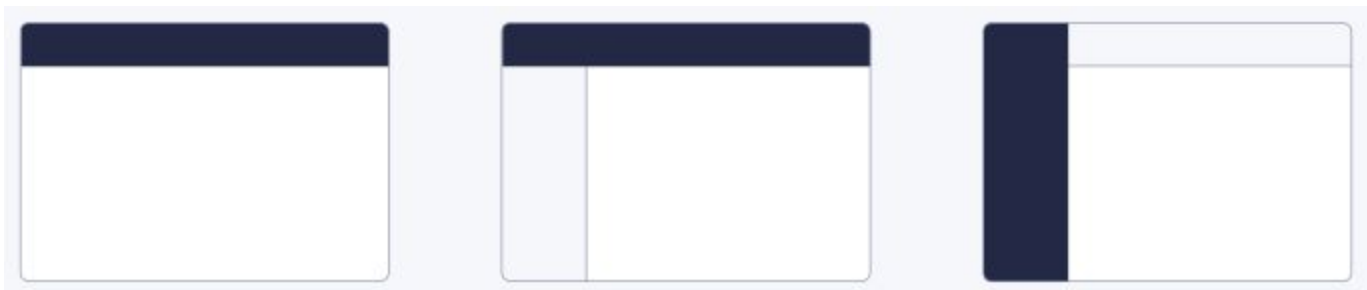
According to the principle of common region, items within the same boundary or container are perceived as a group and assumed to be related

You can create containers using borders, shadows, and background colours

Using containers is the strongest visual cue to group interface elements

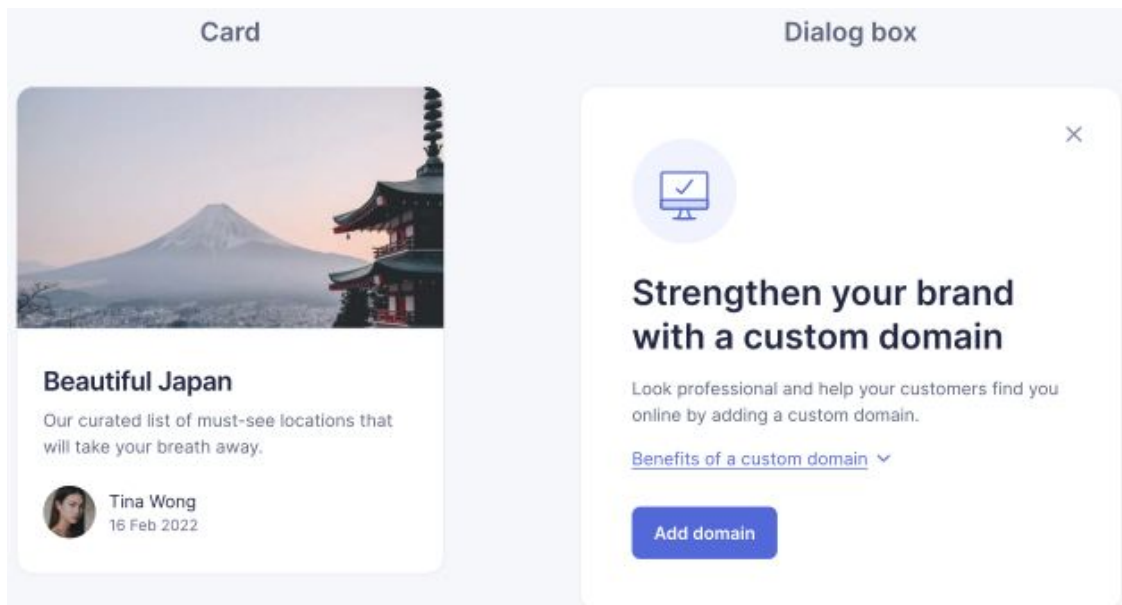
Place related elements in the same container

Containers are often used to create the main structure of an interface



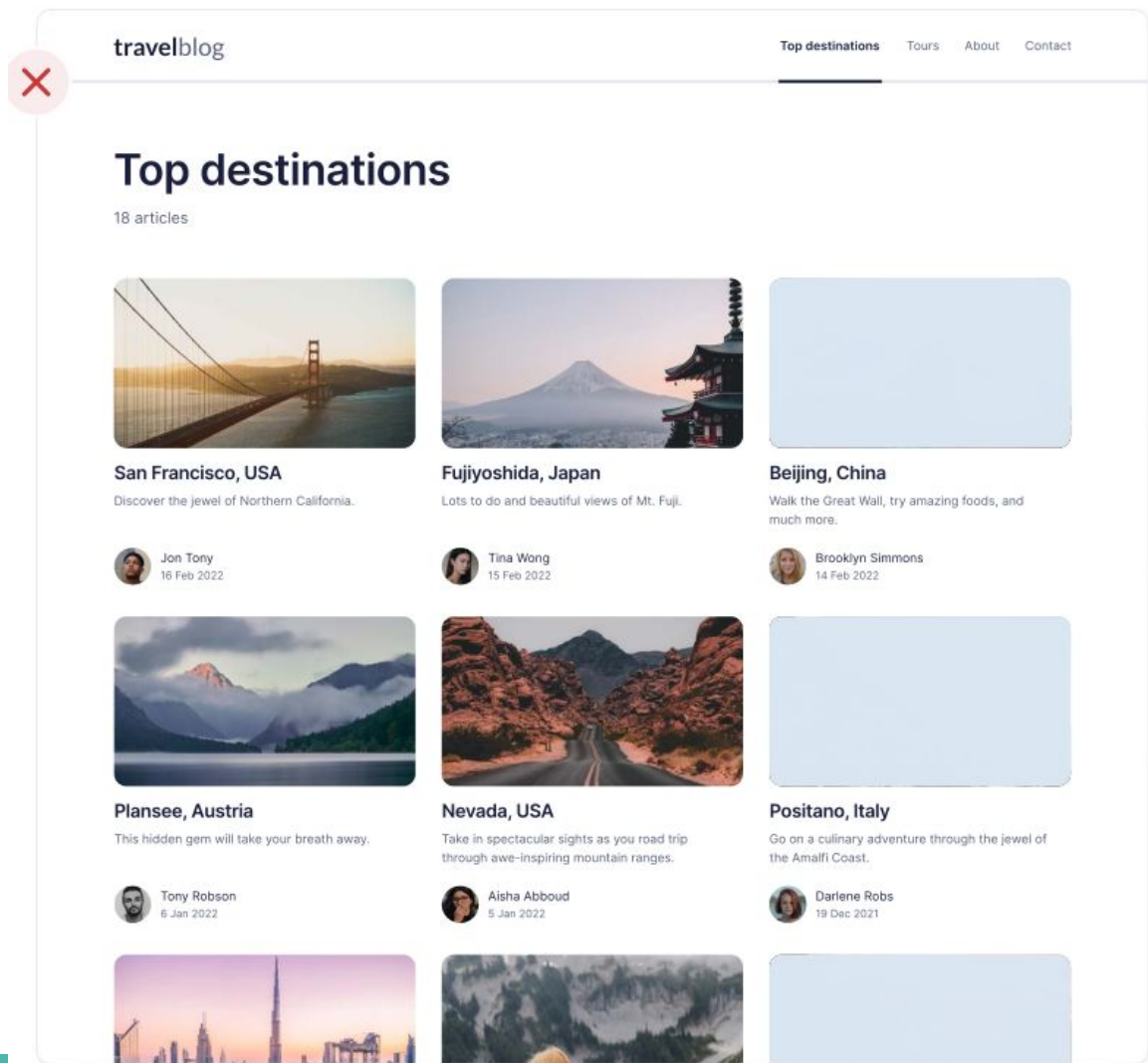
Place related elements in the same container

Cards and dialog boxes are a common type of container used to group smaller pieces of related content



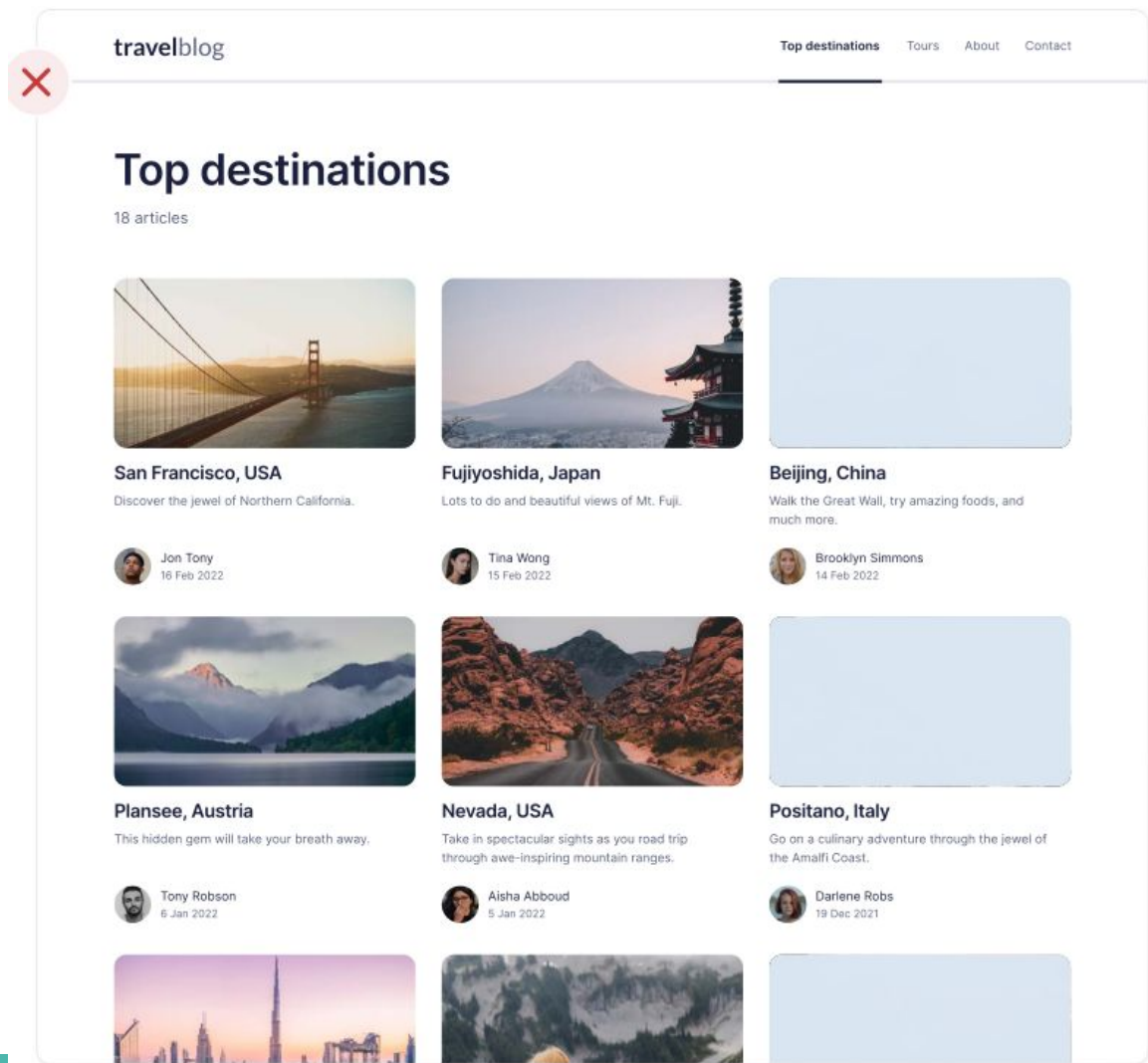
Place related elements in the same container

What is the issue with the UI design displayed?

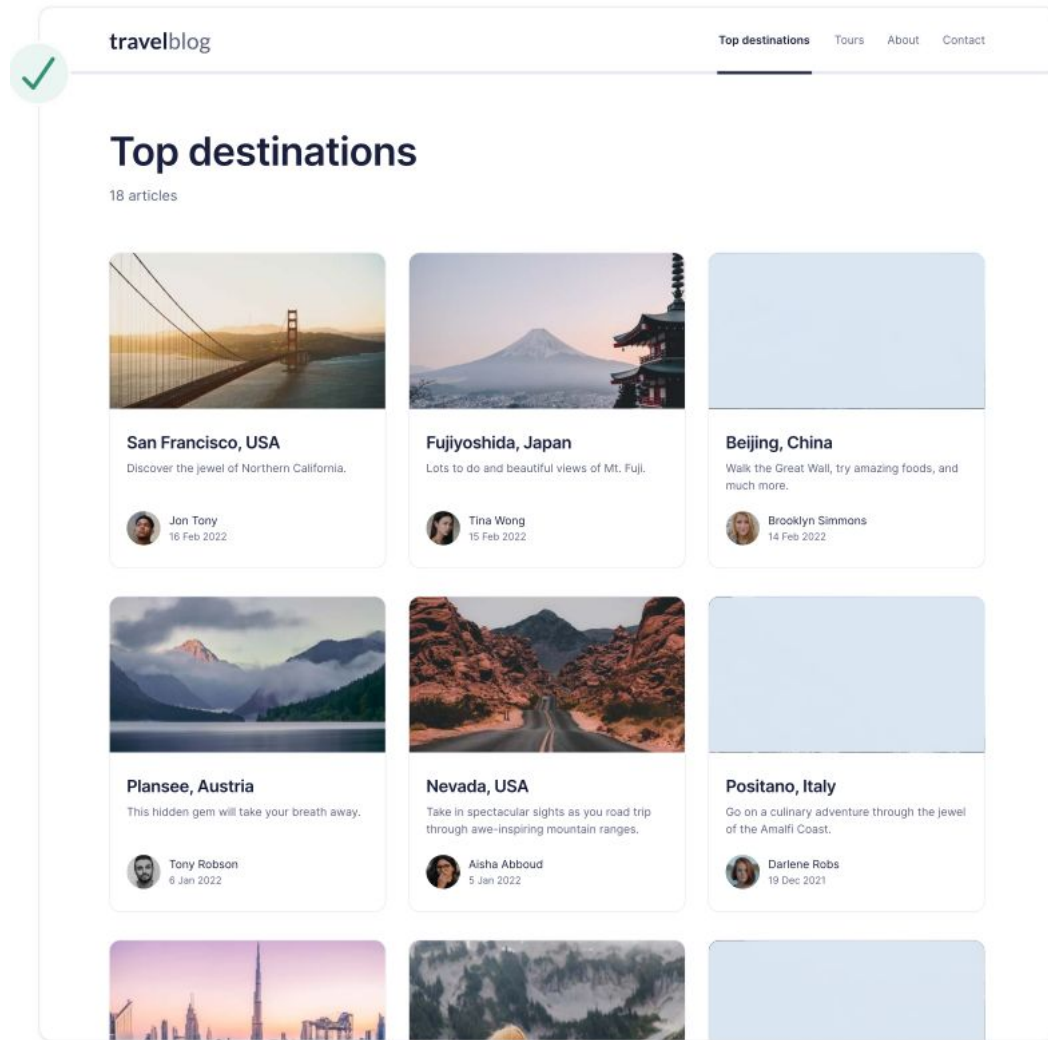


What is the issue with the UI design displayed?

It's difficult to tell who wrote each article due to unclear groupings



Containers are used to clearly associate the author with their article



Space related elements close together

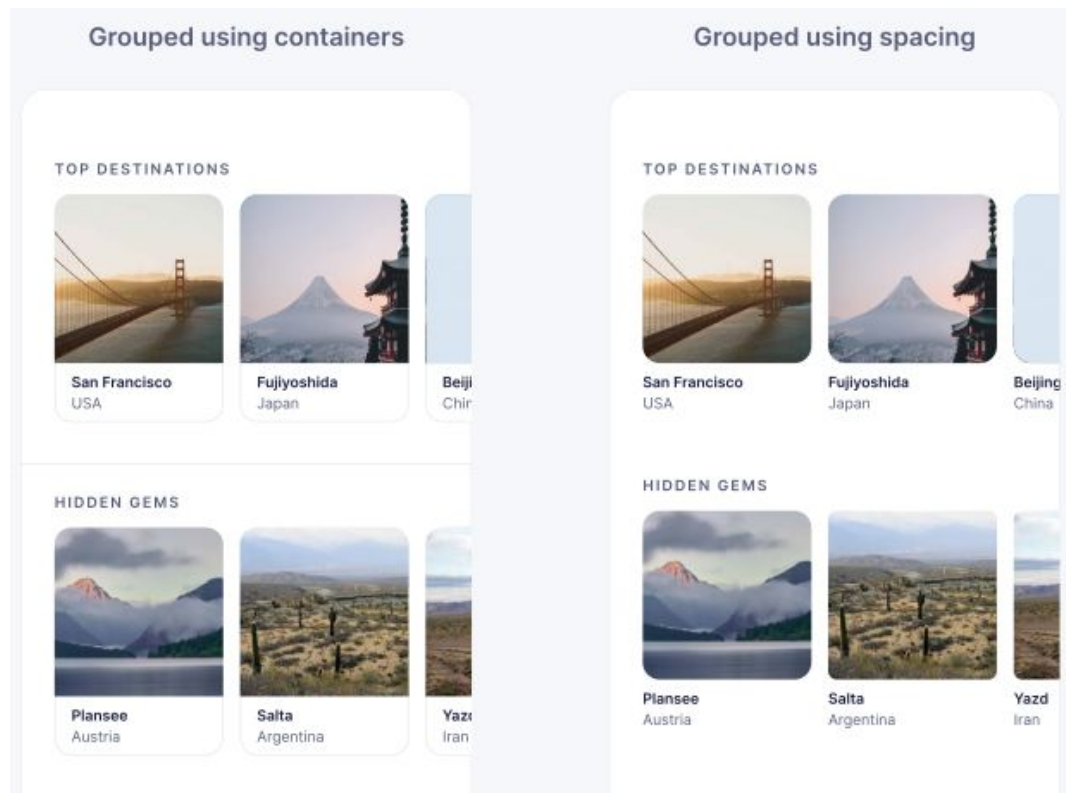
Elements near each other are perceived as a group and assumed to be related

Place related elements close together to group them

Separate unrelated elements by placing more space between them

Space related elements close together

Using spacing to create groups, rather than containers, can help declutter and simplify an interface



Space related elements close together

Sometimes spacing is enough to clearly group related elements

Removing containers can help simplify an interface

The next two slides show UI designs with and without containers

RECENT PROJECT

Waterview residence

Inspired by the vast ocean views, our goal was to bring the outside in wherever possible in this full renovation.

[View projects](#)

Architecture

We believe in the power of architecture to enhance our lives and the cities in which we live, now and in the future.

[Architectural projects](#)

Interiors

We specialise in designing beautiful, thoughtful, and functional interiors that stand the test of time.

[Interior design projects](#)

About

Drawing inspiration from the world around us, our practice strives to create elegant and thoughtful designs.

[About us](#)

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About

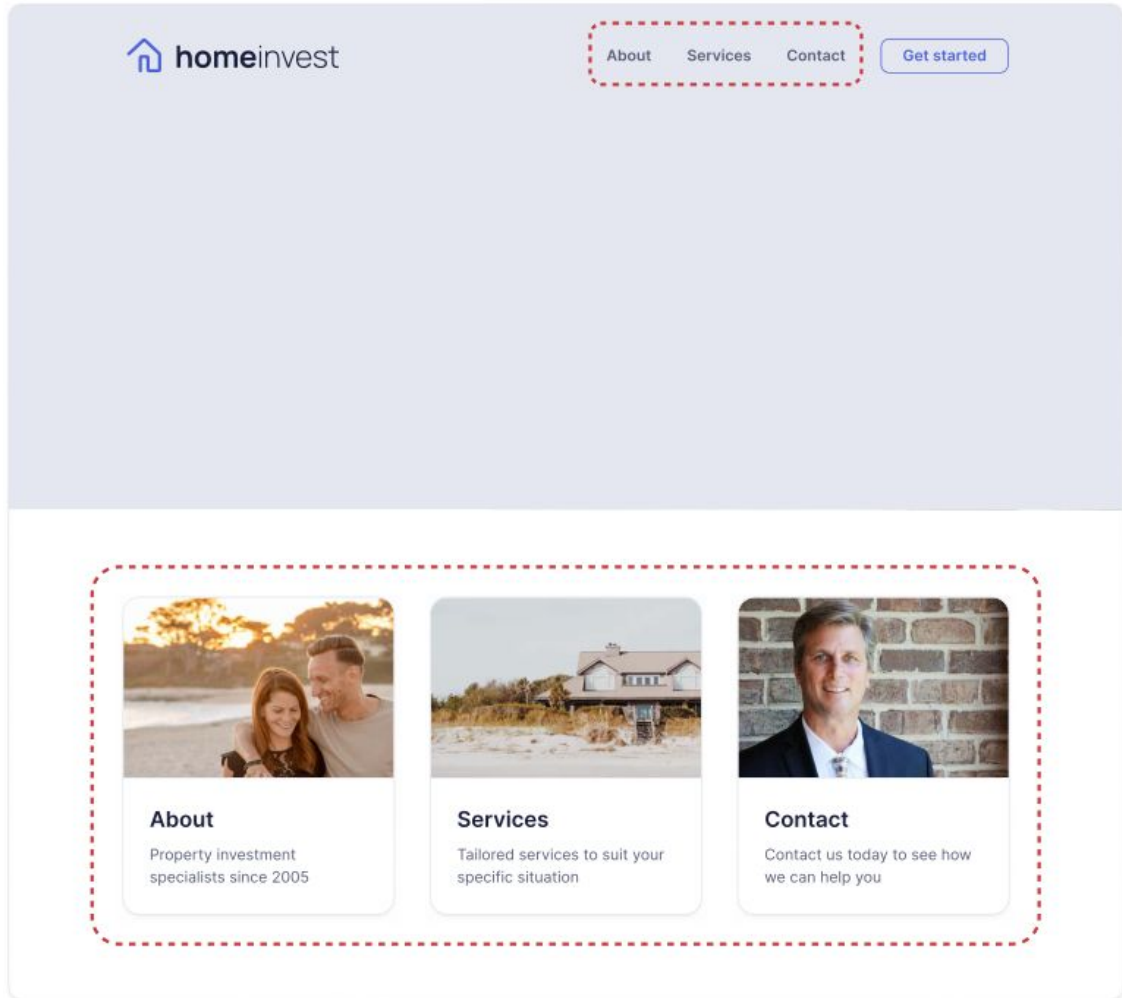
Drawing inspiration from the world around us, our practice strives to create elegant and thoughtful designs.

[About us](#)

Make related elements look similar

Make related elements look similar by giving them similar visual characteristics, such as size, shape, and color

Examples of related elements being grouped by similarity



Make related elements look similar

Within a group of related elements, you can highlight certain ones by making them look slightly different

The middle one stands out

It's larger, has a higher contrast border, a deeper shadow, a filled button, and a "most popular" badge

Pricing options

Join 50,000+ designers growing and optimising their businesses.

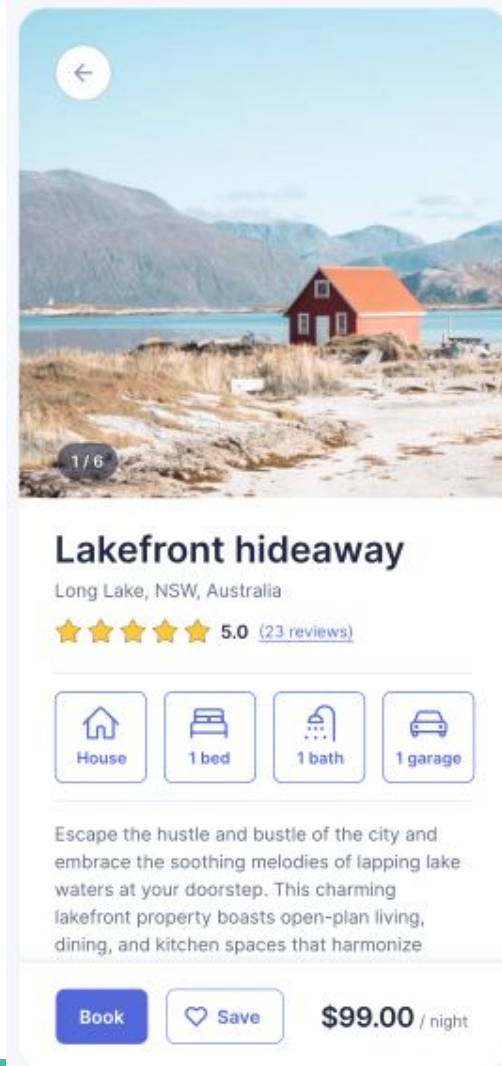
The image displays three pricing plans in a row. The middle plan, 'STANDARD PLAN', is highlighted with a green 'Most popular' badge and a blue border. It features a blue icon of three stacked squares. The 'BASIC PLAN' on the left has a light blue icon of a diamond. The 'PROFESSIONAL PLAN' on the right has a light blue icon of three stacked squares. Each plan lists its price, billing cycle, and features. The 'STANDARD PLAN' has a blue button, while the others have white buttons with blue borders.

Plan	Price	Billing Cycle	Features	Button
BASIC PLAN	\$10/month	USD billed annually	✓ 1 user ✓ 10 GB limit ✓ Email and chat support	Buy basic plan
STANDARD PLAN (Most popular)	\$20/month	USD billed annually	✓ Up to 5 users ✓ 25 GB limit ✓ Email and chat support	Buy standard plan
PROFESSIONAL PLAN	\$30/month	USD billed annually	✓ Up to 10 users ✓ 100 GB limit ✓ Email and chat support	Buy professional plan

Ensure similar looking elements function similarly

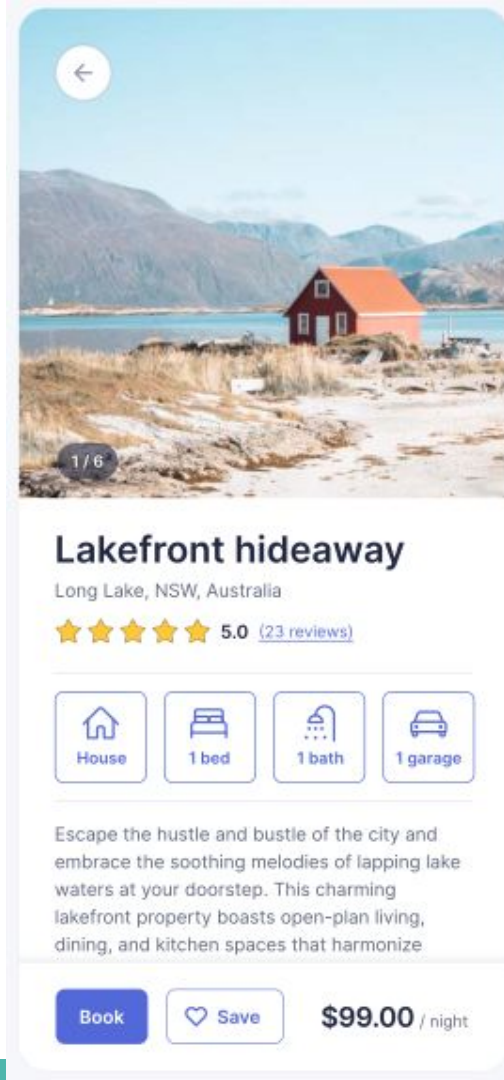
If elements look similar, people will expect them to work in a similar way

What is the issue with the UI design displayed in terms of element similarity and functionality?



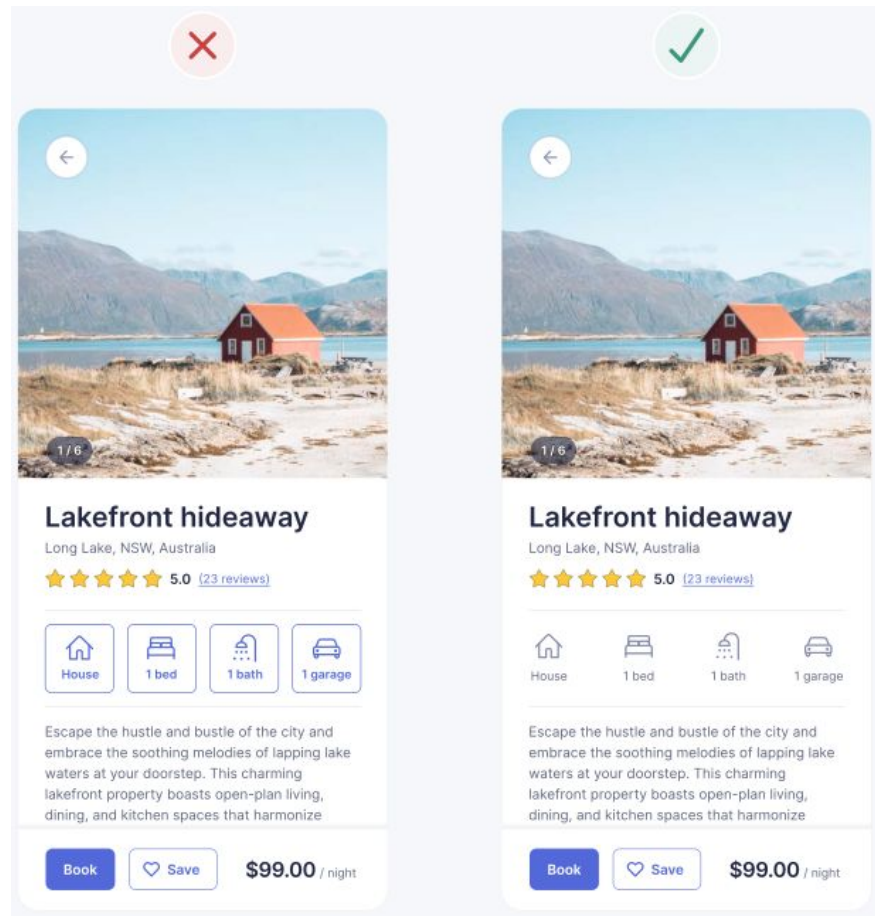
What is the issue with the UI design displayed in terms of element similarity and functionality?

Because the icons look like the secondary button, they seem interactive, even though they're not

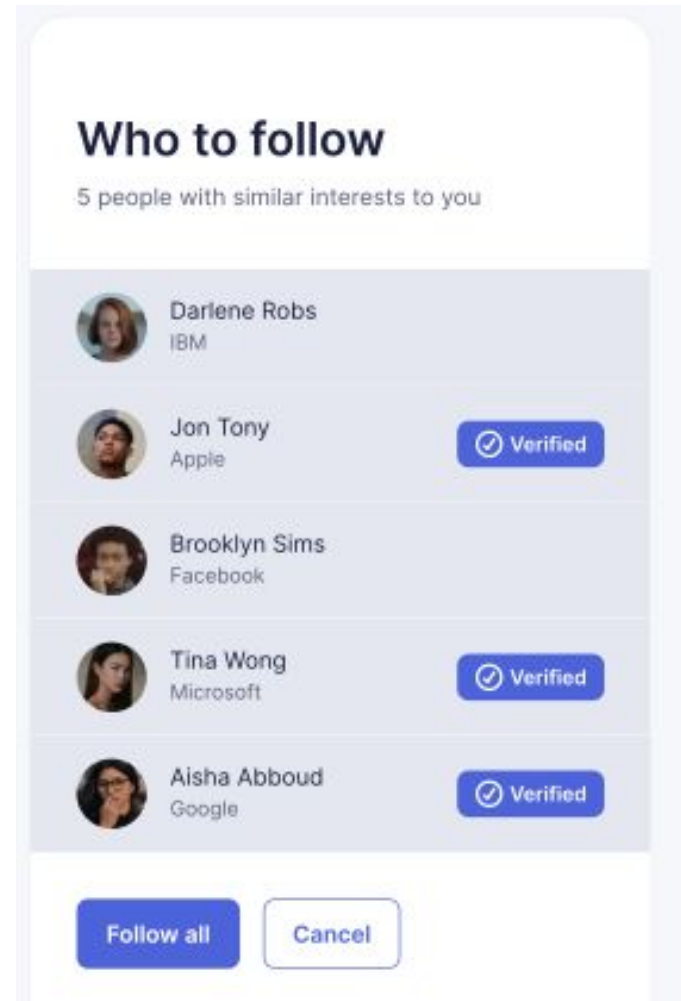


Removing the blue colour and border helps to differentiate the icons from the secondary button

This makes it clearer that the icons function differently to the secondary button

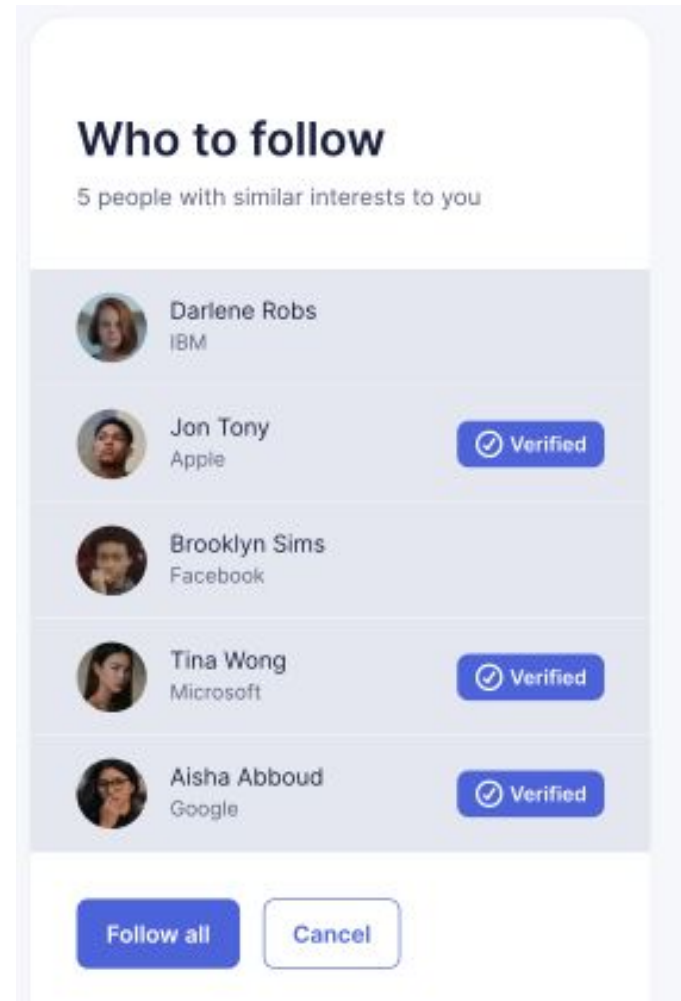


What is the issue with the UI design displayed in terms of element similarity and functionality?

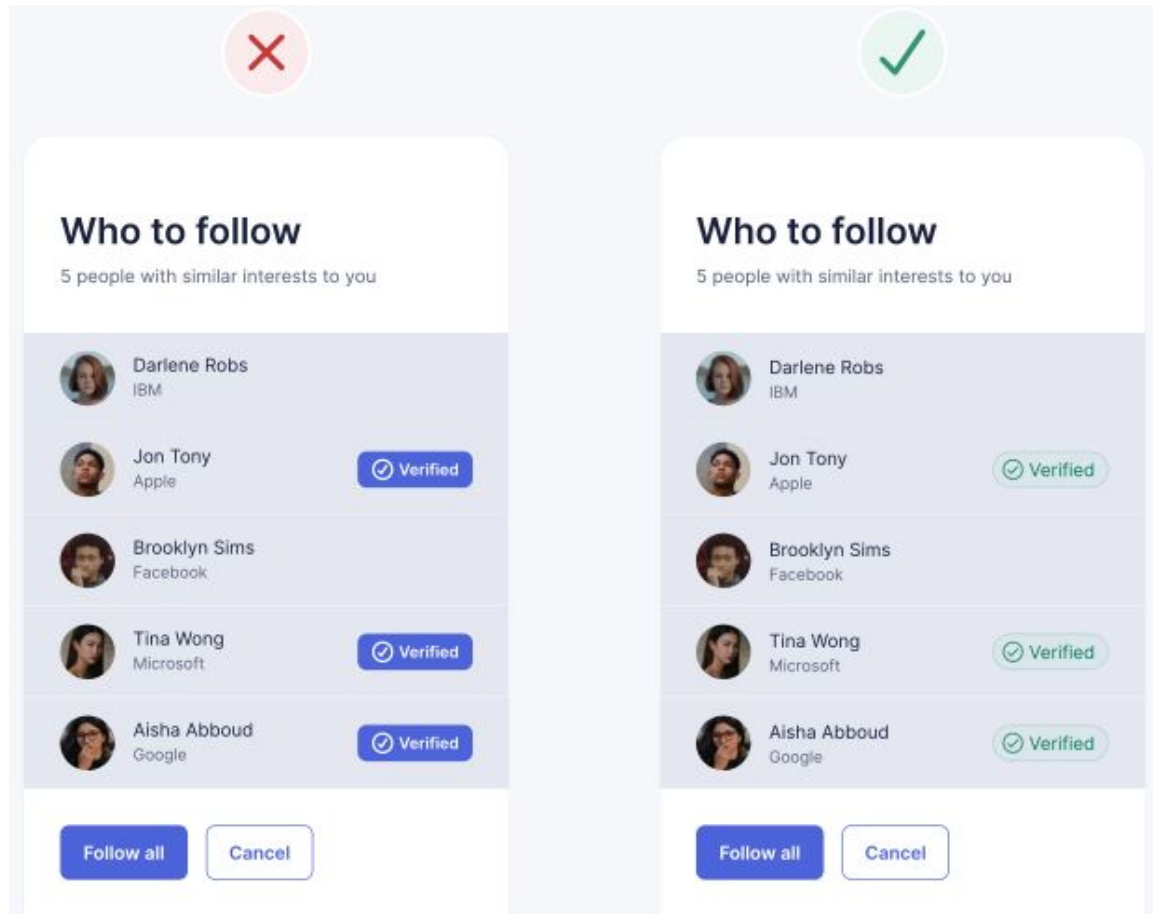


What is the issue with the UI design displayed in terms of element similarity and functionality?

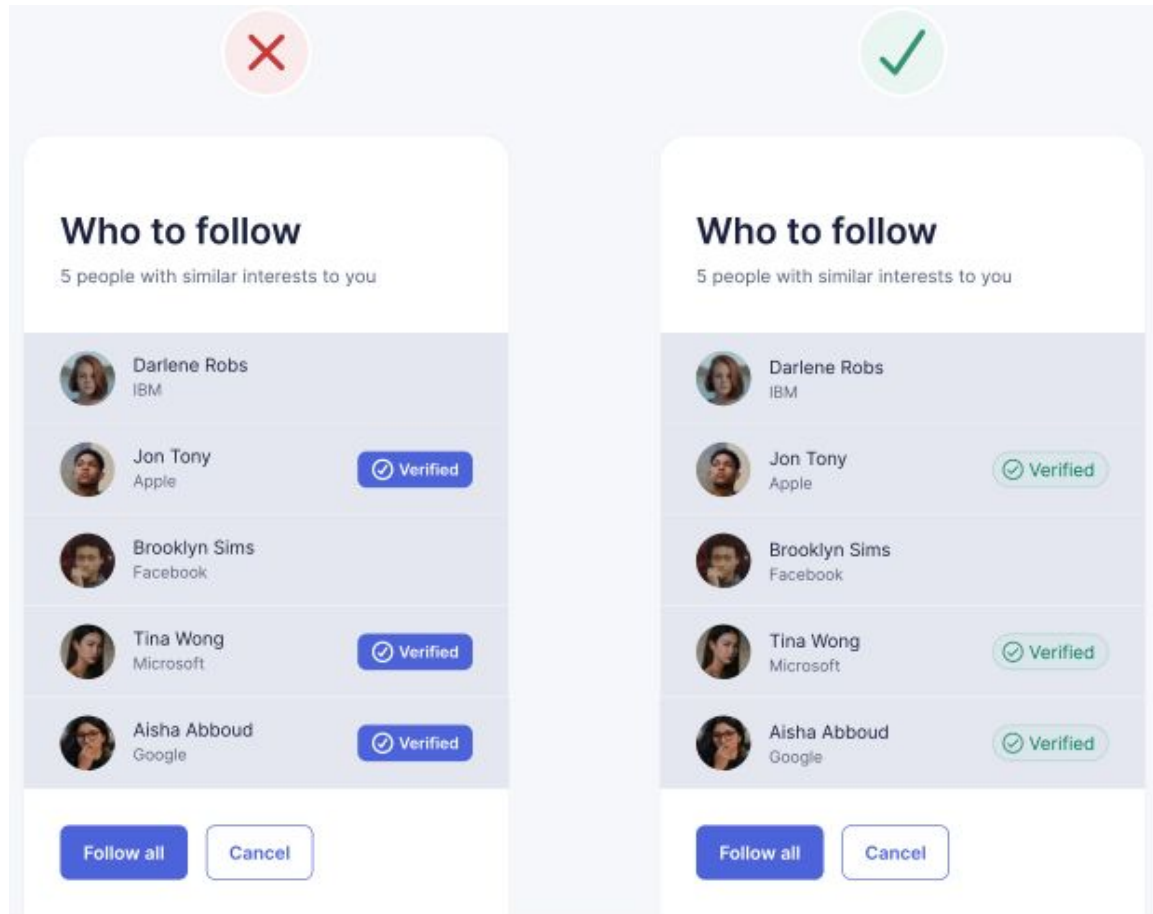
The badges look like the primary button, they seem interactive, even though they're not



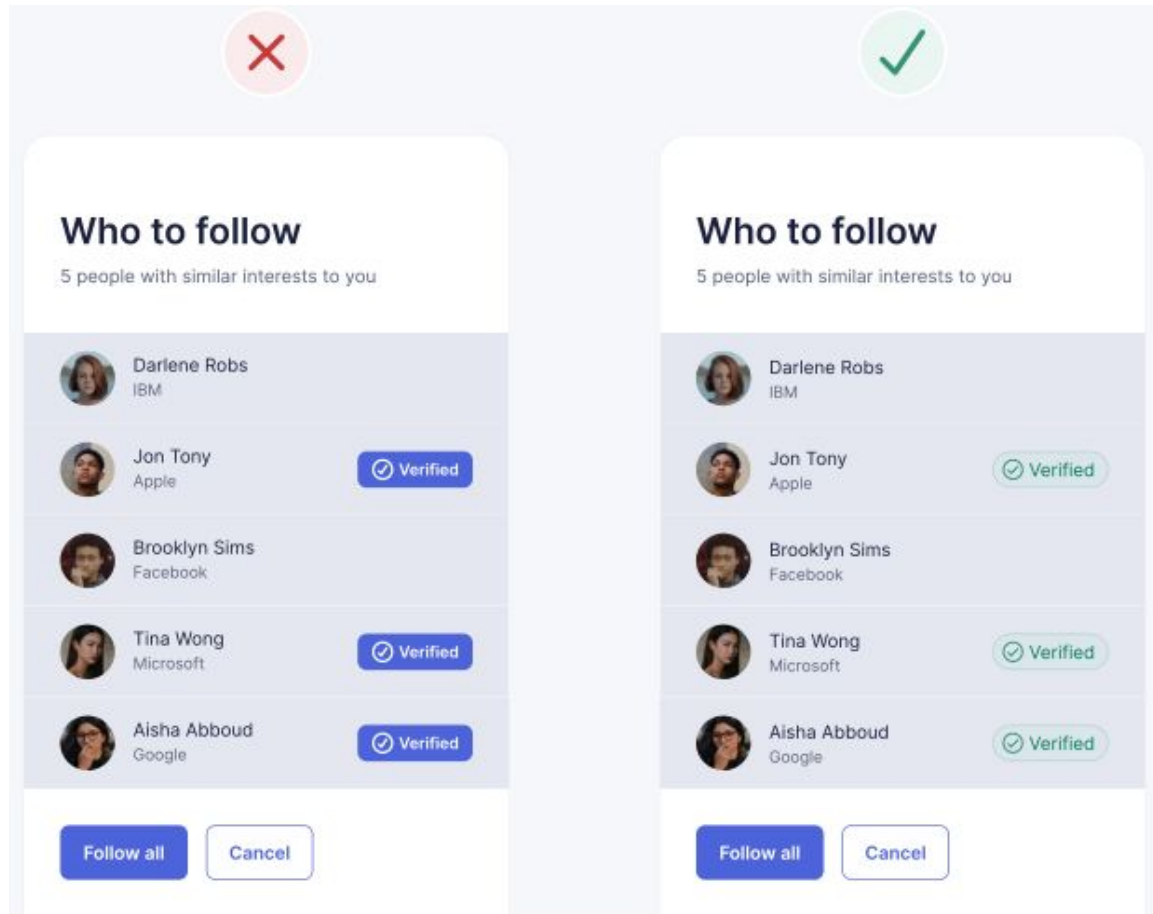
Remove the blue action color as the badges are not interactive, instead use green to indicate success



A more rounded shape is commonly used for badges to help differentiate them from buttons



A lighter background color helps correct the visual hierarchy, so the primary button is the most prominent element



Align related elements in a continuous line

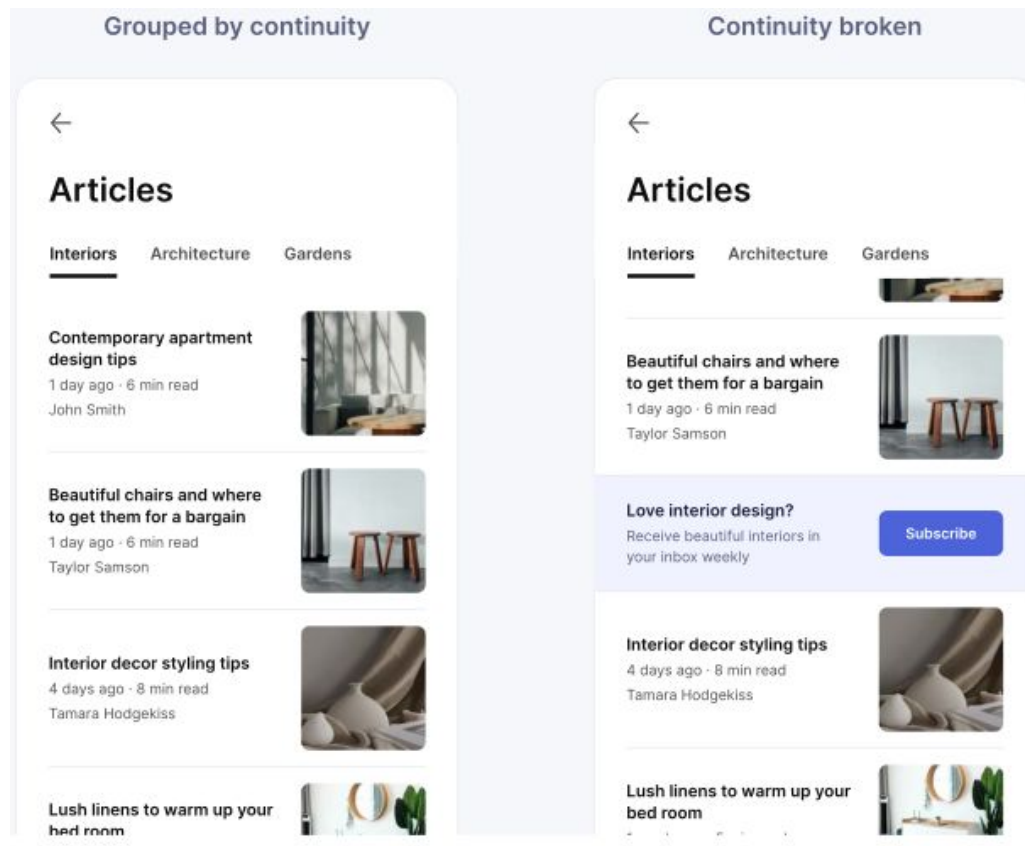
People perceive elements that are arranged in a continuous line to be related

Our eyes naturally tend to follow elements aligned in continuous straight or curved lines

Align related elements in a continuous line

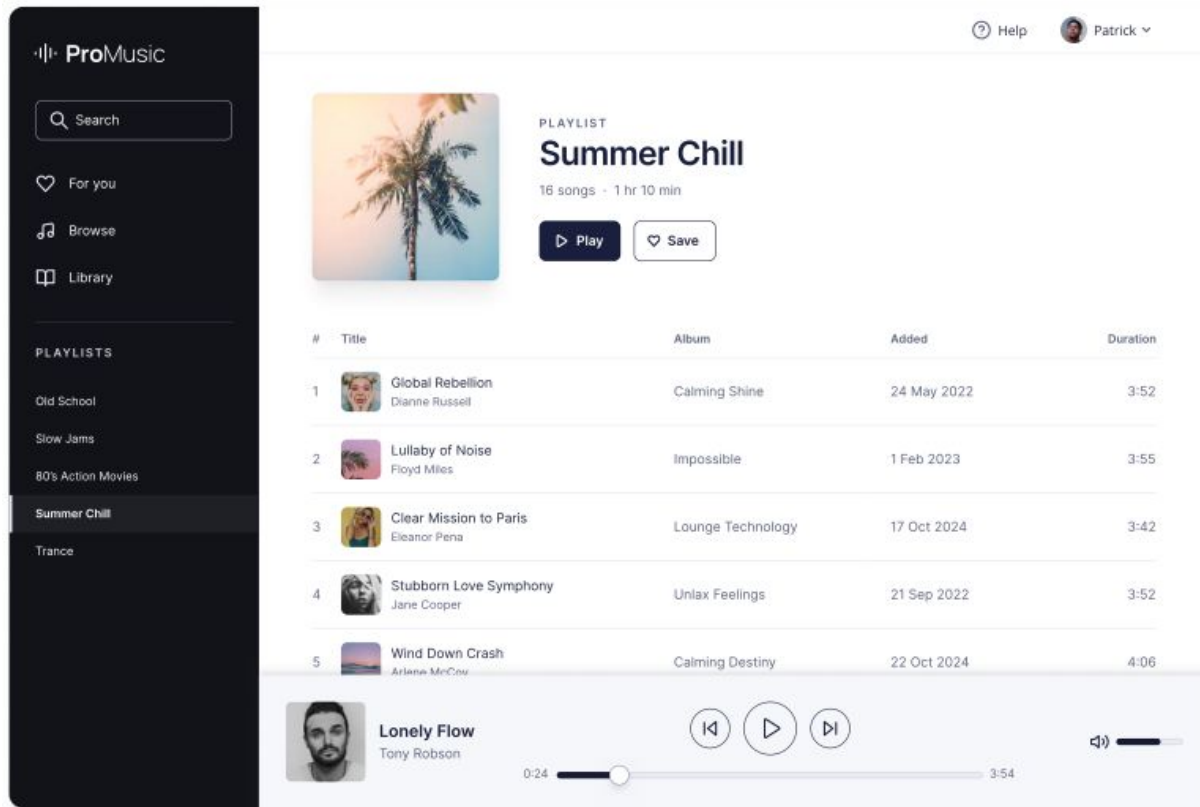
Lists are a common way of using continuity to group related elements in an interface

You can disrupt continuity to indicate the end of a group of related elements or to highlight a particular element



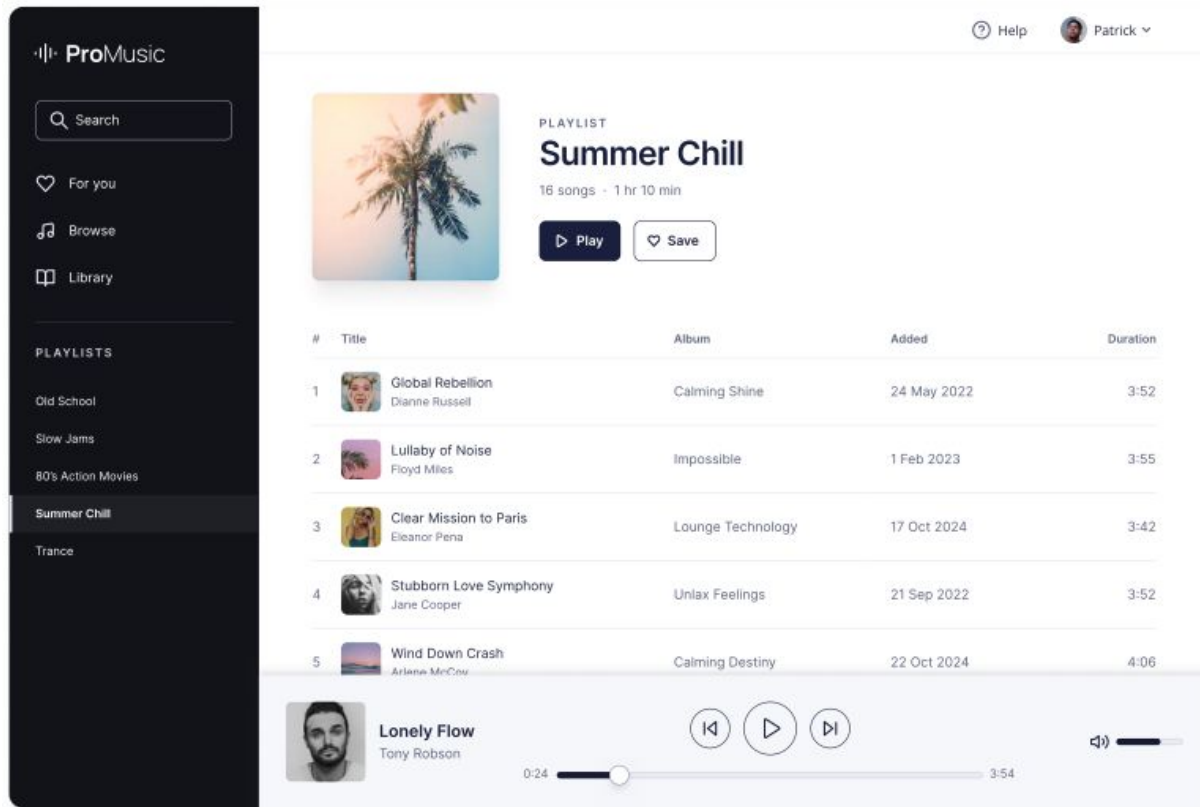
Grouping methods example

Containers are used to create the main structure of the interface



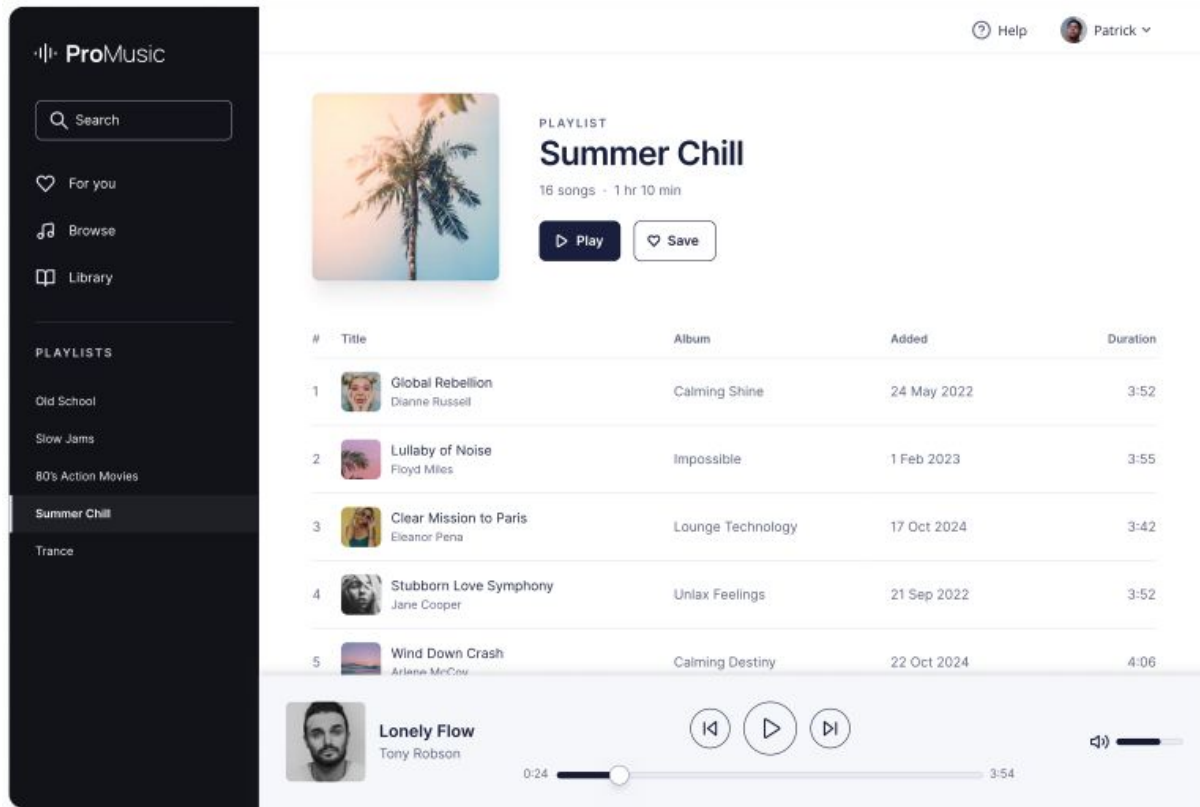
Grouping methods example

A dark grey background is used to contain the left side navigation



Grouping methods example

A light grey background and shadow are used to contain the music player controls along the bottom



Grouping methods example

A grey border is used to contain the account menu along the top

The image shows a music application interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with the 'ProMusic' logo, a search bar, and navigation options: 'For you', 'Browse', 'Library', and a 'PLAYLISTS' section. The 'Summer Chill' playlist is highlighted in the sidebar. The main area displays the 'Summer Chill' playlist with a cover image of a palm tree, 16 songs, and a 1 hr 10 min duration. It includes 'Play' and 'Save' buttons. Below is a table of the first five songs. At the bottom is a player for 'Lonely Flow' by Tony Robson, showing a progress bar and playback controls.

ProMusic

Search

For you

Browse

Library

PLAYLISTS

Old School

Slow Jams

80's Action Movies

Summer Chill

Trance

PLAYLIST

Summer Chill

16 songs · 1 hr 10 min

Play Save

#	Title	Album	Added	Duration
1	Global Rebellion Dianne Russell	Calming Shine	24 May 2022	3:52
2	Lullaby of Noise Floyd Miles	Impossible	1 Feb 2023	3:55
3	Clear Mission to Paris Eleanor Pena	Lounge Technology	17 Oct 2024	3:42
4	Stubborn Love Symphony Jane Cooper	Unlax Feelings	21 Sep 2022	3:52
5	Wind Down Crash Arlene McCoy	Calming Destiny	22 Oct 2024	4:06

Lonely Flow
Tony Robson

0:24 3:54

Grouping methods example

The songs in the table are grouped in multiple ways

They have a container

They're in close proximity

They look similar

They're aligned in a continuous line

The screenshot displays a music application interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with navigation options: 'ProMusic', a search bar, 'For you', 'Browse', 'Library', and a 'PLAYLISTS' section. The 'Summer Chill' playlist is selected in the 'PLAYLISTS' section. The main area shows the playlist details: a cover image of a palm tree, the title 'Summer Chill', and '16 songs · 1 hr 10 min'. Below this is a table of the first five songs in the playlist.

#	Title	Album	Added	Duration
1	Global Rebellion Dianne Russell	Calming Shine	24 May 2022	3:52
2	Lullaby of Noise Floyd Miles	Impossible	1 Feb 2023	3:55
3	Clear Mission to Paris Eleanor Pena	Lounge Technology	17 Oct 2024	3:42
4	Stubborn Love Symphony Jane Cooper	Unlax Feelings	21 Sep 2022	3:52
5	Wind Down Crash Arlene McCow	Calming Destiny	22 Oct 2024	4:06

At the bottom, a player bar shows the current song 'Lonely Flow' by Tony Robson, with a progress bar at 0:24 of 3:54 and standard playback controls.

Grouping methods example

Container is used to group songs in the table

#	Title	Album	Added	Duration
1	 Global Rebellion Dianne Russell	Calming	24 May 2022	3:52
2	 Lullaby of Noise Floyd Miles	Impossible	1 Feb 2023	3:55
3	 Clear Mission to Paris Eleanor Pena	Lounge Technology	17 Oct 2024	3:42
4	 Stubborn Love Symphony Jane Cooper	Unlax Feelings	21 Sep 2022	3:52
5	 Wind Down Crash Arlene McCoy	Calming Destiny	22 Oct 2024	4:06
6	 Lonely Flow Tony Robson	Summer Vibes	2 Dec 2024	3:48

Grouping methods example

Since the songs are grouped using multiple methods, you can remove the outer container, and the songs still appear to be grouped

#	Title	Album	Added	Duration
1	 Global Rebellion Dianne Russell	Calming Shine	24 May 2022	3:52
2	 Lullaby of Noise Floyd Miles	Impossible	1 Feb 2023	3:55
3	 Clear Mission to Paris Eleanor Pena	Lounge Technology	17 Oct 2024	3:42
4	 Stubborn Love Symphony Jane Cooper	Unlax Feelings	21 Sep 2022	3:52
5	 Wind Down Crash Arlene McCoy	Calming Destiny	22 Oct 2024	4:06
6	 Lonely Flow Tony Robson	Summer Vibes	2 Dec 2024	3:48

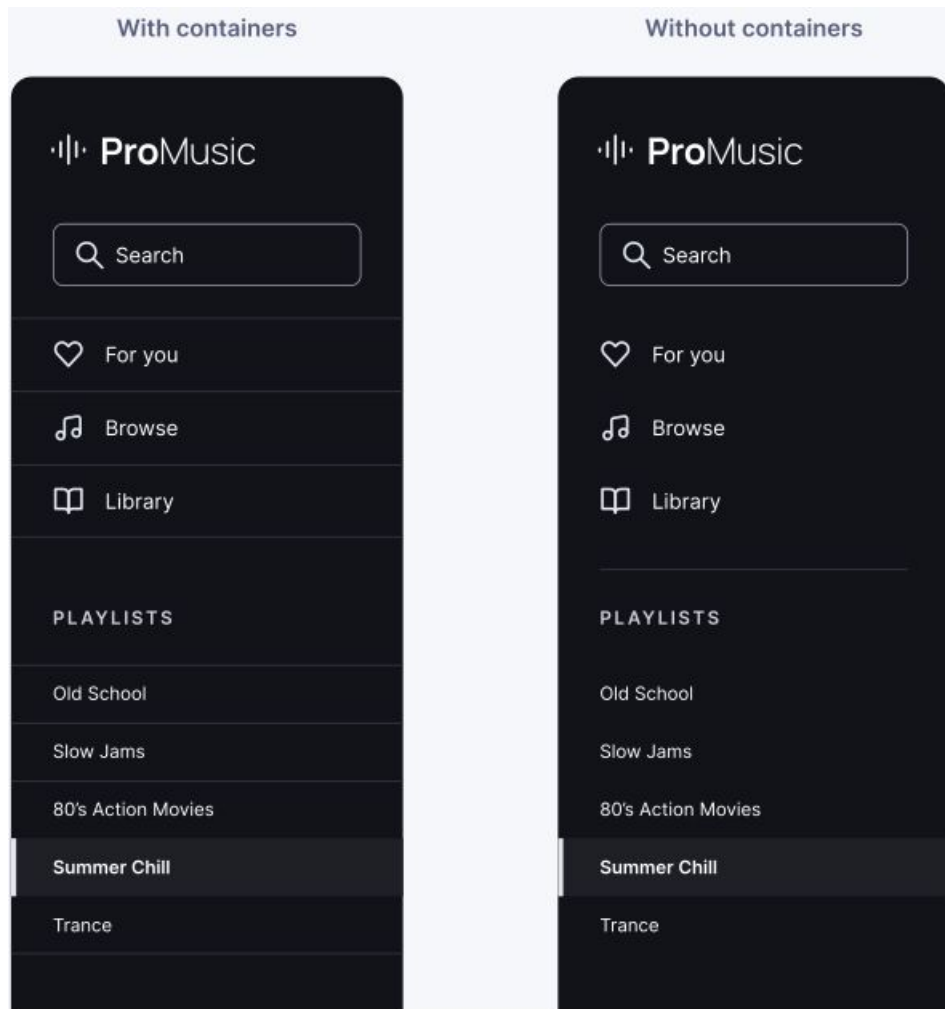
Grouping methods example

Since the songs are grouped using multiple methods, you can remove the outer container, and the songs still appear to be grouped

#	Title	Album	Added	Duration
1	 Global Rebellion Dianne Russell	Calming Shine	24 May 2022	3:52
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5	 Wind Down Crash Arlene McCoy	Calming Destiny	22 Oct 2024	4:06
6	 Lonely Flow Tony Robson	Summer Vibes	2 Dec 2024	3:48

Grouping methods example

You can simplify the side navigation by removing unnecessary containers



Create a clear visual hierarchy

Aim to present information in order of importance by making more important elements look more prominent

A clear order of importance, or visual hierarchy, helps people scan information quickly and focus on areas of interest

It also improves aesthetics by creating a sense of order

Create a clear visual hierarchy

You can create a visual hierarchy using

Size - make important elements larger

Color - use brighter, richer, warmer, or higher contrast colors for more important elements

Contrast - style important elements differently to help them stand out

Create a clear visual hierarchy

You can create a visual hierarchy using

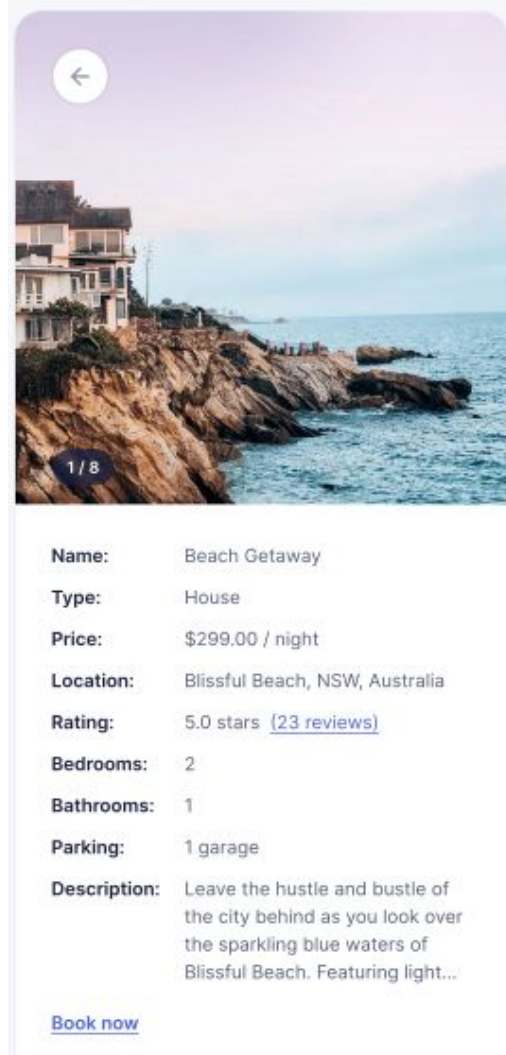
Spacing - surround important elements with more space

Position - place important elements toward the top of an interface or first in a row of multiple items

Depth - elevate important elements so they appear closer to users

Create a clear visual hierarchy

What is the issue in the UI design displayed in relation to visual hierarchy?

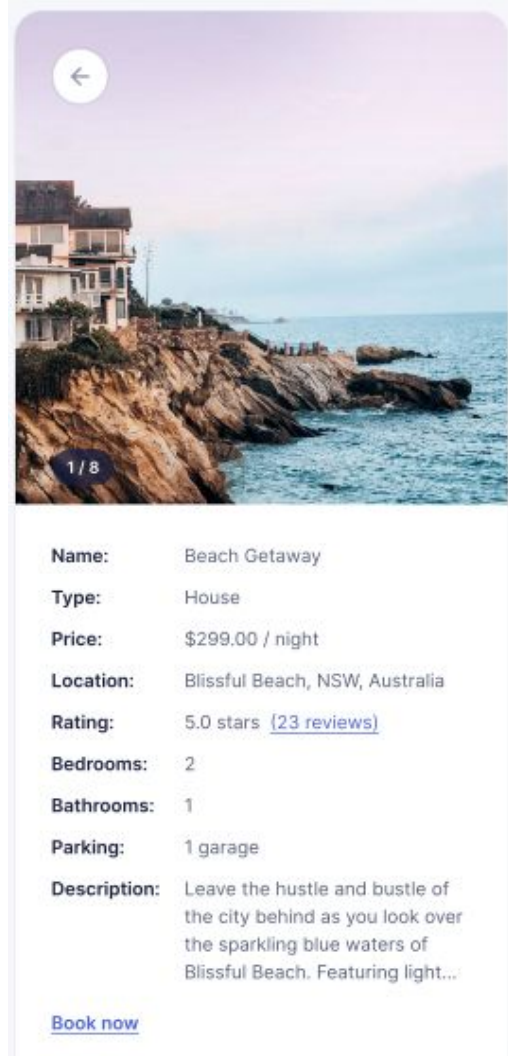


Create a clear visual hierarchy

What is the issue in the UI design displayed in relation to visual hierarchy?

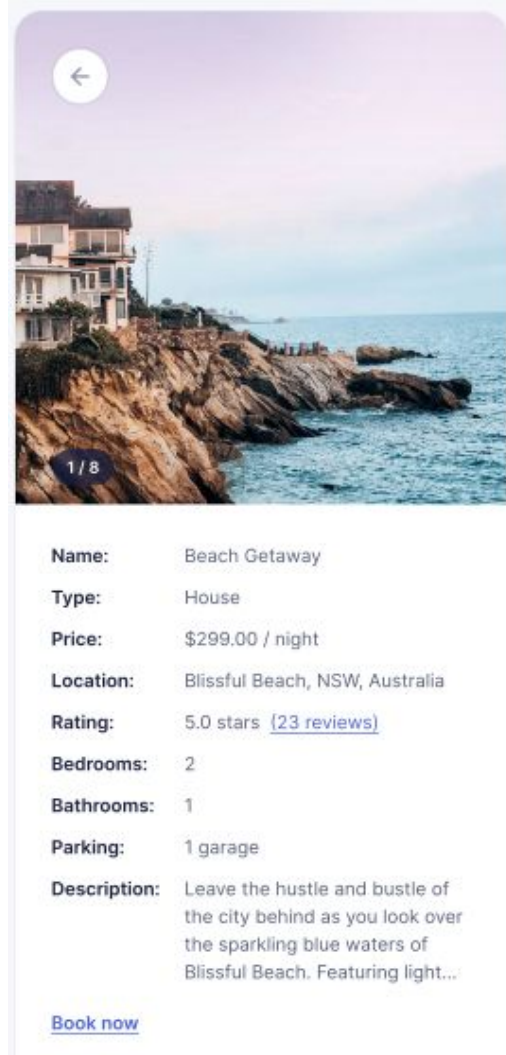
The interface do not have a clear visual hierarchy

All elements have similar visual prominence



Create a clear visual hierarchy

How to fix the issue?

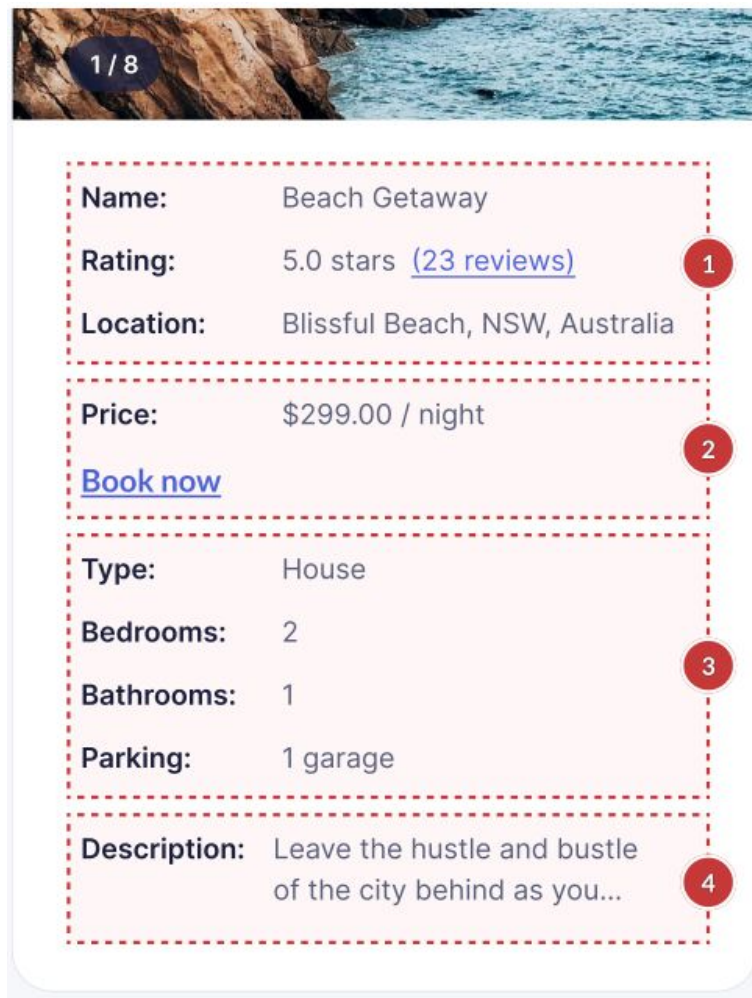


Create a clear visual hierarchy

Group related information into separate sections

Order the information in each section by importance

Place more important sections towards the top of the interface to give them prominence



Create a clear visual hierarchy

Make the name large, bold, and use the “Text strong” color variation from your colour palette

Since the location is secondary information, make it smaller, regular weight, and use the “Text weak” colour variation

Introduce icons for the star rating (following common pattern) to make it easier to scan

1 / 8

Beach Getaway

Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 (23 reviews)

Price: \$299.00 / night

[Book now](#)

Type: House

Bedrooms: 2

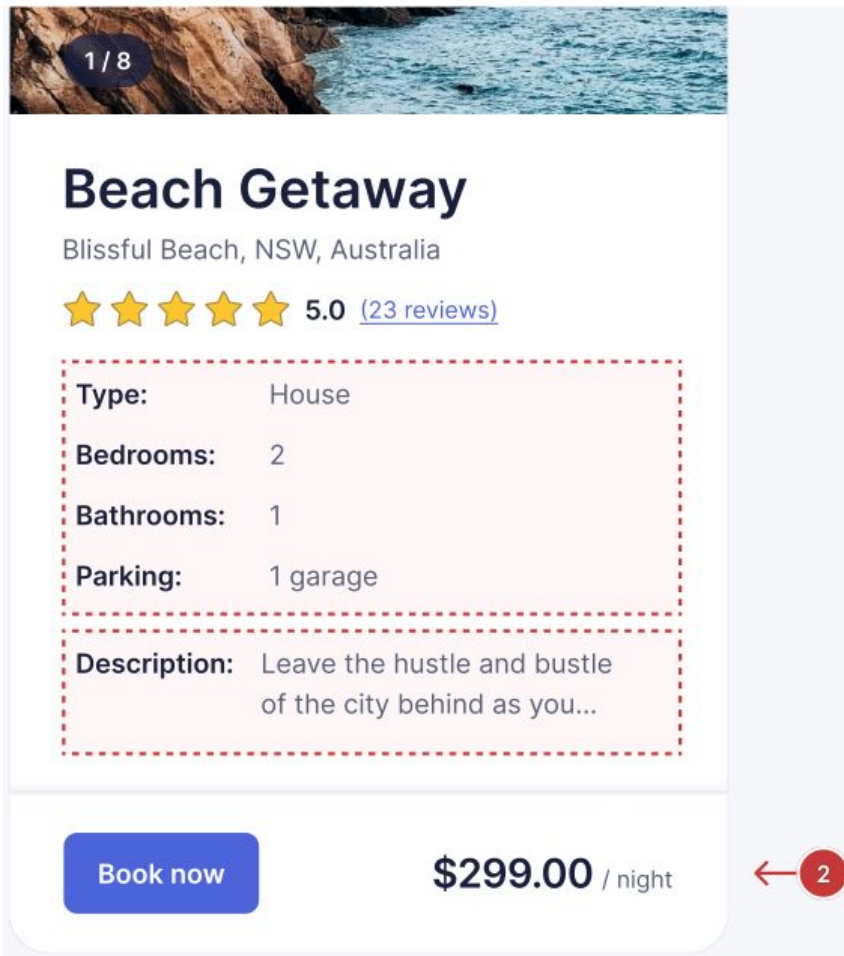
Bathrooms: 1

Parking: 1 garage

Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

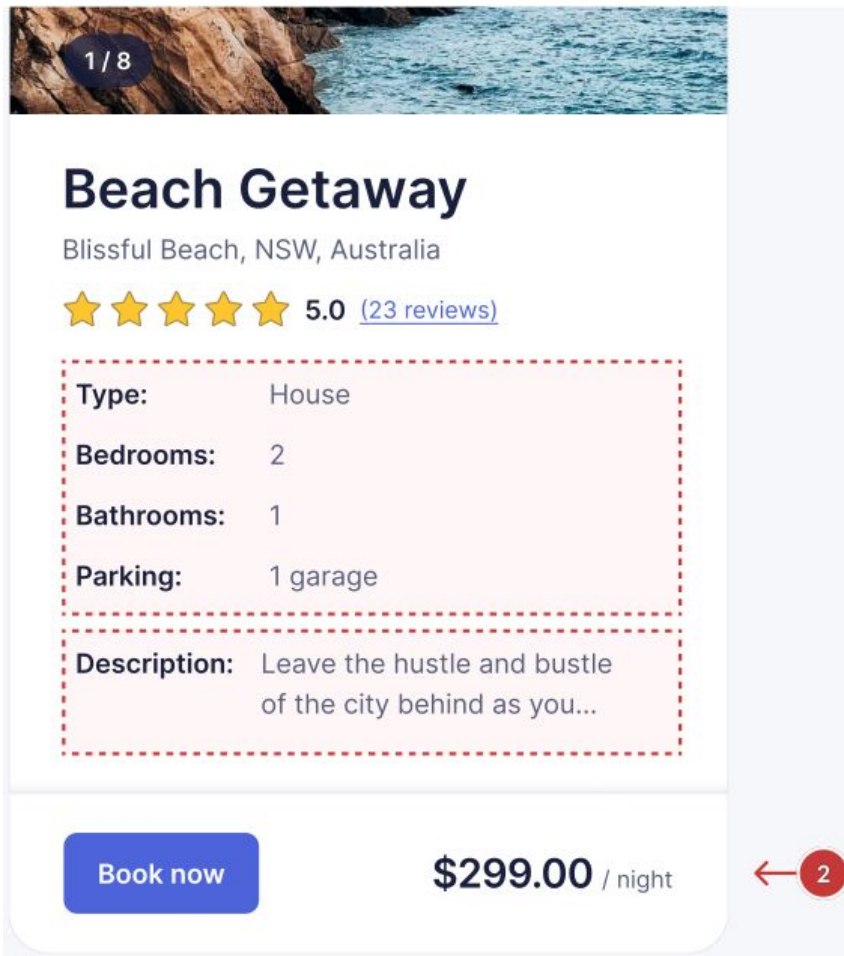
Create a clear visual hierarchy

To ensure the second section is always visible and within thumb's reach, elevate it using a shadow and stick it to the bottom of the screen



Create a clear visual hierarchy

Increase the prominence of the primary call to action by making it a primary button with the brand color



1 / 8

Beach Getaway

Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 [\(23 reviews\)](#)

Type:	House
Bedrooms:	2
Bathrooms:	1
Parking:	1 garage

Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

[Book now](#)

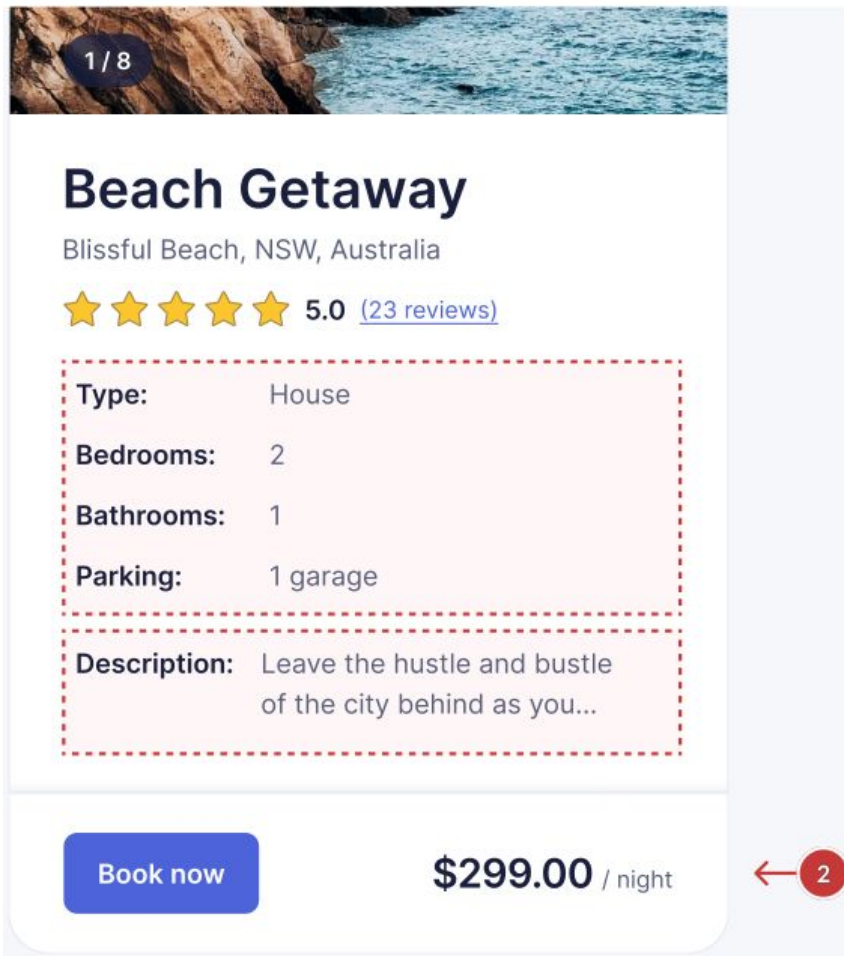
\$299.00 / night

← 2

Create a clear visual hierarchy

Highlight the price by making it bigger and bolder and placing it last on the interface next to the book button

According to The Serial Position Effect, people best remember the first and last items



A mobile app listing for a 'Beach Getaway'. At the top is a photo of a rocky coastline with a '1/8' indicator. Below the photo is the title 'Beach Getaway' in bold, followed by the location 'Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia'. A row of five yellow stars and the text '5.0 (23 reviews)' are displayed. A dashed red box encloses a table of property details: Type (House), Bedrooms (2), Bathrooms (1), and Parking (1 garage). Below this box is a 'Description' section with the text 'Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...'. At the bottom, a blue 'Book now' button is on the left, and the price '\$299.00 / night' is on the right. A red arrow points to the price, and a red circle with the number '2' is in the bottom right corner.

1 / 8

Beach Getaway

Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 [\(23 reviews\)](#)

Type:	House
Bedrooms:	2
Bathrooms:	1
Parking:	1 garage

Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

[Book now](#) **\$299.00** / night

← 2

Create a clear visual hierarchy

Use icons with text labels to help make the property details easier to scan

The property details now look similar and it helps group them together to show they're related



Beach Getaway
Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 [\(23 reviews\)](#)


House


2 beds


1 bath


1 garage

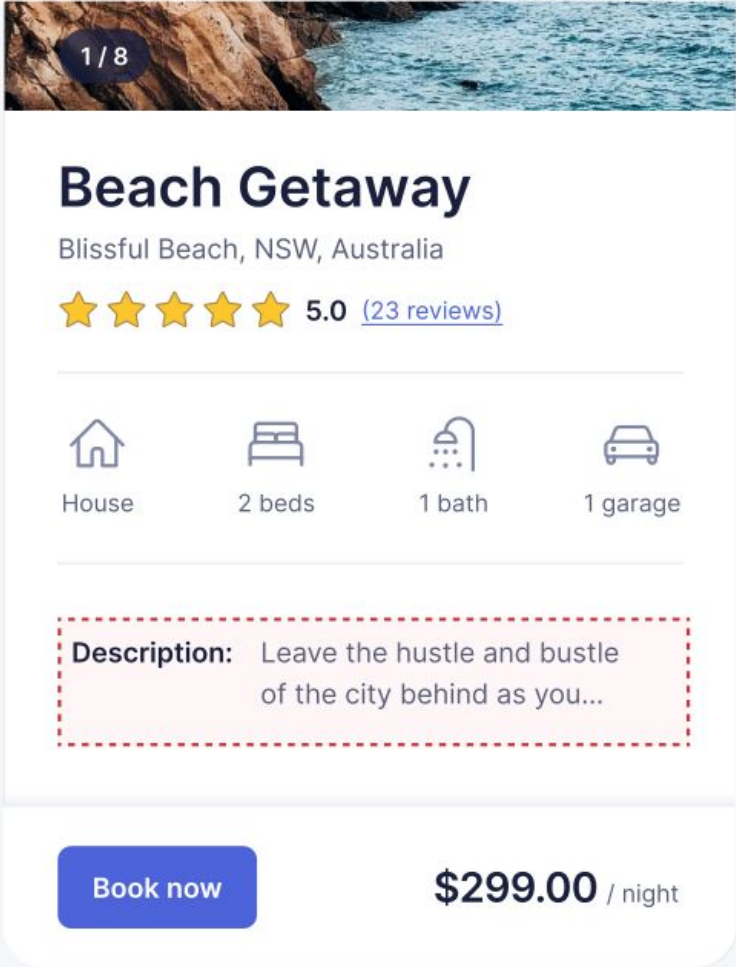
Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

[Book now](#)

\$299.00 / night

Create a clear visual hierarchy

Since icons can be very prominent, use unfilled icons and the “Stroke strong” color variation to decrease their prominence



Beach Getaway
Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 [\(23 reviews\)](#)



House2 beds1 bath1 garage

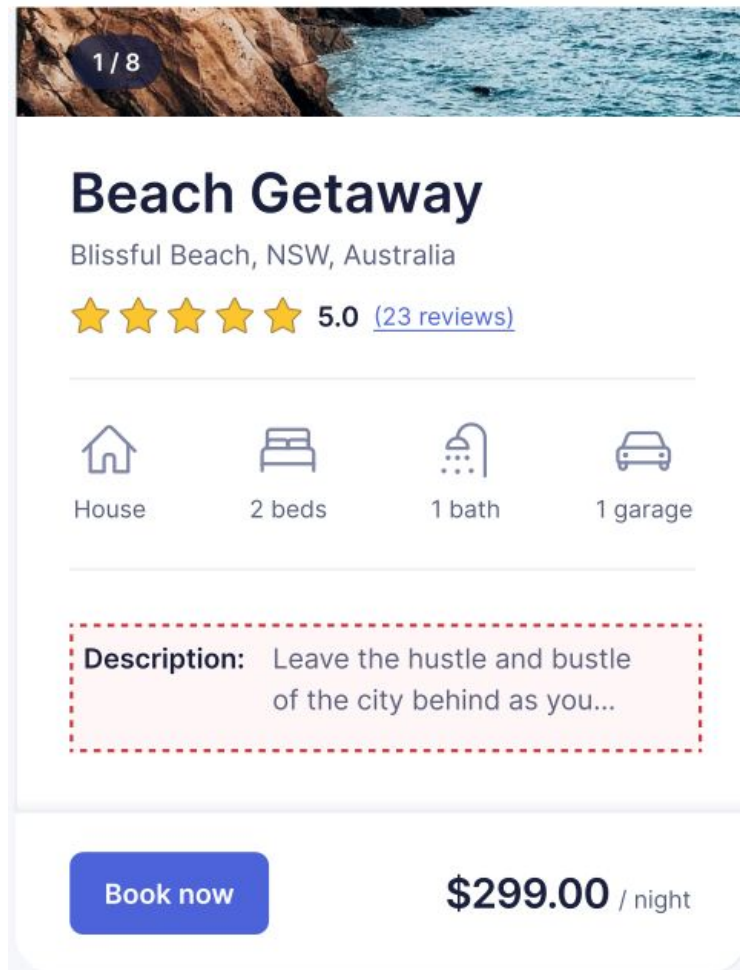
Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

[Book now](#)**\$299.00** / night

Create a clear visual hierarchy

Use the “Text weak” color variation for the text labels, rather than the “Text strong” variation

This gives the text labels and icons similar prominence and creates balance



The image shows a mobile app interface for a vacation rental listing. At the top is a banner image of a rocky coastline with blue water, with a '1 / 8' indicator in the top left corner. Below the banner is the title 'Beach Getaway' in a large, bold, dark blue font, followed by the location 'Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia' in a smaller, lighter blue font. Below this is a row of five yellow stars, the text '5.0', and a link '(23 reviews)'. A horizontal line separates this from a row of four icons: a house, a bed, a shower, and a car. Below each icon is a label: 'House', '2 beds', '1 bath', and '1 garage'. Another horizontal line separates this from a description box with a dashed red border. The description box contains the text 'Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...'. At the bottom is a white bar with a blue 'Book now' button on the left and the price '\$299.00 / night' on the right. On the far right edge of the screen, there is a red circle with the number '3' and a red arrow pointing left towards the listing card.

1 / 8

Beach Getaway

Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

★★★★★ 5.0 [\(23 reviews\)](#)

 House  2 beds  1 bath  1 garage

Description: Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you...

[Book now](#) **\$299.00** / night

Create a clear visual hierarchy

Remove the “description” label as it’s already obvious what this information is for

Use the “Text weak” colour variation for the text at regular weight so it’s less prominent than the second section

1 / 8

Beach Getaway

Blissful Beach, NSW, Australia

 **5.0** [\(23 reviews\)](#)



House



2 beds



1 bath



1 garage

Leave the hustle and bustle of the city behind as you look over the sparkling blue waters of Blissful Beach. Featuring light and airy spaces throughout, you'll be greeted by a residence that harmoniously connects with its coastal

[Book now](#)

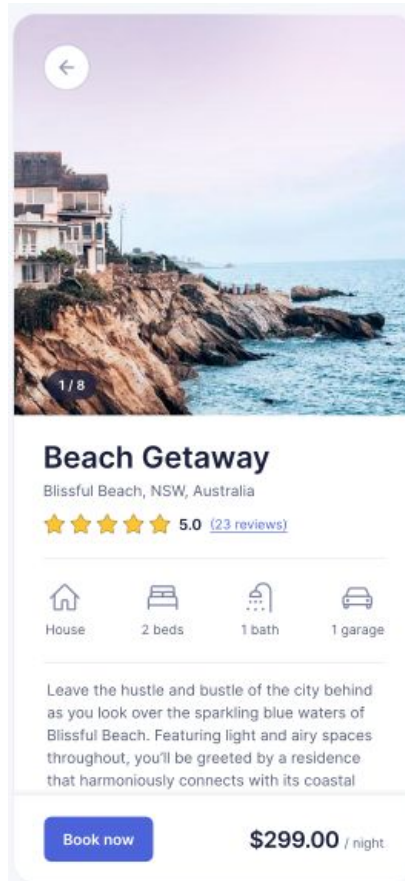
\$299.00 / night

Test visual hierarchy

Step back from your screen

Zoom out to make your design smaller

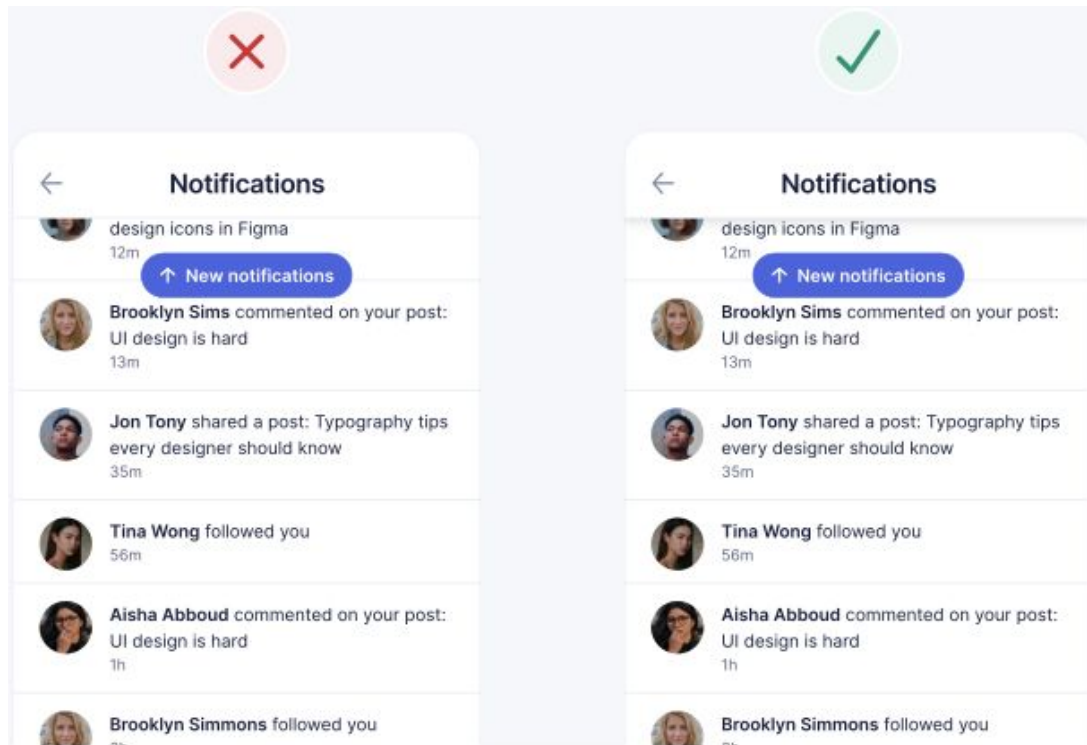
Blur your design



Use depth to create visual hierarchy

Use different levels of elevation to help create a clear order of importance or visual hierarchy

More important things should be elevated higher to make them more prominent



Understand the box model

Interfaces are made up of lots of rectangles within rectangles

Each rectangle can have an outer margin, inner padding, and a border according to the box model

Margin - the space between the box and neighbouring boxes

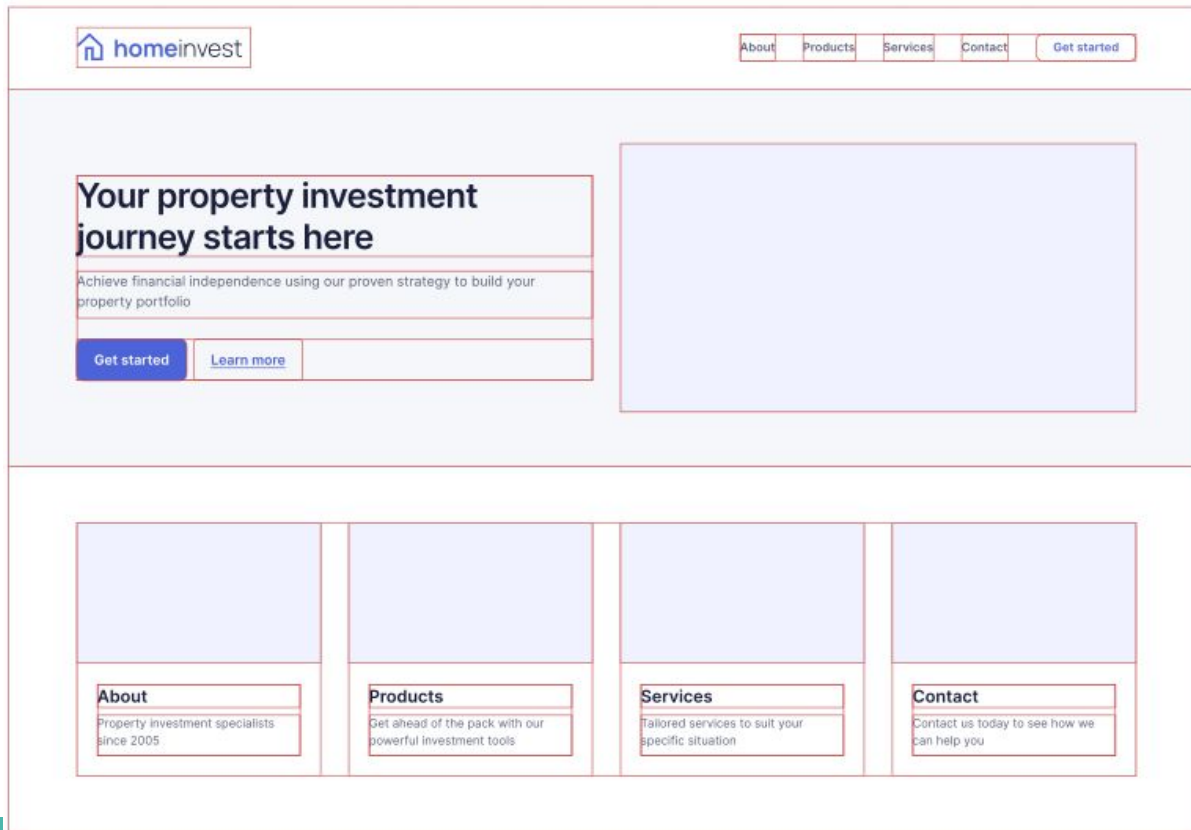
Border - the stroke around the edge of the box

Padding - the space between the border and the contents of the box

Understand the box model



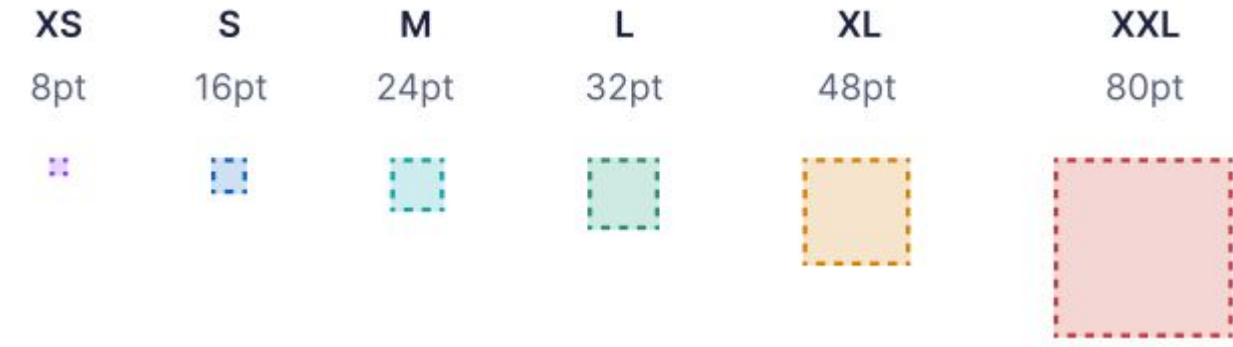
Understand the box model



Create a set of predefined spacing options

An example set of predefined spacing options

This is also known as using an 8 point grid, as all interface elements will end up aligning to a series of vertical and horizontal guidelines separated by 8 points



Create a set of predefined spacing options

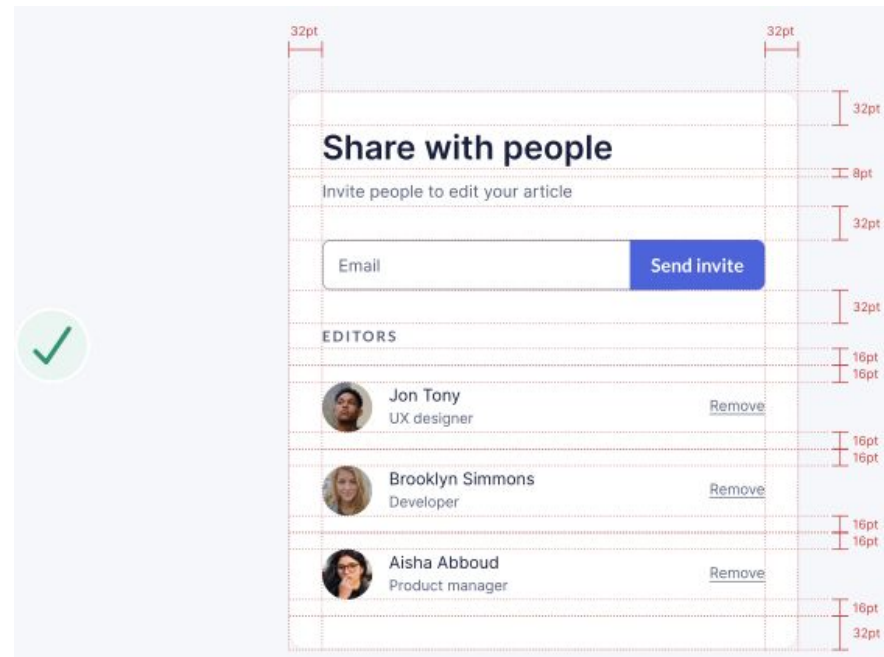
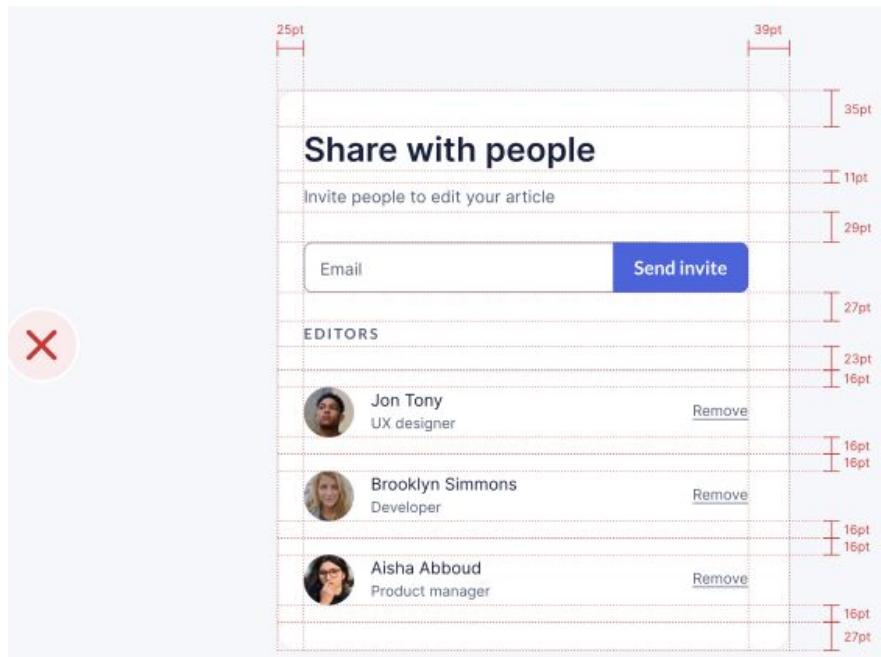
Benefits of using a predefined set of spacing options

Simplified designs - as there's less variation between spacing

Improved consistency - as spacing across interface elements will match

Design faster - as there are fewer options to choose from

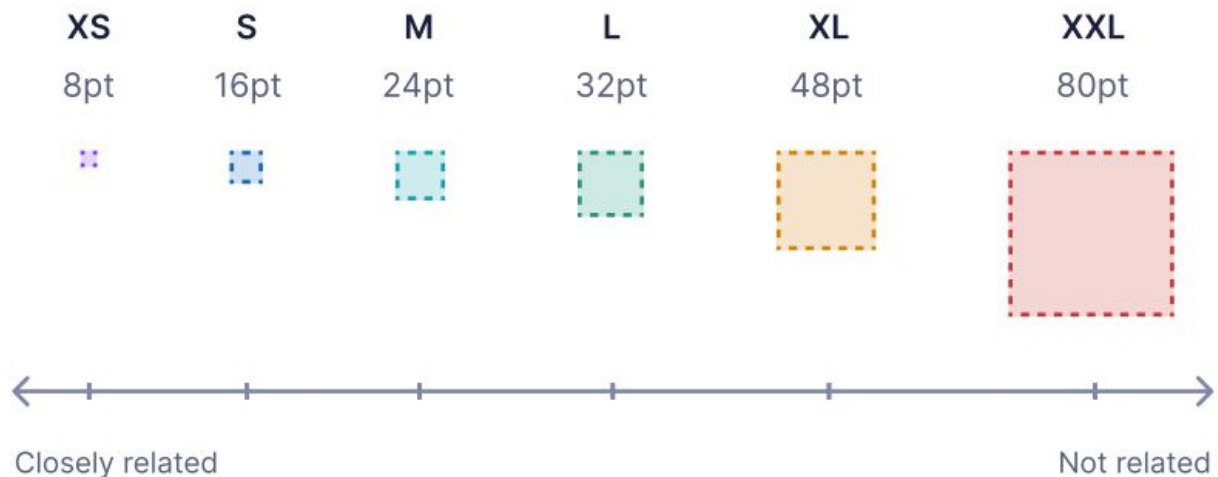
Create a set of predefined spacing options



Space elements based on how closely related they are

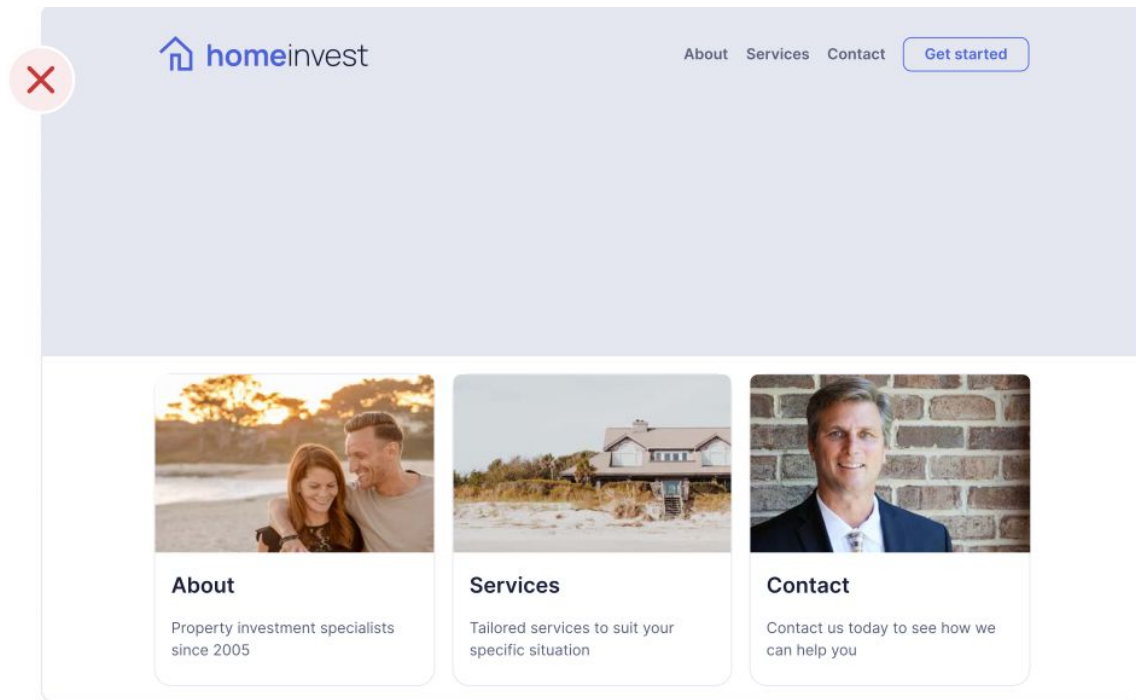
More closely related elements should generally be closer together to show that they're related

Unrelated elements should be separated by placing more space between them



Space elements based on how closely related they are

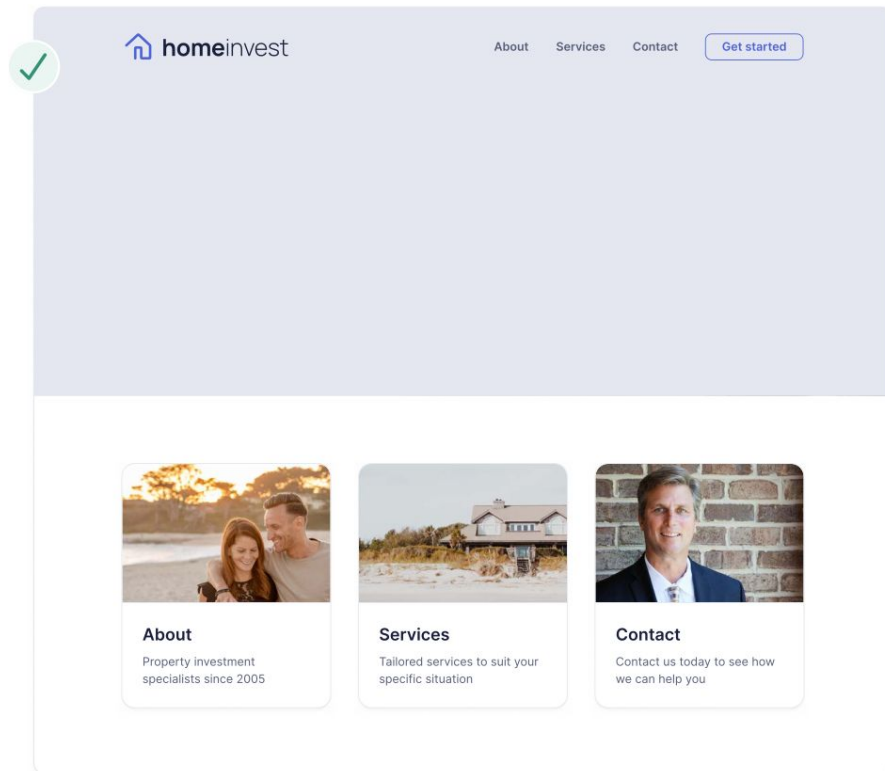
Landing page example with small spacing option applied everywhere



Space elements based on how closely related they are

To fix the spacing issue apply extra small (8pt) spacing to the innermost rectangles and gradually increase the spacing between rectangles as you move outwards

The design is now clearer, neater, and easier to understand



Space elements based on how closely related they are

It's a good idea to create spacing rules to help achieve better consistency and to speed up spacing decisions

Example spacing rule

- Use medium (24pt) internal padding for components like card

- Use large (32pt) gaps between column

- Use extra extra large (80pt) vertical padding for website sections

Spacing Example

Extra small (8pt) spacing is used for the innermost rectangles (the card text)



About

Property investment
specialists since 2005



Services

Tailored services to suit your
specific situation



Contact

Contact us today to see how
we can help you

XS

8pt



S

16pt



M

24pt



L

32pt



XL

48pt



XXL

80pt

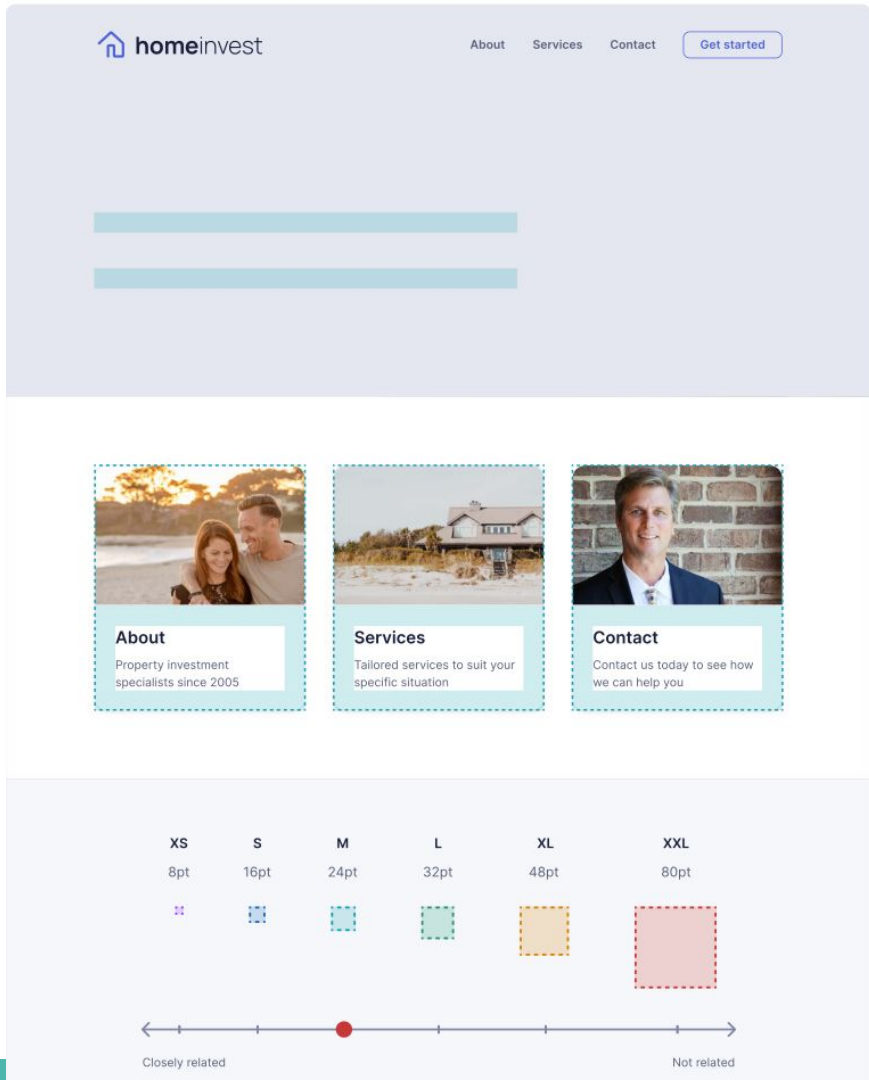


Closely related

Not related

Spacing Example

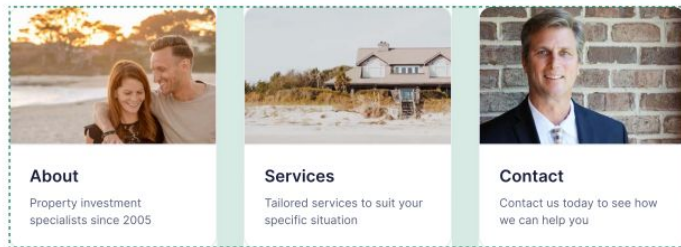
Increase the spacing to the medium (24pt) option for the next level of rectangles (the top section content and card padding)



Spacing Example

Moving further outwards, apply the large (32pt) spacing option between top navigation links and cards

The cards are actually sitting on a 12 column grid which has gaps of 32pt between columns



XS

8pt

✖

S

16pt

✖

M

24pt

✖

L

32pt

✖

XL

48pt

✖

XXL

80pt

✖

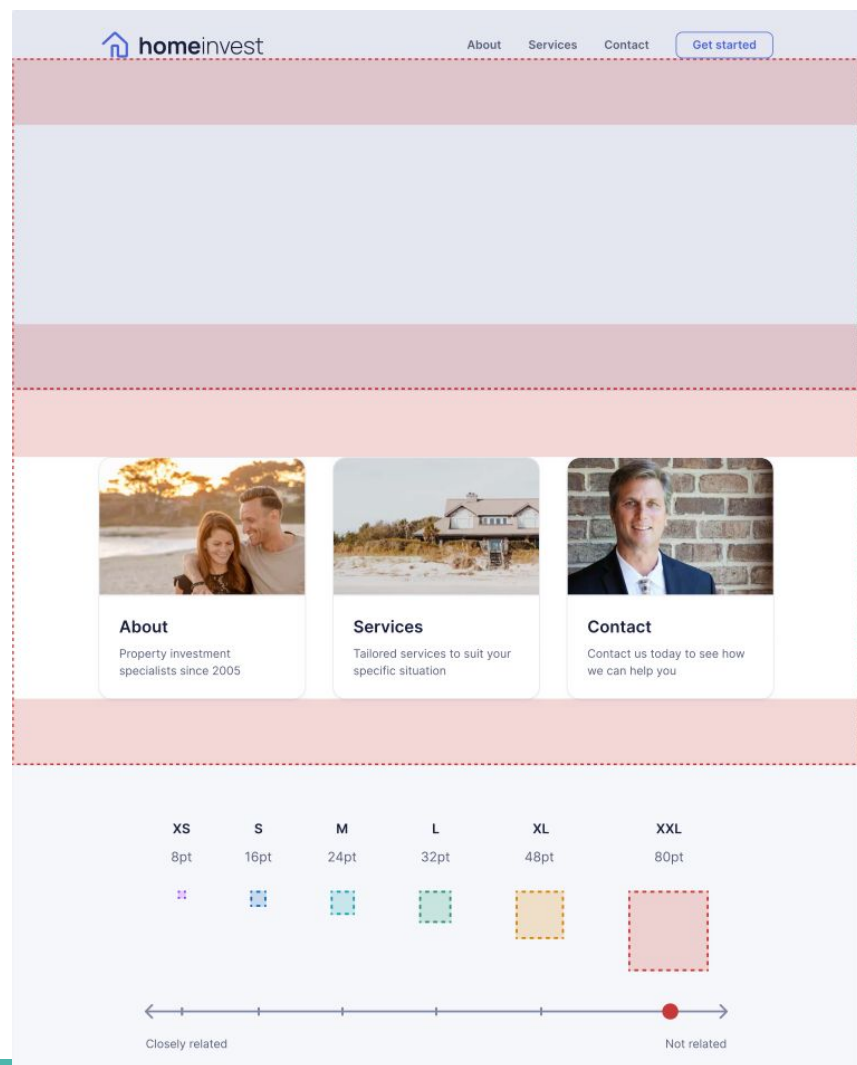


Closely related

Not related

Spacing Example

For the outermost boxes of section content, apply the extra extra large (80pt) spacing option to help separate each section of content



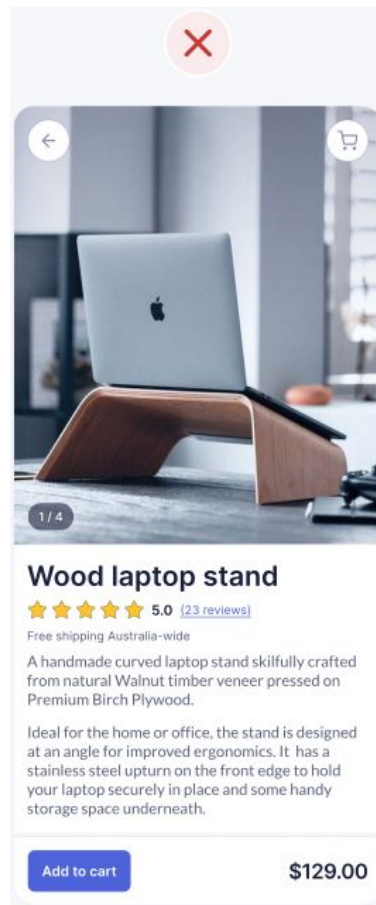
Be generous with empty space

Empty space refers to the empty space between and around design elements

It can be padding, margins, or even the space between lines of text

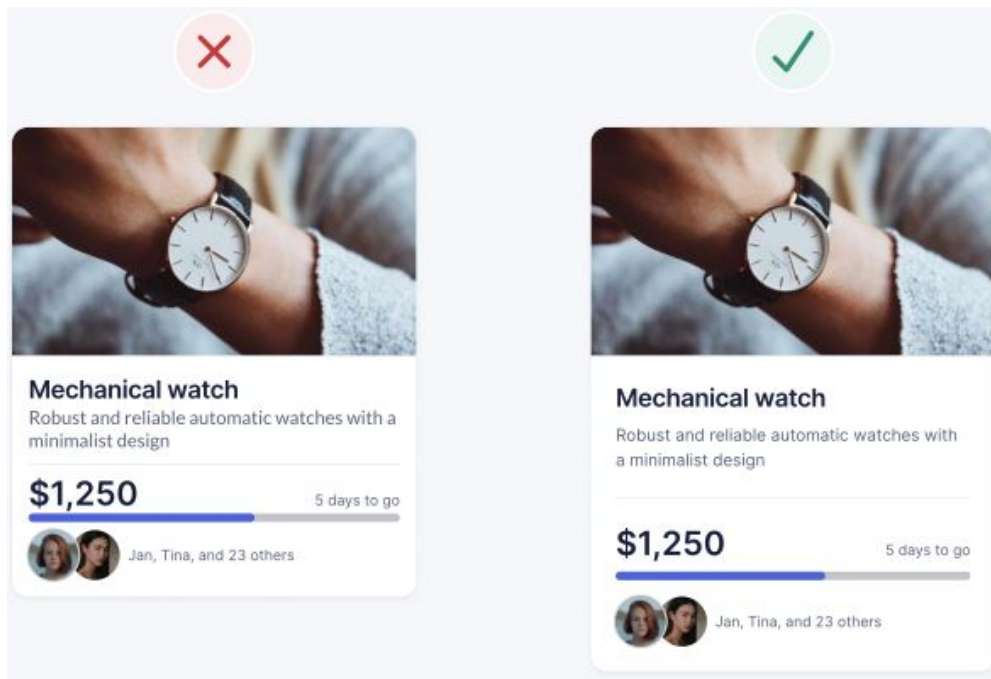
Be generous with empty space

Example of an interface with tight spacing versus one with generous spacing



Be generous with empty space

Example of an interface with tight spacing versus one with generous spacing



Align the main layout to a 12 column grid

The more interface elements you align, the more ordered and structured your interface will appear

This reduces cognitive load and makes it easier for people to understand an interface

A quick and simple way to improve alignment is to use a 12 column grid

12 column grid

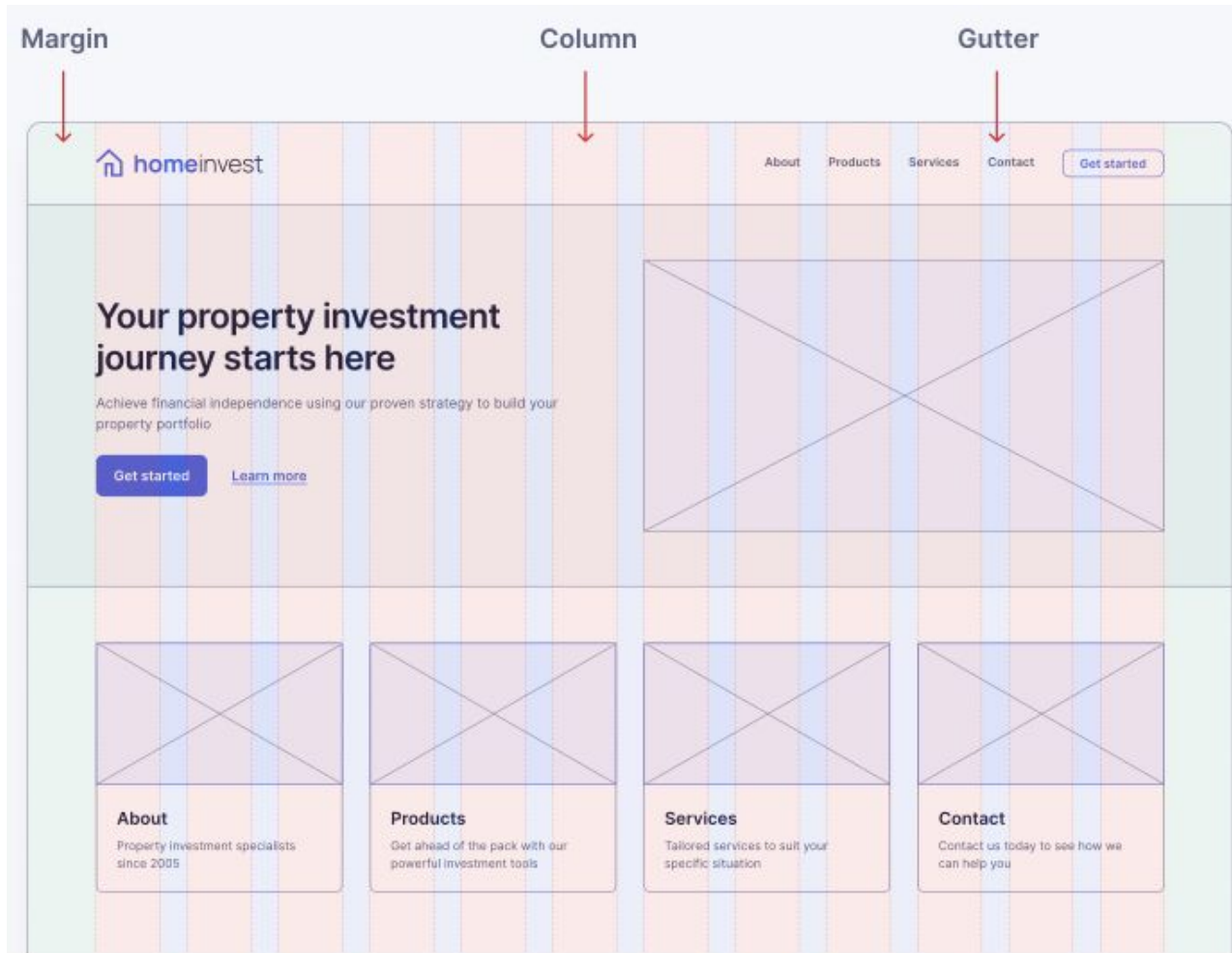
A 12 column grid consists of 12 vertical columns separated by empty spaces called gutters

Outer margins prevent the content from hitting the left and right edges of a screen

Columns provide a structure for the layout of the main elements of an interface to align with

12 column grid

12 column grid layout
overlayed on a website



12 column grid: Columns

Create different page layouts by aligning the main containers to one or more columns

Smaller elements inside the main layout containers don't need to align to the 12 columns

Use your predefined spacing options for these smaller elements

12 column grid: Columns

Columns generally have a flexible width, defined with percentages, rather than a fixed width

This allows them to adapt to different screen sizes

Start with 12 columns for large screen sizes, like desktops and laptops

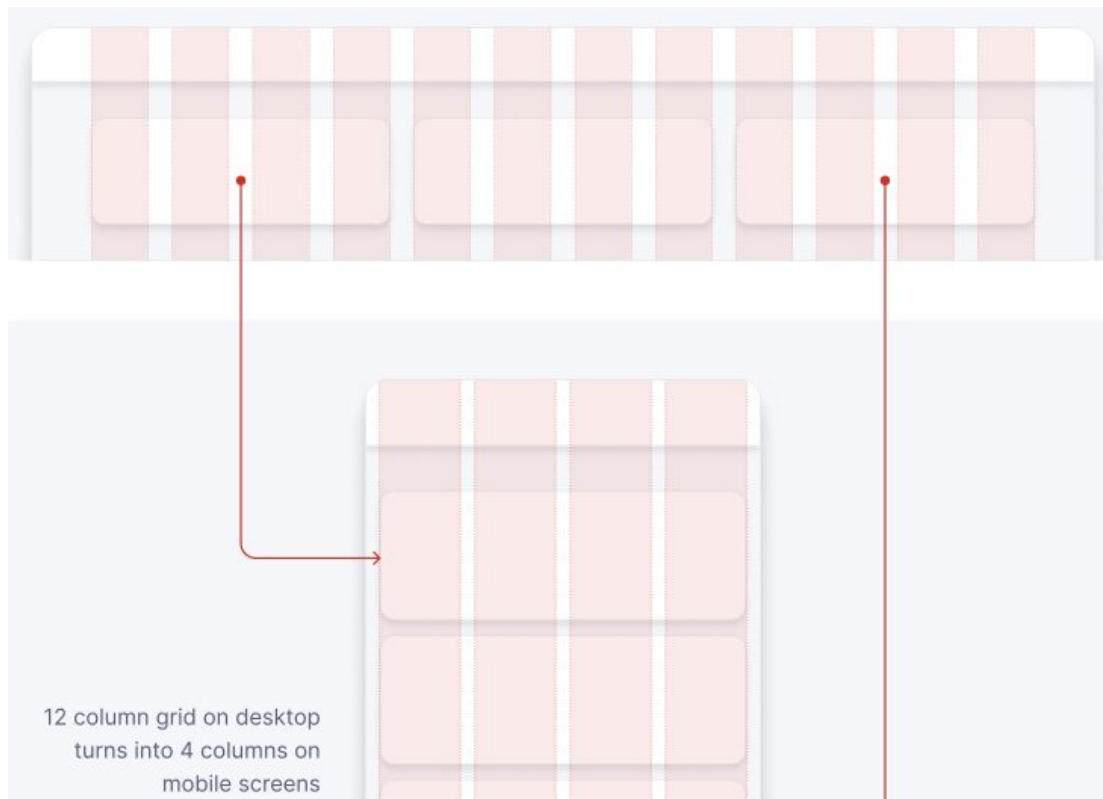
Decrease the number of columns for smaller screens, like tablets and mobiles

12 column grid: Columns

For example, on a large screen, 3 content cards might be aligned in a row across 12 columns

Each card spans 4 columns

On a smaller mobile screen, the cards stack on top of each other across 4 columns



12 column grid: Gutters

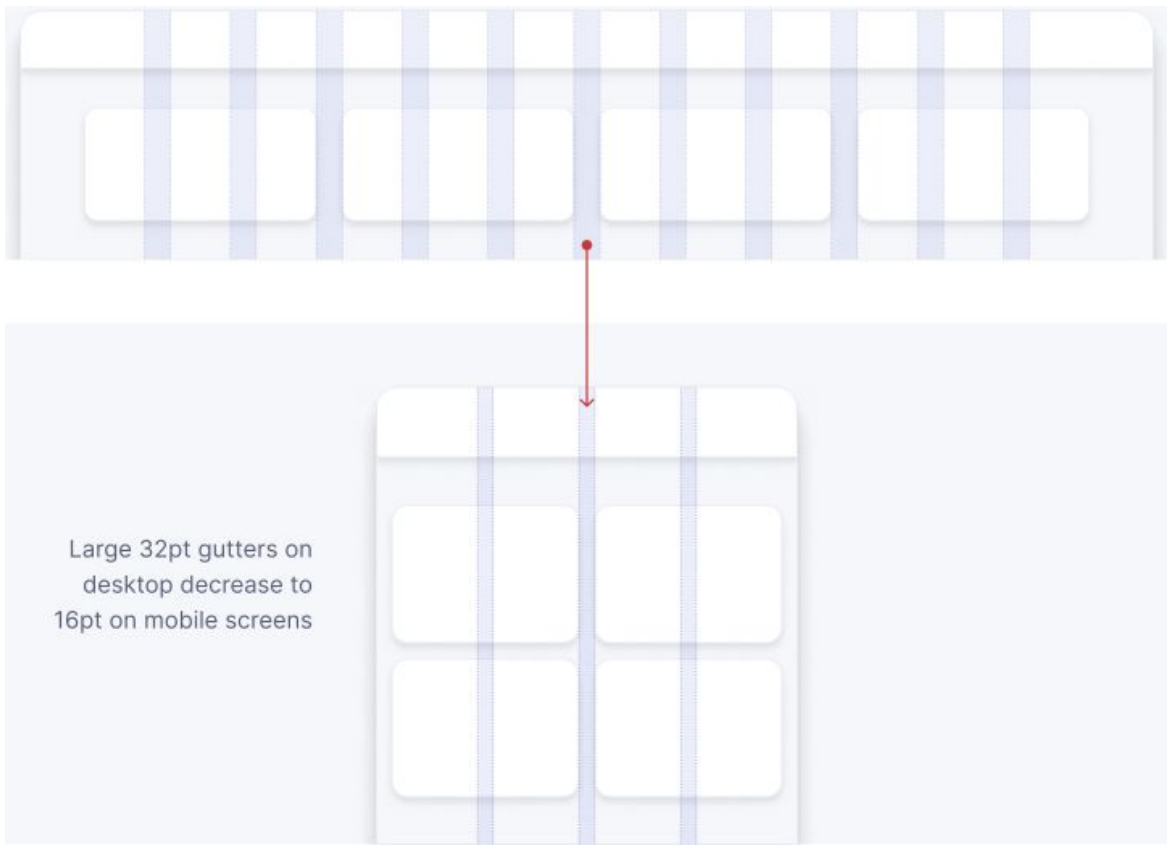
The purpose of gutters is to separate and align columns of content, not to contain content

Gutters should remain empty and should be narrower than columns

Gutters generally have a fixed width and are often wider on larger screens to keep spacing proportional

12 column grid: Gutters

For example, a large (32pt) predefined spacing option might be used for gutters on large screens, while a small (16pt) spacing option is used on smaller mobile screen

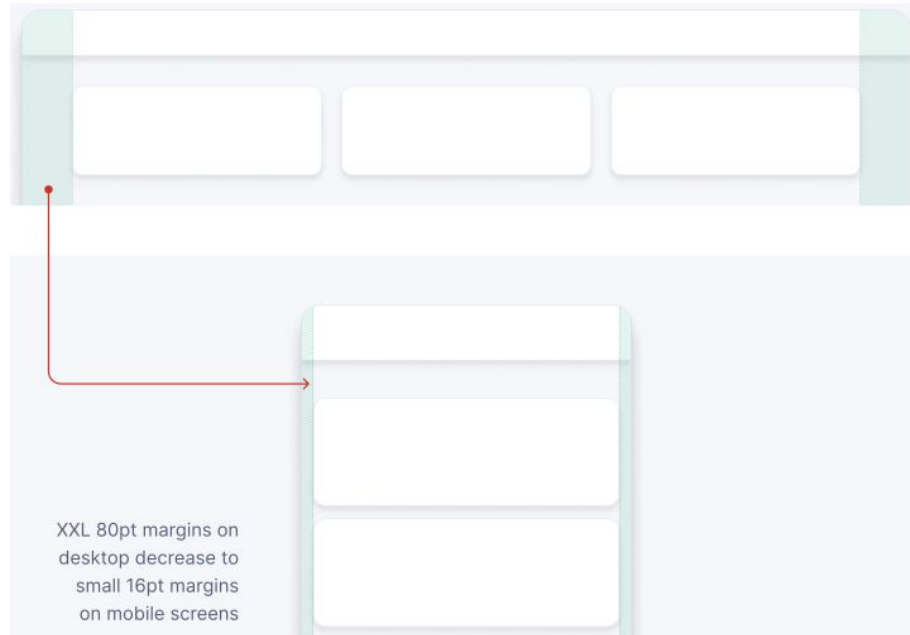


12 column grid: Margins

Margins are the empty space on the left and right of the 12 columns

They prevent the content from hitting the left and right edges of a screen

Margins can have either a fixed or flexible width and are generally wider on larger screens



Align text to improve readability

Left aligned text is easiest to read because each line starts along the same straight left edge

This gives your eyes a consistent anchor to quickly jump back to at the end of each line

Try to maintain a straight left edge when aligning text with other interface elements like icons

Align text to improve readability

In the UI shown, the icon placement breaks the straight left edge

This adds unnecessary cognitive load



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Align text to improve readability

The following UI alternative, aligns text to a straight left edge, making it more comfortable to read



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Align text to improve readability

While centre aligning long blocks of text makes it harder to read, it can work well in moderation, for short blocks of text



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[Explore templates](#)

Align horizontal text to the baseline

The baseline is an invisible line that text sits on

It creates a relatively straight bottom edge that our eyes can easily follow



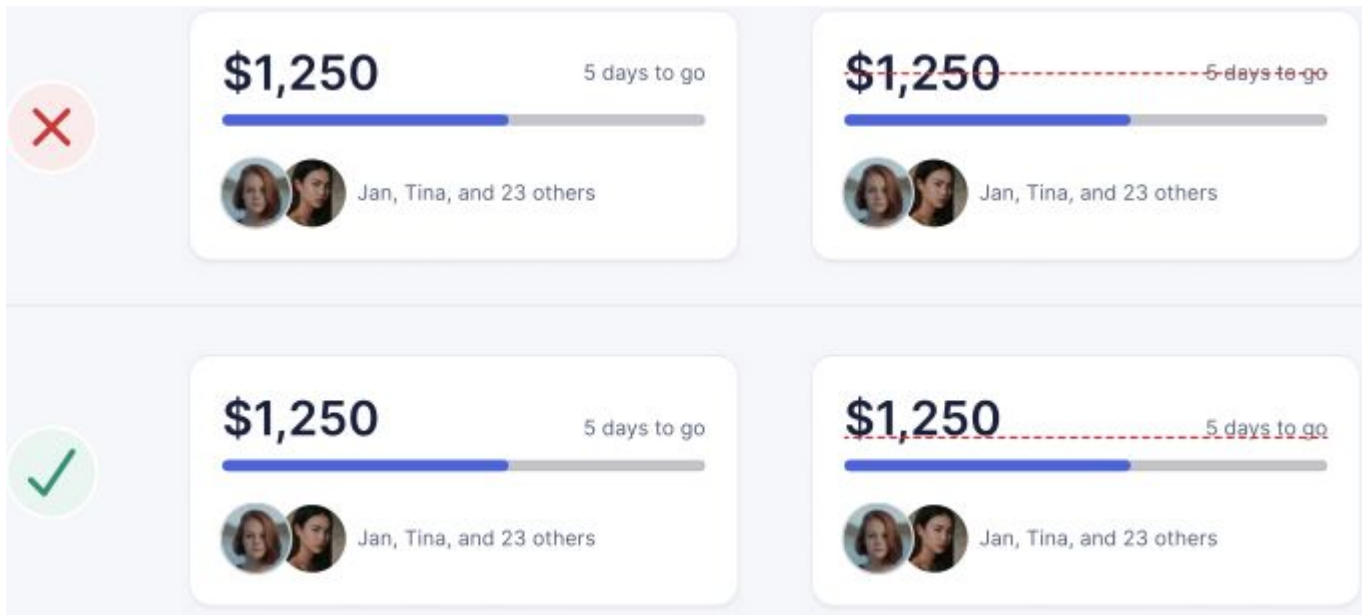
Align horizontal text to the baseline

When you have different sized text sitting in a horizontal line, align it to the baseline, rather than the vertical centre

This makes the text easier to read and also results in a neater looking design, as more elements are aligned

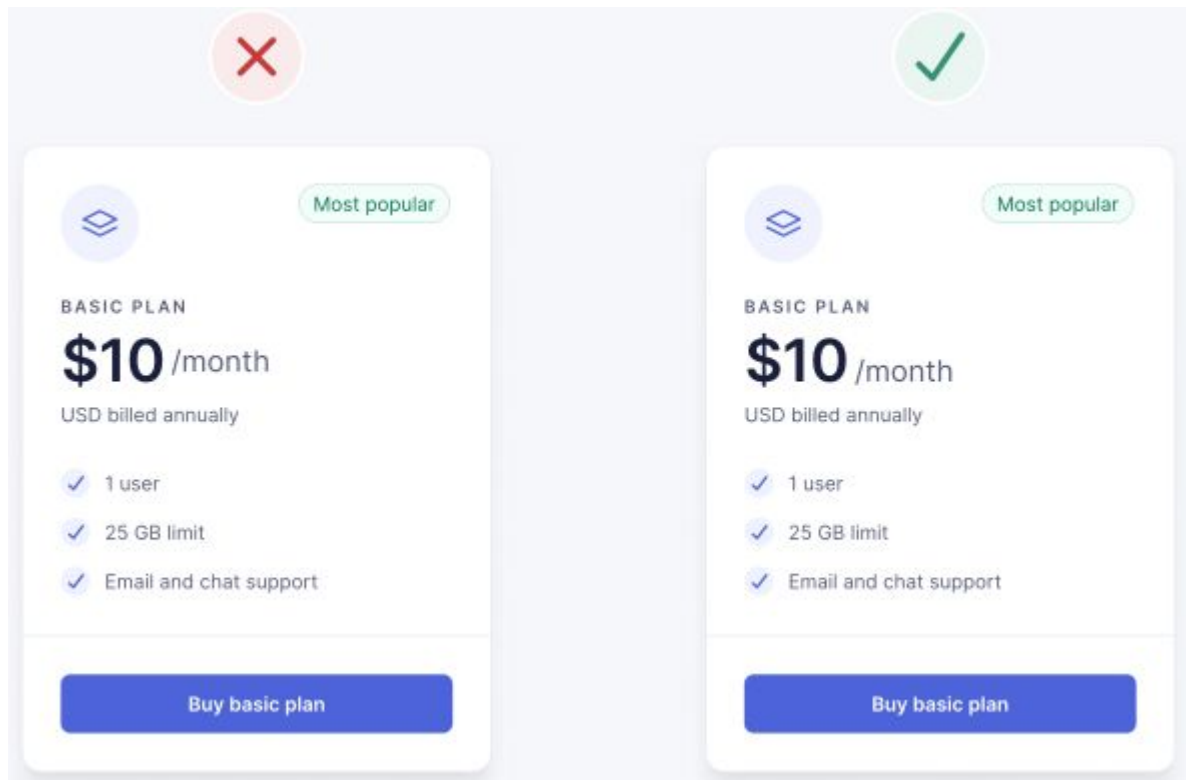
Align horizontal text to the baseline

Text aligned to vertical centre versus text aligned to the baseline



Align horizontal text to the baseline

The “/month” text is aligned to the vertical centre versus the baseline



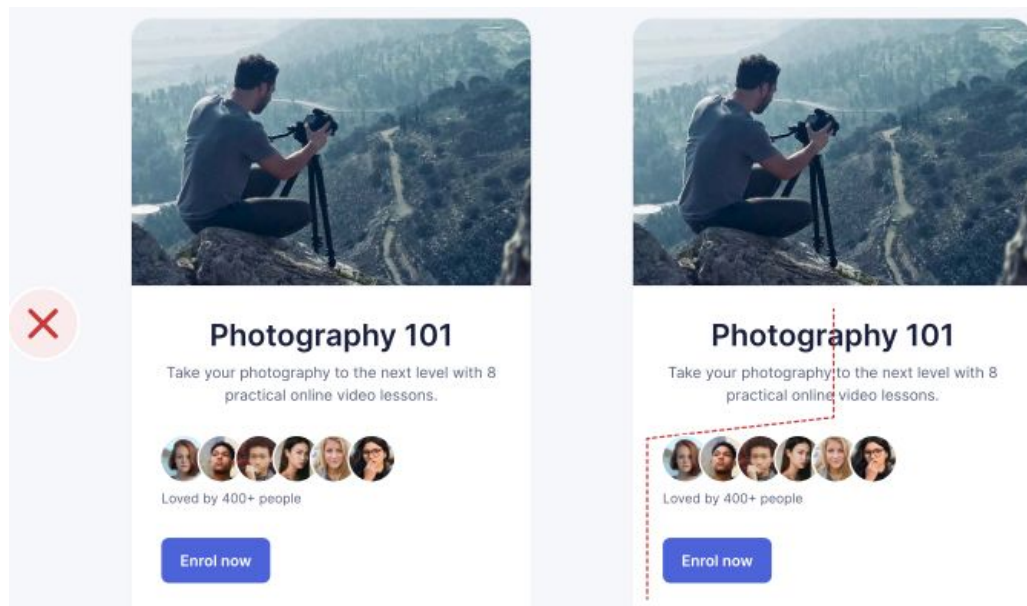
Try to avoid using multiple alignments

The more different types of alignment you use (left, right, or centre), the more complex and messy an interface can look

Sticking with a single alignment (or as few as possible) helps to simplify an interface, making it look neater and tidier

Try to avoid using multiple alignments

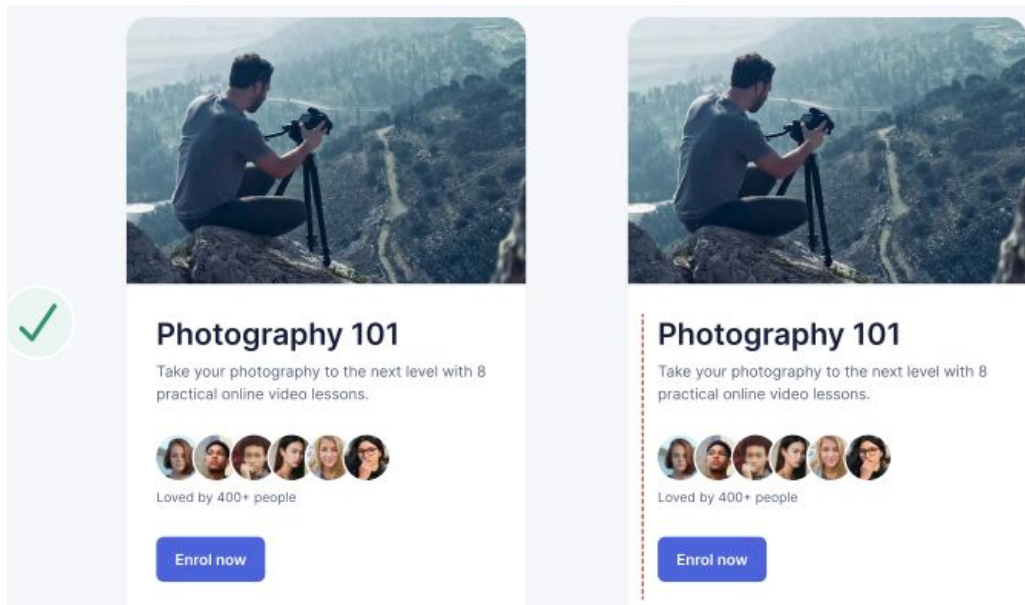
Example of an interface with multiple alignments



Try to avoid using multiple alignments

Left align all interface elements

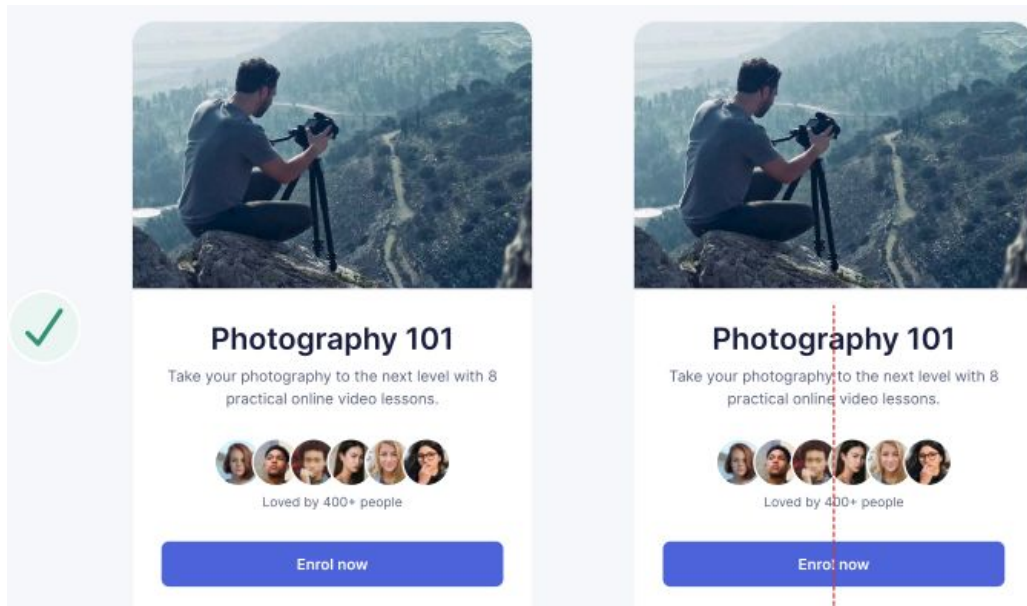
The straight left edge also improves readability



Try to avoid using multiple alignments

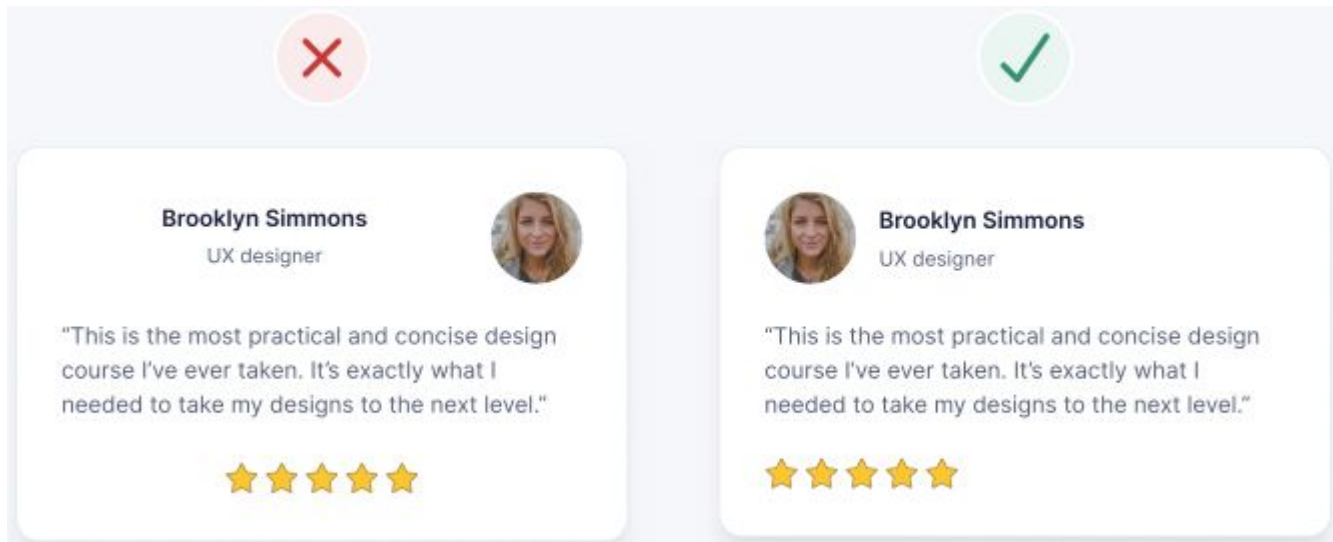
Since there's only a small amount of text, you could also centre align all elements

Make the button full-width to help both left and right handed users easily reach it with one hand



Try to avoid using multiple alignments

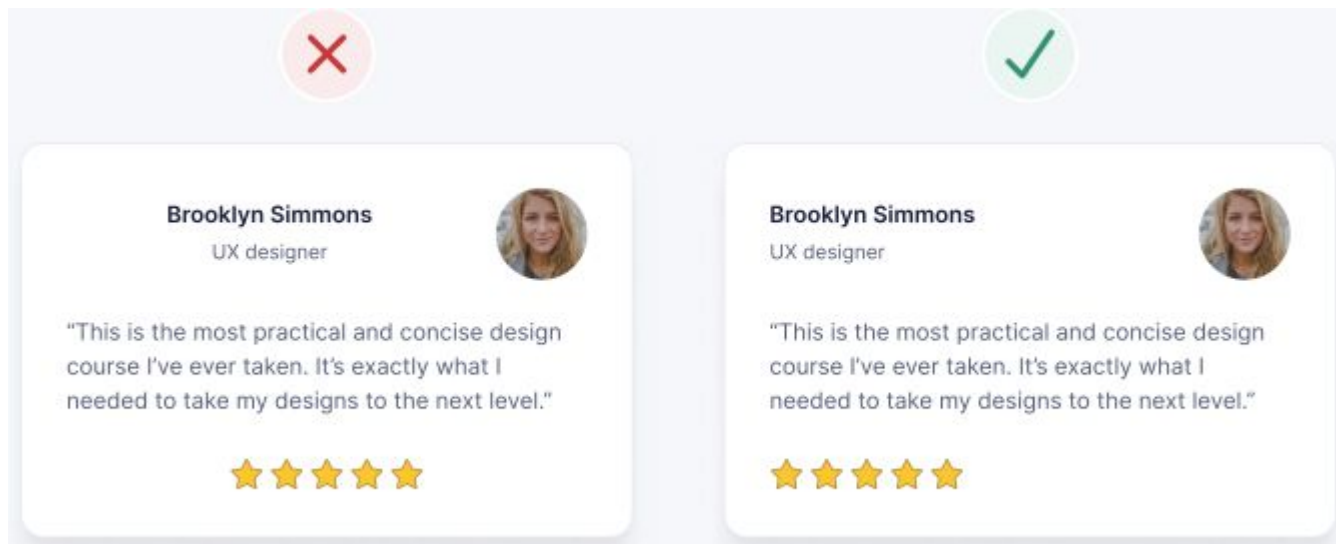
Aligning the majority of elements to the left is simpler and neater



Try to avoid using multiple alignments

You could also improve readability by aligning all text to the left edge

The right aligned photo is ok, as the majority of elements have 1 alignment



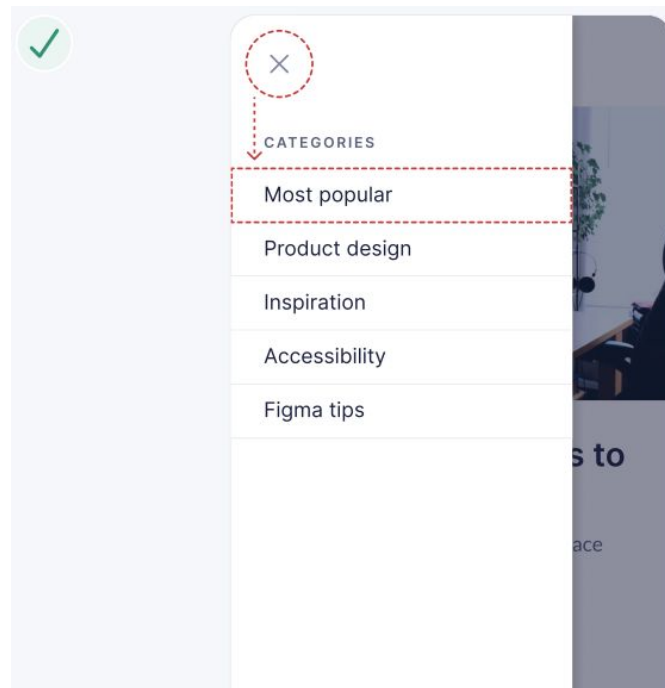
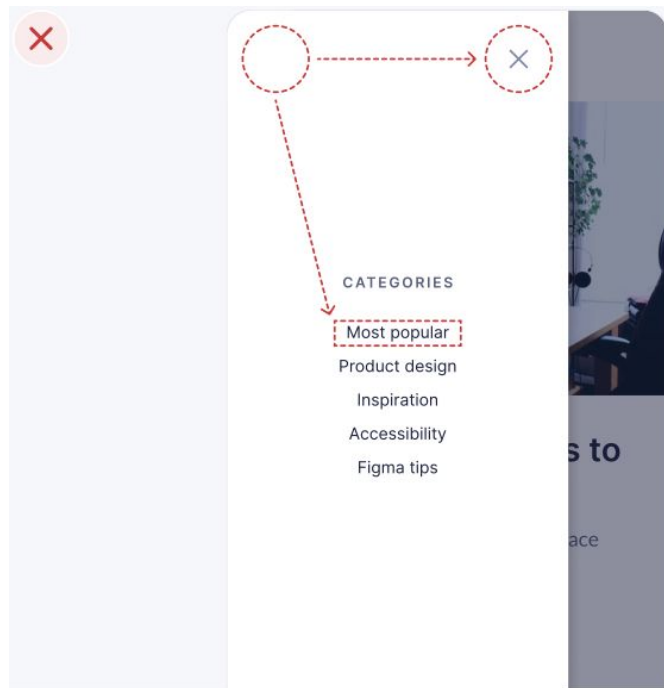
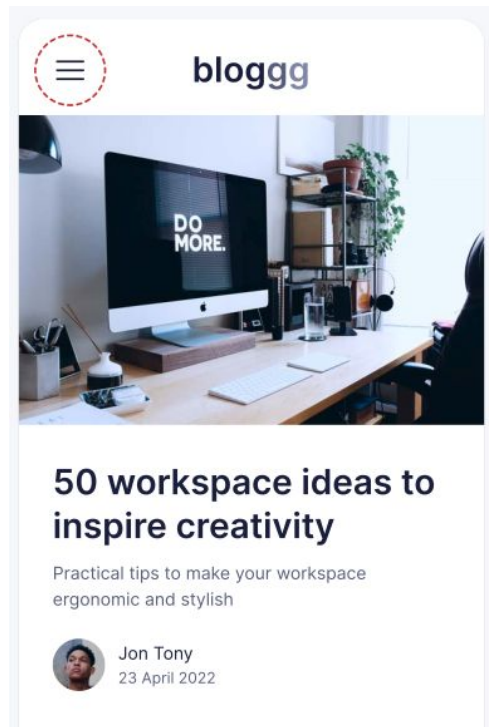
Keep related actions close

Reduce interaction cost by keeping actions close to the element they relate to

Try to ensure they have a sufficient target area. At least 48pt by 48pt is a safe size

Keep related actions close

Interaction cost comparison to navigate to a category or close the menu



Ensure an interface is unbreakable

Don't just design an interface for small numbers and short text

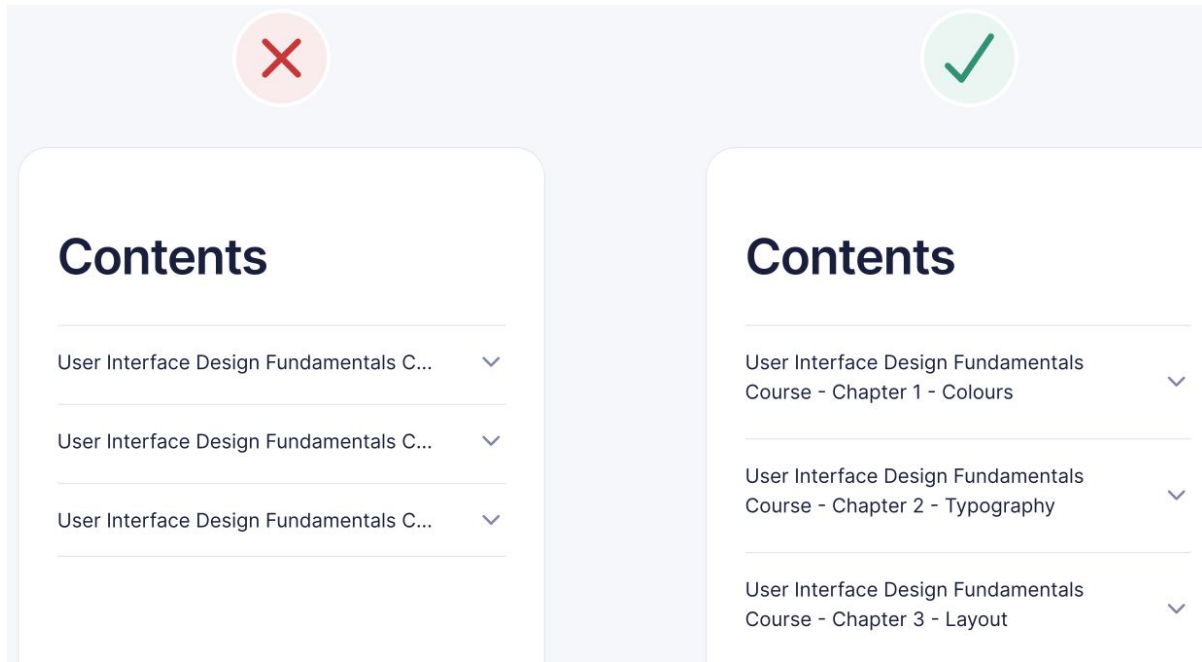
Make sure it can accommodate long data and edge cases (uncommon cases) too

Try to avoid hiding data that overflows, as you could be hiding essential information

Keep your components flexible to allow for reflow of content, or decrease font sizes to allow for long data

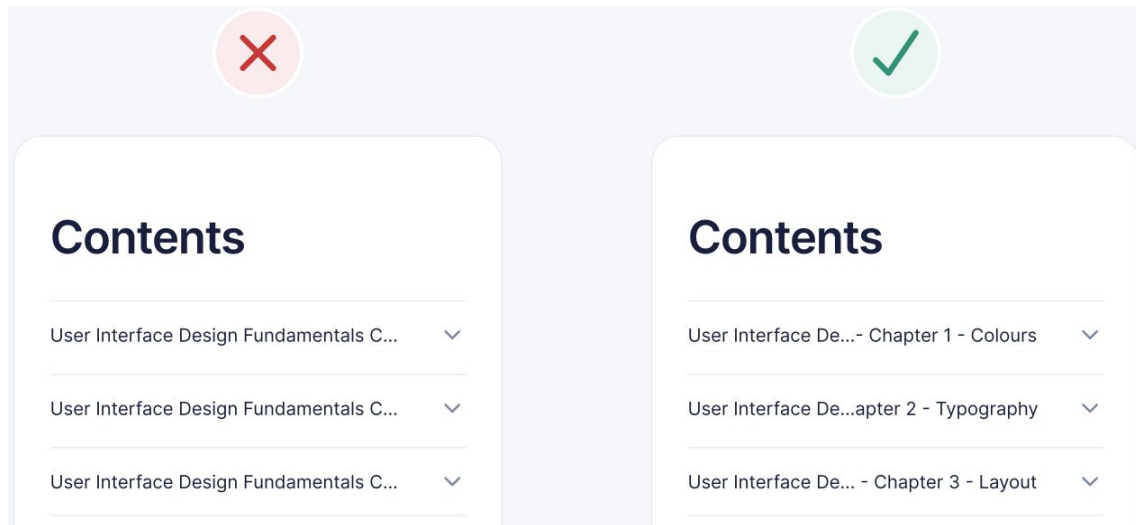
Ensure an interface is unbreakable

If you need to hide data due to space constraints, try to ensure that you're not hiding essential information



Ensure an interface is unbreakable

Consider cropping text in the middle, rather than at the end, so that people can differentiate items



Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

The Rule of Thirds is an effective way to make photos look more balanced, natural, and dynamic

Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

Divide your photo into thirds by creating a grid that's 3 columns wide and 3 rows tall

This creates 4 focal points where the lines intersect

Our eyes naturally gravitate towards these focal points

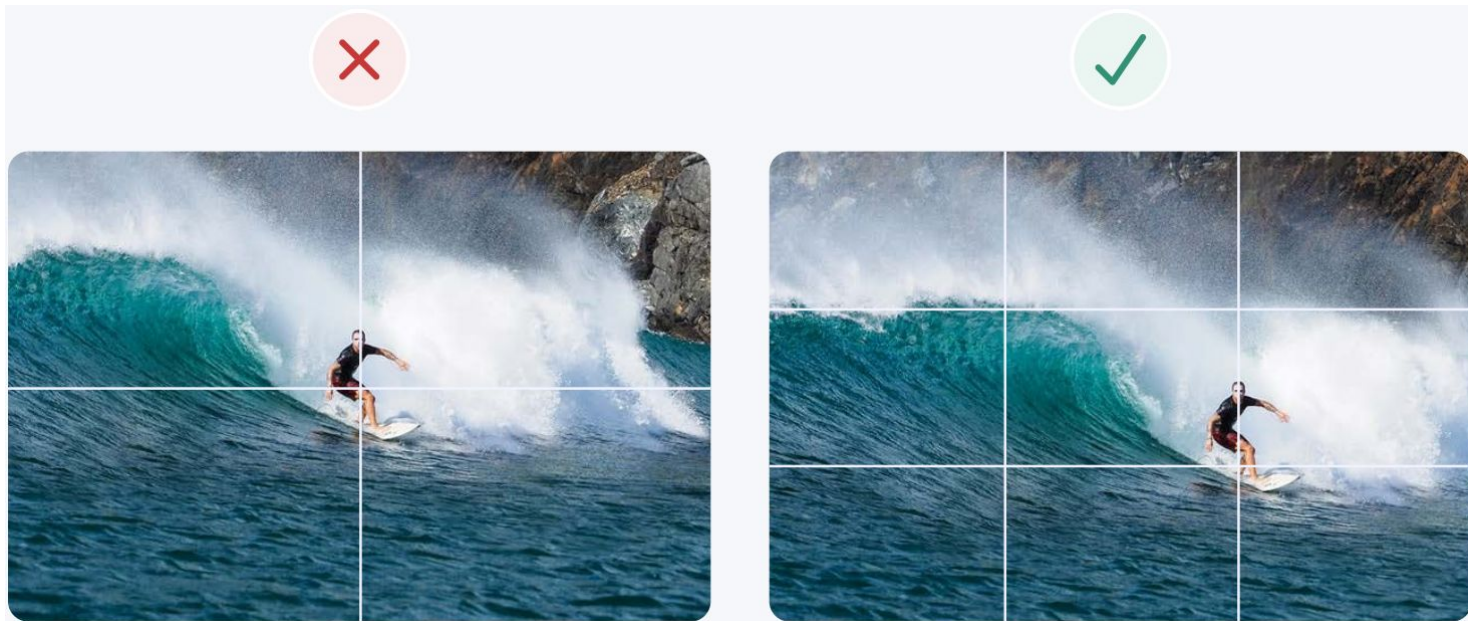
Try to roughly align key elements of your photo to the grid, ensuring that the main subject sits on one of the 4 focal points

Use the Rule of Thirds for photos



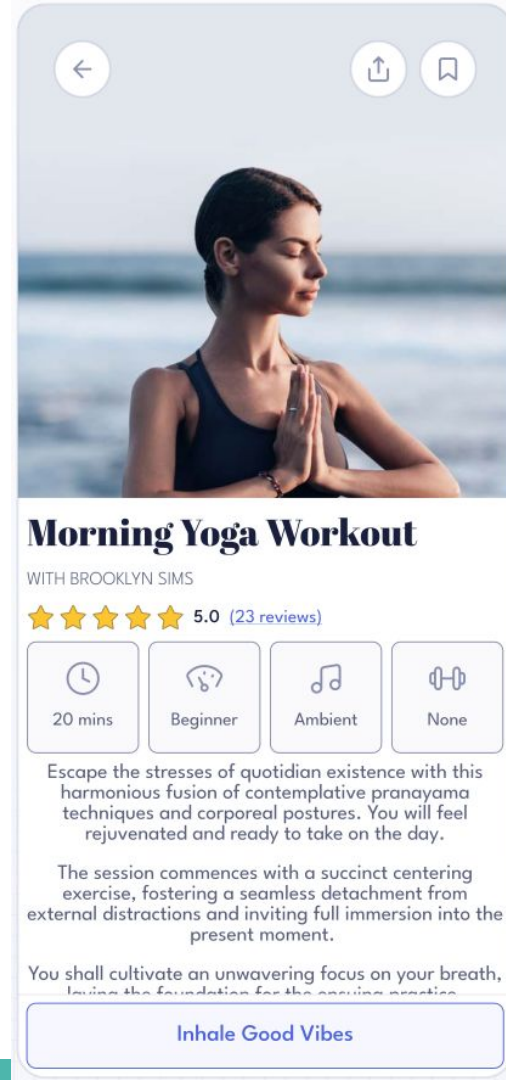
Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

The Rule of Thirds is especially effective for action shots, as it increases the sense of motion already present in the photo



Applying Layout and Spacing

Identify layout and spacing issues in the design displayed

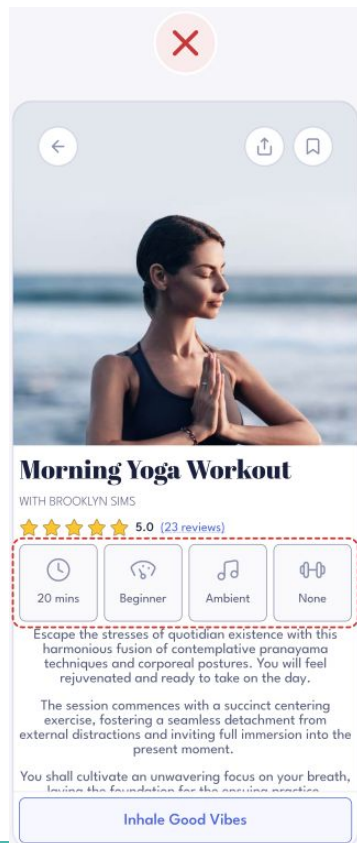


Ensure similar looking elements function similarly

Issues

The icon containers have a similar visual style to the button at the bottom

This makes them seem interactive, even though they're not

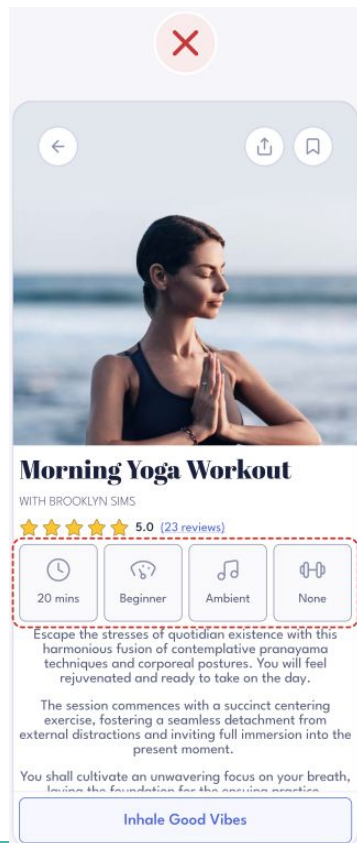


Ensure similar looking elements function similarly

Issues

The icon containers have a similar visual style to the button at the bottom

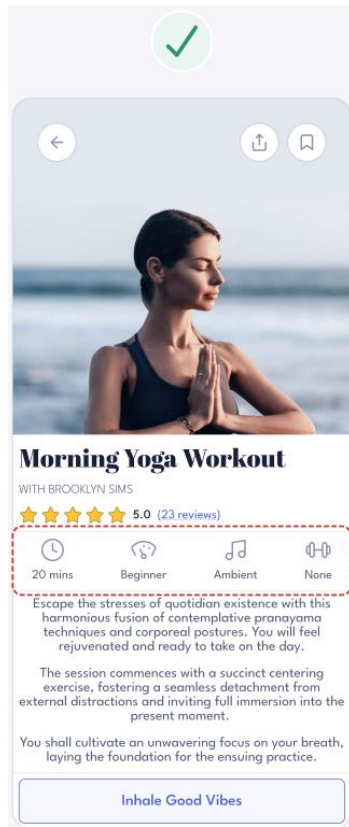
This makes them seem interactive, even though they're not



Ensure similar looking elements function similarly

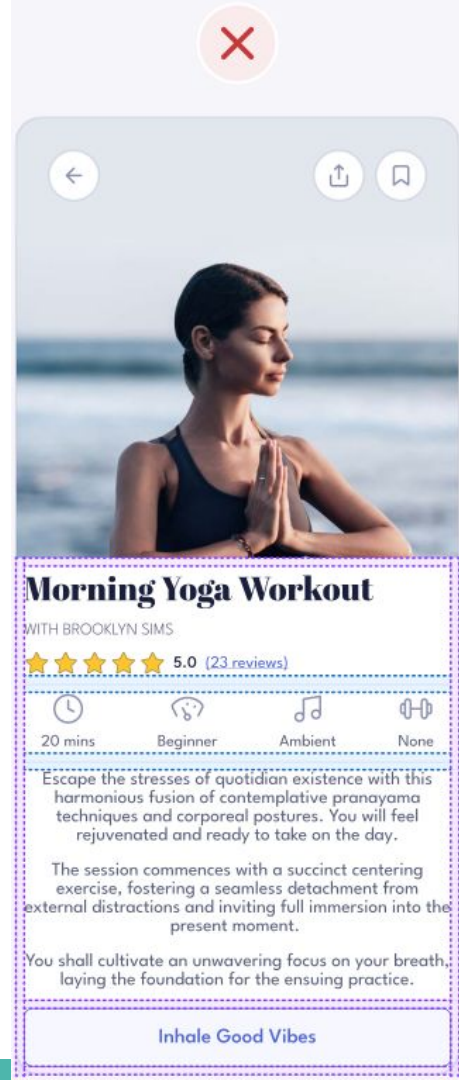
Fixes

Removing the button styling from the icons helps to avoid them being mistaken for interactive elements



Use space to group related elements

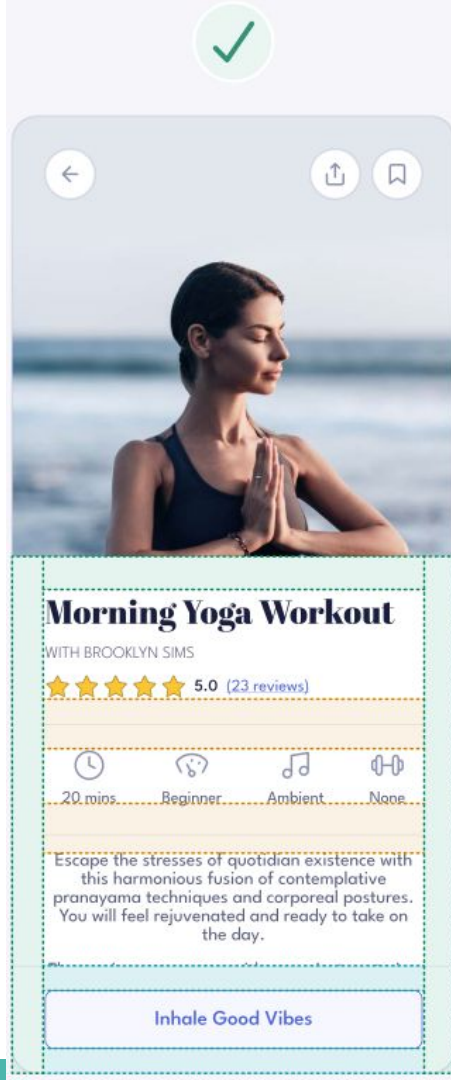
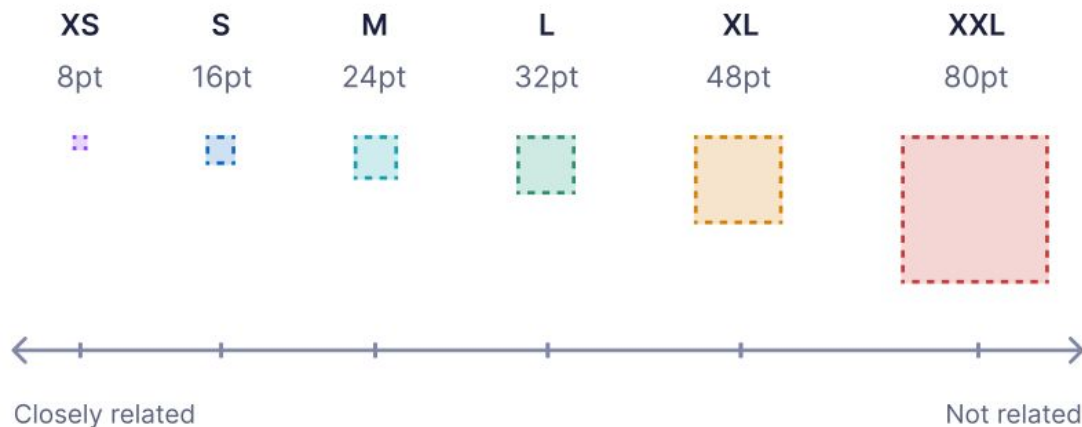
In the UI shown all of the content is spaced very closely together, making the design look cluttered and difficult to understand



Use space to group related elements

More closely related elements should generally be closer together to show that they're related

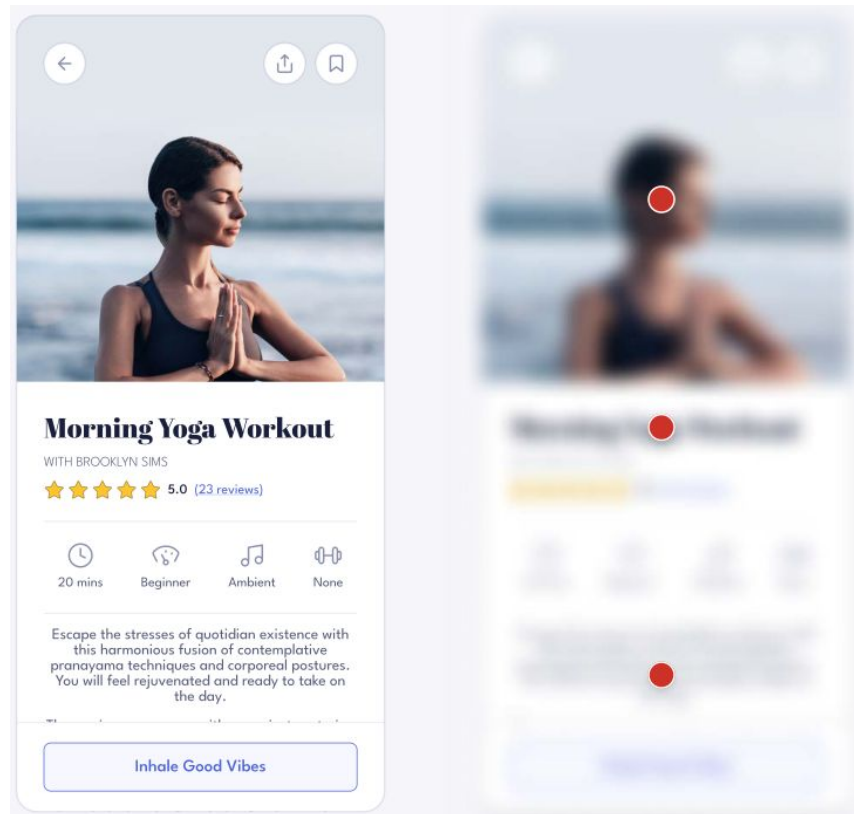
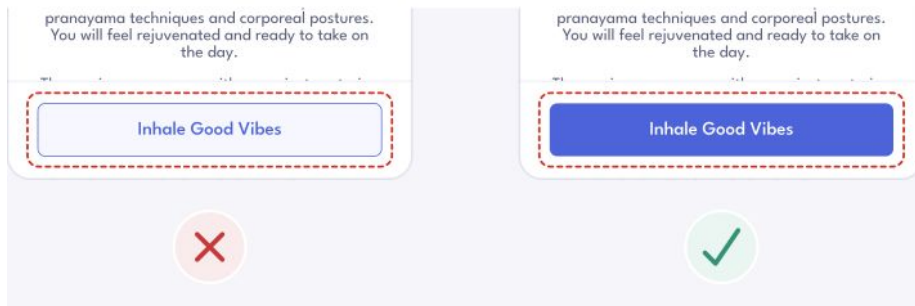
Unrelated elements should be separated by placing more space between them



Create a clear visual hierarchy

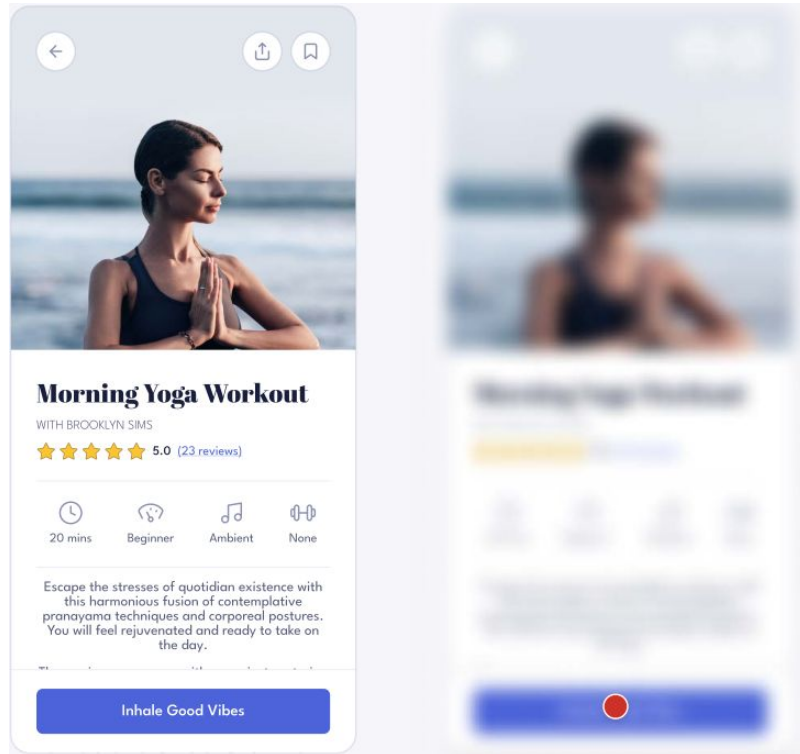
There are multiple elements with similarly strong prominence competing for attention

The primary action at the bottom doesn't stand out much



Create a clear visual hierarchy

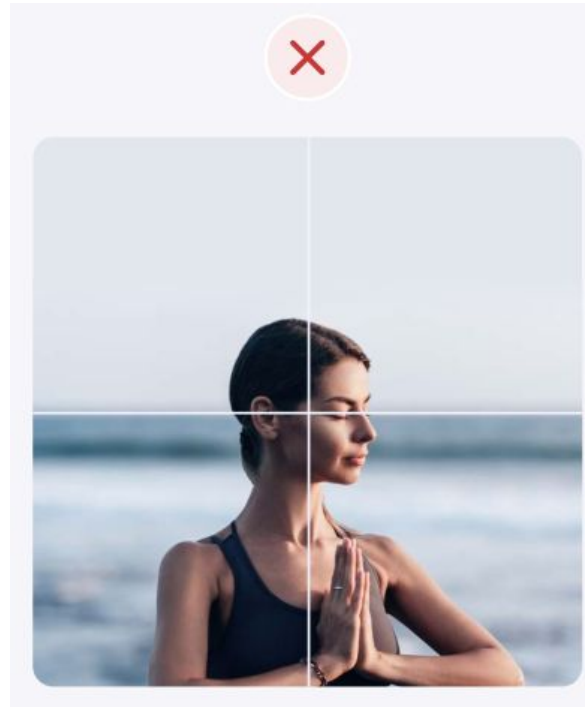
Applying the brand color to the Primary Action button to make it more prominent



Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

In the UI shown, the photo looks a bit rigid and still, as it's very symmetrical

The focal point is the person's face and it's positioned in the centre of the photo

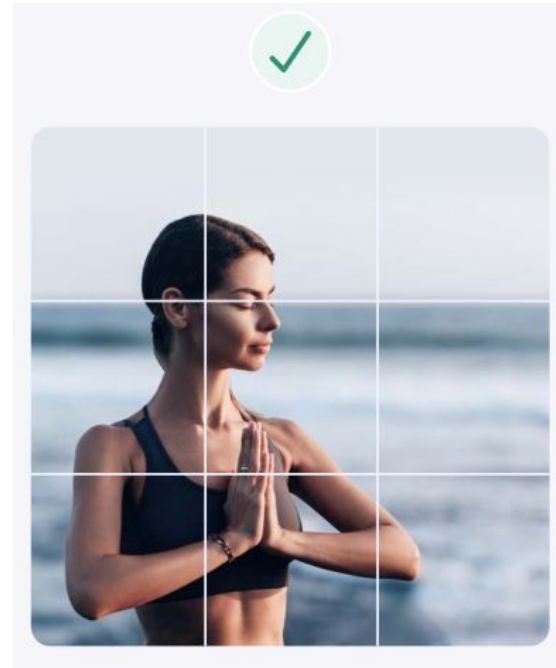


Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

Instead of centre aligning their face, move it to align with one of the 4 points of intersection on the grid

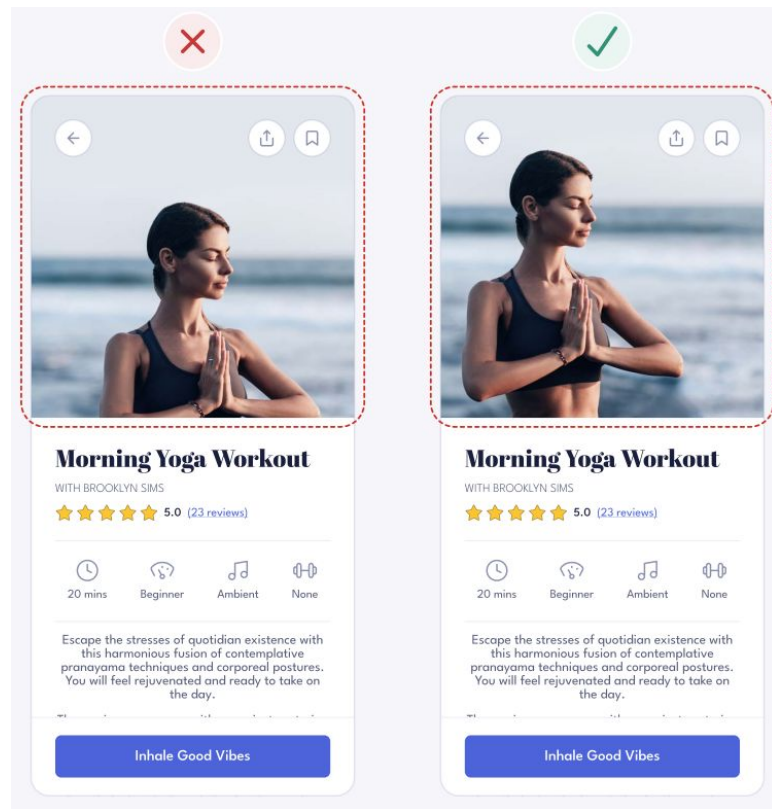
The asymmetry introduces a sense of natural motion and flow

You should also make sure that the horizon aligns with the horizontal grid



Use the Rule of Thirds for photos

The photo is realigned based on the Rule of Thirds



Typography

Guidelines

Typeface

A typeface is a set of related fonts with a similar style or aesthetic

Helvetica is an example of a san serif typeface

Fonts are variations within a typeface, like weights or sizes

For example, Helvetica Bold and Helvetica Regular are 2 different fonts within the Helvetica typeface

Typeface

There are 5 main classifications of typefaces:

serif, sans serif, script, display, and monospaced

Serif typefaces

Serif typefaces include decorative tails or feet at the ends of letters

They often convey a traditional, classic, or formal mood

Some serifs are more legible than others and can be used at small sizes

Others are better suited for use at large sizes



Sans serif typefaces

Sans serif typefaces don't include decorative tails or feet at the ends of letters

They generally look more modern due to their simplicity

Sans serif typefaces are highly legible, making them suitable for use at small and large sizes

Due to their simplicity and lack of character, sans serif typefaces are a safe and neutral option that suits most interface designs

Sans serif

Script typefaces

Script typefaces are based on handwriting

Their low legibility means that they're not suitable for use at small sizes

Script typefaces can be effective at conveying a formal or casual mood at large sizes



Display typefaces

Display typefaces come in a wide range of varied styles

They're decorative typefaces specifically designed to be read at large sizes

Due to their strong character and detail, they can be especially good at conveying a range of different moods

Display typefaces aren't suitable for use at small sizes due to their visual complexity



Display

Monospaced typefaces

In a monospaced typeface, every character takes up the same amount of horizontal space

For this reason, they're often used for displaying code

They're also useful for displaying numbers to make them easier and faster to compare

The word "Monospaced" is displayed in a dark blue, monospaced typeface. Each character is contained within a vertical column defined by two red dashed lines, demonstrating that every character occupies the same horizontal width. The background is light blue with horizontal white lines.

Use a single sans serif typeface

It's safest to use a single sans serif typeface for most interface designs

Sans serif typefaces are generally the most legible

Sans serif typefaces generally don't convey a strong mood or personality

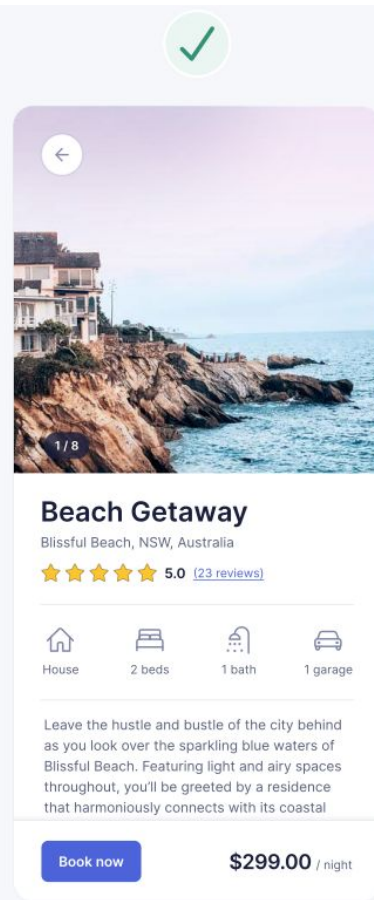
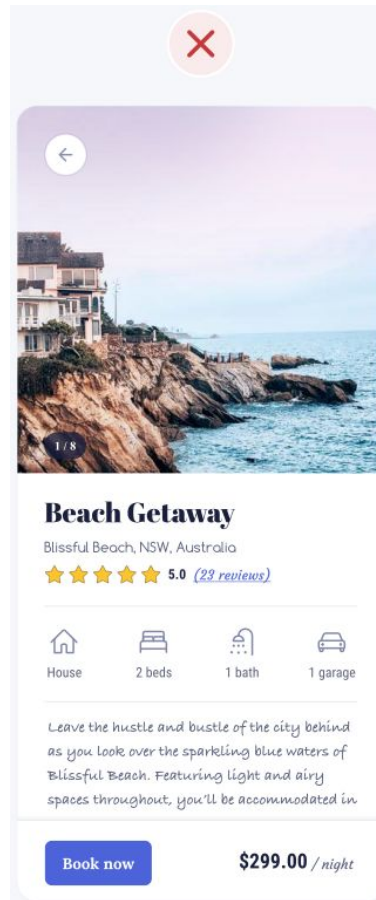
The typeface will fit with most brand personalities

The content is the focal point, rather than the typeface

Sans serif typefaces are generally simpler than others as they have less character and detail

Use a single sans serif typeface

Example of an interface with multiple typefaces versus one with a single sans serif typeface



Tips for choosing a sans serif typeface

Choose a popular typeface that's been tried and tested by many

Look for typefaces that come in a variety of weights, as they're generally better quality

Those with light, regular, medium, semibold, and bold weights are a good place to start

Look for typefaces with taller lower case letters and greater letter spacing, as they're generally more legible at small sizes

The height of lowercase letters in a typeface is known as the x-height

Tips for choosing a sans serif typeface

Get inspiration from designers and companies known for good design

If your interface needs to support multiple languages, make sure the typeface does too

Look for typefaces with OpenType features

They support both Mac and Windows computers, usually offer better language support, and often have additional advanced features

When in doubt, just use the default system typeface native to the platform

Evoked emotion using a second typeface for headings

While it's safest to use a single sans serif typeface for most interface designs, you might want to add some personality depending on the brand

Classic

Neutral

Soft

Handmade

Elegant

Luxury

Evoked emotion using a second typeface for headings

Along with colour, shape, and imagery, you can use typefaces to help evoke emotion or convey a mood

While the emotions people feel from different typefaces are largely subjective (based on personal experiences, preferences, and culture), there are still some general guidelines you can follow to choose a typeface that fits the brand personality

Evoked emotion using a second typeface for headings

Different typefaces generally evoke different feelings, for example

Sans serif typefaces generally feel neutral, minimal, or modern

Serif typefaces generally feel traditional, established, or classic

Rounded sans serif typefaces generally feel fun, soft, or playful

Casual script typefaces generally feel personal or handmade

Formal script typefaces generally feel formal, feminine, or elegant

Light sans serif typefaces generally feel chic, modern, or luxurious



TECH

Neutral

Sans serif typefaces generally feel neutral, minimal, or modern.

Add to cart



WATCHES

Classic

Serif typefaces generally feel traditional, established, or classic.

Add to cart



DONUTS

Soft

Rounded sans serif typefaces generally feel fun, soft, or playful.

Add to cart



WOODWORK

Handmade

Casual script typefaces generally feel personal or handmade.

Add to cart



WEDDINGS

Elegant

Formal script typefaces generally feel formal, feminine, or elegant.

Add to cart



SKINCARE

Luxury

Light sans serif typefaces generally feel chic, modern, or luxurious.

Add to cart

Use regular and bold font weights only

Using lots of different font weights can add noise and clutter to your interface

It also makes it more difficult to use each font weight consistently

Keep your design system simple and concise by using regular and bold font weights only

Some typefaces have a semi-bold font option that you can use instead of bold if bold is too heavy

Use regular and bold font weights only

Use bold font weight for headings to emphasise them

Use regular font weight for other smaller text

Reserve very thin or thick font weights for headings and larger text, as they can be difficult to read at smaller sizes

~~Thin~~

~~Light~~

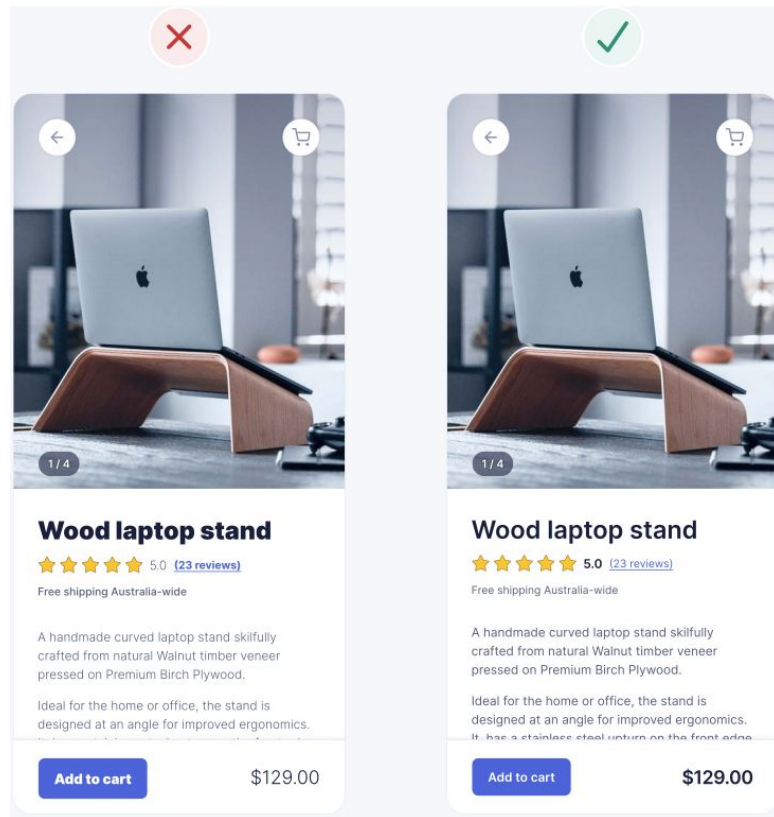
Regular

~~Semi-bold~~

Bold

Use regular and bold font weights only

Example of an interface using multiple font weights versus one using only regular and bold



Use a type scale to set font sizes

To create your set of font sizes, start with a base font size for body text, then keep multiplying it by a certain scale to create larger font sizes

Use a type scale to set font sizes

Here are some popular type scales, ordered from smallest to largest

1.067 – Minor Second

1.125 – Major Second

1.200 – Minor Third

1.250 – Major Third

1.333 – Perfect Fourth

1.414 – Augmented Fourth

1.500 – Perfect Fifth

1.618 – Golden Ratio

Use a type scale to set font sizes

For example

Start with a base font size of 16px and use a “1.200 - Minor Third” scale

Multiply 16px by 1.2 to get the next font size of 19.2px

Round it to 20px for simplicity. Then take 20px and multiply it by 1.2 to get the next font size, and so on

Use a type scale to set font sizes

An example set of font sizes using a slightly modified Minor Third type scale

TYPE SCALE (1.200)	SIZE	LINE HEIGHT
Heading 1	40px	48px
Heading 2	32px	40px
Heading 3	24px	32px
Heading 4	20px	28px
Small	16px	24px
Tiny	14px	20px

Use a type scale to set font sizes

Small type scales

Using a small type scale, like “Major Second”, will result in less of a difference between font sizes than using a large type scale

Small type scales are generally more suitable for complex website applications, tools, and dashboards where more detail is needed

Use a type scale to set font sizes

Small type scales

Using a small type scale, like “Major Second”, will result in less of a difference between font sizes than using a large type scale

Small type scales are generally more suitable for complex website applications, tools, and dashboards where more detail is needed

Use a type scale to set font sizes

Large type scales

Using a large type scale, like “Perfect Fifth”, will result in a larger difference between font sizes

Large type scales are generally more suitable for less complex interfaces, like marketing websites

Use a type scale to set font sizes

Responsive type scales

While large type scales can work well on large screens, they can cause text to wrap onto the next line on smaller mobile screens

To fix this issue, you could consider switching to a smaller type scale on mobile

Make long body text bigger

Most people will be reading text from around an arm's length away, whether it's on a phone, tablet or desktop

Make sure your body text is legible from that distance

For most typefaces, make long body text at least 18px to help improve readability

Make long body text bigger

In the UI shown, the body text is too small at 14px

Increasing it to 18px makes it much easier to read

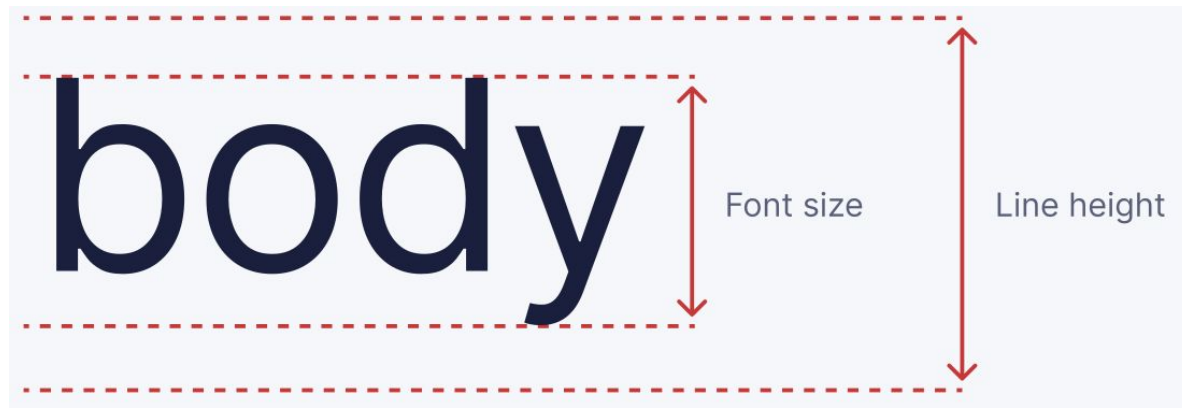
	
14px body text	18px body text
TYPOGRAPHY Too small Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magna. Vivamus ut odio vitae orci. Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.	TYPOGRAPHY Bigger is better Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magna. Vivamus ut odio vitae orci. Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.

Use at least 1.5 line height for long body text

Line height is the vertical distance between two lines of text

For accessibility and readability, especially for long body text, ensure that line height is at least 1.5 (150%)

Keeping line height between 1.5 and 2 generally works well



Use at least 1.5 line height for long body text

Tips to set a suitable line height

Longer lines of text require a taller line height to help separate them

Darker and heavier typefaces require a taller line height to help lighten and separate lines of text

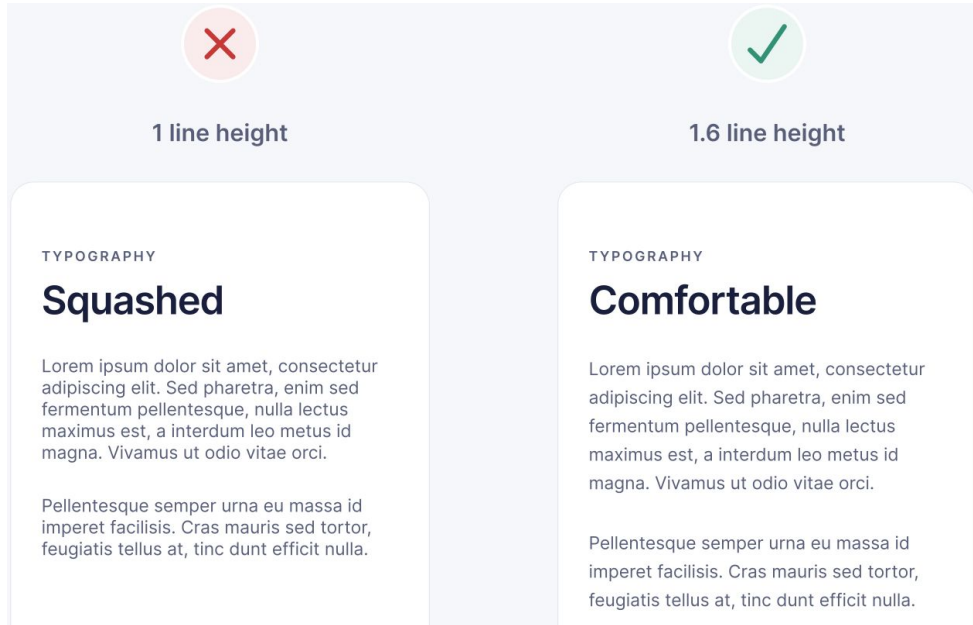
Some typefaces look larger than others, even though they're the same font size

Typefaces that look larger require a taller line height

Use at least 1.5 line height for long body text

In the UI shown, a line height of 1 (100%) is difficult to read because the lines of text aren't clearly separated

Increasing the line height to 1.6 (160%) clearly separates each line



Decrease line height as font size increases

The purpose of the spacing between lines is to help people read from one line to the next, comfortably

While a line height of at least 1.5 (150%) works well for body text, it's unnecessary on larger sized text such as headings

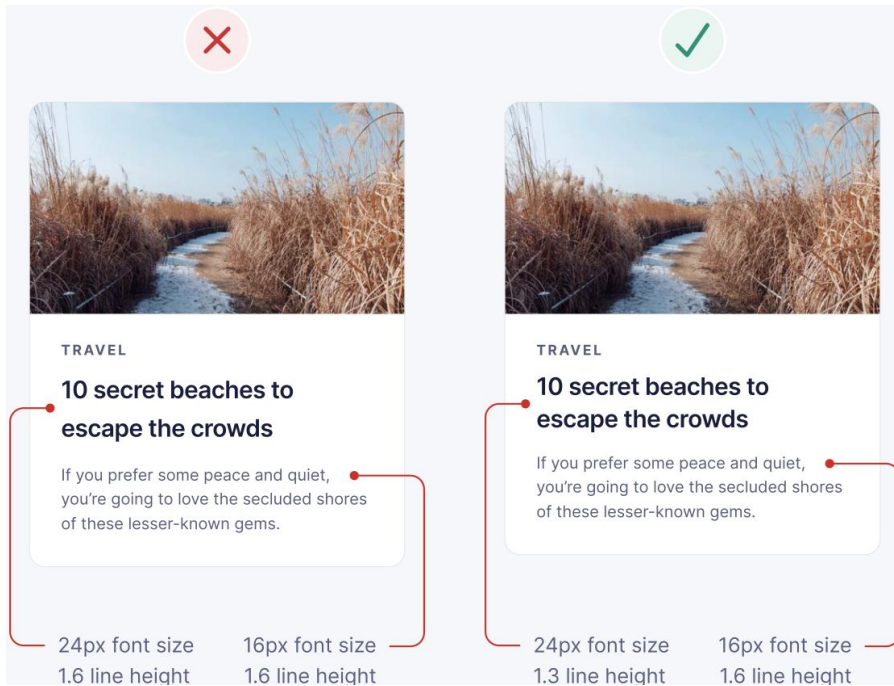
The larger the font size, the smaller the line height should be, to maintain comfortable spacing

Decrease line height as font size increases

In the following UI, the line height of both the heading and paragraph text is 1.6 (160%)

Because line height is relative to font size, the actual space between lines of heading text is much larger than the space between lines of paragraph text

Decrease the line height for larger text to create a consistent gap between lines



Ensure ideal line length

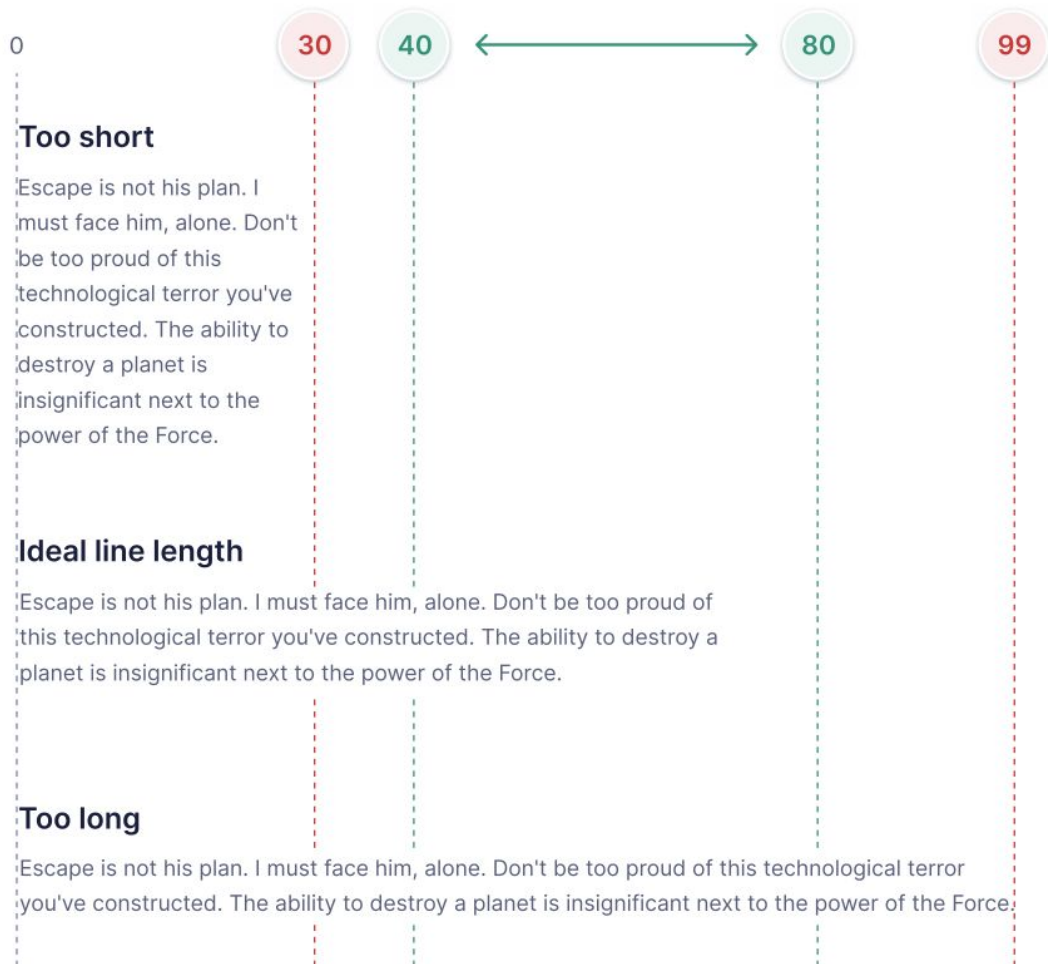
Ensure text is 40 - 80 characters per line (including spaces) to improve readability

If lines are too long, it makes it harder for people to gauge where the line starts and ends

If lines are too short, your eyes get stressed from having to travel back too often. A comfortable line length is especially important for long body text

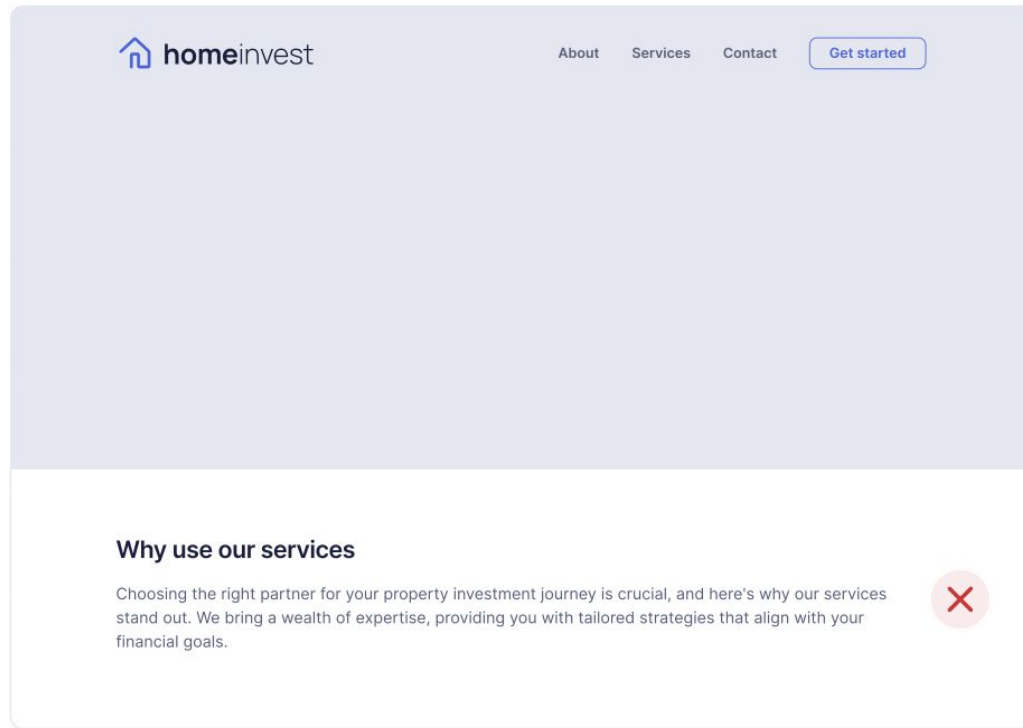
Ensure ideal line length

Ensure text is 40 - 80 characters per line (including spaces) to improve readability



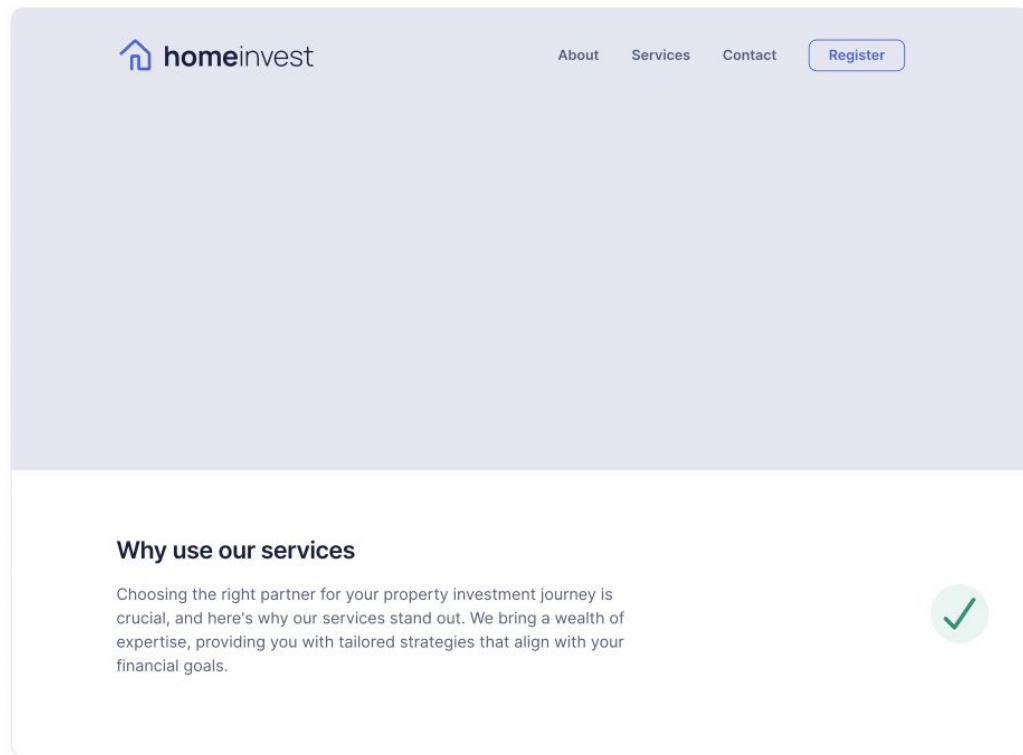
Ensure ideal line length

Example of an uncomfortably long line length



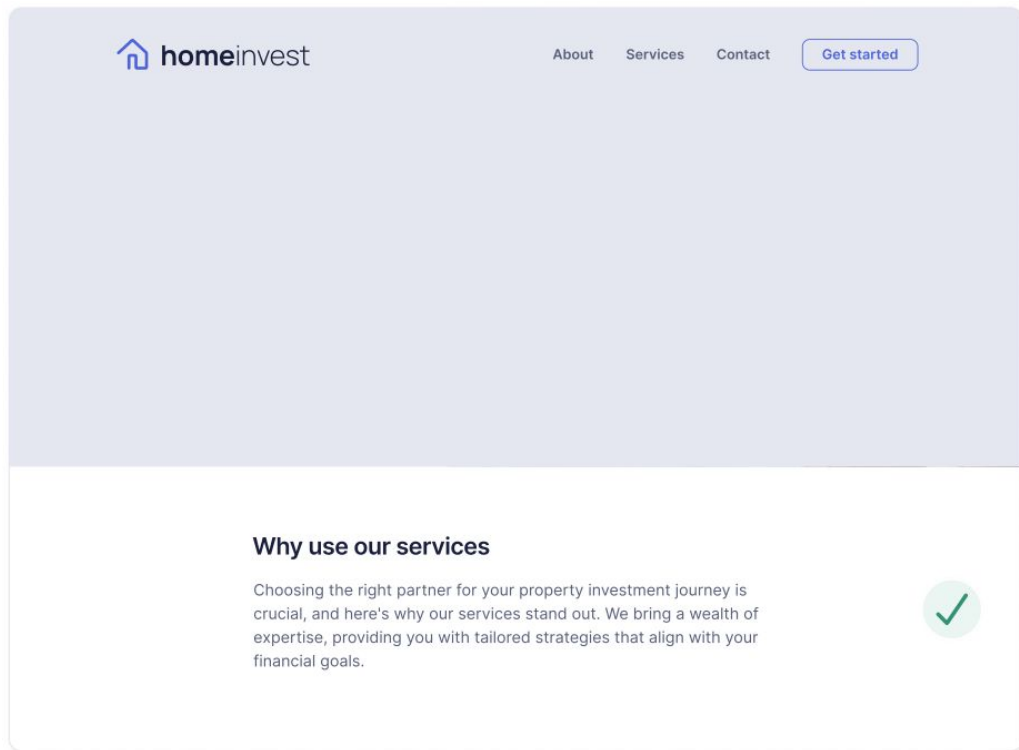
Ensure ideal line length

After keeping line length between the recommended character range and align block of text to the left or centre of the page



Ensure ideal line length

After keeping line length between the recommended character range and align block of text to the left or centre of the page



Left align text

English is read from left to right, downwards in an F-shaped pattern

It's best to keep text left aligned for optimal readability

For long body text, it's safest to avoid centre aligned or justified text

It's more difficult to read, especially for those with cognitive disabilities

Avoid combinations of different text alignments

It's harder for eyes to follow and can look messy

Don't centre align long body text

Centre alignment can work for headings and short text, as it can be quickly read

However, centre alignment makes longer body text harder to read, because the starting point of each line changes

Your eyes need to work harder to find the starting point of each line

Don't centre align long body text

Example of centre aligned versus left aligned text



Don't centre align

TYPOGRAPHY

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magna. Vivamus ut odio vitae orci.

Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.



Left align text

TYPOGRAPHY

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magna. Vivamus ut odio vitae orci.

Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.

Don't justify long body text

The variations in letter and word spacing make it harder for your eyes to distinguish text and follow lines (especially for those with cognitive impairments like dyslexia)

The variations in spacing also create distracting “rivers” of white space, highlighted in the example shown in the next slide

Don't justify long body text

Example of justified versus left aligned text



Don't justify

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magnatur vivamus ut odiores vitae orci.

Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.



Left align text

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus maximus est, a interdum leo metus id magna. Vivamus ut odio vitae orci.

Pellentesque semper urna eu massa id imperet facilisis. Cras mauris sed tortor, feugiat tellus at, tincidunt efficit nulla.

Decrease letter spacing for large text

Example of a heading with regular letter spacing
versus one with decreased letter spacing



about

I'm a product designer based in sunny
Sydney, Australia.

Since 2005, I've enjoyed turning complex problems into simple,
beautiful and intuitive designs. When I'm not pushing pixels, you'll
find me cooking, gardening or working out in the park.



about

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find me cooking, gardening or working out in the park.

Ensure text on photos is legible

Ensure the contrast ratio of text placed on photos meets WCAG 2.1 level AA accessibility requirements

Small text (18px and under) should have a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1

Large text (above 18px with bold weight or above 24px with regular weight) should have a contrast ratio of at least 3:1

Ensure text on photos is legible

Example of illegible white text placed directly on a photo



Ensure text on photos is legible

Tips to ensure your text is always accessible on photo

Add a linear gradient overlay

In the UI shown, a linear gradient overlay is placed behind text to achieve sufficient contrast



Ensure text on photos is legible

Tips to ensure your text is always accessible on photo

Add a semi-transparent overlay

In the UI shown, a dark grey overlay with 50% opacity is placed on top of the photo to achieve sufficient contrast

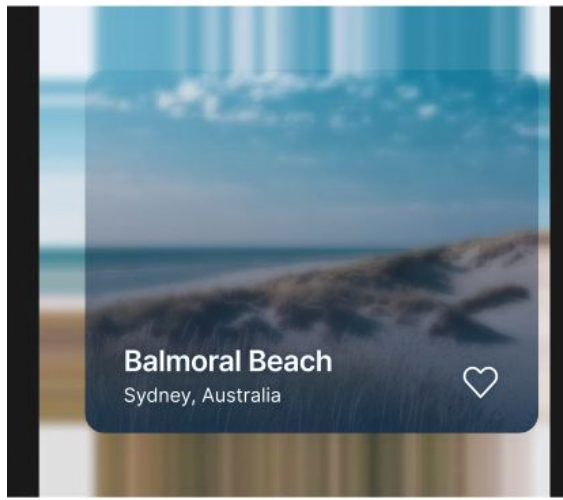


Ensure text on photos is legible

Tips to ensure your text is always accessible on photo

Add a blurred semi-transparent overlay

In the UI shown, a blurred semi-transparent overlay placed on top of a photo to improve text legibility



Ensure text on photos is legible

Tips to ensure your text is always accessible on photo

Apply a solid text background

In the UI shown, a solid background applied behind text to improve legibility on photos



Avoid light grey text

Always aim for text to have at least a 4.5:1 contrast ratio to meet WCAG 2.1 level AA accessibility requirements

The UI shown, compares inaccessible light grey text versus accessible dark grey text



Avoid very light grey text

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consec tetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus.



Use accessible grey text

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consec tetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus.

Avoid pure black text

Avoid contrast that's too high, as it can cause eye strain and fatigue

Black has 0% color brightness and white has 100% color brightness

The large difference in colour brightness causes our eyes to work harder



Avoid pure black text

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consec tetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus.

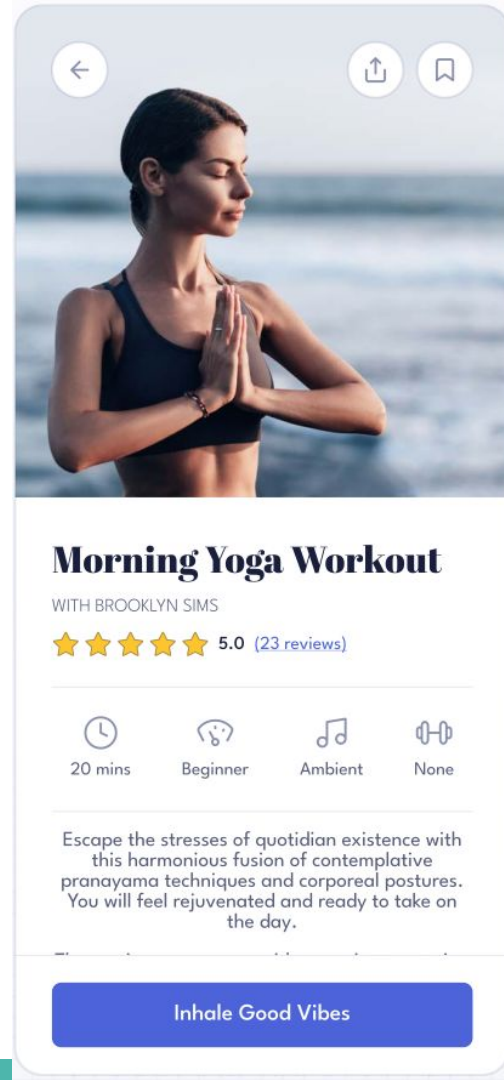


Use accessible grey text

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consec tetur adipiscing elit. Sed pharetra, enim sed fermentum pellentesque, nulla lectus.

Apply Typeface Guidelines

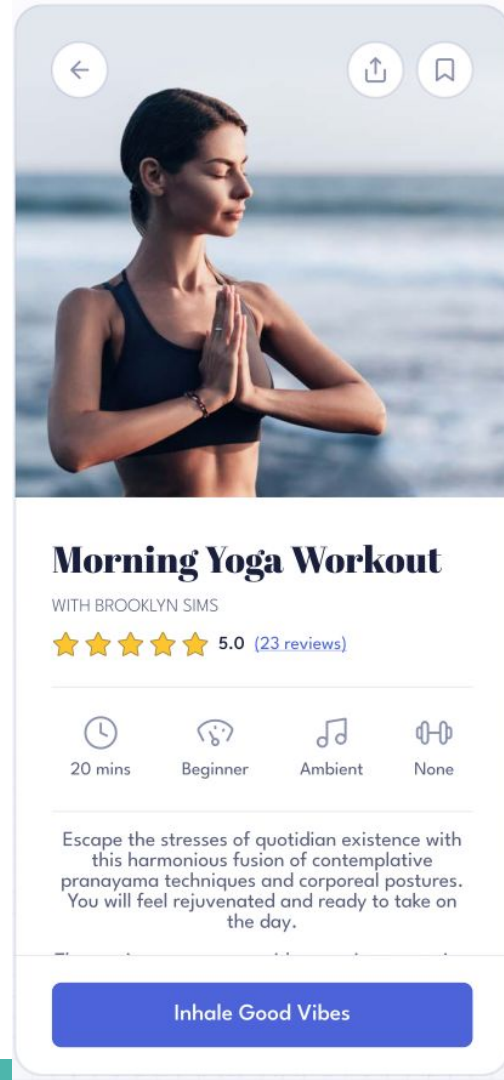
Identify typeface related issues on the UI shown



Use a single sans serif typeface

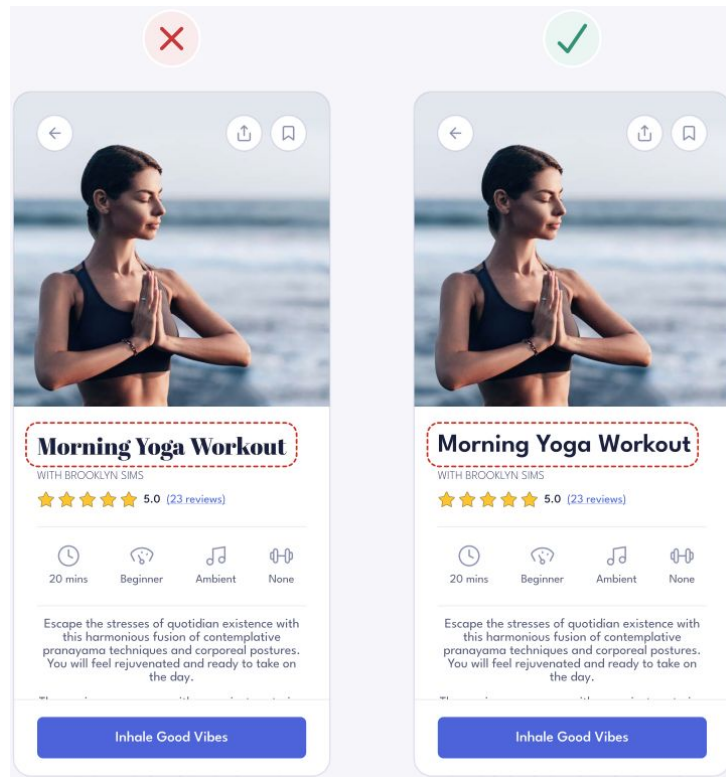
The heading uses a detailed serif typeface that's a bit difficult to read and could be distracting for some

It also has a personality that might not match some content in the app



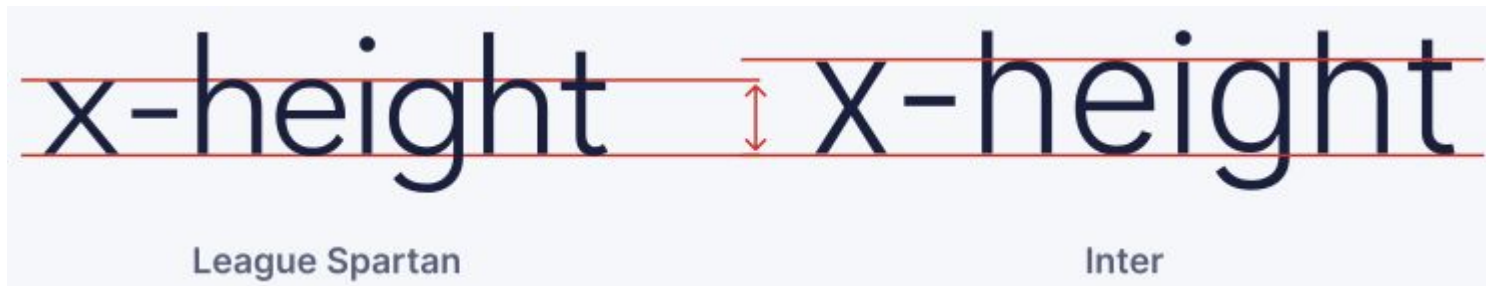
Use a single sans serif typeface

Simplify the heading to a sans serif typeface



Use a typeface with taller lower case letters

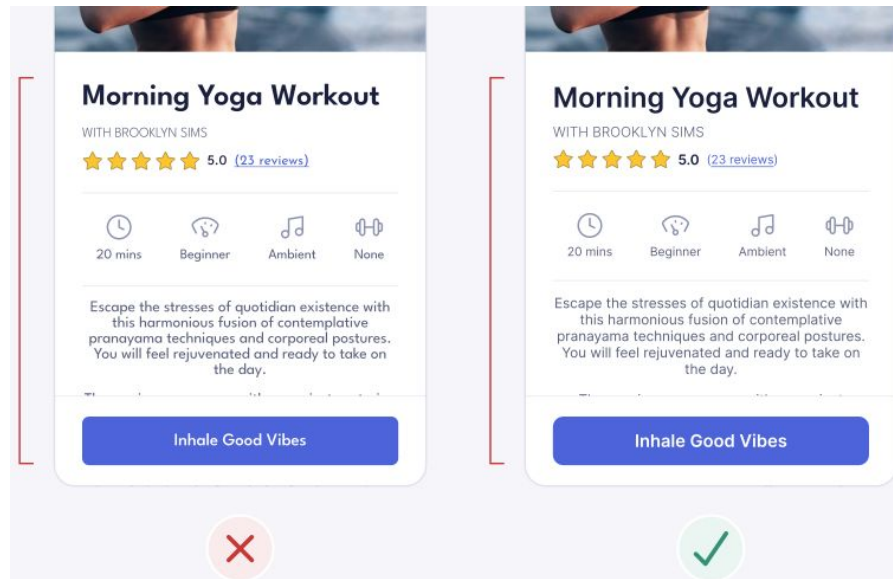
Look for typefaces with taller lower case letters and greater letter spacing, as they're generally more legible at small sizes



Use a typeface with taller lower case letters

The UI shown earlier uses the League Spartan typeface, which has a relatively low x-height

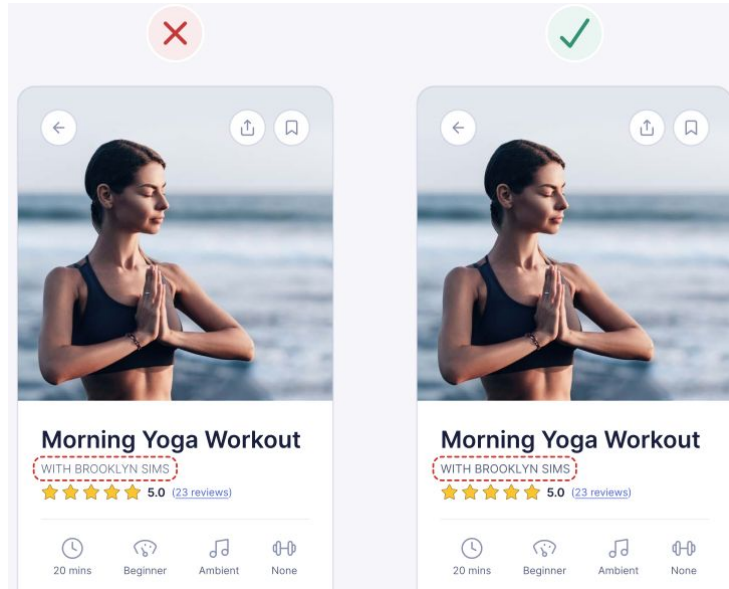
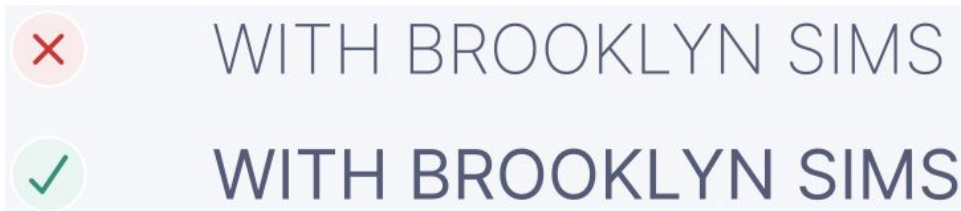
Changing the typeface to one with a larger x-height, like Inter, helps to improve readability



Use regular and bold font weights only

On the UI shown, the text for the instructor's name uses a light font weight

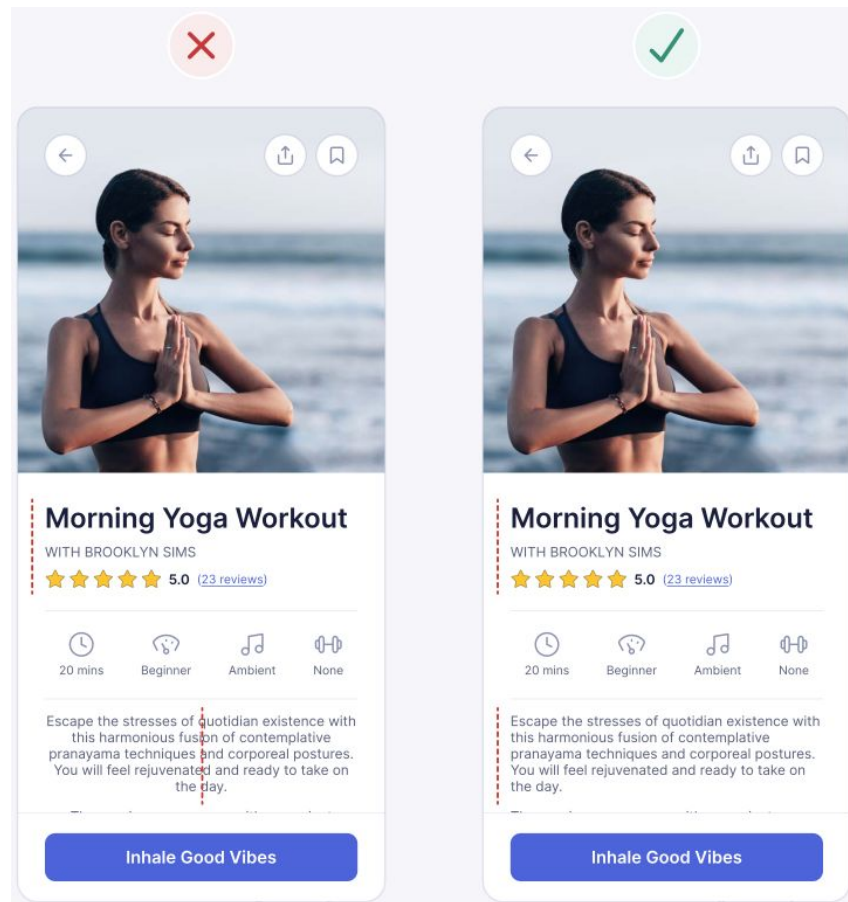
Increasing the font weight to regular helps improve readability and simplifies the design



Left align text

In the UI shown, the block of body text is centre aligned

Left aligning the text improves readability and is also consistent with the left aligned text that sits above it



Use at least 1.5 line height for body text

In the UI shown, the line height of the block of body text is only 1 (100%)

Increasing it to 1.5 (150%) helps to improve readability

